from admiration to love, from love to matrimony

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by moongallery

Summary

"Forgive me, Lord Phainon, I can't help but be curious. How could you possibly not know that Lord Mydei has been your spouse for... *four* months?"

"To be honest, Miss Castorice, I haven't the slightest idea."

Through a series of events that may or may not have involved a Kremnoan courting ritual, Phainon had somehow managed to ask for Mydei's hand in marriage.

For some reason, Mydei said yes.

Notes

taps into the mic so... i'm back with another phaidei fic :D 3.1 RUINED ME. so here is a fic to cope with that.

no beta + english is not my first language so you might encounter some mistakes along the way. all that yap aside, i hope you enjoy this <3

See the end of the work for more notes

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: 【授翻/厄敌】from admiration to love, from love to matrimony 从仰慕至倾心，终成连理 by AuntieTree_0324

Chapter 1: bearer of virtues, a serendipitous exception

Chapter Summary

> First impressions last. This rule, however, holds no water in the face of curiosity. Phainon learns this lesson the hard way.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"That's the thing!" Phainon exclaims, wincing when he feels the left side of his face sting phenomenally that it almost goes numb. "I had *no* clue this entire time!"

Castorice passes him another roll of bandages, sliding it across the table. Phainon catches it with half of his usual finesse considering that the bones of his left arm are currently working far beyond their limits—feeling broken beyond repair while his right arm is stuck in a cast.

"I'm not well-versed in the traditions of Castrum Kremnos," Castorice began, shifting uncomfortably, contemplating the right words to say. "But I do believe that your best course of action is to apologize."

Phainon sighs. Winces again because, *right*, his ribs are also broken. Why he's still alive is genuinely a mystery. Or perhaps it's all thanks to the golden blood running through his veins that makes him capable of surviving death-defying situations.

"I would have done that," Phainon replies, trying to keep his tone in check. It would do him no good to vent his frustrations out on someone who's only trying to help. "But the timeframe was a bit tight, you see. Considering that before I could even get the chance to tearfully grovel on my knees and ask for forgiveness, *he* already had me thrown off the balcony."

He, as in referring to a certain blonde Kremnoan prince who's currently posing as a threat to Phainon's life.

His wounds throb at the thought of what transpired this morning. Even if the healers have done their job and the golden waters from the Heroes' Baths have miraculous effects, the pain from his injuries are far from just being purely physical.

The door opens and in comes Tribbie carrying a tray bigger than her body, stacked full with vials, bottles, towels, and more rolls of bandages. Phainon watches her struggle to place the tray on top of the table with a heavy sense of guilt in his gut.

Lady Tribios is essential to Okhema, and here is Phainon reducing her forms to be his mere personal nurse. Thankfully, Castorice steps in to assist Tribbie with the tray, careful to

maintain a certain distance.

“Thank you, Cas,” Tribbie says with a smile. She pulls out a stool from underneath the table before stepping on it. “How are you feeling, Snowy?”

“Like I just got run over by a bunch of dromases carrying sacks of wheat,” Phainon answers drily. “Other than that, I feel perfectly fine.”

“If you can manage to make jokes, we suppose that the healing bath Agy arranged for you helped tremendously,” Tribbie notes as she pours a slodgy green liquid into a cup. Horrifyingly, she hands it over to Phainon. “Drink up, Snowy. This will help you heal faster.”

Phainon stares at the cup in his hand, filled to the brim with—Oh, *Kephale*. The liquid is hissing and bubbling. It looks more alive than Phainon is at the moment.

Do I really have to drink this? “It stinks.”

“We fully expected you to ask if you’re supposed to drink that before reasoning your way out,” Tribbie says teasingly, capable of reading Phainon like an open book. “Drink it and your bones will be back to normal by the Curtain-Fall Hour, good as new.”

Phainon sighs, closes his eyes and stops breathing before bringing the rim of the cup to his lips, downing the contents in one painful gulp. Goosebumps erupt all over his skin as he slams the cup onto the table indignantly with his broken left arm.

“Did Phagousa Themself put a curse in that?” he asks, glaring at the cup like it had just offended him thrice more.

The aftertaste in his mouth feels as if something had crawled in it, died, and has now started decomposing.

“Just some herbs and a sprinkle of a dromas’ fecal matter,” Tribbie replies.

Phainon thinks his injuries must have affected his hearing because there’s just no way— “I’m sorry, a sprinkle of a *what* now?”

Tribbie grins like she’s happy Phainon even asked. “Dromases have a unique digestive system,” she explained matter-of-factly, like a sage who knows too much. “The caretakers mixed some medicinal herbs into their diet. While that’s digesting, the dromas’ gastric juices help with enhancing the herbs’ medicinal properties.”

Phainon feels very faint. More faint than when Mydei threw him off the balcony five storeys off the ground and left him for dead.

“I guess this is the comeuppance Talanton has deemed acceptable for me,” he says, unable to hide the misery in his tone.

Tribbie offers him a sympathetic smile. “We think De is really angry this time, Snowy.”

“Well. He could’ve actually just killed me, but I guess he’s not angry enough to do just that.” Phainon buries his head in his left hand whose fingers appear all crooked and grotesque, the bones within equally as affected by the fatal ordeal as the rest of his body. “Titans, what have I done?”

“Should we go find De so you can talk to him?” Tribbie offers.

Phainon shakes his head. “Thank you, Lady Tribbie. But I’m afraid there’s no need for that,” he says. “I should probably give him some space considering all that’s happened.”

That, and Phainon is more than a hundred percent sure that Mydei would not take kindly to having him within twenty *pous* distance.

Tribbie looked concerned. “Are you sure, Snowy? It’s no bother at all for us to do it.”

“I’m sure, Lady Tribbie. Not to mention, this is something I believe I must fix on my own.”

Castorice nods, finally joining the discussion after keeping to herself for so long. “I support this decision, Lord Phainon. Lord Mydei is, after all, *your husband*.”

The words echo like a death knell.

Yes, indeed. Mydeimos, the one and only crown prince of Kremnos and a fellow Chryos Heir, is Phainon’s husband for more than *four* months already and Phainon didn’t have a *single* clue. There wasn’t even a wedding ceremony—or, if there was, perhaps Zagreus had robbed Phainon of his wits and vision when it took place.

A moment of silence encompasses the room as Tribbie and Castorice let Phainon wallow in his obvious distress, or maybe it’s their way of paying their respects in advance for his eventual demise at the hands of Mydei. What great friends, Phainon is very thankful.

Castorice clears her throat after a while and Phainon allows himself a little relief for having something else to hear in place of his self-deprecating thoughts yelling at him. As an example, it goes pretty much like this: “*YOU’RE AN IDIOT!*”

“Forgive me, Lord Phainon, I can’t help but be curious,” Castorice began hesitantly. “How could you possibly not know that Lord Mydei has been your spouse for… *four* months?”

Phainon slumps in his chair, also at a loss. “To be honest, Miss Castorice, I haven’t the slightest idea,” he says morosely. “I, too, had just found out about it during today’s breakfast and now, Mydei might actually just kill me on sight.”

How much Phainon wished he’s speaking falsehoods at the moment. But alas, his mind really does come up with a blank whenever he runs through all of the established facts that are of no help in answering the essential questions.

How did he come to marry *Mydei?* How long should he have to wait for Mydei’s temper to cool off enough to guarantee his safety when he’s within Mydei’s impressive range of strangling distance?

Questions, questions. And no answers to the lot of them. Even fulfilling the prophecy single-handedly seemed more feasible at the moment.

Tribbie crosses her arms, an uncharacteristic frown on her face as she regards Phainon. Like this, Phainon would've had a hard time distinguishing Tribbie from Trianne.

"That just won't do, Snowy. You have to think harder!" Tribbie admonishes. "What happened during the Month of Joy that made De think you're married to him?"

Phainon worries his bottom lip, reopening a cut in the process as a ribbon of golden blood drips steadily from the slit. He licks it absentmindedly.

He married Mydei during the Month of Joy—that's been established. By a *very* angry Mydei, no less. Golden eyes were set aflame and the surge of an unforgiving power coursed through the scarlet markings on his exposed skin. The only thing that was left for Mydei to do at that moment was to breathe fire.

Phainon would have loved to see that.

Regardless of the potential for some cheap entertainment, it changes nothing. Phainon still has no clue what caused this turn of events

"I don't know."

There were no wedding feasts during the Month of Joy as far as Phainon was concerned. He'd know if there had been one considering that the Chrysos Heirs have always gotten invitations to such occasions. But Phainon's mailbox was devoid of any such invites.

The only remarkable memory Phainon had during this year's Month of Joy was when *that* happened, and he doubts those actions had an ounce of matrimony rites in them.

If he considered the sensuous slide of his body against Mydei's in a heated embrace as they traded gasps against each other's parted lips, their limbs entangled, and sheets reduced to a debauched mess to be a wedding feast, then perhaps Phainon had indeed been married since the Month of Joy.

All things considered, the sight of Mydei laid bare and open before him *did* look like a feast —

"Might I suggest you start from the beginning, Lord Phainon?" Castorice says, unfortunately interrupting Phainon's train of thought. "Perhaps it will help if you recall your encounters with Lord Mydei from the first time you met him."

"Do I have to?" Phainon asks faintly.

Tribbie resolutely nods in agreement, also curious. "Yes, Snowy. We want *all* the details."

Phainon knew he had no chance of escaping without giving these two a proper story time that could rival that of a bard's. Given his current state, he supposes that the presence of song and dance is out of the question, not like Phainon possessed any ounce of lyrical talent anyway.

And since he can barely stand and Mydei wants *nothing* to do with him, Phainon thinks he has enough time to spare to recount everything.

Starting from the very beginning.

≪ ✵ ≫

calamity season, month of mourning

10 months before the present time

Phainon pants as he rushes his way towards the Marmoreal Palace, heeding Aglaea's call.

“Make haste to the Vortex of Genesis,” she had said, barely a whisper as a golden thread had fluttered by while Phainon was busy stuffing his mouth full with moussaka at the Marmoreal Diner.

He had then forlornly abandoned his meal in favor of his duties (and out of fear because Aglaea disliked tardiness), muttering apologies to a baffled Kyros as he handed him a pouch filled with colorful stones that he’s sure are of equal worth to the food he ordered, before setting course towards the Marmoreal Palace.

Phainon already had an inkling as to what reasons require such an urgent summon.

War had broken out of Castrum Kremnos, a king was slain, and the Titan of Strife had fallen into a complete madness. The mobile nation had then been subsequently lost into the sea of fog and the continuous invasion of the Black Tide was of no help. Nikador’s Titankin run rampant all across the Abyss and the Chrysos Heirs are in dire need of unity to go against a doomed fate.

Truly, there’s never a dull moment in Amphoreus.

There are a couple of hidden portals scattered all around the Marmoreal Palace which led to the Vortex of Genesis that only the Chrysos Heirs are privy to. Phainon takes the one closest to the entrance, an unsuspecting small fountain that didn’t even spit out a single drop of water. He gently caresses its rounded edges as if coaxing it to come to life. The fountain does so, its spout immediately spurting waters mired in a golden shimmer, flooding the basin in no time at all.

Dipping a hand in, Phainon takes a deep breath before plunging head first into the portal. A second later, the echoing chatter of the Marmoreal Palace was no more, only to be replaced by a profound silence.

The Vortex of Genesis is always a sight to behold and Phainon can never seem to get enough of it ever since he's been chosen by the prophecy and granted access within the domain.

He spots Aglaea and Tribbie in the distance conversing with… a blonde, half-dressed man in red, streaks of scarlet marring his exposed tanned skin, and glistening muscles out for display for all of Amphoreus to gawk over.

Phainon approaches the three of them hesitantly, careful not to interrupt their hushed conversation. Before he could make an announcement of his presence, however, Aglaea's clouded gaze had already landed on him.

"Phainon, you're here."

Phainon stops just beside Tribbie and the guest. "My apologies for being late." He turns to the stranger who was also looking at him, eyes of gold sharp and piercing as if sizing him up. Phainon feels a shiver run down his spine. "This is?"

"Snowy, meet De," Tribbie says. "You know about the Kremnoan detachment that arrived during today's Entry Hour? De was the one who led them here."

Phainon does know of the Kremnoan detachment. Their tales of renown across Amphoreus are sung by bards, echoed in halls, and debated upon by historians. Wherever they waged war, victory was sure to follow for they are led by a mighty leader, a king with no crown.

To say that Phainon might be a fan has some semblance of truth in it.

However, despite such a glorious (and bloodstained) track record, the newly arrived tribe are still Kremnoans by blood. And it is of no secret to anyone who is learned that Okhemans and Kremnoans go together like oil and water.

The Kremnoan detachment's arrival sparked quite the discussion amongst the citizens of Okhema whose prejudice have now come to light. It was all the talk Phainon had heard during his daily trip to the market.

"Welcome to Okhema," Phainon says, holding his hand out for a friendly handshake. "It's a pleasure to make your acquaintance, De."

That came out wrong, he was supposed to introduce himself first. Titans, a mere second beneath the golden gaze of a beautiful man and Phainon is already fumbling his introduction.

Before he could right his mistakes, Phainon is interrupted by a deep voice, each syllable reverberating with a tangible power, vibrations settling into Phainon's bones and wrapping itself around his very soul like an insistent whisper of fate.

"I am Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos," the man says, eyeing Phainon's hand with an obvious disdain like he's only seconds away from separating the offending limb from Phainon's body before throwing it into the endless sea of stars. "I am here to respond to the call of the Chrysos Heirs after the fall of my nation. You will address me as Mydeimos, or Mydei. I would take anything else as an offense to my person, and an invitation to fight."

Phainon blinks, utterly taken aback. He knew people of Kremnos had a certain… *temper* to them. But he never expected to be on the receiving end of such temper.

He withdraws his hand awkwardly. It was evident that Mydei wasn't about to take it anytime soon after his unintended slight. To salvage his dignity, Phainon hides his discomfort with a smile.

"My apologies for offending you, Mydei. Believe me, it was not my intention," Phainon says, getting an aggrieved scoff in return. "I am Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. You can call me Phainon, or anything really."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "I've heard of you. You're that great hero of Okhema who saves everyone from calamity," he drawls out, eyes glinting with something that Phainon couldn't quite put a name on. "The *Deliverer*."

Phainon laughs sheepishly, very much uncomfortable. "Ah, well—"

"But in all my travels across the land, I have not heard of a place called Aedes Elysiae," Mydei interrupts. His gaze is searing, as if carefully observing Phainon for any cracks in the facade.

Phainon makes sure there is none. Before he could even reply with an answer, one that he has spoken of countless times before to anyone who had the will to point out his questionable origins, Aglaea decides to put an end to the tense exchange with a slight cough.

"Phainon, now that you and Mydei are acquainted, why don't you show him around the holy city while I have his lodgings prepared?"

Aglaea might just as well send Phainon to his death.

"I care not for such," Mydei says, crossing his arms petulantly. "I will stay with my men."

"Rest assured, your men will be seen to and will be provided places to call their own during their stay here in Okhema," Aglaea replies smoothly. "As a Chrysos Heir yourself, it would be suitable for you to stay somewhere more appropriate for your standing."

Mydei frowns at this, looking poised to argue. In the end, he seemed to decide against it and Phainon can't help but think that perhaps Mydei had already subjected himself to Aglaea's golden threads and had thus formed an agreement with her prior.

"Fine," Mydei acquiesces before turning his glare towards Phainon's direction. "Lead the way, Deliverer."

Phainon smiles stiffly. He did say that Mydei could call him anything, but he didn't expect the other to settle for such a nickname.

"This way, then."

He tours Mydei around the vast city of Okhema, starting from the different sections of the Marmoreal Palace, passing through all the popular landmarks, before finally ending up at the Marmoreal Market.

“You can find basically everything you need in this place,” Phainon says, voice a bit louder to go above the noisy chatter of citizens browsing through shops. “There’s food, clothing, relics, scrolls, and even weapons.”

As he said these, he gestures at their respective stalls. Mydei follows, surprisingly obedient as Phainon leads him to be introduced to the vendors and a couple of patrons lingering in the area.

Their unsettled gazes do not go unnoticed by Phainon, and perhaps Mydei as well, considering that Kremnoans are not exactly a common sight in the holy city.

Even if Mydei did not seem to be bothered by this at all, Phainon takes it up to himself to be uncomfortable in place of the other, leading Mydei somewhere else where the heavy air of prejudice is absent.

“This is Chartonus,” Phainon tells Mydei as they arrive at the smithy. “He is the best blacksmith around these parts. Perhaps even in all of the land, if I do say so myself.”

Mydei looks up and nods lightly at the Mountain Dweller who had stopped in the middle of bevelling the edges of what looks to be the makings of a steel sword.

“Chartonus, this is Mydei,” Phainon introduces. “He is a Chrysos Heir from Kremnos.”

“Of Crown Prince Mydeimos, you speak of, Phainon?” Chartonus asks, his attention darting between Phainon and Mydei.

“In the flesh!” Phainon exclaims, his enthusiasm too pronounced to appear genuine.

He still can’t believe that this ill-tempered man is actually royalty. The princes he’s read about in Cyrene’s storybooks were both chivalrous and kind. At some point, Phainon even dreamed of becoming one.

The person beside him, however—

“A prince without a nation is simply a man,” Mydei says curtly. “There is no need to address me as such.”

Chartonus nods, it is fortunate that Mountain Dwellers are capable of reading the room. The tension Mydei exudes is enough to make even Phainon uneasy.

“Understood,” Chartonus says. “Esteemed Heirs, what do you need?”

“Just here to show Mydei around,” Phainon answers with a strained smile, eager for a change of topic. “Mydei, if you ever find yourself in need of a weapon fixed or forged, Chartonus is

your guy."

Mydei merely hums, eyes fixed absentmindedly on the blade atop the anvil. There's a certain distant look in his eyes that reflected the flickering flames of the furnace. He looks almost sad, the sight of the blade perhaps invoking a deep sense of melancholy.

Before Phainon could decipher such a strange expression, it's already disappeared the moment that Mydei turns his attention back to him.

"Any other *interesting* places I should see, Deliverer?" Mydei inquires with the enthusiasm of a grain of sand.

Phainon grins. "Lots." He looks over to Chartonus. "We won't take up too much of your time now, Chartonus. I'll drop by when I have the chance, yeah?"

Chartonus nods in agreement. "Always welcome, here you are, Phainon. To serve the Chrysos Heirs, it is an honor."

Phainon then leads Mydei towards the spot where they could get a good view of the World-Bearing Titan. Kephale and Their Dawn Device remains as imposing as the first time Phainon saw it.

"So, there's truth in the words of an Okheman after all. Kephale does look magnificent up close," Mydei notes.

To someone with an unobservant ear and a predisposed judgement, the tone in which Mydei conveys the compliment might sound a tad bit sarcastic, enough to warrant the offense of the devout believers that flock around Kephale Plaza. But Phainon thinks Mydei is genuinely impressed despite the lack of effort to show it like a normal person.

"I share your sentiment," Phainon says with a smile that comes easy for once. "Would you like to take a picture?"

A sharp glare from Mydei is all the answer he needed.

As they spend the day roaming more stalls, it doesn't take long for Phainon to realize that Mydei is not much of a talker, more of a 'grunt and glare' kind of guy paired with 'crossing my arms so I can appear aloof and intimidating.' Not to mention, when he speaks, his words lack the sweetness of sugar, coming out bitter and jagged. Tactless and direct.

More often than not, Mydei's disposition do not adhere to the tastes of the Okheman born and raised citizens, conversations ending up either strained or on the brink of an argument. Phainon diffuses the situation fast enough to the best of his ability—which is just him leading Mydei away to have him face the wall in a secluded spot.

"I don't know how you lived your life in Kremnos, but the citizens of Okhema have a sensitive nature," Phainon admonishes. Gently, of course, lest Mydei becomes offended and sees it fit to engage him in a duel in the middle of a busy market. "Please, watch what you say next time."

Mydei rolls his eyes, still facing the wall with his arms crossed. “I lived most of my life away from Kremnos,” is all he says.

Phainon is at a loss, confused as to what the statement entailed. Nevertheless, there’s an issue here that needs to be addressed. “Even if that’s the case, you can’t just randomly insult a citizen for, *what*, preferring Okheman baklava over… Kremnoan baklava?”

Now that Phainon says it out loud, it sounds incredibly ridiculous. More ridiculous is the fact that Mydei does seem thoroughly aggrieved over this matter.

“My insults are never random for they are always deliberately given,” Mydei argues with a scoff, nose turned up and everything. Phainon is exhausted. “And what I said to that Okheman was far from an insult, Deliverer. I was merely conveying my opinion. If he finds fault in my words, then that’s his problem.”

Phainon gives up. “Fine, alright. You’re lucky I’m here or else everyone and their mother might just rally together and throw you off a cliff.”

Mydei snorts. “They can try. Death is not a foreign concept.”

There’s something in the nonchalant way Mydei said it that makes Phainon frown, a tinge of curiosity as to why Mydei views death as such. Familiar and within reach.

If Phainon asks, it would be too personal. He and Mydei are the furthest from being friends at the moment. He could even dub them as strangers still, regardless if they’ve already spent the majority of their day together.

Acceptance is best done early on. Phainon had already made peace with the fact that he and Mydei would never get along. They are too different regardless if their paths are made to be intertwined by the prophecy. It would be Phainon’s first failure to make friends, but it certainly won’t be the last.

Mydei turns around, deeming his time-out to have already run its course. Gold eyes scour the market as if looking for something.

“Do you know a place where I could procure some fresh fruits, Deliverer?”

Phainon raises an eyebrow. It was not what he expected to hear. He thought perhaps Mydei would ask him for some dining recommendations, or even inquire if the Kremnoan relics sold in the market are authentic.

Still, Phainon nods. “You can never go wrong with Demetria’s fruit stand,” he says, leading Mydei to the right direction.

After a round of introductions and pleasantries with Demetria, which thankfully did not result in Phainon trying to rein in Mydei’s filterless mouth, Phainon watches as Mydei places a bag filled with gold upon Talanton’s Scale, balancing it out with the worth of a sack of fresh pomegranates, emptying the stock.

“Would you like to sample the other fruits I have for sale, Lord Mydei?” Demetria asks with a smile, no doubt she already developed a soft spot for a new avid patron of her store. “The figs were freshly harvested just this morning, sweet and juicy. I’ll give you three minae's worth of them, free of charge.”

Mydei shakes his head. “Thank you for the offer, but I’m afraid I would have to decline for now. I'm in a hurry to cross off all the items on my list and I don't think I'll have enough time to sample your produce in its peak condition.”

So he can be civil, Phainon thinks amusedly. Maybe the elderly are an exception to Mydei’s callous attitude. Phainon finds this discovery strangely endearing. And then Mydei’s words properly register in his head.

“You have a shopping list?” Phainon asks, unable to hide the surprise in his voice. “Why didn’t you say so earlier?”

Mydei gives him an unimpressed look. “You kept going on and on about this and that, dragging me here and there until my arm was about to fall off. You think I had such a chance to do so?”

“Reducing my shop recommendations into mere ‘this and that’ saddens me deeply,” Phainon chides, feigning offense. “Mydei, were you simply allowing my words to enter in one ear and out the other?”

“Perhaps.”

Phainon couldn't believe this man. He shakes his head in resignation before turning to Demetria. “Ma’am, can I take those fresh figs on his behalf if that’s okay?”

Demetria nods enthusiastically. “But of course!” She then proceeds to get a bag to store the fruits in before handing it to Phainon. “Do let me know what you think!”

“Certainly, ma’am.” He turns his attention back to Mydei whose impatience seeps through every wrinkle of the frown gracing his fine face. “Mydei, your youth would be wasted if you’re so adamant to look twice your age.”

Mydei does not indulge him with a retort. Instead, he says, “Direct me to a place where I would be able to purchase some firewood, barrels of the finest quality to store juice, hay, and incense. And I need a cart to help me carry all those things.”

Phainon raises an eyebrow. “Are you preparing a feast with no food and only drinks?”

“There are no feasts to be held during the Month of Mourning, idiot Deliverer,” Mydei chastises. “Or does the holy city not follow such a tradition?”

To say that Phainon simply forgot about this fact would be akin to admitting defeat. “I was merely assuming that the Kremnoans were the ones who would find time to celebrate during such a month, but it seems that your nation and Okhema can find a common ground when it comes to matters of life and death.”

Mydei huffs. “Kremnos and Okhema can never find a common ground on *anything*. It would do you well to remember this fact, Deliverer.”

“No need to be so negative.”

“Direct me to a place where I would be able to purchase some firewood, barrels of the finest quality to store juice, hay, and incense,” Mydei says in lieu of a reply, an impatient repetition of his words from earlier. “And I need a cart to—”

“To help you carry all those things,” Phainon finishes for him. “Yes, Your Highness. I heard your directives loud and clear the first time around.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “I have until the Parting Hour. We’ve dawdled enough already.”

“Well, if you just told me about your list earlier—”

Mydei steps on his foot and Phainon bites back a yelp. His leather boots are of no match against Mydei’s. On Kephale’s mercy, the gold metallic footwear Mydei wears could pass off as weapons on their own, clinking against the ground as Mydei walks off like he knows the place, Phainon trailing miserably behind him.

The rest of the Action Hour passes by without much fanfare. By the final quint, Mydei is able to purchase all the items he needs, dragging a huge cart filled haphazardly to the brim, uncaring of the way the citizens of Okhema point and stare at his questionable buying habits.

“You still haven’t told me what these things are for,” Phainon says as they make their way towards a Dromas Post, a hand supporting a bundle of hay that looked seconds away from toppling over.

“The war in Kremnos waged for weeks. The detachment has lost a lot of people during the carnage,” Mydei replies. “Once the old king was felled, Kremnos was already on the brink of collapse, and Nikador’s Titankin were swarming like locusts. I had to get my people out of there.”

Phainon furrows his eyebrows. “The old king? Don’t you mean—”

“My father, yes.” He doesn’t look at Phainon when he says the next words. “It was my spear that drove straight through his heart that ultimately killed him. It was his death that signified the end of the battle at Kremnos.”

Again, it would be too personal to inquire as to what had led to such a drastic turn of events. Based on Mydei’s rigid countenance and the edge in his voice, Phainon could deduce as much that Mydei would rather not talk about the matter either.

“Due to our hasty retreat, we didn’t have the time to hold a proper Rite of Parting for the deceased,” Mydei continues, an answer to Phainon’s initial question that Phainon forgot he even asked.

Perhaps it would have been better if he kept his mouth shut. “I’m sorry.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow at him. “What for? My soldiers died with honor. They fought for a cause they believed in and their deaths had not been a waste.”

He pauses, as if his thoughts had interrupted him, and Phainon is able to witness that look in his face again—a grief so profound that it makes even Phainon mourn for those people he never even met.

“Everyone lost someone important to them during the war,” Mydei continues resolutely. “It is only right to properly commemorate the souls of the departed, for both the dead and the living to be at ease.”

They arrive at the Dromas Post, thankfully there’s no line of people awaiting their turn for a ride. Phainon rings the bell for Mydei, somehow desperate to make himself useful to wash away the guilt of bringing up such a topic.

“Will you be needing a priest?” Phainon asks. “I just happen to know someone—”

“No,” Mydei answers, effectively cutting him off. “I don’t need Okheman blood soiling the traditions of Kremnos.”

That’s a shame, Phainon thinks, helplessly looking down at the ground as he tries to come up with another way to assist, only for his mind to end up as blank as the day he was born for he doesn’t even have the slightest idea on how Kremnoans conduct funerals.

A heavy sigh interrupts Phainon’s train of thought. He looks up and sees Mydei sporting a conflicted expression.

“You look like a kicked chimera.”

Phainon’s frown deepens. “Why would anyone kick a chimera? They’re adorable.”

“Exactly.”

It would take days to decipher Mydei’s one-liners. Phainon knows how to choose his battles and gives this one up when he sees a dromas approach. It’s time for him to take his leave for the Parting Hour is upon them.

He clasps his hands together, ignoring how sweaty his palms had gotten. “If there’s anything else I can help you with, Mydei, you already have my contact in your teleslate.”

“Spoken like a true Deliverer,” Mydei muses. “While I appreciate your concern for this matter, there truly is nothing else to be done.”

Phainon feels his smile falter for a little bit. It would be pathetic to push his luck a third time considering how adamant Mydei is to make it known that he is not needed.

“Right.” Phainon nods, agreeing to nothing in particular. “I’ll, uh, take my leave now.”

He turns around without waiting for Mydei to bid his goodbye. He doubts Mydei would even do such a thing in the first place given his open hostility towards Phainon. Well, it’s not like

Phainon didn’t try his best in befriending the difficult crown prince of Kremnos—

“Deliverer.”

Phainon turns his head back so quickly that he thinks he might've stretched a muscle in the process. “Yes?”

Mydei hesitates, an uncharacteristic look that Phainon didn’t expect he’d be able to witness this early on in their acquaintance.

“If you wish to witness the rites with my tribe, you’re free to do so,” Mydei says. Even if he seemed like he’s at odds with himself for saying such words, he makes no move to take it back. “Consider it as my thanks for helping me out today.”

Phainon would like to reiterate that a show of thanks is unnecessary. Touring Mydei around Okhema is more of an honor than a bother, regardless if Mydei is admittedly not the easiest person to be around and neither is he the most enthusiastic conversation partner Phainon has had the pleasure of talking to.

However, Mydei's invitation somewhat causes Phainon to retract most of his initial thoughts. Perhaps the crown prince isn't so unsociable after all.

He can't believe this, a mere gesture of cordiality from Mydei has him thinking that the world is indeed beautiful despite the impending doom. The rainbows that swirled around Okhema is such a fascinating sight, the roar of the dromases livening up the atmosphere, the chirping of birds, the rustle of leaves, the sway of every blade of grass—

“Yes. I’ll be there.”

Mydei rolls his eyes at the blatant show of enthusiasm. “No need to look so happy. You can come on one condition.”

Phainon is all ears. “Anything.”

“You’re not to bring anybody else.”

The funeral rites are held later that day during the Curtain-Fall Hour in the middle of a secluded clearing in the forest, some ways away from the Marmoreal Palace. The trees are tall and their trunks are thick, the foliage abundant enough to shroud the area in an almost complete darkness despite the presence of Kephale’s Dawn.

Torches lit up the place and the warriors of the Kremnoan detachment all wore their full battle regalia, skin streaked with red and gold paint as they chatted minimally amongst themselves. If Phainon didn’t know any better, he’d think the tribe is planning a full-fledged siege against Okhema.

When the detachment notices Phainon's presence, they stop and stare. His garb of blue and white does not exactly fit with the theme so perhaps he does stick out like a sore thumb.

To try and dissipate the awkwardness in the air, Phainon waves his hand and smiles at a group of Kremnoan warriors unsubtly eyeing him up and down in the same manner that Aglaea does whenever Phainon decides that he's in charge of his outfit for the day.

The Kremnoans don't return his smile, nor do they bother to wave back, simply baffled by Phainon's attendance. Phainon feels sweat beginning to trickle at the back of his neck. It's not that he feels unwelcome…

No, he *definitely* feels unwelcome. Like he's intruding—

"You've come."

Phainon nearly jumps out of his skin. Turning around, he comes face to face with none other than Mydei. Gold streaks marred his solemn face as he offers Phainon a chalice filled with crimson liquid.

Phainon takes it with a mutter of thanks before throwing a quick glance at the group of warriors, only to find that they've engaged themselves in conversation once more.

"Is something wrong, Deliverer?"

Phainon turns his attention back to Mydei, willing out a smile. "Everything's fine. It's just…" He inspects the contents of his chalice, gently swirling the liquid within. He recalls a distant legend he's read in a scroll once and can't help but ask, "Is it true that Kremnoans sustain their bodies with fresh blood?"

Mydei seemed thoroughly amused by this, golden eyes glinting from the dim lighting of the clearing. "Why don't you find out for yourself?" he says, nodding at the cup as a way of urging Phainon to take a sip.

The warning bells ring within Phainon's mind causing him to have a brief moment of regret for even accepting Mydei's invite. He shakes it off for cowardice is not something befitting of a hero.

Blatantly ignoring Mydei's goading gaze, Phainon gingerly brings the rim of the chalice to his lips, tipping his head back and bracing himself for the coppery taste of blood.

Only, it doesn't come.

A sweet, almost syrupy taste floods his tongue. Fruity, a bit of tartness, a creamy texture… Phainon downs the rest of it, pleasantly surprised by this turn of events and at the same time, baffled at the stark contrast of reality from his expectations.

Once the chalice has been emptied of its contents, Phainon is left wanting more. He licks the corners of his lips to savor the remaining taste of heaven, one that's even akin to ambrosia. He looks up and finds Mydei staring, leaving him to belatedly realize his shamelessness for downing a drink so hurriedly.

Perhaps it's because of the poor lighting in the clearing that Phainon could see a hint of a smile gracing Mydei's lips.

"Did the 'blood' taste that good for you to finish the whole drink before the ceremony has even begun?" Mydei snickers.

Phainon goes along with the jest, throwing Mydei a smile of his own. "I have to admit that it does." He inspects his empty cup. "Pomegranate juice and milk?"

Mydei crosses his arms defensively, an eyebrow raised. "Do you have a problem with that? Milk is usually not a part of the recipe. If you prefer its traditional version, you can ask Idaeus over there for a pour."

Phainon marvels at Mydei's talent for assuming things. It gives him the urge to learn more about the ways Mydei's profound mind works and how he manages to come up with conclusions that are not even supposed to be there.

"I quite like this combination, actually," Phainon admits earnestly despite tasting the drink for the first time in his life. "Do you have any more of where that came from?"

Mydei's eyes widened for a fraction, it only takes him a split second to school his expression back to normal which seemingly conveys something along the lines of a grumpy 'you better not be trifling with me' look.

"Give me a moment," is his response, leading Phainon to a table where a barrel is placed. Beside it, there's a pitcher of milk.

Phainon watches quietly as Mydei turns the knob of the spout, dark crimson liquid pouring out until the cup has been filled midway. Mydei then proceeds to add the milk, swirling the liquid gently with a teaspoon as he does so.

The action is mesmerizing. How could such formidable hands enclosed in fearsome golden gauntlets be capable of doing something so reposeful? So much so that Phainon finds himself having trouble looking away.

Mydei hands him his cup. "I do hope you won't finish it in one sip this time, Deliverer," he chastises without much heat. More of a tease, if anything. "It is meant to be drunk with the rest of us after dousing an amount on the shields of the deceased."

The unusualness of such an action does not escape Phainon's confused mind. "Shields?"

"Yes," Mydei answers with a nod, surprisingly patient to indulge Phainon with his questions that might've sounded quite foolish. "In Kremnos, when an army returns with shields bathed in blood, it is seen as a symbol of triumph—the shields have fulfilled their purpose, and so did the warriors. It is the reason why we douse the shields of the deceased with pomegranate juice during the Kremnoan Rite of Parting. A symbol of a triumphant return despite death."

Phainon looks over at the crowd of Kremnoan warriors, somber as they spoke amongst themselves. The atmosphere is far from being triumphant.

“I see,” he says absentmindedly, eyeing the liquid in his cup.

In the face of death, Phainon can’t help but feel the helpless doubt gnaw at his gut incessantly. Like a knife constantly twisting and stabbing, reopening wounds and making them worse. How could the people of Kremnos view death alongside triumph like the two contrasting concepts were nothing but old friends?

He jolts when a hand suddenly clamps on his shoulder, the action catching Phainon off-guard that he almost spills his drink. He turns to Mydei who seemed amused for some reason.

“No need to think too deeply of it, Deliverer,” Mydei tells him with a light squeeze on Phainon’s shoulder, a grounding gesture. He withdraws his hand afterwards with no intent of lingering. “We Kremnoans handle death differently. If this tradition leaves you unsettled, then feel free to take your leave. I won’t hold it against you.”

Phainon attempts a laugh. “How could pouring pomegranate juice over the shields of deceased warriors leave me unsettled? If anything, I find it quite interesting.”

“Is that so?”

“Well, I admit I do feel somewhat forlorn.” Phainon lightly swirls his cup. “To spill such a delicious drink that tastes much like ambrosia, it makes me think that I’m not cut out to participate in the rites at all.”

Mydei huffs. “I didn’t think you’d be capable of offending three Titans in a single breath, Deliverer. Phagousa, Nikador, and perhaps even Thanatos. Not to mention, my kingdom as well who have observed this tradition since the late days of Era Bellica.”

“If it allows me to express my sincerest compliments to the maker of this drink, then I consider the offense of the Titans as a worthy consequence.”

It was supposed to be in jest and Phainon was just about to apologize for his impropriety. But seeing Mydei’s fair face color in the slightest tinge of pink has caused his tongue to go still, utterly lost for words.

A tense silence befalls them. Phainon wishes he’d simply kept his sentiments to himself. He wonders what Mydei is thinking now who seemed insistent to avoid eye contact.

“The ceremony will commence soon,” Mydei eventually says, clearing his throat. He looked poised to leave. “I shall be on my way.”

Phainon doesn’t bother chasing after Mydei this time, choosing to join a group of warriors who seemed agreeable to have a non-Kremnoan amongst them. Most of them held two to three shields in both arms. Phainon gratefully accepts one from a warrior, allowing himself to listen in to their chatter as he awaits the ceremony to start.

The rites consisted of a huge burning stake, with warriors tossing a variety of items into the flames—a broken sword, a cloak, a satchel, a quill, a teleslate, and many more. There seems

to be no pattern to it. Phainon can deduce as much that these items must've belonged to their dead comrades, all of whom the tribe wishes to commemorate.

Once all the items were burned to ash, Mydei makes his way in the middle. Even without uttering a single word, Mydei commands the undivided attention of everyone as easy as it is to breathe. Even Phainon seems to be caught in a trance himself.

Perhaps it is Mydei's status as royalty that makes him appear regal without so much as an effort. Or the way he conducts himself with pride that amplifies his worth. Even now, the way he spoke lacked tawdry pleasantries that run shallow, only choosing to convey words that hold weight.

"There is no grief for parting in Kremnos, only the promise of glory," Mydei begins, his own chalice in hand as his deep voice echoes throughout the clearing.

Everyone maintains the silence, listening with rapt attention. Phainon awaits the next words with bated breath.

Mydei continues, "As the spirits of our fellows traverse the River of Souls, their names shall forever be etched in the annals of history. Their victory will undoubtedly be spoken of, transcending generations—never forgotten." He raises his chalice up high. "My fellows, our time of glory has yet to come. But for now, we shall spill this blood and drink to those who have already achieved it."

The Kremnoan warriors erupt into cries and roars, raising their chalices in a show of esprit de corps, no room for melancholy and regrets for death is seen as an honor.

The splash of crimson liquid against the surface of battered shields follow suit, mimicking the sight of shields bathed in blood as Mydei had explained beforehand. Phainon douses a relative amount of his drink onto the scratched surface, his reflection a blurry sight.

Before he could take a sip from his cup, his eyes meet that of Mydei's from afar. Mydei gives him a slight nod of acknowledgement before partaking in his own drink, gaze akin to that of molten gold. Sharp like a lion's, searing its way into Phainon's mind until it's forever etched into his memory.

Mydei shines like a flaming beacon for his people, even brighter than the burning stake behind him. His kin gazes at their prince with hope for the future, entrusting their lives to him, willing to lay them down when necessary.

It hasn't even been a day since Phainon had met the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos. And yet, there's a strong pull, an unavoidable urge to get closer.

Even if he'd end up likened to a moth lured by the ever so tempting flame.

The Kremnoan Rite of Parting is an extremely sacred ritual. It does not possess the same delicacy as that of a different nation's, but its importance is just as comparable. ***Only a true Kremnoan is worthy of bearing witness and participating in said rite****; one must embody the virtues of the Titan of Strife in order to bid farewell to the glorious souls of one's kin.*

Exceptions include...

*...****a spouse or a significant other that is of non-Kremnoan descent may participate in the ritual provided that they already exemplify the appropriate virtues to be chosen by a true Kremnoan****... apart from this, it is absolute to decline the presence of outsiders...*

— an excerpt. On the Kremnoan Rite of Parting: Rituals for Souls Who Underwent Valorous Deaths

. . — . — . .

Chapter End Notes

me: i rarely read the readables in-game.

also me: let me make my own readables for the sake of making two men appear gayer for each other.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

thank you so much for reading!! <3 i hope you enjoyed this first chapter :3

Chapter 2: epiphany of a wife, affectionate will of a mother

Chapter Summary

> Phainon is no stranger to establishing connections with others. Nevertheless, it still takes him by surprise when he successfully manages to form one with the unlikeliest of fellows.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

calamity season, month of fortune

9 months before the present time

· · — ·𓂀· — · ·

The Kremnos Festival was my chance to prove my worth. His Majesty, King Eurypon is as mighty as the tales depict him to be. ***I believe I have met my true match.*** *He asked me to be his queen after our duel, one that he insisted concluded in a draw.*

My whole life, I saw him as a figure to be conquered. I never thought Mnestia's influence would come to play. ***To find one's equal—there's something inherently romantic to it even if there is no place for Romance in a kingdom who glorifies Strife.***

— an entry from Her Majesty, the late Queen Gorgo's diary, dated [redacted]

· · — · — · ·

Cards fly into the air as Mydei stands up from his seat and flips the table with fiery contempt. It all happened in a mere blink of an eye, barely a second after Phainon proclaimed his victory in their game of koum-kan.

Phainon watches as Mydei finishes the job—slamming a foot down on the side of the toppled table, splitting it in half. It's a clean cut, more impressive to witness than the performance of a random busker on the streets of Okhema.

"Mydei, this table is not ours to play havoc with," Phainon says lightly, making no move to leave his chair. "We're going to have to pay for this—"

Mydei lunges towards him, aiming for a quick jab to Phainon's face before swiftly following it up with a low kick aimed at his foot. Phainon dodges on instinct, rolling out of his seat and causing both of Mydei's hits to miss him by a fraction.

Phainon's chair did not survive the ordeal, three of its legs broken and the backrest cleanly separated, skidding some ways away from the seat itself.

Panicked yells erupt from the market at the sudden display of violence. Some citizens chose to flee and board up their stalls while others stayed to watch.

"Dear Mydeimos, I doubt such a reaction is needed for a mere silly little game of cards," Phainon says, attempting to pat away the dust in his clothes.

Mydei's scowl darkens, eyes narrowed into slits that spell danger. "You cheated."

"It's called strategy," Phainon retorts.

It was the wrong thing to say. Mydei lunges a second time, tackling Phainon by the neck as they tumbled onto the ground. Phainon attempts to gain the upper hand only for Mydei to land a knee into his chest, knocking the air out of his lungs.

Mydei settles on top of him, bearing down on Phainon with gritted teeth. "You chose not to discard the ace. Why?"

Phainon smiles despite the situation, finding it very hard to breathe. The reason for it is surprisingly *not* because Mydei is currently restricting his airflow.

"If I did such a thing, it would have been your victory," Phainon replies, voice strained as he tries not to get lost into the molten gold of Mydei's eyes, sharper than before in his rage.

Mydei tightens his grip on Phainon's neck. "You had no need for it. You chose not to meld by discarding that queen instead of the ace."

Phainon relishes the cool metal of Mydei's gauntlets beneath his palm, holding onto Mydei's wrist to ground himself. "In the end, it worked in my favor, didn't it?"

As Mydei registers his words, Phainon chooses this moment to flip them over, pinning Mydei to the ground, Phainon's chest pressed on his back.

Mydei thrashes in his hold with a growl, hands akin to deadly talons as it tries to swipe at anything of Phainon he could reach behind him. Phainon takes hold of both his wrists, locking them in place upon Mydei's back.

"You play with cheap tricks," Mydei says coolly, his attempts to escape have stopped. Or perhaps it's to subject Phainon to a false sense of security.

Phainon aims to relish this brief show of pliantness, leaning close, allowing his breath to ghost over the shell of Mydei's ear. "I fail to see how my tactfulness could be considered as cheap tricks."

He gets a sharp glare in return, Mydei eyeing him vindictively from the side. If Phainon lets his hold on the other falter, he might not survive the retaliation Mydei would unleash upon him.

“Now that I think about it,” Phainon continues, doubling down and playing with risks out of curiosity. He wonders how the honorable Mydeimos would react when his patience is being pushed to the brink. “Your play mostly consisted of you melding your cards on the table, purely offensive in nature with no room for contingencies.”

“You meld when you have the hand for it,” Mydei snaps back. “Isn’t that part of the rules you spoke of when you challenged me to partake in your game?”

“Melding is *optional*, Mydei,” Phainon corrects, biting back a laugh when he sees something snap within Mydei—his patience or sanity, Phainon wonders which one. “Now that you know, you can use that to your advantage in our next round.”

Mydei’s eyes flash, muscles tensed beneath Phainon’s hold. “You withheld this information from me.”

“Not deliberately,” Phainon simpers. “I simply must have forgotten.”

At a blatant show of strength, Mydei contorts his body in an attempt to slip free, successfully managing to loosen Phainon’s hold on his arms. The brief moment allows for just enough window of time for Mydei to wrench himself away, hands finding purchase on the ground, the sharp fingertips of his gauntlets drawing angry lines. With a sudden twist, he elbows Phainon right on the sternum before rolling away to regain his footing.

As Phainon scrambles, Mydei takes this chance to land a kick squarely at the side of the his face, hard enough for him to see stars. But before anything could fully register, Mydei was on top of him again.

And Phainon finds it hard to breathe. *Again*.

Kephale’s Dawn shines magnificently behind Mydei, painting him in an almost haloed light, holy despite the presence of brute strength. It’s hard to decide which of those two things Phainon prefers to see more of.

He tastes copper in his tongue and spits to the side, eyes never leaving Mydei’s as he does so. He grins, gold staining his teeth. The man above him truly doesn’t know what it means to hold back.

“My apologies for winning?”

Mydei roughly grabs his chin, pinning Phainon’s head further into the ground. “A foul opponent who still indulges in his spoils,” he snarls. “How low can you go?”

“It’s just a game, Mydei,” Phainon offers, an attempt to diffuse the situation.

“My issue lies with you not playing fair,” Mydei tells him, his grip on Phainon’s chin tightening. Phainon feels the sharp fingertips of the gauntlet starting to dig into his skin. “You

should have informed me of *all* the rules beforehand."

Phainon sighs. *This* is what his curiosity has led him to. Rest assured, it will be the last time he'll provoke the crown prince of Kremnos. No promises, however.

"Alright. I sincerely apologize," Phainon says, attempting to sound sincere, yielding out of necessity. "Now, enough of this. People are staring."

In his periphery, he could already see a crowd of people watching the exchange within a safe distance with their teleslates out, capturing the scene in real time. There's no doubt that this event would be talked about for a week.

He can already predict the articles that would circulate around the holy city: Two Chrysos Heirs unable to get along. Will this spell disaster for Okhema?

A bit exaggerated, but knowing the Verax Leos' creativity, his exaggeration might pale in comparison to the actual thing.

Thankfully, Mydei does peel himself away. Phainon only manages to sit up followed by a single deep inhale to regain his bearings before the sharp end of a red crystal is directed at his throat. He looks up at Mydei questioningly.

"I challenge you to a fight to settle our differences," Mydei declares.

Phainon winces, leaning away from the range of the crystal's sharp tip just in case Mydei does stab him *accidentally*. "I'm not fond of destroying public property," he reasons to someone he is well aware isn't capable of being reasoned with at the moment. "Accepting would mean that such an occurrence is unavoidable."

Mydei seems to consider his words, lowering the red crystal. Phainon thinks that perhaps he had thought wrong of Mydei's capabilities for a civil discussion in the presence of certain grievances.

Just as Phainon concludes he's managed to quell what was about to become a city-wide disaster, the red crystal in Mydei's hand grows thrice in size, almost as tall as his height. Before Phainon could *ask*, Mydei directs his attention towards one of the city's stone walls, leaning back and raising the red crystal with an intent to throw—

In a split second, a resounding *boom* echoes throughout the market. What had been a flawless ivory brick wall has now been impaled by Mydei's red crystal, cracks continuing to form from where the crystal was lodged so deeply that Phainon wonders just how much force Mydei used during the throw.

The wall crumbles and the crowd starts to panic after being stunned into silence. This time, even the gossip mongers knew that staying for the show was not worth it if they wanted to preserve their lives.

Phainon stares at the wall in shock. He turns to Mydei who looks rather pleased with himself despite the strife he had just caused.

“There,” Mydei muses, eyeing his work one last time before meeting Phainon’s gaze. “Now the inevitable you’re worried about is done.”

Phainon huffs in disbelief. It seems that *someone* is in dire need to be put in their place.

Extending his hand to the side, Phainon summons his greatsword. It is a welcome weight in his hand and it’s been a while since he last had it drawn while within the safety of Okhema’s borders for the threat was always coming from the outside.

Right now, there might be some semblance of truth to that.

“Destruction of public property warrants an arrest,” Phainon proclaims, readjusting his grip on his weapon before flinging it to the air, the tip of the blade just shy away from Mydei’s bare chest. “I’m going to have to bring you to justice, Your Highness.”

Mydei smirks. “I’m not opposed to that.”

How a mere tussle ends up being a full-blown fight, Phainon has no idea. As the citizens flee for cover, Phainon and Mydei utilize the Marmoreal Market as their arena, trading blows with a complete disregard to the surrounding structures.

“Someone stop them!”

“Send for Lady Aglaea!”

“My stall is *ruined!*”

Despite the panicked yells, the urge to stop never crosses Phainon’s mind as he drags the tip of his greatsword to the ground before launching it towards Mydei’s direction, clicking his tongue when he misses by a mere hairbreadth’s distance.

Mydei lets his amusement be known, leaping over a canopy before launching another attack —deadly sharp red crystals soaring the air, trailing after Phainon’s hasty steps with the fervent intent of subduing him.

“Tired, Deliverer?”

Phainon swipes at the red crystals with his greatsword, shielding his face from the broken shards. He turns to Mydei with a smirk of his own. “I’m just getting started.”

Mydei smiles, and Phainon is… caught off-guard.

Wow.

Kephale’s Dawn Device may shine light in all of Okhema. But right now, it is Mydei’s eyes of molten gold and a smile so brilliant that Phainon is able to exist in a world with two suns.

A red crystal soars towards him and Phainon barely manages to dodge, the whistle of air sharp and shrill against his ear as he still wraps his head around what he had just seen and

what he had just *thought*. His heart is pounding and he hopes that it is due to the exertion and not something else that's currently beyond reason.

The only way to get a hold of his senses is to wrap this fight up. They've already caused quite the mess around the market, more than Phainon could deem acceptable.

He leaps onto the canopy where Mydei is perched, the latter's eyes glinting with a certain liveliness. Phainon comes to realize that Mydei is enjoying this. Even if the same could be said for him, he had already allowed Mydei get away with a *lot*.

"Enough, Mydei."

Mydei's smile fades, almost carrying along with it Phainon's resolve to put an end to their 'conflict.' Phainon dismisses his greatsword, slivers of gold flickering as it disappears into thin air.

"You yield?" Mydei asks, arms crossed. The perplexity in his voice does not go unnoticed.

Phainon sighs. "Not necessarily."

"Then take out your weapon and we shall conclude this dispute once and for all."

A Kremnoan's bull-headedness would be one of the things that would truly drive Phainon mad one day. "The market is already a mess. We've inconvenienced the citizens far more than what is considered as justifiable."

"Caring about such trivialities," Mydei scoffs with a roll of his eyes. "Truly a Deliverer in every aspect."

Phainon frowns, taking a step forward. The canopy dips beneath his and Mydei's combined weight. "The comfort of the citizens is not a triviality. In Okhema, we—"

A sequence of snaps was heard as the ropes that tied the canopy to its poles finally gave in, unable to hold on any longer. The canopy falls through, enclosing both Phainon and Mydei into its heavy fabric like a cocoon as they fall to the ground in a lumpy pile of white cloth.

The squabble resumes, both Phainon and Mydei clawing at each other despite the current circumstance limiting their range of motions. Phainon feels something sharp graze his cheek as the sole of his boot makes contact with something hard and solid.

Their frantic movements caused the fabric to entangle even more upon them, until it encompasses them within a tight roll with only their heads out for display, bodies glued together from chest to foot.

Their faces are merely a breadth of a finger apart as they both regain their bearings after being under the heavy fabric for so long. The lack of oxygen must have affected their minds because how in Amphoreus do you even end up in a situation such as this?

Phainon's mind has a set of answers prepared, all of which evaporates into thin air the moment that Mydei *moves* against him in a futile struggle. Even if the rub of their bodies

against each other is purely incidental, Phainon is grasping at loose straws just to stop himself from relishing in the sensation.

He is simply a *man*.

Mydei mutters a curse under his breath in a language that sounded foreign. Phainon wishes that the other would just stop moving, internally reciting prayers and hymns for strength and restraint to all the Titans—corrupted or dead, it matters not. As long as They'll *listen*.

"Deliverer, are you—?"

Phainon closes his eyes. "Please. *Stop* moving—"

"I'm *trying* to get us out of here," Mydei snaps, evidently affronted by the request.

"You're doing a great job," Phainon replies sarcastically, voice strained beyond belief. "Now, I'd like you to stay still."

Mydei scoffs, puffs of air blowing against the sweaty skin of Phainon's neck as he continues to squirm most likely out of spite. "If you didn't come up on the canopy with me, this wouldn't have happened."

"Yes, yes. My fault and all."

A brush of a hand against his thigh, dangerously close to the current wellspring of his unbearable shame causes Phainon to inhale sharply. If Mydei's hand had been a tad bit higher, Phainon's humiliation would be set in stone.

"*Mydeimos*—"

Both of them tense when they hear the slow clack of heels against the ground. The Titans must have heard Phainon's prayers.

It is but a brief moment of reprieve. Phainon may be spared from enduring a lifetime of embarrassment due to his flawed nature of being born as a human male, the punishment for the destruction he'd caused today still remains to be a part of his fate.

In a flash, the Marmoreal Market becomes overtaken by threads of gold, making it seem as if both Phainon and Mydei are ensnared in a spider's web, helpless prey to a predator who now casts shadows as she looms upon them.

The two Chrysos Heirs look up slowly, *hesitantly*, and finds Aglaea gazing down at them. Even if her face rarely shows any distinct emotions, her displeasure is made known clearly with the downturn of her lips, a frown that conveys nothing but clear disappointment.

"Heroes," she says, voice silky smooth. Her calmness belies her displeasure. Something about the way she addressed them as such holds a certain weight, like a reminder of what he and Mydei's purpose are. "May I inquire as to what had transpired here?"

Knowing Aglaea, she probably already knew but simply wished to hear the answers from the people involved herself. Phainon shares a look with Mydei, a mix of terror and uncertainty.

They're so close that the scent of something inherently sweet invades Phainon's nostrils. Despite the sweat and the dust, Mydei smells like warm pastries and the sharpness of freshly harvested pomegranates. It's a stark contrast, one that Phainon realizes he can't seem to get enough of.

I'm screwed.

The situation is most unfortunate. Phainon thinks he's at a disadvantage here, especially when his mind makes the decision *against* his will of wanting to shoulder all the blame in favor of letting Mydei walk free from Aglaea's wrath.

Why? Because the man is a delight to his depraved nostrils, apparently. Phainon thinks a rigorous soul-searching is overdue.

Only, before he could even open his mouth to speak, Mydei had already beaten him to it.

"It was me," Mydei says. "I started it."

Phainon blanches. "I— What? No! *I* provoked you!"

Mydei narrows his eyes at him, wordlessly telling him to go along. "Aglaea and I had an agreement that I am not to cause trouble during my stay in Okhema."

The statement does sound believable enough. However—

"It is due to my shortcomings that I failed to apprehend you," Phainon shoots back, adamant to take the fall. "If I was a tad bit more competent, the mess would've no doubt been minimal."

Mydei doesn't give up. As expected of a Kremnoan. "*I* openly disregarded the law. You don't blame an authority for the crimes committed by a malefactor."

"You're not from Okhema—"

"I've been staying here for more than a month now."

Phainon exhales sharply. "It took me two years to memorize all the rules and regulations of this city. A month is barely enough time."

There's an unreadable expression on Mydei's face as he struggles to come up with something to snap back. Phainon thinks that he's won, only to realize that such things matter not when Aglaea clears her throat, reminding them of her presence.

"Heroes, there is no need to argue on who is to take the blame for all this," she says. "For it shall be the both of you who will be detained for three days in the dungeons."

Phainon and Mydei give each other a look. They expected their punishment to come in the form of something much more gruelling.

Aglaea makes a nondescript gesture with her hand and two Garmentmakers step forward. “Help them up.”

The Garmentmakers unroll the fabric of the canopy, freeing Phainon and Mydei from its bind. Phainon helps Mydei up before turning to Aglaea.

“You’ll only subject us to confinement?” he asks.

“Of course not,” Aglaea replies. “You will have no meals while you’re detained. Once you’re released, you are to clear the borders of Okhema of any roaming Titankin. This will last for another three days and you will only be provided a mere jug of water as sustenance. After that, you will spend the seventh day in your quarters to recuperate and hopefully, *reflect* on the troubles you’ve caused to the citizens.”

Mydei says nothing. Phainon feels guilt gnaw at him as he looks around the state of the Marmoreal Market. He wonders if people got hurt during the tussle.

“There are no casualties, Phainon,” Aglaea says, able to read his mind. “Despite your delay in awareness, you can rest assured.”

Phainon nods gingerly.

Aglaea continues, “If there are no objections, please follow me to your confinement cells.”

No conversations were made as Aglaea escorted them to the basement of the Marmoreal Palace where the dungeons are located, rows and rows of Garmentmakers trailing behind them like a makeshift army.

If Phainon and Mydei were to resist arrest, their odds of winning would be miniscule regardless of their combined strength. Not like they plan to anger Aglaea even more than they already have.

Two Garmentmakers open the cells facing each other. Aglaea gestures for Phainon and Mydei to get in, both of them choosing a cell of their own.

“Someone will come fetch you in three days’ time,” Aglaea tells them as the Garmentmakers ensure the locks on the cells are secure. “Now then, heroes, I shall take my leave.”

Phainon waves at her retreating figure while Mydei simply crosses his arms and manages a grunt.

Finding a comfortable spot in the cramped and uncomfortable cell, Phainon settles for resting his back against the wall where he could get a good look at his trouble-making companion. He makes sure that Aglaea and her terrifying minions have completely left the dungeons before attempting conversation.

“Are you good at chess?”

Mydei furrows his eyebrows, also leaning against the wall. It's a shame that the iron bars enclosing their cells are significantly thick enough to relatively hinder Phainon's vision of the prince.

"Has it not occurred to you that we are being punished?" Mydei asks, deep voice reverberating all throughout the stone walls and floors.

Phainon shoots him a smile. He's not sure if Mydei can see him any better than he does Mydei. "It has, and there's nothing I can do about it. So, chess?"

Mydei shakes his head in disbelief. Nevertheless, he still indulges Phainon in his whims. "A close friend of mine liked to play. Some nights by the campfire in between campaigns, he would call upon me to have a match with him so he could practice the techniques he's read about in his books."

Phainon can't help but notice that the other's tone has significantly mellowed down compared to how he usually speaks. It must have been a really close friend of Mydei's to warrant such a tone that thinly belies a hint of fondness.

"I know of the rules enough that you won't be able to deceive me like you did so earlier," Mydei finishes.

Now that he's addressing Phainon, the sharp edges have returned and the walls are put up, traces of vulnerability hidden and out of sight.

"To be fair, I really did forget about melding being optional," Phainon explains earnestly. Despite his teasing, he really did intend to play fair. "When I saw you in the market, my eagerness to have you partake in a game of koum-kan with me must have overtaken my senses."

"You don't say," Mydei drawls, sarcasm coating his words thickly.

Phainon presses on. "Let's have a game of chess once we get out of here— I mean, when our punishment has run its course. I'm pretty good! I was once known as the chess grandmaster back in my hometown."

Mydei doesn't respond to his offer right away and Phainon feels the unwelcome sensation of uncertainty beginning to crawl upon his skin.

Phainon, you are an embarrassment.

In the hopes of trying to convince Mydei, he successfully managed to make himself appear ostentatious. If he assumed that Mydei had harbored a poor opinion of him before, then it's most likely the definitive truth now. From poor to abysmal, no doubt.

A sigh can be heard from Mydei's cell. "I dislike foul tactics," Mydei says to a Phainon that's been tense from head to toe, barely breathing. "I will partake in trivial games with you as long as you keep your honor and play fair."

Phainon cannot believe his ears. “Of course! Allow me to take this moment to apologize for not admitting to my mistake earlier.”

“It’s fine. In turn, I’d like to apologize for creating a… mess.” Phainon sees Mydei shift uncomfortably in his cell, the crimson fabric of his garb a stark contrast against the gray of stone. “You seemed really distressed when Aglaea was scolding us.”

“It’s the lack of scolding that makes me uneasy,” Phainon points out. “And I seemed to find you enjoying yourself when creating such messes.”

Mydei’s smile that was as radiant as Kephale’s Dawn would forever live in Phainon’s memory. When he finds himself obscured in darkness, no fear would ensnare him for he’ll be carrying a piece of light with him until the end of the times.

“I’ve never had an equal in battle,” Mydei tells him. “Even if what we did was far from being an all-out fight, you held your own splendidly well against me.”

“Is that a compliment, Your Highness?” Phainon teases, unable to stop himself. No one must know how the feeling of warmth seeps into him like a gentle caress. “To be considered as your equal is nothing but an honor. Especially when it’s coming from the crown prince of *Kremnos* himself.”

Mydei scoffs. “Don’t let it get to your head, Deliverer.”

“It’s already embedded in the deepest crevices of my mind,” Phainon says, smiling so hard his cheeks are beginning to hurt. He can’t seem to remember a time since arriving in Okhema where he was this giddy.

“Think however you want of it,” Mydei says, an obvious dismissal. He clears his throat. “If you’re amenable, I’d like to engage you in a spar from time to time.”

Phainon pretends to think about it. He fails spectacularly. “Absolutely. Let me know when it suits you. I’ll make sure to free up my schedule then.”

“Setting aside your Deliverer duties in favor of heeding my call?” Mydei muses. “There is no need to go leaps and bounds for me, Deliverer. I can take a no for an answer in the event that you’re unavailable.”

Most people would think Phainon to be somewhat thick-faced. Phainon thinks so, too. He wonders when the exact moment it was that shame has departed his body without so much as looking back. Mydei must think him pathetic for implying that he’s willing to drop anything for him.

“I apologize,” Phainon says in an attempt to salvage his pride. “It’s simply because I, too, have found myself unsuccessful when it comes to finding a suitable sparring partner. I admit, it has hindered my progress on improving my abilities in battle. You’ll have to forgive me for appearing so eager.”

It's quiet in Mydei's cell after that. Phainon assumes that he must have offended the other in some way once again seeing as how it comes so naturally for him to do so. Pondering his words, he wonders when exactly had Mydei seen him as an equal despite their clear differences in almost everything. Perhaps the only thing they have in common is combat prowess.

"There is no need for apologies," comes Mydei's voice after quite some time that Phainon almost forgot their conversation had halted prematurely. "In fact, I should thank you for being so willing. As a Kremnoan, my honor shall see to it that your efforts to accommodate me are repaid."

Phainon blinks, perplexed, catching a glimpse of a searing golden gaze behind the iron bars ahead of him. "I— Really, Mydei. You said it yourself that we're equals. I would assume that formalities are not necessary. No need for all that 'repayment' fuss."

A deliberately audible sigh. "If that is your preference, Deliverer."

"It is," Phainon confirms.

"Okay."

"Great."

"I'd like some peace and quiet now," Mydei says, an implication for Phainon to keep his mouth shut most likely.

Phainon does so out of gratitude for Mydei's surprisingly generous indulgence of his whims. Mydei's peace and quiet, however, does not last for as long as Phainon had predicted it.

"Do you know of a game we can play during our stay here?" Mydei asks after what had seemed to be half a quint. "I'm beginning to feel rather dull."

Phainon allows himself to smile, wondering if Mydei could see his glee from within his own cell. "I thought you'd never ask."

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The Coin of Whimsy's mercurial nature is felt even more so than usual in everyone's day-to-day livelihood during the Month of Fortune. Gamblers are aflock, thieves run rampant, a rich merchant goes bankrupt, and a humble shoe cleaner stumbles upon a sack of gold on his doorstep.

It is as good a day as any to test one's luck, and Phainon is no exception to thinking the same.

Only a day after their one-week punishment, Phainon and Mydei once again find themselves in the Marmoreal Market, flipping coins and betting on heads or tails. Established equals they

may be, luck is not something that favors balance.

The coin lands on heads. The crowd claps amicably, trading bets amongst themselves for the next round, eager and excited.

Only one person does not share the sentiment.

“I can’t believe this,” Mydei groans, eyeing the coin with pure loathing like it had just managed to offend his entire ancestry.

Phainon counts a hundred drachmae’s worth of balance coins with a victorious grin on his face before shoving it into his money pouch that weighs significantly heavier than when he arrived at the market. He throws a wink at Mydei’s direction who reciprocates with a scowl of his own.

“Thank you for your generosity, kind prince,” Phainon simpers. “In honor of your ten-in-a-row loss for betting on tails, I shall let you bet on heads in the next round.”

Mydei scoffs. Thankfully, he doesn’t destroy a table this time. “Enough of this. You’ve wrung me dry, Deliverer.”

“Giving up already?” Phainon teases, unable to help himself. “A bit unusual of you, I must say.”

Their seven days of punishment together had somehow made them even closer. Only slightly, of course, considering Mydei’s aversion to friendliness and his nature of being notoriously downright hard to get along with. Nevertheless, it’s still a progress that Phainon thinks is worthy of recognition for it’s no easy feat to gain a Kremnoan’s trust.

“This is not surrender,” Mydei reiterates with his arms crossed and nose up high, exuding what Phainon would call the ‘air of a royal who finds himself above luck-based circumstances just because he’s lost consecutively.’ “I simply know where my limits lie.”

Phainon laughs at the lame excuse but doesn’t argue. It was not his intent to impoverish the crown prince of Kremnos. But seeing Mydei’s scrunched face, handsome despite the grimace, Phainon realizes that the joy in flipping coins did not stem from his victories alone.

“Alright,” he tells Mydei. “We can stop here.”

While the crowd bids their goodbye to them, Phainon takes the chance whilst Mydei is distracted to swap their money pouches in a manner that could rival the “Spirithief” Bartholos’ finesse.

Most of the balance coins in Phainon’s money pouch belonged to Mydei anyway. Phainon is simply returning what belongs to it’s original owner.

Zagreus might frown upon him for doing such a noble act, specifically during the Month of Fortune even. But Phainon values Mydei’s friendship more than the highly sought-after, fleeting favor of a Titan.

As they walk around the stalls, blatantly ignoring any calls for more entertainment, Phainon realizes that neither he nor Mydei had eaten any meals for the day, too caught up in their game of coin toss to even bother with sustenance.

Seeing as they're about to pass by the Marmoreal Diner, Phainon turns to Mydei and asks, "Should we grab something to eat—?"

"My lords!"

Both Phainon and Mydei stop in their tracks. To their side, a man in purple carrying a stone tablet bigger than his torso rushes over to them.

"Good day," Phainon says in greeting, a smile on his lips like a habit.

"Did you need something?" Mydei asks, tone clipped. What a charmer.

The man in purple beams upon being acknowledged by the two Chrysos Heirs. "Pardon me for interrupting your stroll, my lords. My name is Dolius." He manages a light bow, a hand on his chest to convey sincerity. "I can't help but notice that my lords seem to take quite the penchant for betting games."

Mydei huffs, clearly offended. "Do not perceive me as such. I hardly know you."

Sensing a volcano on the verge of eruption, Phainon makes a move to step in before poor Dolius is subjected to the explosive wrath of a roaring lion.

"We don't usually engage in such activities," Phainon explains lightly. "It's simply because it's the last day of the Month of Fortune that we thought it appropriate to partake in various entertainments."

"I see." Dolius nods slowly, seemingly pondering something before he brightens up again. "If my lords can spare the time, there's a feast being held by the followers of Zagreus to celebrate the one extra day of the month!"

Phainon had been so caught up with his punishment that he didn't realize Zagreus had bestowed upon them a Scarlet Month for this year.

"A feast hosted by tricksters?" Mydei clicks his tongue. "Consider me uninterested."

Phainon sighs. "Mydei, that's mean."

"It is simply the truth," Mydei shoots back.

Before Phainon could retort about how some opinions must not be said if they convey nothing but negativity, Dolius raises the stone tablet higher in favor of regaining their attention.

"The Feast of the Scarlet Month commences on the first quint of the Curtain-Fall Hour," Dolius tells them, uncaring of the tension in between the two Chrysos Heirs in front of him. Phainon commends the dedication to promote his cause. "Look here, this is the address."

Phainon and Mydei peer closely at the stone tablet, guided by the tip of Dolius' finger. The address is engraved in fine inscription beneath the huge and bold letters that read,

EVERYONE IS INVITED! DRINK AND GAMBLE TO YOUR HEART'S CONTENT! ALL HAIL ZAGREUS!

Mydei scrunches his nose in distaste. "I don't drink. And why does it start so late?"

Phainon eyes the address. "I'm familiar with the area…"

"Deliverer, you can't possibly be considering the idea of going."

"Why not? It's a leap day," Phainon reasons. "We should savor this one extra day Zagreus gave us. Who knows, come next year, this month might end up a day short." He turns to Dolius. "We'll be there."

Mydei is unable to contain his shock. "*We?*"

Phainon raises an eyebrow. "Not up for a challenge?"

"We do have drinking games prepared, my lords," Dolius pipes in.

"And there you go," Phainon says, nodding favorably at Dolius' direction. "I'm also not an avid drinker myself, you know. Not to mention, I do believe that you haven't had a taste of Okhema-brewn liquor just yet."

Mydei frowns. "The only reason as to why that is so is because I have no interest in sampling alcohol."

Phainon rethinks his tactics. "Then, consider attending for the sake of making friends."

His tactics fail, as it always does considering that Mydei is simply an impenetrable wall of rigid principles.

"They are followers of *Zagreus*," Mydei points out, affronted. "The foundations of forming amicable relationships are built from trust. Deliverer, you can't possibly think I can make *friends* with the likes of *them*."

At least he tried.

Phainon turns his attention back at Dolius who, thankfully, doesn't seem at all offended by Mydei's words. In fact, he looked quite intrigued by the exchange.

"Well," Phainon starts. "Regardless of your opinion, I'm still going."

Dolius smiles brightly, all crooked teeth and crinkled eye corners.

"You'll regret it," Mydei says.

"Won't know until I get there," Phainon shoots back with a shrug.

Mydei leaves him to fend for himself after that, angrily muttering something about Phainon 'spending time with his new untrustworthy *friends*.' Phainon leaves him be, no use chasing after an aggravated Mydei (he did this once and decided that not doing so yielded better results).

The theory is proven right once again when the Curtain-Fall Hour arrives and a knock lands on Phainon's door just as he was about to leave for the Feast of the Scarlet Month.

When he flings the door open, a disgruntled Mydei greets his sights.

Phainon smiles. "Change of heart?"

"By the end of this nonsense, you'll realize that I'm right," Mydei replies vindictively.

When they both arrive at the address of the feast—a tavern located near the outskirts of the city—all the attendees cheer with joy at the appearance of two Chrysos Heirs.

"The heroes have come!"

"Lord Mydei, is it true that you drink blood?"

"By Kephale's mercy, it's indeed Lord Phainon!"

While Mydei stews in his discomfort at being hounded by a crowd of admirers, it is Phainon who does the difficult role of entertaining the lot of them with rehearsed pleasantries and smiles that do not quite reach his eyes.

"My lords!" a familiar voice calls out. Dolius emerges from the crowd after a moment's struggle. "It's truly a joy for my lords to have honored this humble one's invitation. Praise be to Zagreus for this luck!"

Mydei rolls his eyes. "I'd rather eat my own fist than praise the embodiment of Trickery."

"I apologize on his behalf," Phainon says after a light elbow on Mydei's ribs. "So, drinks?"

At the question, Phainon and Mydei are immediately led to a vast table filled with rows and rows of cups containing clear, amber liquid. The stench of alcohol fills the air and it admittedly makes Phainon feel a bit nauseous despite having yet to partake in a drink.

"This is the main event of the feast," Dolius explains. "The one who finishes the most drinks gets to win ten thousand balance coins!"

The crowd goes wild at the proclamation, eagerly conversing amongst themselves and making bets on who is to take home the grand prize by the end of the feast.

Phainon turns to Mydei. "Hear that, Mydei? You can win back what you've lost earlier today."

Mydei scoffs. "You assume that I am not aware of you swapping our money pouches, Deliverer. Did you really think I wouldn't discover your schemes?"

Phainon opts to keep his mouth shut. Dolius is more than happy to occupy the silence.

“The drinks served here are the finest liquor natively brewed in Okhema,” Dolius continues. “It has also been infused with Phagousa’s blessings. With Zagreus bestowing luck upon the Scarlet Month, the odds of winning are at an all time high.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “From what I remember, drinking in excess is not something the Chalice of Plenty holds favor to. You speak of Their blessings when it is evident that your words are nothing but falsehoods. Dishonorable man, your lies have no effect against me.”

Phainon already feels a headache coming. He attempts to divert the topic to something else. “Dolius, has anyone accepted this… drinking game you speak of?”

“Not yet, my lord. Everyone was hoping that you would do the honors.”

The crowds await Phainon’s move with eager anticipation. Even Mydei’s golden gaze now flickered with interest despite his initial reservations.

Phainon sighs. He takes one cup, schooling his expression as he brings the rim to his lips before downing the entire drink in one go. The crowd cheers his name, a bard bursts into song, and Phainon already feels the kick of the alcohol just moments after the liquid has completely gone down his throat.

A cough makes its way past his lips, the burn of the liquor is something that Phainon is not used to. Thankfully, everyone seems to be caught up in their merriment to even notice.

All except one.

Mydei shakes his head. “This is ridiculous.”

“You forfeit?” Phainon asks, voice rough around the edges. It is a struggle to speak.

“I haven’t even agreed to going against you,” Mydei says.

Phainon takes another cup. “Shame.”

When he coughs after a rather painful and searing gulp, Mydei finally makes his amusement known, the corner of his lip curled upward in a barely there smirk.

“You know not of the ways on how to drink, Deliverer.”

Phainon attempts a laugh and regrets it immediately. His throat stings and he feels himself slowly going dizzy despite only having consumed two servings.

“I remember saying that I am not an avid drinker,” he tells Mydei. “Your Highness, if you’re amenable to do a demonstration, this amateur would be very grateful.”

Mydei’s eyebrows twitch, a telltale sign that he’s about to bite into the bait Phainon has cast. He walks towards the table, eyeing the cups with growing trepidation. Before he could grab one, however, he was stopped by Dolius’ hand on his arm.

“I forgot to tell my lords the rules of the game,” he says sheepishly before retreating his hand away after being subjected by Mydei’s sharp glower.

Mydei turns to Phainon. “You share your forgetfulness with this man, Deliverer. Or is it simply because you prefer announcing the rules *after* the game has commenced?”

“I prefer no such thing,” Phainon dismisses. “Dolius, if you please.”

Dolius nods. “Once you drink, you are to continue without pause. Spilling is prohibited. So, too, is making a mess. That includes regurgitation among others.”

“Reasonable,” Phainon says, feeling himself grow faint. The announcement of the rules just made the situation all the more real. “Mydei?”

Mydei responds by taking a cup and downing his drink in one sweeping motion. To his credit, he doesn’t cough like Phainon did, able to maintain his composure with ease.

Only, under close scrutiny, Phainon can see the furrow in Mydei’s eyebrows and the grimace on his lips. Mydei looks like he’s about to flip the entire table upside down and set fire to the tavern.

Seeing that Mydei has finally joined the game, the crowd erupts into applause.

“Who do you think will win?”

“Lord Mydei, for sure! I heard Kremnoans drink the blood of their victims. Fine liquor such as this is nothing to him!”

“I place my bets on Lord Phainon. He looks capable of holding his liquor.”

Phainon drowns out the noise in favor of observing Mydei as the latter picks up another cup from the table.

“I take it this is you accepting the challenge?” Phainon asks, a teasing smile on his lips. He can’t believe he actually managed to get Mydei to drink.

Mydei brings the rim of the cup close to his lips, shooting Phainon a questioning look. “Do my actions convey anything else?”

“You’re on, then.”

“Sure, Deliverer.”

A quint or more passes. Phainon has admittedly lost count of all the cups he’s managed to drink, and along with that, was his sense of reason and time.

All he remembers are sharp eyes of gold, a heavy head on his shoulder, and the familiar scent of pomegranates and something inherently sweet interlaced with a bit of spice.

Strands of blonde hair tickle the side of Phainon's face as he struggles to maintain his balance —on his hunches with both of his hands gripping the edge of the table. Beside him, Mydei is in no better shape either, leaning against Phainon on the floor, blinking slowly and staring at nothing in particular with a face almost as red as the fabric of his garments and the marks that streaked across his exposed skin.

The world is spinning, there's an acrid taste in his mouth, and Phainon thinks he's on the verge of passing out. The noise in the tavern only worsens Phainon's dizzying condition. What he would give for some peace and quiet.

"Deliverer," comes a murmur beside him.

The sound of Mydei's voice sobers Phainon up for just a little bit. "Are you okay?"

A sigh, softer than expected. "I'm thirsty."

Phainon laughs. He should've known that Mydei wouldn't back down so easily. It's a shame that Phainon has to admit defeat this time.

Nevertheless, it's comforting to know that neither of them managed to hold their liquor very well—like they had just formed some sort of an unspoken consensus that alcohol is not something to be trifled with so casually.

"Drink one more cup and it'll be your victory," Phainon tells Mydei, words slurring as he struggles to maintain consciousness.

Mydei shakes his head, more strands of blonde hair caress Phainon's cheek at the action. Phainon finds that he doesn't mind this at all.

"Not liquor," Mydei says, barely intelligible as buries his face onto Phainon's shoulder. "I want water."

When he feels Mydei's weight against him grow heavier, Phainon deduces that it's time to take their leave. With great difficulty, he manages to scour the crowd for any signs of Dolius while supporting a half-conscious Mydei.

It probably took almost half a quint for Phainon and Mydei to bid goodbye to the followers of Zagreus with as much dignity as two men drunk out of their minds could possibly muster.

Phainon can't even remember the reason why he participated in a drinking game and roping Mydei along with his whims. A cup is more than enough for Phainon to lose his senses, participating in drinking games should have been out of the question for someone like him.

The streets of Okhema are thankfully deserted. Perhaps it had been a good idea after all to host such a feast in the late hours or else everyone would be able to witness two drunk Chrysos Heirs navigate their way with dragging footsteps, nonsensically mumbling words into the air.

"I told you it's ridiculous to have come," Mydei chastises. How he's able to maintain the signature agitation in his tone, Phainon has no idea. "Now look at us, no better than the

drunken bards who make a fool of themselves."

"I'm afraid I'm having trouble trying to spot a mirror in the area to examine our current countenance and confirm your outrageous claims," Phainon tells him sincerely.

Mydei grunts. "We should procure one."

"Have you got any money on you?"

"No. My money pouch was stolen by those followers of Zagreus while we were in the middle of our drinking game."

They both stop in their tracks. Phainon's grip on Mydei's arm slung around his neck loosens out of shock, but not enough to release lest the poor prince loses his balance. Not like he had any in the first place for Phainon's been supporting most of his weight this whole time.

Phainon tries to meet Mydei's gaze, leaning down. "Mydei, you got robbed?"

Mydei nods slowly, head hanging low. "Yes."

"And you didn't say a thing?"

"I met eyes with the thief while he was in the process of the heist."

Phainon could not believe his ears. "And you did nothing? *You*, of all people, let the thief slip away free?"

"Of course I didn't," Mydei retorts with an aggrieved scowl. "I told him that his face will be forever engraved in my memory until the end of times, and I will hunt him down when I'm in my peak condition."

That sounds reassuring. It would've been far more convincing if Mydei didn't speak as if he's simply commenting on the weather instead of swearing vengeance.

"What did he look like?"

"I can't remember," Mydei answers casually. "I'm drunk."

Phainon didn't know whether to laugh or cry. There had to be at least a worth of ten thousand balance coins in Mydei's (formerly Phainon's) money pouch. And now it's gone.

Sober Mydei would scour Okhema upside down until he finds the offender. Drunk Mydei, on the other hand, simply lays limp against Phainon's side, talking as if being robbed of what most would consider a small fortune is nothing out of the ordinary.

"How much did you drink?"

Mydei is quiet for a moment. "I lost count."

All the alcohol in Phainon's system seemed to evaporate after this turn of events, rendering him sober.

He then ceases all talks of money just in case Mydei blinks away the haze of alcohol and remembers how he was wronged by a follower of Zagreus. Not exactly unexpected, but it was Phainon's idea to attend the feast so by extension, the blame is his to share.

By Janus' guidance, they were able to arrive at the entrance to the Marmoreal Palace, which was the only way they could reach the quarters dedicated to the Chrysos Heirs.

Upon seeing the pools of glistening water, Mydei peels himself away from Phainon's hold before making his way towards the floating platform that led to the Heroes' Baths. Phainon follows suit, confused out of his own mind.

Before Phainon could ask what Mydei was planning, the latter had already dunked his whole head into one of the pools swirling with golden waters.

Bewildered at the action, Phainon approaches, feeling silly at the sight. He debates whether or not he should take a picture, but then he realizes that Mydei hasn't risen for air once and almost has a full-blown panic attack.

Phainon pulls Mydei back by the nape, almost collapsing in relief when he sees Mydei's eyes blink languidly at him. He looks fine for the most part. Dazed, but *fine*.

"What were you thinking?" Phainon admonishes, feeling like a mother who had just discovered her son eating dirt. "Were you trying to drown yourself dead?"

"I can't die," was Mydei's response.

Phainon scoffs. "Way too confident for someone who's too drunk to function."

"I'm thirsty."

"And you thought that it's a brilliant idea to drink from the bath?" Phainon says, trying his hardest to keep a straight face.

Mydei says nothing. Phainon does not push the matter further, hoisting Mydei upright before laying him down on the floor, far away from any bodies of water that Mydei could use to endanger his life.

"Would you like some moment of reprieve before I carry you to your chambers?" Phainon asks, wiping Mydei's drenched face with his sleeve, brushing away any strands of hair that stuck to the skin.

He can already hear Mydei's aggrieved response of, *How dare you suggest such a crass way of transporting me!*

"I'm perfectly fine where I am," Mydei replies, eyes closed.

Phainon stares. "On the floor?"

“Yes.” Mydei confirms this with three firm nods.

“Mydei, you can’t sleep in this place.”

“I’m not. Join me down here.”

“I beg your pardon?”

Mydei huffs, exasperated, opening his eyes to throw Phainon a look that said ‘enough with the questions,’ before closing them once again. “Do as I say for once.”

Despite his befuddlement, Phainon lays down beside Mydei with his back on the floor, gazing up at the refined craftsmanship of the Marmoreal Palace’s grand ceiling.

“This is the first time I’ve felt like this,” Mydei tells him, unprompted.

Phainon tries not to place too much attention on the softness of Mydei’s voice. It is uncharacteristic, for Mydei always spoke so unambiguously in Phainon's presence—leaving no room for neither gentleness nor hesitation.

“You mean, you’ve never been drunk before?”

Mydei nods beside him. “This state of mind leaves me vulnerable.”

Phainon would like to agree wholeheartedly given that Mydei is ten thousand balance coins poorer and the thief remains to be unapprehended.

“Did you not have a good time?”

“The battlefield is the only place that caters to my enjoyment.”

Spoken like a true Kremnoan. Phainon can’t help but laugh. “You didn’t have fun even for just a little bit?”

Mydei ponders the question this time, long enough for Phainon to assume that the other has fallen asleep. Thankfully, it was not the case.

“Seeing you struggle downing a drink has contributed greatly to my amusement,” Mydei shares, a hint of a smile on his lips. “Perhaps I did enjoy myself after all.”

“At the expense of my misery, looks like.”

“Well, it was *your* idea to participate in a drinking game.” Mydei sighs. “I never had time for merriments such as these before I met you, Deliverer. I’m beginning to think that you’re fulfilling the role of a bad influence.”

Phainon turns to the side, disgruntled at the accusation. “You think being happy is a bad thing?”

“Such follies and nonsense divert me from my goals.”

“Has no one ever told you that being so adamant to remain miserable is never of benefit to one’s state of mind?”

Mydei was quiet. “A will lost to time had once wished for my happiness.”

Perhaps it was the inebriation. This time, Phainon lets curiosity take the reins. “Of whose?”

“My mother’s,” Mydei answers.

Phainon blinks, the statement catching him off-guard. Cautiously, he says, “She seems like a caring woman.”

“Perhaps,” Mydei says. “Even so, her tender disposition never made her any less of a warrior.”

“I never would’ve assumed as such, seeing as how her son managed to become a formidable man.”

A sober Mydei would call him out for such a blatant compliment, regarding it as an unrefined method of gaining his favor. A drunk Mydei, on the other hand, chooses to remain in contemplative silence, as if Phainon’s words hadn’t registered at all.

“My memories of my mother are little to none, and the rare dreams I have of her serve as our only connection,” Mydei says after a while. “I’ve only heard tales of her from my teacher, and he made it seem as if I was there myself witnessing all those great deeds of hers.”

“You sound like you miss her.”

Mydei huffs. “One cannot simply miss what was never there in the first place. The image of her in my mind was not one born out of knowing her myself, but of other people’s opinions of her. She sounds more like an idolized figure than a mother to me.”

“But your estrangement didn’t stop you from wanting to know more about her,” Phainon says. “You shouldn’t discount her affectionate will wishing you happiness just because you barely knew her.”

Mydei goes quiet. Phainon thinks that perhaps he might’ve pushed it too far, an apology ready at the tip of his tongue—

“Happiness hardly comes easy for someone like me,” Mydei tells him. It makes Phainon feel worse than before. “But hearing you convey your opinions regarding this matter, the fog that clouded my mind has somewhat dissipated.”

Phainon’s emotions are currently moving in between two ends of a spectrum. Just moments before, he’d been on the verge of an admonishing self-reflection, and yet now, simple words from Mydei has him almost melting into a puddle out of sheer relief.

“I’m happy to have helped with that,” Phainon says lamely.

Mydei hums, painfully unaware of Phainon's inner turmoil. "If my mother was still alive, I have no doubts that she would have favored you immensely."

It is known all across Amphoreus that Mydei can strike down any foe with his might. Right now, he strikes Phainon down with his words.

All coherent thoughts in Phainon's mind vanishes pitifully without a trace upon hearing the statement uttered. To say such a thing should not be allowed.

Phainon feels his heart thud erratically within his chest. The words of a drunk man should never be of consequence. But if it's Mydei, Phainon can't help but make an exception out of selfish indulgence.

If Phainon's sense of hearing were to be taken tomorrow, he would have nary a regret for Mydei's words are enough to keep him company in a lifetime of silence.

"I'm honored that you think of me so highly, Mydei," Phainon says, unable to stop himself from touching the end of the golden cuff that kept Mydei's braid in place. The sight of it never fails to draw Phainon's attention. "How could I ever manage to convey my sincerest gratitude?"

Mydei huffs, seemingly amused at the question. It's fortunate that his eyes remain closed or else Phainon would have trouble schooling his expression to appear more dignified despite his crumbling demeanor.

"You never fail to ask the stupidest of questions, Phainon."

Phainon has forgotten to breathe. Perhaps his sobriety had been an illusion all this time because there is no way that this conversation is real.

"You said my name," he tells Mydei.

"It seems I have."

"It sounds nice. I like your voice."

"Thank you, Deliverer."

Phainon laughs. "You are going to hate me when you wake up tomorrow."

Mydei doesn't respond after that, and Phainon is left to ponder the intricacies of their exchange in silence, until his own consciousness fades away.

The loud chatter that echoes incessantly is what wakes Phainon up from his dreamless sleep. When he opens his eyes, he almost passes out from shock when he realizes that his head is right at the edge of the platform that housed the Heroes' Baths.

The sight of the Nerid Spring below is already aflock with activity—musicians livening the atmosphere, citizens engaged in productive discourse, and some leisurely others simply basking in the pleasure of being submerged in the waters blessed by Phagousa.

Phainon finds it all nauseating due to the height from where he is situated. But before he could move away from his perilous position, he finds his back colliding with something heavy and solid.

Mydei is passed out cold behind him, handsome face squished on the floor. Far from being princely-like, in Phainon's modest opinion. He takes out his teleslate and snaps a picture.

The sound is loud enough to cause Mydei to stir in his sleep, aggravated by the loud *click* of his picture being taken without his knowledge. He blinks slowly, eyes of gold landing on Phainon.

"Good morning," Phainon greets with a wince when he feels his head throb.

Mydei doesn't respond right away. Perhaps he's trying to get around the concept of what morning is and what's so good about it. Or maybe he's wondering how he'd ended up sleeping on the floor of the Heroes' Baths.

"What time is it?" he asks Phainon after the prolonged pause.

"It's the third quint of the Action Hour," a smooth voice answers behind them.

Both Phainon and Mydei jolt, scampering to sit up and make themselves presentable. Phainon feels as if his head is about to split open while Mydei kept muttering curses in Kremnoan while he tries to smoothen his hair out.

Looking up, Aglaea's imposing frame lords over them. The sight gives Phainon a strong sense of déjà vu mixed with a subtle fear that stems purely from his survival instincts.

Aglaea regards the two Chrysos Heirs with a blank expression. She looked as if she had something to say but decided against it at the last minute.

"Heroes, I apologize for cutting your merriment short for I have received some dire news," Aglaea tells them.

Phainon struggles to follow what she's saying while Mydei has simply given up. The latter is not even trying to *conceal* that his mind is elsewhere, blankly staring at a plant some ways away like he's marvelling at the manner the verdant leaves drooped, or the sturdiness of it's stem.

Aglaea continues without mercy, "Some disciples of Janus wishes to perform a ritual welcoming the Month of Gate at the ruins of the Abyss of Fate. I'm asking you to conduct a rescue operation. Please, bring them back safely to Okhema."

Both Phainon and Mydei nod like it's a habit—an accustomed response for every single one of Aglaea's orders.

“It seems that you have understood clearly,” Aglaea says.

Phainon would beg to differ, but he doubts he has enough eloquence to debate his stance against Aglaea while sporting a dreadful hangover.

“Three dromases will be prepared for you by Lady Tribbie. She will accompany you to the Abyss and help you with this mission,” Aglaea concludes when it was clear that there were no objections. “I wish you the best of luck, heroes.”

She leaves both Phainon and Mydei on the floor. Phainon rubs his aching temple with his fingers, finding the action to be futile.

“What did she say again?” he asks Mydei beside him, who currently has his head buried in his hands.

Mydei’s response comes out muffled. “...something about disciples.”

Phainon frowns, inherently dizzy. “Disciples? That’s…”

Light and hurried footsteps approach and neither Phainon nor Mydei are ready for a sudden attack. Phainon barely registers the sight of Trianne when she exclaims at a *very* loud voice—

“De! Snowy! Agy said you should eat something before you leave!”

The pained groans of two Chrysos Heirs could be heard. Two men thrice the size of a small child, rendered unquestionably defeated by such cheerful delivery of words. It should be considered as the humiliation of the era.

Trianne eyes them with confusion. “What’s wrong? De, Snowy, are you okay?”

Mydei is bent over the marble floor in complete agony, clutching his head out of desperation as he mutters, “Is this it? Has the Hand of Shadow come to fetch me at long last?”

Phainon, on the other hand, crawls over the edge of the platform. “Pardon me, Lady Trianne. I think I’m going to be sick—”

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My beloved child,

The song of slaughter might sing in your veins as it had in generations past, but let this not hinder you as you carve a new path for yourself.

As I await for your arrival in this world, I so earnestly wish for you to ***be merry in your youth. Make good memories and bask in the pleasure of remembrance. Form bonds, find your equal as I have done, make allies and protect each other in the face of death.***

When the time comes for your rightful ascension to the throne, I hope you'll keep these ramblings of your dear mother in mind.

— words found in a worn stone tablet that's been discarded in the deserted halls of Kremnos' inner city, written by unknown

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Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for reading!! i hope you liked this chapter <3 phaidei are truly such natural clowns. (my queen aglaea is so fucking tired of them and honestly? i understand)

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

all your kudos and comments are super duper appreciated :D thank you so very much for them <3

Chapter 3: as death looms, sorrowful tears glisten

Chapter Summary

> Sail the Sea of Souls with no way of turning back, for Death is a destination where the prospect of return is out of the question. This applies to every living being. All, except one.

Chapter Notes

▶ ⚠️ **click for chapter warnings** (contains spoilers)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

fate season, month of gate

8 months before the present time

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...the Sea of Souls have rejected me. My father has succumbed to his own selfishness, and our Titan is now on the brink of madness…

...I have met with exiles from my land of birth. They speak of my mother with profound admiration. As of this moment, she is nothing more than a stranger to me…

...they said she wept for my fate, pleaded for my life until her dying breaths at the hands of her husband whom she considered her equal. My father's betrayal led to her demise…

*...**the tears from my mother's love fuels me, I shall make everything right once more**.*

— words etched in scraps of paper with dates of entry spanning years, written by unknown; the author depicts a lack of mastery in using the Kremnoan alphabet

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"The ritual is going to be performed in three different locations, each commemorating the Titans of Fate," Tribbie says, her small finger pointing at three spots in the map consecutively. "We're going to have to split up to be able to find all the disciples quickly."

Phainon nods absentmindedly. “I see.”

The map of the Abyss of Fate may appear simple, significantly reduced in size from its former glory after the invasion of the Black Tide. But that doesn’t mean the puzzles scattered around the ruins are sparse in nature. Beside Phainon, Mydei sports the same pinched expression as he frowns at the map. There’s no doubt that he also harbors the same sentiments.

Tribbie seems to see through both of them, able to read their perturbation. She smiles. “Don’t worry, the puzzles you two will come across aren’t that complicated to solve. At least, you wouldn’t need our help to get past them.”

Both Phainon and Mydei let out sighs of relief. Neither of them are really that gifted to wield the power of Oronyx’s Miracle.

“Just to be clear, our tasks are to reach the site of the ritual assigned to each of us, get the disciples, and rendezvous back here,” Mydei clarifies.

Tribbie nods. “Yup.”

“Is the ritual going to be a problem?” Phainon asks. “I have no intentions of indirectly offending the Fate Titans.”

At the statement, Mydei snorts pointedly. If he speaks of Phainon’s recurring habit of committing blasphemy against the Titans in front of Tribbie, Phainon is going to have to throw him off a cliff in order to keep his misdeeds a secret from the Holy Maiden.

Thankfully, Mydei merely throws a smirk at Phainon’s direction and nothing else. Phainon ignores him.

“Not necessarily,” Tribbie answers, a finger on her chin. “The disciples are simply discarding items and keepsakes in accordance with the Month of Gate’s tradition.”

“Except, they chose a perilous location,” Mydei adds with a huff, pouring scorn over the disciples’ evident lack of good judgement.

Tribbie musters a wry smile. “We can’t fault them for it, De. Followers of Janus used to do these rituals here before the Black Tide’s invasion, back when this place was still called the Janusopolis.”

Mydei seems conflicted by this, as if he regrets speaking so callously over the matter. He doesn’t make a move to argue this time.

“I suppose we should get going,” Phainon says in an attempt to get rid of the awkwardness. “Better for us to find those disciples first before they fall prey to the roaming Titankin.”

“We agree,” Tribbie says. The look of concern on her face makes both Phainon and Mydei equally unsettled. “If one of us is not here by two quints, the ones who managed to return here shall saddle the disciples to the dromases and send them back to Okhema first before proceeding to look for one another.”

Phainon and Mydei nod. “Understood.”

Tribbie seems satisfied with this response. “We’ll get going now. The site we need to reach is the furthest from here.”

And one with the most puzzles, no doubt. Phainon and Mydei got away with the easy ones, headed east and west respectively with far lesser obstacles, as well as a straight-cut route with barely any twists and turns.

“Take care, Lady Tribbie,” Phainon says, trying hard not to let his worries and guilt show.

Tribbie smiles at him reassuringly. “We’ll be fine. We know this place like the back of our hands. If anything, we’re more worried about how you and De will fare on your own.”

“I’ll be alright.” Mydei throws Phainon a look. “Can’t say the same for this Deliverer, though.”

Phainon scoffs. “Oh, *really* now—”

“Please don’t fight,” Tribbie says, standing in the middle of the other two with her small arms outstretched. “We don’t have time for this.”

Both Phainon and Mydei immediately throw away the urge for a brawl. It’s a wonder how Lady Tribbie can appear intimidating despite her small stature.

“We really have to go now,” Tribbie tells the other two, poised to begin her journey into the Abyss of Fate, taking the route headed north. “Be careful out there, De, Snowy.”

“I will, Lady Tribbie.”

“Yes, Lady Tribios.”

Tribbie nods and smiles. She then makes her way into the ruins without looking back, leaving Phainon and Mydei to stare at her retreating figure until she’s out of sight.

Phainon turns to Mydei. “Fancy a tally? Loser treats the winner to a meal.”

Mydei chuckles darkly. “A bold challenge from someone who lost his money pouch only a day prior.”

Oh, right.

Phainon had completely forgotten about that entire ordeal. Ten thousand balance coins may be of no consequence for a Chrysos Heir like him, but it’s *still* ten thousand balance coins. That amount just doesn’t simply fall from the sky out of nowhere.

“Dear Mydeimos, I think you’ve forgotten one crucial detail,” Phainon starts. “From what I can remember, it was *you* who lost my money pouch. Are you finally able to remember the thief’s face now that you’re sober?”

Even if Phainon generally doesn't mind considering that he still has some spare money stored somewhere else, the circumstance does give him a valid reason to tease Mydei, risking it all at the rare chance that Mydei might've felt guilty about the whole thing and chooses to indulge Phainon's antics as a way to compensate for failing to apprehend the thief.

Mydei simply turns away at the question that was evidently meant to throw him off. Even if Mydei still retained most of his composure despite the jab, Phainon is more than willing to count this as a small win.

"I'll see you later with trophies a far greater number than yours," is Mydei's response, amusingly elusive.

Whether or not Mydei is embarrassed to discuss his inebriation, or the fact that he still cannot remember the thief's face, Phainon is merciful enough to let this slide. He'll take a flustered Mydei over an angry Mydei any day.

"We shall see, then," Phainon says.

Mydei merely responds with a noncommittal hum before turning around, his back on Phainon as he heads west. Phainon takes the route to the east, following the directions as Tribbie's map had illustrated.

As Phainon navigated the desolate halls of the Abyss of Fate, he noticed with dismay that there's a significant lack of Titankin in the area. The trophies on his person still remained less than ten, a far from ideal amount if he were to go against Mydei who most likely had about twenty by now.

At the end of the day, it all comes down to luck.

From memory alone, the location of the ritual should not be too far from where he is. A couple paces forward and Phainon finds himself in front of a closed double door, tall and looming over him.

The initial grandeur of it might have been lost to time, but Phainon can still marvel at its magnificence. He fiddles with the lock, muttering prayers to Janus until a click resounds. He then pushes the heavy double door open with a bit of effort, making his way inside.

The room within was vast, dimly lit by candles that did no better in dissipating the shadows from the corners. In the middle was a pile of tomes and treasures arranged haphazardly over a faintly drawn inscription on the floor.

The disciples of Janus were surrounding the said inscription, hooded faces turning their attention towards Phainon with their hands still clasped together in prayer.

Phainon waves at them, feeling awkward for the interruption. "Um, greetings."

The disciples turn their attention amongst themselves before unanimously returning their gaze back at Phainon.

"Is Lord Phainon here to join us in this ritual?" one of them asks.

Phainon can't tell which of the disciples had spoken due to the hoods they all fashioned. "I'm sorry to disappoint you, but I'm afraid the ritual has to be postponed for the time being."

The disciples let out sounds of disgruntlement, murmuring amongst themselves.

"How so?" one of them demands, the medallion hanging from his neck signifies his leadership of the group.

"Lady Aglaea has tasked me to return you all back to Okhema," Phainon answers amicably despite the growing agitation of the disciples. "This place is not safe."

A scoff resounds before another one speaks, "But the ritual must see completion!"

"Indeed," says the leader with a firm nod. "We will return once it's done."

"You will only serve to endanger your fellows, good sir," Phainon says. "Whatever it is you plan to do here, it can be done just the same in Okhema. Not to mention, it will be safer."

The room erupts into an uproar as the disciples leave their prayer positions, crowding around Phainon oppressively and using their numbers to their advantage to make him bend to their will.

Phainon sighs. Convincing others to understand his intentions might be his strong suit (most of the time), but it never comes easy.

It takes a while to calm down the agitated disciples, and it also takes another while long*er* of negotiations to convince them that leaving the place is the better option. It was ever a surprise that no roaming Titankin have found them by now because of the raucousness in the room.

After some more reassurances that involved Phainon mentioning Aglaea's willingness to accommodate the disciples' rather absurd demands for the ritual, as well as the Holy Maidens' well-sought participation, Phainon had finally managed to convince the disciples of Janus to leave.

Even if the clauses he mentioned were made up on the spot and there's absolutely no way that Aglaea would agree to them, it was better than having to tie them all together with a rope and drag them out forcefully.

As they make their way back to the agreed location, few Titankin block their way but it was never really much of a hindrance. Phainon is more than happy to take them down considering that it adds more trophies to his rather pitiful count.

When Phainon reaches the entrance to the Abyss of Fate, only Tribbie had made it back safely with her share of disciples.

"Lady Tribbie, your expertise never fails to amaze me," he says as he helps Tribbie settle the newly arrived disciples with the others. "Even if the location you chose was the furthest, not to mention, barred by a significant amount of puzzles, you still managed to return the quickest."

Tribbie grins toothily at the praise. “It wasn’t that long since we returned, Snowy. Seeing that you were able to make it out safely without mishaps is already impressive enough, too.”

Aside from the grueling task of convincing the disciples, Phainon could say that his trip to the ruins went pretty smoothly. So smoothly that it’s almost unsettling.

“Mydei’s not here yet, huh.”

Tribbie nods, looking over to the direction where Mydei went. “Not yet. But there’s no doubt he’ll be here soon. Let’s just wait a bit.”

“He’s probably hunting down all the Titankin in the area to inflate his trophy count,” Phainon says lightly, unable to hide a smile.

“You two and your silly little games,” Tribbie admonishes without much heat, shaking her head like she's a tired mother of two unruly kids despite her child-like appearance.

While Tribbie ensures that none of the disciples are injured, Phainon keeps watch from on top of a dilapidated pillar, making sure that he’s able to see any Titankin’s approach from afar (as well as Mydei’s).

A quint passes and there’s still no crimson silhouette coming from the west. Phainon feels the nerves start to kick in as he fiddles with a fragment of debris in between his fingers. Mydei was supposed to be here by now.

Two quints was the agreed upon time, but the silence of the ruins was loud enough to render Phainon ill at ease. Mydei is not someone who usually takes too long when it comes to things like these. Titankin shouldn’t even be a problem. Needless to say, Phainon barely saw any Titankin roaming around the area so what was taking Mydei so long?

The disciples couldn’t be giving him a hard time…

Phainon jumps down from the pillar and finds Tribbie waiting for him there. The disciples of Janus are all taking a rest by the dromases, quietly murmuring amongst themselves.

“Lady Tribbie—”

“You’re worried about De, aren’t you?” Tribbie asks before Phainon could get a word out.

There’s no use denying it. Phainon replies, “It’s not something I can help with.”

Tribbie smiles. As always, she is able to understand. “You can go ahead and find De,” she tells Phainon. “We’ll stay here with the disciples. But don’t take too long, okay?”

Phainon had no intention of keeping Tribbie waiting on her own anyway. “You have my word, Lady Tribbie.”

He wastes no time and heads west. It was fortunate that, very much like his trip to the east of the ruins, there’s not much of Nikador’s Titankin roaming around. Or perhaps Mydei had already made quick work of them.

But there's no Titankin remains anywhere.

As Phainon makes his way further into the building in search of Mydei, the desolation of the place only serves to fuel his dread even more. Since the fall of Castrum Kremnos, the ruins of the Abyss of Fate has always been teeming with Titankin. The significant lack of them makes one assume that something has gone terribly wrong.

Dread creeps in like a slow, invisible tide. Its presence barely perceptible at first, but gradually worsens with each step that Phainon takes as he navigates the maze of empty hallways, the sound of his own labored breathing deafening amidst the silence.

The air thickens, unnerving. Mydei shouldn't be too far from him now. And then he hears it, feels it upon the ground, vibrations reverberating across stone walls—

The building rumbles, a loud roar resounds followed by an ear-piercing crash. Phainon feels his pulse quicken as he makes haste towards the source of the commotion. The huge door at the end of the hall was slightly agape. The sounds grow louder, the stench of rust ever so pronounced.

Phainon hears screams.

He bursts into the room, greatsword at hand and ready to strike. The sight that greets him makes him feel faint.

Titankin are amass, a mix of white and gold, barely distinguishable like a swarm of insects, a relentless sea of hostile intent.

In the middle of the room was a flurry of blood red crystals taking down every Titankin that comes close with deadly precision. But no matter how vicious of a defense is put up, the sheer number of enemies are just seemingly endless.

A hundred against one. Phainon chokes on air.

"Mydei!"

Phainon rushes over to the center, his own greatsword slaying every Titankin he comes across —as many as possible, enough to at least make a difference.

He steps over the remains of the felled enemies that bled golden ichor on the floor, paying no mind to the mess soiling the soles of his boots or the fear of tripping for his eyes are glued ahead.

To that mesmerizing whirling movement, the dance of crimson fabric and a glint of gold, the sight of tanned skin marred with cuts. The vision of Mydei grows clearer, mighty and magnificent despite the odds stacked against him.

His gaze meets that of Phainon's briefly, a fervid and brilliant gold. Phainon swings his greatsword in a sweeping motion, taking down the remaining Titankin that hinders his path towards Mydei.

At last.

“Are you alright?” Phainon yells at Mydei, hoping his voice was loud enough to be heard above the carnage.

The response he gets is a rough shove on his shoulder as Mydei pushes him away without so much as meeting his eyes. Phainon feels his shoulder ache, a distinct sting he tries not to dwell on too much, whispering the bitter implication of rejection.

“Take the disciples by the fallen pillar and go!” Mydei yells back, the red crystal in his hand impaling a Titankin straight through, golden ichor splattering over his face as he throws the Titankin towards the hoard, knocking down several in the process.

Phainon refocuses his attention back to the battle. “You didn’t answer my question!”

The ground beneath them rumbles as Mydei’s red crystals emerge from the stone floor, fatally injuring some of the Titankin. He turns to Phainon with a hint of irritation.

“Just go!”

“Not without you!”

Phainon narrowly dodges an arrow aimed at his head, the sharp tip almost grazing his cheek. He feels Mydei’s back against his own as they’re further cornered at the center of the room, the swarm of Titankin upon them seemingly endless.

Trying to spot an opening, Phainon instead catches sight of the fallen pillar Mydei had mentioned earlier. There’s a large red crystal making sure that it won’t crumble any further in a manner that would harm the disciples huddled beneath.

They’re hidden enough that the Titankin don’t seem to pay them any mind, their attention solely focused on taking down the two people in the middle of the room.

Phainon hears Mydei curse. The word is familiar, undeniably Kremnoan.

“What happened here?” Phainon asks, keeping his guard high and his blade raised. “Why are there so many of them?”

“Those disciples of Janus activated a mechanism that lured all the Titankin in the area,” Mydei explains, back heaving against Phainon as he tries to catch his breath.

That explains the lack of Titankin, Phainon thinks. No wonder the ruins of the Abyss of Fate was almost devoid of them for they all came running into this one single room for Mydei to fend off.

Alone.

Phainon feels his throat begin to tighten up. He wonders how Mydei was able to hold up for so long, thankful that all this time, all the injuries Mydei was able to sustain were a few cuts —quite telling of the battle prowess Mydei possesses.

While the Titankin had let up on their attacks temporarily in favor of ominously approaching Phainon and Mydei—almost as if there is no need to rush for the defeat of the two men is imminent—Phainon uses this as his chance to communicate without the hindrance of loud noises and blatant attempts on his life.

“Mydei, we need to leave now,” Phainon says, pointing his blade threateningly at a Titankin who got too close for comfort. “You’ve found the disciples. No use in lingering here.”

Mydei scoffs behind him, the essence of his power palpable enough to make even Phainon shiver. “These Titankin will follow us to the trail if they’re not taken care of at this instant. Go ahead and leave with the others. I’ll handle this.”

Phainon grits his teeth. Kremnoans and their bull-headednes.

“Now’s not the time for arrogance,” Phainon argues, his grip on the hilt of his blade tightening. The Titankin are bound to resume their attack soon, perhaps only a few paces in and they will strike. “Mydei, you can’t possibly fend them all on your own—”

You’ll die.

The Titankin charges, arrows fly with a *woosh,* Phainon’s greatsword crosses with another, and Mydei leaps off, grabbing three enemies by the scruff before crushing them with a flurry of red crystals into the wall.

He watches through the reflection in his blade how Mydei swiftly dodges the lunge of a Titankin’s spear, watches as Mydei leans back to avoid an arrow aimed at his heart, watches as Mydei stops the sword of a Titankin with one hand, the sharp tip barely a hairbreadth away from Mydei’s eye.

Phainon hears the sharp sound of another arrow being released, distinct amidst the chaos. It brushes past him, it’s aim soaring straight and true towards a target behind him—

Towards *Mydei*.

Phainon pushes the Titankin off of him with the edge of his greatsword, feels his muscles ache at the exertion so extreme that he almost could’ve broken his wrist. The Titankin is thankfully knocked back, and Phainon swiftly turns behind him, a hand outstretched as he tries to reach Mydei, an attempt to stop the arrow from reaching its destination.

Mydei meets Phainon’s gaze, an instance so brief and yet Phainon could’ve sworn that it had lasted much longer. Time slows down, everything else fades into vision. Any moment now, the arrow that flies midair would find itself a new terminus.

It would no longer be Mydei’s heart, for how could it be so in the first place? How could Phainon allow another to die before his very eyes?

The belligerent tip of an enemy’s arrow could pierce any part of Phainon’s body. Though his skin is littered with cuts of varying depth, Mydei’s flesh shall never be acquainted with the sensation of cold metal that swoops like an eagle that spotted its prey.

Phainon sees Mydei's eyes widen a fraction, the product of realization perhaps. For Mydei to be the last person he sees is more than what Phainon could ever deserve. He just hopes his death would be able to serve some semblance of purpose.

It all happens in a blink of an eye. One moment Mydei was surrounded by Titankin, outnumbered to almost an extreme that he fails to notice the arrow nocked specifically aiming at his direction. In the next, blood red crystals dominates Phainon's vision, followed by a flurry of red fabric and exposed tanned skin.

Phainon feels the world spin, Mydei's scent permeating his senses. A grunt follows, Mydei's ankle twisting awkwardly as he maneuvers Phainon out of the way and onto the ground, covering Phainon's body with his own like a forbidden shield.

The glint of a spearhead's tip is caught from Phainon's periphery, and then there's the soft *thwack* as the dreaded arrow finally meets flesh. The blade of the spear follows, piercing mercilessly through muscle and bone.

Golden ichor spills and lands on Phainon's face in rivulets from where he's laid on the ground. There's nothing else he could do but stare ahead, look up to the source of the golden waterfall, harrowing despite the mesmerizing shimmer.

Mydei's eyes are unfocused, muted gold as he meets Phainon's gaze. Although, it feels as if he's barely even there anymore.

Phainon chokes out a gasp when Mydei collapses on top of him. He catches him with ease as he sits up, ears ringing when he pulls out the spear that impaled Mydei's side without much thought, absent minded as if his body is being controlled by another being.

A hateful, *vengeful* being.

Mydei's soft groan echoes in Phainon's ears like a devastating plea. Hands stained in golden ichor finds the wounded skin of Mydei's back, pulling Mydei closer towards a body whose blood had run cold despite the thrum of life and anguish.

Without letting his hold upon Mydei falter, Phainon throws the spear with deadly precision towards the closest Titankin with so much force that it pierces five others, pushing them further away until the spearhead meets the hard surface of the cracked stone wall, stopping its momentum entirely.

Phainon's other hand shakily snakes up towards the wound on Mydei's throat where the arrow is lodged so deeply that the tip protrudes from the other side of Mydei's neck. Phainon stares at nothing in particular as he pulls the arrow out, jaw clenched tight when he feels the warm gush of blood flow, further staining his hand in glistening gold.

The arrow flies without the need of a bowstring, its tip trailing the blood of someone precious as it soars, striking the Titankin archer situated far away who had so graciously bestowed such a gift, the fated arrow it chose from its quiver carved in marble.

The Titankin archer falls. The rest of the damned retreats, a hoard without a leader. A little too late, Phainon is finally able to know silence.

Mydei's body lay limp against him, head resting heavy on Phainon's shoulder, golden ichor pooling onto the ground around them like a gruesome puddle, wetting fabrics both red and blue. Phainon blinks the haze away, a stained hand making its way onto Mydei's hair, blonde strands dipped in crimson soft to the touch.

"Mydei," Phainon calls out quietly.

There's no hint of a breath ghosting Phainon's neck where Mydei's face is buried. No thump of a beating heart within Mydei's chest. Mydei does not indulge Phainon with a reply like he usually does, always responding to each one of Phainon's calls of his name without fail.

Right now, Mydei has gone quiet.

With a gentle push, Phainon repositions Mydei to lay on his lap. Mydei's eyes remain open, half-lidded, dull and unblinking. Gone is the fervid flame in those eyes that Phainon admires so much. He fears that he may never see them again, dreads a life without it.

Phainon cups Mydei's face with shaky hands, sticky and wet with warm liquid gold.
"Mydei…"

Mydei remains still. Thanatos is ever so unforgiving. Phainon makes a tally of his possessions that he could give up when he eventually sets sail to the Sea of Souls, a barter ready for the Hand of Shadow—all his treasures and all that he is, all for the life of a man who is far more precious than anything Phainon could possibly offer.

A most dearest, most cherished equal who saved his life without hesitation.

"Mydeimos."

Surely, Mydei's soul still lingers within the room. Perhaps Mydei could hear Phainon, feel pity on him, enough to convince the dead to return to his mortal body.

But Mydei doesn't budge, and golden blood continues to flow ceaselessly until fair skin turns pale, the once pink and full lips fading into lifelessness.

Phainon has seen countless corpses before. He's seen people equally as significant die before him, souls reaped as he dwells in his suffering. He vowed that he would never witness such a thing again. As long as he lived, no harm would befall the people he considers as friends, as family.

That was supposed to be the last time, scenes of a harrowing past coming to haunt Phainon once more. And yet, before Phainon's very eyes was the proof of his failure.

Not again.

"Mydei, wake up."

Not again.

“Mydeimos.”

NOT AGAIN. NOT AGAIN. NOT AGAIN!

“Myd—”

Phainon chokes on his words, a stinging behind his eyes as he wallows in his delusions that Mydei might just survive this ordeal even if his heart had stopped beating long ago.

You didn’t even say goodbye.

He hears a soft murmur of voices from the distance followed by the scuffling of sandals against stone and the rustle of fabric. Phainon watches dazedly as the disciples of Janus make their way out from beneath the fallen pillar. He completely forgot that they were even there in the first place, forgot the reason why he even went here.

Phainon felt his throat tighten when he couldn’t spot the once present cluster of red crystals supporting the pillar. The red crystals that used to scatter around the room during the battle had also disappeared, as if erasing the memory of Mydei’s power from existence.

The disciples looked terrified out of their minds. Phainon couldn’t even bring himself to care at the moment. There’s a chance that the group must have some knowledge of healing. They are no followers of Aquila from the Twilight Courtyard with miraculous healing abilities, but Phainon can’t afford to be picky right now.

“I need a healer!” he yells at the huddled group of pale-faced disciples.

The disciples visibly jolt at the sudden harsh address, murmuring amongst themselves, gazes darting at each other. Their shoulders shake, most of them starts fiddling with their fingers, but they make no move to step forward and help.

Phainon’s patience runs out.

“*Quickly!*”

A young man is pushed forward by his fellows. He looked like he would rather be anywhere than here. Seeing Phainon’s piercing gaze at him, weighed with profound expectation, the young man gingerly makes his way to the center of the vast room, crouching beside Phainon and the bleeding man he held in his arms.

Phainon watches with rapt attention as the young man removes Mydei’s gauntlets, muttering prayers as he takes both Mydei’s bare hands in his before ripping a piece of fabric from his clothes to cover the wounds and stop the bleeding. Once done, he checks Mydei’s pulse—both on his wrist and neck. He inspects Mydei’s half-lidded eyes closely, monitoring for any pupil dilation before bringing his ear close to Mydei’s chest.

The disciple had a grim look after his inspection. “My lord, I’m afraid that he’s already—”

“You must be mistaken,” Phainon says, the sound of his own voice foreign to him. “Check again. Heal him.”

“But—”

Before Phainon was about to unleash disaster that could even rival the Black Tide upon the poor disciple of Janus, the sound of the double doors being pried open catches his attention.

The disciple of Janus uses Phainon’s distraction to bolt away back towards the huddled group in the corner lest Phainon remembers his grievances and punish him for being unable to do the impossible.

Tribbie rushes in, the little wings on her back fluttering ever so slightly. She had a worried look on her face. “Snowy! And—”

Her gaze drops to Mydei, nothing but a lifeless corpse on Phainon’s lap. She gasps, faltering in her approach.

Phainon’s lip quivers, his grip on Mydei’s stiff body growing tighter. “Lady Tribbie, Mydei is…

Not dead. *Anything* but dead.

He feels something warm and wet trickle down his cheek. His vision of Tribbie blurs as he tastes blood in his mouth, belatedly realizing that he’d bit his tongue hard enough to warrant a bleeding.

The sting is dull compared to the terrible ache of sorrow that wedges itself deeper into the crevices of his heart, enough so that it would be nigh impossible to flush it out.

Upon seeing Phainon’s tears, Tribbie sports an equally tearful expression, empathizing with Phainon’s pain. She opens her mouth to say something, perhaps to offer consolation.

But it would be futile. Phainon couldn’t be consoled at all. It took him *years* to mourn the death of a close friend from the past. Who’s to say that it wouldn’t take *decades* for him to mourn the loss of Mydei? Someone who’s not just a close friend, but also—

A cold finger pokes the tip of Phainon’s nose.

Phainon startles, looking down in an instant with no preparation whatsoever to what sight was about to greet him.

Mydei blinks up at him. Once, then twice. The light in his eyes of gold have returned, the fairness of his skin restored, the bleeding on his throat and on the side of his torso have stopped, the cuts that once littered his skin gone.

No wounds, no scars. *Nothing*.

Phainon furrows his eyebrows. He must have truly lost his mind. Mydei, on the other hand, seemed far from being amused as he withdrew his hand.

“I knew you were dramatic. But not *this* dramatic,” Mydei admonishes without much heat.

It’s Mydei’s voice. No other voices could hold such power over Phainon in the same way Mydei’s does. He would be able to single it out in a noisy room full of people, would be able to listen for its echoes even if he and Mydei are valleys apart.

As of this moment, however, even if he knew that it is Mydei who spoke, Phainon finds it difficult distinguishing reality from illusion. No matter how much he’s able to recognize Mydei’s voice in any shape or form, it would only be in vain if such a sound merely stemmed from his imaginations rather than the truth of the circumstance.

A teardrop falls from Phainon’s chin, landing squarely on Mydei’s cheek. Mydei sighs as if the unintended act has aggrieved him thoroughly.

“Tears,” Mydei notes, disbelief etched in his tone as he brings a hand towards his face. The tip of his finger lightly touches the spot where Phainon’s tear had fallen, pulling his hand away to examine the wetness. “For *me?*”

This allows Phainon a moment of sobriety from the haze of pure bafflement, hastily wiping his face with the back of his hands, further smearing golden ichor onto his skin—proof that death had indeed occurred in his presence.

The sight of Mydei alive and *conversing* with him might simply be just a product of some deceptive illusion that’s spurred on by the profound grief that Phainon is able to see the dead coming back to life.

Mydei sighs, puffs of air blown lightly against Phainon’s face as he awaits for Phainon to snap out of his self-induced haze. Phainon thankfully does so some moments later.

“You!”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Me?”

“You died! You were…” Phainon tries to at least make himself sound coherent. “Your heart stopped beating!”

Mydei had the audacity to roll his eyes, as if all this was something merely trivial to him. He sits up like nothing had happened, ignoring Phainon’s jumbled mess of accusations altogether.

“I’m still talking to you!”

Phainon watches with a disbelieving scowl as Mydei hoists himself off the floor as if he had not been skewered and pierced by an arrow and a spear moments prior. He offers a hand to Phainon in an attempt to help the latter up.

Indignantly, Phainon slaps Mydei’s hand away, azure eyes glaring daggers at the man before him.

Mydei hums lightly, rubbing the back of his hand. The skin is starting to turn red from where Phainon had hit it. Phainon feels guilt swirl in his gut, an apology on the tip of his tongue.

“Suit yourself,” is all Mydei says.

Phainon notices the tinge of pink coloring Mydei’s face as well as the tips of his ears, a stark contrast to the paleness from earlier. Even if relief awashes Phainon’s body anew, the thumping of his heart within his chest has yet to be calmed.

There’s just so many questions—

Is this real?

Mydei, are you really alive?

Are you okay?

How did you defy death?

Why did you save me?

None of those words are able to escape Phainon’s frozen lips as he watches Mydei inspect his garb of red and black fabric, frowning at the stain of golden ichor that had seeped through. It was his very own blood that had ruined his garments, the dreadful puddle something that Phainon is still settled upon.

Perhaps it would be better to challenge Mydei in a duel after all, for Phainon to be able to let off all the surging emotions that have rendered him almost a stranger to his own body. He wants to do *so* much, *say* so much more—

There’s a small hand on his shoulder, grounding him. Phainon turns to his side and sees Tribbie. There’s no smile on her face this time.

“Snowy, we need to leave before the rest of the Titankin comes back.”

Phainon couldn’t even find it within himself to nod or say something in reply. He simply stands, legs feeling like jelly with most of his clothes dripping golden blood, the liquid seeping through the fabric and allowing the cold air to bite into his skin rather mercilessly.

With resolute steps, Phainon marches out of the room. He can feel Mydei’s gaze on his retreating figure, searing like a brand. Phainon is barely able to resist the urge to look back.

The ride to the holy city was quiet save for the whimpers and murmurs of the petrified disciples.

Phainon stays in his corner of the dromas' saddle, eyes glued at the passing view of desolation that is Amphoreus without Aquila's Eyes to shine light upon them. Okhema is still some ways away, and Kephale's Dawn Device could barely even illuminate the path.

In the darkness, Phainon allows himself to wallow in his own thoughts.

He hasn't thrown a single glance towards Mydei's direction out of fear for what he might see —Mydei's corpse perhaps, when Phainon's hallucinations have finally run its course and it turns out, Mydei's soul is indeed already halfway in its journey towards the Hand of Shadow's embrace, his resurrection simply a product of Phainon's own imagination.

Tribbie, sensing the tense atmosphere, kept to herself during the entirety of the journey. The only time she spoke was when she asked both Phainon and Mydei if they were hungry. Neither accepted the bread and drink Tribbie offered, and neither spoke.

Phainon's insides is a swirling mess of unspoken emotions. He fears that the moment he partakes in any type of sustenance, he'll just end up hurling it back out in no time.

As for Mydei… Well, the dead cannot eat, can they?

A couple more hours of uncomfortable silence pass before Kephale's Dawn finally showers them in its golden glow like a divine blessing, cleansing them of the darkness caused by the Black Tide.

Okhema's city gates is just up ahead, and Phainon couldn't be more eager to simply retire to his chambers and call an end to this terrible day. Tomorrow, he'll have his wits about him. And perhaps he'll also be able to engage in a conversation with Mydei.

Corpse or not, Phainon *will* come to see him.

Upon arrival, Tribbie leads the disciples of Janus into the city, leaving the other two Chrysos Heirs alone to their own devices. Perhaps Tribbie had sported some grievances of her own for she left without so much as a word.

Before Phainon could aimlessly walk away, a firm grip on his shoulder stops him. He doesn't turn around even when he hears a heavy sigh from behind him, faltering his resolve.

The next thing that comes after the touch is *his* voice. Unmistakable and yet foreign all the same. "Deliverer, I—"

There's a long pause. Days could have gone by with Phainon simply standing motionlessly by Okhema's entrance with nothing but the warm hand on his shoulder.

And then it's gone, as quickly as it had come into existence.

"Nevermind."

Phainon's jaw clenches. This time, he finally allows himself to turn around and face *him*.

How could Mydei just stand there before him, taking in breaths with his eyes of gold, fiery and glistening from reflecting the light of Kephale's Dawn, looking very much alive as if Phainon had not held his limp body hours prior?

For Mydei to be able to regard Phainon so casually when Phainon had watched the life disappear from his eyes, acting like nothing happened when his blood still stains Phainon's clothes and skin like a grievous reminder is something that ticks off Phainon more than he'd expected.

Not like he expected that he'd be able to experience something of the sort anyway, how else was he supposed to prepare himself to react appropriately?

Phainon opens his mouth in an attempt to speak, but no words escape his parted lips. Instead, there's a tightening in his chest that makes it hard to breathe.

The stinging from behind his eyes makes their unwanted return, followed by the trickle of something warm that unbiddenly flows down his face like a steady stream whose waters sing the songs of sorrow.

The blurring of his vision worsens just before he could see Mydei's expression turn into that of unbridled shock.

Mydei takes a couple of steps closer. Phainon doesn't have the energy in him to take a step back.

"Why do you weep for me?" is Mydei's question, barely above a whisper as if only Phainon is meant to hear the words. It was only thanks to their proximity that Phainon was able to do so.

Phainon scoffs, the question somehow offending him. Of all the things Mydei could ask, he chooses one that barely even made sense, one whose answer is as plain as day.

Blinking frantically, Phainon wipes his tears away with the back of his hand, ignoring the shimmer of dried gold that is still present upon his skin.

"What kind of question is that? I just saw you *die* because of *me*," Phainon spats, his voice raw and almost childish in its frustration. "I think the better question here is: why did you save me knowing that you'll…"

He trails off, unable to finish the rest of his sentence. It's as if he's afraid that he might speak it into existence and the image of Mydei in front of him, alive and well, would then morph into the vision he saw back at the Abyss.

Mydei as a corpse, cold and lifeless. Phainon feels the helplessness starting to creep in. It's a terrible feeling, one he wishes to be rid of forever if it were possible.

"You've already witnessed firsthand the curse I bear," Mydei says, ever so straightforward. "And you forget one detail. You were the one who jumped in front of me first—"

“To shield you from that arrow!” Phainon snaps, voice cracking at the exclamation. He’d spoken loud enough for the innocent citizens passing by to stop and stare. “You were careless.”

Mydei scoffs, crossing his arms defensively. “And you’re not? I’d say we’re one and the same.”

Phainon looks away, blinking rapidly. Tears of sorrow were replaced by that of pure irritation because in a sense, Mydei’s words made sense. They’ve both made rash decisions during the battle back at the ruins even if Phainon is loath to admit it out loud.

When it looks as if Phainon was not about to argue, Mydei continues, “Save your heroic acts for someone else. I’m far from one that needs saving. Death, as you already saw, is out of my reach so don’t even bother shielding me from harm next time.”

“How could you say such a thing?” Phainon admonishes. “You expect me to just watch like an uncaring audience the next time an enemy stabs you straight through?”

An unreadable expression crosses Mydei’s face, gone in a blink. “If it puts you in danger, then yes.”

Phainon could not believe his ears. He may argue with Mydei more often than not, but those arguments usually stemmed from something harmless. Once handled, it becomes something rather amusing to look back on, a somewhat fond memory that makes Phainon smile absentmindedly when he recalls it.

However, the situation at hand is different. Phainon thought Mydei knew him enough to not ask such an outrageous request from him. It’s a case of asked and answered. Only, Phainon got the worst possible response.

“Since you so cruelly expect me to just watch the next time you pull this stunt,” Phainon began. “Then do me the favor of gouging my eyes out this instant.”

Mydei sighs, heavy and exhausted. “You exaggerate.”

“And you piss me off,” Phainon shoots back. “Severely, I might add.”

“If you want to settle this with a fight then be my guest.”

Phainon grits his teeth, mind at a total loss. And though his hands itch to land a blow, clenched tightly into fists by his sides, he can’t seem to find the will to do so. His vision blurs even more, heat accumulating from behind his eyes, every blink a wrestle to keep his dignity at bay as tears carelessly flows.

Mydei reaches a hand out and Phainon flinches, wet lashes fluttering as he clenches his eyes shut, bracing for impact in the event that Mydei might want to engage in a brawl after all to settle their differences.

Only, there is no ache in his jaw and in its place, was the gentle touch of warm fingers deftly catching the steady cascade of tears, the sensation light as a feather that Phainon could barely

feel the touch against his skin.

It is as if he is the most delicate of all porcelains, prone to breaking at the slightest brush of wind against the surface.

Phainon opens his eyes. Mydei gazes back at him, gold eyes unwavering. His hand upon Phainon's cheek remains, palm radiating a distinct comforting warmth that renders Phainon almost weak, allowing him to lean into the touch as his grievances all but dissipate into the atmosphere.

"You weep like you've lost something," Mydei tells him, the tip of his thumb catching another stray tear from the corner of Phainon's eye. "I'm still here, Deliverer."

They both know that this discussion is far from being over. Phainon still had his reservations about Mydei being so blasé about his own safety, and Mydei has yet to take back his sickening request of having Phainon do nothing for him in the face of danger.

But the reassurance acts as an anchor as Phainon navigates the waves of doubt. There's no hint of deceit in Mydei's tone for a Kremnoan such as him could only mean every single word that escapes his lips.

Before Phainon could respond, however, the touch on his face disappears as Mydei's hand drops without warning.

Phainon watches as Mydei collapses to his knees with a pained expression, clutching his chest with labored breaths. Phainon is there to support him, his own ears ringing as he calls for healers.

Horror engulfs him once more when Mydei's weight against him grows heavier.

"You worry for him."

"How could I not?"

Castorice gives him an encouraging smile. "The healers will see to it that their jobs are done well. Lord Mydei will be fine."

Seated at a bench across the door that led to Mydei's chambers, Phainon buries his head in his hands with a groan.

"An undying body, that's his curse," he says, disbelief etched in his tone. "It makes me wonder just how many times he's perished without my knowledge. All those times he referred to death so casually and I didn't think much of it. I was a *fool*."

"You are not at fault, Lord Phainon," Castorice reassures. "You were simply unaware. All of us are on the same footing with you in this regard."

Every Chrysos Heir bears Kephale's golden blood in their veins. However, in exchange for the blessing of the divine, one must bear a tragic curse to be carried until the prophecy sees fulfillment.

Mydei is, unfortunately, not an exception.

It's a pity that death needed to occur for all of them to find out about Mydei's curse. Phainon is beginning to think that Mydei has a penchant of shouldering all his troubles by himself. A nasty habit.

The doors to Mydei's chambers swing open as the healers begin to file out. Aglaea is the last to leave, her clouded gaze landing upon Phainon and Castorice in an instant, almost as if she had already expected them to be there.

Phainon bolts out of his seat, Castorice following at a distance behind him. "How is he?" he asks Aglaea.

"His wounds have healed but the ache still lingers," Aglaea answers smoothly. "According to the healers, it might take some time for Mydeimos to recover. Other than that, he is alright."

Phainon allows a sigh to escape his lips. "I see."

Even if he's already heard from Aglaea that Mydei is doing relatively fine, it wouldn't beat having to see it for himself. There's a high possibility that Mydei would downplay his pain in favor of concealing weakness.

Despite their earlier spat, Phainon would still very much like to see Mydei in the flesh to know how he's faring. They're still friends after all, and it's because of him that Mydei is in his current state. Guilt truly is an old friend of his.

"Lord Phainon, are you alright?" Castorice asks. "Lady Aglaea bears good news, and yet you seem upset."

Aglaea schools her expression with a cough. The odd behavior does not escape Phainon's keen notice.

"The golden threads are wound tightly due to your agitation," she tells Phainon. Though this is something that sounds far from ideal, the tone of Aglaea's voice belied a hint of amusement. "If you wish to be in Mydeimos' presence so much, you only need to walk through the door."

Phainon fails to hide his apprehension. "Is it really okay?"

"According to Mydeimos' words, a certain man is permitted entry for he doesn't want said man to look like a kicked chimera who stalks the entry of his chambers," Aglaea says. And then she adds, "Do believe me when I say that I quoted his words verbatim."

Verbatim or not, Phainon's mind still struggles to comprehend exactly what Aglaea had just said.

Castorice turns to Phainon with a smile. “It seems that Lord Mydei wishes to see you just as much as you wish to see him, Lord Phainon.”

“Oh,” Phainon voices out. Rather intelligently.

Mydei probably only wanted to resume their conversation from earlier. Phainon is not entirely opposed to the idea for he also harbors a fair share of sentiments that needed to be expressed now that he’s managed to calm down from the shock of Mydei’s temporary death.

Perhaps an apology is in order. He didn’t mean to lose his composure so much in front of Mydei. Mydei must’ve thought him to be akin to a child throwing a temper tantrum.

“You can go see him, Phainon,” Aglaea encourages gently when Phainon makes no move to enter Mydei’s chambers after being given permission. “Your company will do Mydeimos good.”

Castorice supports Aglaea’s claim with a nod of her own. “Kindly relay my regards to Lord Mydei on my behalf, Lord Phainon.”

Phainon nods, attempting to smile despite his inner turmoil. It’s a relief that Castorice didn’t point out his poor attempt to look composed. He turns his attention towards Mydei’s door and inhales sharply before Janus permits him passage.

The room smells of incense, warm and sweet with a tinge of spice as Phainon slowly made his way through a relatively short hallway, noting how the layout of the room was similar to his albeit the lack of decorations.

Sidestepping the partition, he then finds himself in the main sleeping area where a huge kline was situated in the middle, taking up a significant amount of the space.

The curtains that led to the balcony were drawn, Kephale’s Dawn bathing the room in a resplendent glow, the almost blinding light reflecting through the glinting golden eyes of someone whose attention now belongs to Phainon.

Mydei sat upright atop the kline with a blanket thrown haphazardly over his bare legs. He is dressed down in a loose red robe, unfastened, exquisitely exposing his torso that’s marred in streaks of scarlet.

His skin glistens with a hint of dampness, expectedly flawless and fair, but Phainon knew better than to assume that no pain belies the allure. The healers must have subjected him to a bath while they examined his state, a palliating method to ease the ghostly sting of a fatal injury.

From where he stands, Phainon couldn’t help but think that with or without the extravagance of armor, Mydei never fails to look formidable (and beautiful).

“I initially assumed that it would take you a day before you’d come to see me,” Mydei muses, interrupting Phainon from his unabashed staring. “Consider me mistaken.”

His tone suggests that he has time for jests, a blatant attempt to lighten the mood despite it being uncharacteristic of him. Rather unexpected as well considering how their earlier conversation had ended in a… rather *odd* note.

But who is Phainon to deny Mydei of anything?

“And why would you come up with such an assumption?” Phainon replies, a tease of his own. “Do you really think me to be heartless?”

Mydei shrugs, his robe sliding down his arm and exposing a bare shoulder in the process. Phainon’s gaze follows the gratuitous movement of the silk as it drags further down against tanned skin.

And *swallows*.

Even if Mydei parades himself around the city half-naked at all times, it feels as if this is Phainon’s first instance of witnessing Mydei in such a state of undress.

Perhaps it’s the lack of armor. Perhaps it’s Phainon being in Mydei’s private quarters, the two of them in each other’s presence with nary a witness that makes the situation seem more intimate than it should be.

“I thought you’d have an aversion to seeing me,” Mydei says, dragging his robe back up to clothe his exposed skin. Phainon mourns the loss but shall forever remember the vision. “I’ve been told that the sight of my death tends to be quite gruesome at times. Enough to render even *you* to tears, I suppose.”

Phainon sighs, shifting his weight from one foot to another. “The reason for my tears is not out of disgust. I weep simply because the loss of a friend causes me great sorrow.”

Silence follows, awkward and tense. Mydei refuses to meet Phainon’s gaze and Phainon allows his own to examine the room in an attempt to appear casual.

“Two months in and you still haven’t decorated your chambers?” Phainon asks, a diversion.

“I dislike such unnecessary opulence,” Mydei replies. “Despite my protests, the Goldweaver insisted that I stay here.”

Phainon huffs, amused. “A prince who steers clear of grandeur. I truly have seen it all.”

He then takes another look around the room even if he’s already committed every single detail to memory, enough to vividly paint the picture of Mydei’s chambers with his eyes closed. The lack of effects helps with it.

“How are you feeling, by the way?” It is a long overdue question, one that Phainon itched to ask since he stepped foot into the room.

“I’m alright,” Mydei answers.

“Still stubborn to the bone.”

A scoff. “I’m not being stubborn,” Mydei defends. “This curse is nothing new. I’ve lived with it my whole life.”

“Your curse is not yours to bear alone now,” Phainon says, an attempt to gradually ease his stance in regards to Mydei’s nonchalance in throwing his endless lives away. “Even if death is not something you worry about, I— *We* will make sure it’s something you won’t ever have to endure the pain of again.”

Mydei sighs. “I have no need for such reassurances, Deliverer. Death and battle go hand in hand together. It is a bitter cycle, one I know not the end of.”

“But you suffer.”

There’s a hint of a smile on Mydei’s lips, barely there. “It’s called a curse for a reason.”

Another bout of silence follows for Phainon is at a loss in determining how to appropriately respond. He feels helpless and conflicted, unsure if he should just succumb to acceptance like Mydei clearly has done, or maintain his resolve.

Does he even have the right to chastise Mydei in regards to his recklessness when it is not even his own body to have an opinion of? When does concern begin to cross the line and become overbearing?

“Are you so averse to the idea of a friend having your back?” Phainon finds himself asking. The waver in his voice couldn’t be concealed this time.

“You speak of our conversation from earlier,” Mydei says. It was not an answer. “You refer to yourself as a friend of mine and yet you stand so far away. Take a seat first.”

“There’s no seats anywhere,” Phainon points out graciously. Mydei is seriously in dire need of some decorating. “Not to mention, I thought you’d prefer it if I kept my distance.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “I fail to recall when I mentioned seats.”

“You’d like me to sit on the floor?” Phainon asks, unable to mask his incredulity.

A sigh follows, one that speaks volumes of Mydei’s exasperation. “On the bed, Deliverer.”

“I beg your finest pardon?”

“Sit on the bed,” Mydei orders with such finality that it is enough motivation for Phainon’s legs to get moving, stiffly making his way over to the foot of the kline before gingerly lowering himself onto the plush mattress.

He gives Mydei a smile, more grateful than it is uncomfortable. Mydei simply rolls his eyes.

“Don’t get used to it,” Mydei says.

“I shan’t dare to disrespect your hospitality.”

Phainon struggles to keep his gaze from wandering. Now in closer proximity, every detail of Mydei's exposed skin seems all the more clearer, heightened only by the thin sheen of wetness from the bath.

Phainon resolves that anything below Mydei's bare neck is something his eyes could only have a glimpse of once in a while with relatively long intervals in between. For his gaze to linger for far too long is infinitely bad for his well-being.

Actually, Mydei's neck is just as alluring. Phainon thinks that wall behind Mydei is a much more suited spot for his eyes to rest on.

"Go on then," Mydei urges, interrupting Phainon from his stupor. "Let's talk. I'll humor you this time and never again."

Phainon would beg to differ for Mydei is always willing to indulge his curiosity, albeit in a way that's far from what one might consider gentle.

"If my question was too personal, just say the word and we shall talk about something else," Phainon says lightly, making it known that he won't take offense in the event that Mydei refuses to answer.

"Between us, nothing is too personal anymore."

Phainon's mind blanks out, thinking he'd heard wrong because what, exactly, did Mydei mean by his words?

"I— Uh… Thanks?"

Mydei snorts. "If only to smoothen that crease in between your brows, sure. You're welcome, Deliverer."

"Does it bother you when I frown?" Phainon asks with a wry smile.

"Does this signify the beginning of your interrogation?"

"Perhaps," Phainon simpers. A glare from Mydei is all it takes to set aside the jests. "But first, I'd like to thank you for saving my life. And I apologize for my behavior from earli—"

"No," Mydei says sharply. "It was wrong of me to expect such a thing from you. I understand your intentions, Deliverer. You only wanted to help."

Phainon didn't have it in him to deny the statement. "Thank you for seeing things from my perspective."

"I have thought about it thoroughly, and I'll make it clear now that you're worthy to have my back," Mydei says. "And I yours."

Phainon allows himself to relax, relief flooding his entire being like a tide that cleanses his perturbation. He can't help but smile.

“That means a lot to me, Mydei,” he says, almost breathless. “As long as I’m around, I’ll make sure that no harm comes your way.”

Despite the blatant show of sincerity, Mydei’s severe expression remains. “It still doesn’t mean that I’ll permit you to lay down your life for me. The undying cannot die. You, on the other hand…”

“Not if I can help it.”

“How reassuring,” Mydei says drily. “If you die, I’ll scour the Sea of Souls for *any* and *all* traces of you. Thanatos Themself can’t stop me from bringing you back.”

Phainon blinks, utterly taken aback by such a declaration. “I— That’s—”

“And then I’ll kill you myself for dying in my stead,” Mydei finishes. “Do we have an agreement?”

Phainon allows himself to laugh. He should’ve expected something of the sort from Mydei. The threat does sound terrifying, but Phainon knows Mydei enough that his words are nothing but well-meaning. Despite the threat, the deluge in Phainon’s heart has calmed.

“We have an agreement,” Phainon replies, holding his hand out for Mydei to shake.

Somehow, it reminds Phainon of their first meeting in the Vortex of Genesis. Two months into their acquaintance and Phainon has already been granted permission to enter Mydei’s chambers.

If he told his past self that the crown prince of Kremnos would become one of his closest friends, he probably wouldn’t have believed it. And yet—

Mydei takes his hand this time, his skin is warm against Phainon’s. Unexpectedly smooth to the touch, almost like a scholar’s. Perhaps even a woman’s, although Phainon has lesser experience in that regard. He doesn’t exactly go around holding hands with women in his free time.

But the feel of Mydei’s bare hand against his—now free of those formidable golden gauntlets he always fashioned—is a memory that Phainon would never forget, precious and tucked away carefully into the inner crevices of his mind.

Mydei is the first to let go, and Phainon is thankful that the decision of withdrawing did not fall upon him. He fears that he might take too long simply ruminating about whether or not he would allow himself the displeasure of parting his own hand with Mydei’s. Even now, he already mourns the loss of warmth.

“I… don’t make promises I can’t keep,” Mydei began. This time, he avoids Phainon’s gaze, opting to set his sights on the view of Kephale’s imposing figure from the balcony instead. “But I’ll do my best to try and not subject you to the sight of my corpse again.”

Phainon frowns. “The sight of your corpse is far from being the reason as to why I don’t want you to die, Mydei.”

“You don’t have to lie, Deliverer. I know the sight of it appalls you.”

“It doesn’t,” Phainon insists, hoping that his sincerity would seep through. “Even as a corpse, you will never appall me. I just don’t want to see you in pain, that’s all.”

Mydei is unable to hide the traces of conflict on his face. He looked poised to argue, but seeing that Phainon didn’t seem too keen on backing down either, he decides against.

A sigh. “It’s a steep request. I’ll try not to die so easily next time, but I’m going to have you agree with me on one more thing.”

“Anything.”

“Your tears,” is all Mydei says. Seeing Phainon’s confused expression, he continues, “The sight of it misleads me.”

Phainon always thought that crying is an appropriate way to release emotions—frustration, sadness, and even joy. As a man, he never thought it to be embarrassing. Even Aglaea had commended him once for being able to express such extreme emotions, something that she’s not capable of apparently.

Perhaps the Kremnoans see tears as a sign of weakness. Given that Mydei has entrusted Phainon of watching his back, a blatant show of vulnerability might weaken Mydei’s resolve in thinking that Phainon is strong and worthy enough.

There’s nothing else left to do but to comply.

“Alright. I’ll try to rein in my emotions next time. But if you die again, I can’t promise that I won’t shed some tears.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “Tears are precious,” he says. And though he may sound admonishing, Phainon couldn’t help but notice the hint of softness that belies the firm tone. “Don’t waste yours so carelessly. Especially not for my sake.”

Phainon sighs heavily, feigning reluctance. “If His Highness commands it, who am I to disobey?”

“I forgot how insufferable you are.”

“Does that mean you’ve found me quite agreeable for some time now?”

Mydei scoffs. “I abhor lies so I’ll choose not to answer that question.”

Phainon raises an eyebrow. “What about the question tempts you to lie?”

Instead of the expected scathing response, Mydei simply lies down and buries himself beneath the blanket. Phainon stares at the Mydei-shaped lump out of disbelief.

“You should leave,” came Mydei’s muffled voice after some time. “I’m rather exhausted.”

So Mydei chooses to retreat this time. Phainon doesn't intend to push his teasing further.

"Do you wish for me to draw the drapes close?" Phainon asks, standing up from the bed.

"That won't be necessary."

That sounds like a goodbye more than anything. Phainon honors Mydei's wishes and turns on his heel. But before he could enter the hallway that led to the door, he heard his name being called.

"Phainon."

Phainon halts in his steps and turns to Mydei who has his head poked out of the blankets. It's an endearing sight, one that causes Phainon to feel as if he'd just been punched in the gut.

"Yes?" Phainon asks weakly.

"Thank you for having my back," Mydei says. There's a hint of a smile on his lips, eyes of gold glistening against Kephale's Dawn. "I'll let you in on my story someday. Consider it as my thanks."

Phainon sighs, unable to help a smile of his own. *There's no need,* he wanted to say. But it would be a lie to do so for he is very much eager to learn more about Mydei, the person who's managed to retain his curiosity consistently for the past two months.

And to respect the Kremnoan's innate need for honor, Phainon shall only accept Mydei's gratitude without complaint.

"I appreciate that," Phainon responds earnestly. "I hope you get well soon, Mydei."

Mydei nods lightly in return before settling back beneath the covers. This time, Phainon doesn't linger.

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Receipt of Purchases

Decorative Sabany-style red-figure amphora, side-table appropriate *(Treasure of Ages)* • *80,000 Balance Coins*

Pink Carnations, large bouquet *(Ianthe's Flower Shop)* • *5,300 Balance Coins*

Pomegranates (juiced), 5 minae *(Demetria's Fruit and Veg Store)* • *1,500 Balance Coins* + *100 Balance Coins for the juicing service*

Goat's Milk, 2 jars *(Okhema Fromagerie)* • *1,600 Balance Coins*

Honey Biscuits, 3 boxes *(Marmoreal Diner)* • *3,000 Balance Coins*

Chamomile Aromatherapy for Muscle Pain, 2 vials *(Iris' Apothecary)* • *1,200 Balance Coins*

Signed Buyer: *Lord Phainon*

Delivery Address: *Lord Mydei's Chambers, Room of the Flame Lily. Chrysos Heirs' Tower, the Marmoreal Palace (Received)*

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Chapter End Notes

????? they're in love, your honor. next chapter, we will dig deep into all those courting rituals as promised heh.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

as always, thank you so so much for reading!! i devour all your kudos and comments like a starved peasant. very much appreciated <3

Chapter 4: might of a warrior, worth of a lover

Chapter Summary

> Phainon unknowingly tips the scales that signifies the equality he shares with Mydei. He offers something of profound weight, one that could only be balanced with affection.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

fate season, month of balance

7 months before the present time

· · — ·· — · ·

To present one's prey to a desired lover signifies the commencement of courtship. *It is an essential tradition that our ancestors have faithfully adhered to since the Era Bellica, one that signifies a hunter's might and capability to provide for one's own during wartimes. The bigger and more magnificent the catch, the more worthy the hunter.*

...gold and produce are acceptable rewards, but even better is ***the hand of the person bearing the hunter's affections****...*

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Chapter 1: The Art of the Hunt

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Phainon thinks he's had enough.

The Chrysos Heirs residing in the Marmoreal Palace typically convene for the *deipnon* before retiring to their chambers, right before the Parting Hour ends. For Phainon, it is a mealtime he used to look forward to the most.

That's right. *Used* to.

The Heroes' Mageiros, Sir Parmenion, was of old age and had subsequently fallen ill during the second week of the Month of Gate. Aglaea had then gave him his retirement notice in due haste so he could spend more time with his family and rest to recover his health.

It was Mydei who took up the mantle of Heroes' Mageiros after that.

Having proven his prowess not only in battle, but also in the kitchen, the Chrysos Heirs allowed Mydei the pleasure of preparing their meals. Which meant that Phainon had to endure Mydei's cooking for three full weeks now.

Emphasis on *endure*.

During Sir Parmenion's time, the Chrysos Heirs shared the same meal. But Mydei took it upon himself to specifically prepare different ones in accordance to everyone's tastes.

On Aglaea's plate was a light serving of buttery white beans glazed in a rich tomato sauce mixed with delicately sliced garlic and onions. It is then topped with freshly picked herbs served with a side of horiatiki.

Castorice's meal consisted of three bell peppers of generous size, almost akin to that of a child's small fist, stuffed with a mix of seasoned rice, pine, nuts, raisins, and a variety of herbs. Mydei even took the liberty of garnishing the dish with fresh edible flowers, some of it sprinkled onto the yogurt that served as an appropriate pair for the meal.

The Holy Maidens, on the other hand, share a plate of doll-shaped puff pastries stuffed with sautéed spinach, leeks, and cream cheese, served with a side platter of apples, carrots, and celery stalks fancily cut into adorable little shapes.

Before Phainon could wallow in his envy, Mydei emerges from the doorway that led to the kitchen. He then sets his own meal down on his place at the dining table, which is just directly across from Phainon, before taking a seat.

Today, Mydei's meal consists of a grilled chicken souvlaki with a side of tabbouleh, that's made with a mix of bulgur wheat, tomatoes, parsley, and onion, tossed in both olive oil and lemon juice which made the salad glisten appetizingly.

Phainon looks down at his own meal and *sighs*.

He can't even begin to try eloquently describing it. The food Mydei prepared for him is simply just a gray sludge on a plate. It's not even a porridge, and there's not a single slice of meat or vegetable in there.

In hindsight, it's much better than yesterday's meal—which only consisted of a stick and nothing else. Phainon feels his stomach grumble in protest.

As the others began to dig in after muttering their prayers of gratitude to Phagousa and Georios, Phainon casts a glance towards Mydei in front of him before clearing his throat. It is effective in garnering the attention of the man.

"Mydei," Phainon began. Today is the day he takes a stand. "Did you perhaps serve me an entrée of quality grade cement drizzled with the shimmering slush of a dromas' saliva?"

Mydei couldn't even be bothered to put up an irritated front, or perhaps ruthlessly admonish Phainon for choosing such insulting descriptions for a meal he personally prepared. In light

of the circumstance, he looked rather calm. Unnervingly so.

“An astute observation,” is all Mydei could say. And then he takes a bite of his chicken.

Phainon is going to lose his mind.

“Are you serious? I have to fend off the Titankin terrorizing the northwest border after this, from the Curtain-Fall Hour to tomorrow’s Entry Hour,” Phainon laments, rather desperate. “As the Heroes’ Mageiros, at least give me something decent to eat so I don’t collapse due to malnutrition while I fulfill my duties.”

The volume of his voice had risen unintentionally, the last of his words echoing throughout the marble walls of the Grand Dining Hall. Everyone had ceased partaking in their meal. With the exception of Aglaea, Castorice and the Holy Maidens have evidently grown tense in their seats.

Despite the simmering conflict, Mydei simply raises an eyebrow at Phainon, clearly unbothered by the sudden outburst. Phainon feels shame creep up on him and sighs, looking away.

“I… apologize.”

He throws a quick glance at Mydei’s way only to find that the other’s eyebrow still remains to be raised, urging Phainon to continue.

Phainon does so, like a puppet on a string with nary an agency to his own actions. “My gratefulness knows no bounds for having you, Mydei, take the time to provide a…” Phainon trails off in favor of swallowing thickly as he stares at the contents of his plate. Indeed, it still looks disgusting. “...very *delightful* looking meal just for me.”

Mydei hums, satisfied. Phainon sends his prayers to all the Titans who are willing to set aside time from Their busy schedules of either being dead or wallowing in their madness just to listen to his woes.

Even the ever so merciful Kephale would turn Their back away from this abomination of a meal; Okhema would no longer know Dawn if They were to consume Mydei’s creation as an offering. Not to mention, the gray sludge on Phainon’s plate looked as if it’s only moments away from possessing its own sentience.

Perhaps it would be better for Phainon’s blade to end the existence of this unnamed atrocity. That, or he should just set fire to the entire thing.

But at the end of the day, it is *still* Mydei’s creation. Mydei prepared it *specifically* for him. How could he dare think of such disrespectful methods of discarding Mydei’s cooking instead of just handling the matter properly?

“Mydei,” Phainon calls out again, gentler this time. He can’t give up. Tomorrow, he’ll be subjected to the same sickening torment of being fed *things* that are not even edible. He has

to put a stop to this nonsense *now*. “There must be some other dish I could eat, yesterday’s leftovers perhaps?”

“There are no leftovers,” Mydei replies curtly without missing a beat.

Phainon catches his bottom lip between his teeth, rethinking his approach. “Anything. I’ll eat anything—”

“Then why bother looking for something else? Partake in what has been served.”

“I’ll eat *anything* that won’t kill a fully-grown human with divine blood running through his veins,” Phainon reiterates firmly. “Yesterday, you made me eat a *stick*.”

“The stick had *leaves*, Deliverer,” Mydei graciously points out. “Or are you so blinded by your concerns, so much so that you choose to dwell fervidly on the misfortunes instead of the blessings?”

Phainon scoffs. “*That’s* your argument? Mydei, it’s been so long since I had a proper meat stew. Ask me what meat tastes like and I’ll undoubtedly fail to answer.”

His itinerary was quite full today so he didn’t have the time to take a trip down to the Marmoreal Market and purchase something to eat from Kyros. To say that Phainon was starving would be an understatement. He could eat a whole dromas in one sitting at this point.

Mydei gives him an unimpressed look, gaze dropping to the pile of gray mush on his plate. Phainon *swears* he saw a hint of a smirk grace Mydei’s lips, only for it to be gone as quickly as it had appeared.

“I can’t make anything else,” Mydei simpers, dabbing the corners of his lips with a napkin. What a prince. “We’ve run out of meat, you see. Hence, why I had to forgo it when preparing your meal.”

Phainon feels his eye twitch.

Mydei’s been forgoing meat when it comes to preparing Phainon’s meal since he became the Heroes’ Mageiros. Correction, Phainon does remember eating something of the sort one time, but the steak was rather blue and he swears there were maggots crawling and making a home on the surface.

(“Mydei, can I even eat this?” Phainon asks wrily, eyeing the little maggot that had begun to crawl up his fork. Goosebumps erupt on his skin as he feels bile rise up to his throat.

“You have a mouth don’t you?” Mydei asks in turn, an irritated non-answer. “And you’re capable of digestion.”

Phainon made the toilet his home after that incident. Thankfully, Mydei never served him anything that involved live crawlies and spoiled steak. Together, that is.)

“The Heroes’ Pantry… ran out of *meat?*” Phainon repeats, disbelief etched in his tone.

There has never been such an instance in the long history of the Flame-Chase Journey. A most unfortunate circumstance indeed. Even Phainon, who barely steps foot into the Marmoreal Palace's kitchen, knew that the Heroes' Pantry is always well-stocked with various ingredients, fresh and of the finest quality even.

For it to run out of meat—

"I'm not entirely opposed to a meatless dish," Phainon counters with a frown, sullen with how he must come to terms with the fact that his expectations ought to be lowered a bit more. "Did you also perhaps run out of vegetables for a small salad?"

Mydei pretends to think about it in a manner that is so evidently spurious. Phainon itches to call him out for being so difficult beyond belief.

"I'm not sure," Mydei muses, humming lightly. "Maybe if you apologize sincerely for what you did yesterday, I could be impelled to go ahead and start planting some lettuce for you. If I'm not mistaken, it should be ready when the Month of Joy comes around, as most harvests are."

And there it is. Suddenly it all makes sense. *So that's what this is about.*

"I told you it was an accident," Phainon reasons.

Mydei nods, even if he looked the furthest from being convinced. "How else could it be seen as? You, on a dromas' back, laughing with great amusement whilst your finger had so tauntingly pointed at *me*—"

"Listen—"

"—who's covered in *mud* of which *you* and your dromas had so kindly splattered."

The Grand Dining Hall was almost quiet. Phainon hears Castorice gasp softly at the revelation, the anxious murmurs of the Holy Maidens, and Aglaea… Well, she had far more important things to do (like finishing her meal) than to be invested in the squabbles of two Chrysos Heirs.

Mydei looked smug, assuming that he had claimed the upper hand. Unfortunately for him, Phainon won't go down so easily without at least defending himself.

"I was high up!" Phainon exclaims. "How was I supposed to know that there was a puddle of mud beside you?"

"*Really?*" The corners of Mydei's lips quirk upward in a mean smile. "If that's the case, it's either you forgot that dromases are not allowed in an area exclusively for foot traffic, or you *deliberately* navigated your dromas to stomp *five* times on a mud puddle that's in the middle of the market, right where *I* was standing."

Phainon falters. "Dorothea is a…" He clears his throat, mustering conviction. "Dorothea is a *very* spirited dromas! How could I possibly ever hope to control her with a leash? And I only approached you because I wanted you to meet her!"

The reasoning is true. To some extent.

Dorothea is a dromas that Phainon has known since her hatching. Now that she's mature enough to have a saddle on her back, the caretakers thought it appropriate for Phainon to be her first passenger.

The skies of yesterday were clear and Kephale's Dawn shone warm golden light upon Okhema, no hint of clouds or rain. During their leisurely tour around the city, they passed by the outskirts of the Marmoreal Market where Phainon's eyes were immediately drawn to the sight of blonde hair dipped in crimson, exposed tan skin marred in scarlet streaks, and the blood red fabric of the garments a certain Kremnoan crown prince fashioned from the distance.

Phainon thought that Mydei might appreciate sharing the honor of being one of Dorothea's first passengers. That assumption, however, was thrown out of the window when Phainon lost control of Dorothea.

The mud puddle had been too tempting to play with for a dromas still new in her maturity. Dorothea's youth remains, to the chagrin of one oblivious Chrysos Heir who had to unfortunately bear the consequence of the dromas' merrymaking.

Phainon is not entirely innocent either. The sight of Mydei, who never fails to appear regal in any and every circumstance, drenched in mud with a disbelieving scowl on his face was enough for Phainon to put even Phagousa in shame for the extent of his laughter.

The rest was history.

(Mydei had subsequently dangled Phainon by the neck atop a nearby cliff with the threat of dropping the latter to his death. Phainon had apologized many times whilst gasping for air, still unable to hold his snickers at the sight of Mydei's fair face soiled with mud, eyes of gold sharp and blazing with barely concealed fury.

Thankfully, both Kremnoan and Okheman soldiers managed to pry the two Chrysos Heirs away from each other before Phainon could experience the feeling of being subjected to the Hand of Shadow's cold embrace.)

"I already said I was sorry," Phainon says.

"People tend to speak nonsense when put through dire circumstances," Mydei replies pointedly. "How should I know if you sincerely meant the apology you offered?"

"Mydei, I'm *really* sorry."

Mydei lets the apology hang in the air for a moment. Eventually, he nods. "It's acceptable enough."

The sigh of relief that escaped the lips of the others in the room was too loud than what should be considered as normal. The resumption of the clinking sound of utensils molded

from gold against the ivory plates is an indication that the unwilling eavesdroppers have resumed to partake in their meals.

The calamity was quelled, Phainon and Mydei have made peace with each other without the need for violence. It would be a shame if the Grand Dining Hall were to be reduced to mere ruins.

Only, Phainon knew Mydei well enough to distinguish if he was truly forgiven. The insistent avoidance of Mydei's gaze was one clear sign that he's still sporting some unsettled grievances.

Phainon wears a strained smile on his lips, willing to put Mydei's adamance to appear indifferent to the test. "Now that we've settled the matter, can I have a salad?"

Mydei gives him a dry look, still undeniably cross despite Phainon's attempts to convey his genuine remorse. Three months into their acquaintance, Phainon is slowly, but surely, finding it easier to read Mydei like an unfurled scroll.

"It would be disrespectful to the meal if I were to leave my seat without finishing it just to make you a *salad*, Deliverer."

"It wouldn't be so much of an issue if you didn't forbade me from stepping foot in the kitchen," Phainon retorts. "I could go and make myself a salad right now. Only if you'd promise not to tie me up on a stake and hover me above an open flame like you did the last time you spotted me barely walking through the kitchen's doorway."

"I've heard a lot from Sir Parmenion, questionable explosions and all." Mydei smirks, finding amusement in Phainon's kitchen failures without so much as acknowledging the serious allegations thrown against him. "It was ever a wonder how he's never able to reach the limit of his forbearance with you running amok. You won't be having the same privilege with me around."

Phainon, for the first time during the entire exchange, finds himself at a loss for what to respond. He considered Sir Parmenion as his close friend and even confided in him. How could the old man have the heart to easily betray him like this by speaking of the many incidents he had a hand in to his rival?

Seeing Phainon's distress, Mydei uses the opportunity to press on. Utterly merciless.

"Eat what I have prepared for you," Mydei says, his tone firm enough for the normal folk to understand that there's no room for negotiations. "It is by Talanton's guidance that I get you back for vexing me yesterday."

Not belonging to the category of normal folk mentioned above, Phainon simply rolls his eyes. "That still doesn't explain every horrible meal I've had since you took over the kitchen. I couldn't have vexed you all those times to earn such a horrible treatment."

At this point, it almost sounds as if Phainon is whining. To fight for a decent meal in exchange for his dignity sounds plausible enough. Rather unnecessary, though.

Mydei drops his knife and fork upon hearing Phainon's words, eyebrows furrowed together. "Why don't you take a guess?"

That sounds more like a, *You are indeed the source of my aggravation in all of those occasions. How dare you think otherwise.*

"Is that an accusation I hear?" Phainon questions, feigning offense. "Are you not averse to the idea of listing it all down, then? Do you have some sort of hidden record detailing all of my misdeeds upon your person?"

Mydei scoffs, a glint of something dangerous in his eyes. "You speak of proof? Pipe down, Deliverer, or you'll end up humiliating yourself."

"The Month of Balance demands fairness in honor of Talanton," Phainon insists. "During these past three weeks, I've let you get away with more than what most would consider hardly fair."

"Don't you speak of fairness in *my* presence."

"Why not? Are you perhaps horrified that you've gone too far with your so-called revenge against my so-called offenses against you?"

Mydei laughs sardonically. "I *do* have a record. I would show it to you but the dining table of five dromases in length is not long enough to accommodate the scroll in its unfurled entirety." He then takes a sip from his cup, no doubt containing his beloved honey brew. Phainon can't even be granted the honor of partaking in a glass of water. "Now, eat your food."

"And die of poison?"

"It's not poisoned."

Phainon crosses his arms, leaning back on his chair. Sarcastically, he says, "Right. Because you *tasted* it."

Mydei nods lightly, giving Phainon a small pleased smile. The beauty of it might be enough to quell Phainon's feelings of injustice, but it is his hunger for a warm, decent meal that steels his resolve.

"Of course I tasted it," Mydei admits as if it was the most obvious thing in the world, nothing out of the ordinary or anything.

Upon hearing this, everyone had stopped eating once again. Phainon can feel the others' attention land on the gray abomination on his plate before their gazes dart at Mydei, who had apparently managed to stomach the atrocious thing and live to tell the tale.

Well. Mydei is not exactly capable of dying now, is he?

"It tastes horrible," Mydei says, an answer to the unspoken question that hung palpably in the air. "Far more than how it looks in my proud opinion."

Phainon could not believe his ears, eyes wide and almost bulging out of their sockets as his mouth laid open out of pure shock. He feels very faint. Aghast, he turns to Aglaea who was currently just finishing up the last remaining crumbs of her meal.

“Aglaea, are you *hearing* this man?” Phainon asks, almost like a plea.

Aglaea’s clouded gaze looks up. She turns to Mydei with a smile of her own. “Mydeimos, dinner was magnificent as always.”

Castorice nods, her own plate empty. “The taste of life on my tongue is the most pleasant sensation. Thank you kindly for this meal, Lord Mydei.”

“You’ve really outdone yourself this time, De!” Trianne exclaims, giving Mydei a thumbs up.

“Yes. I think this meal is one of my favorites now,” agreed Tribbie.

Trinnon is still munching on her share of the puff pastry so she couldn’t quite convey her opinions just yet.

Mydei says nothing in return at the sudden shower of praise, simply continuing his meal with a hint of pink coloring his face and the tips of his ears that don’t go unnoticed by Phainon’s keen observation.

Beside Mydei, Phainon catches Castorice looking at him and gestures for her to help. They’re close after all, surely Castorice would take Phainon’s side in this argument. Her sympathy would mean the world to him.

Unfortunately, Phainon’s initial expectations of their friendship were for naught, as Castorice only smiles lightly before taking a sip of her drink. Evidently, she’s not willing to get caught in the middle of Phainon and Mydei’s petty dispute.

Phainon sighs heavily, utterly defeated, betrayed by his own kin that he even considers as family. He picks up his spoon before taking out a relative amount from the gray sludge. With a shaky hand, he brings the foul-smelling curse of nature to his lips, taking a small bite with his eyes closed.

Miserably, he does agree that the food tastes as bad as it looks. What Phainon would give for a thin slab of meat at this moment.

The battle against the Titankin at the northwest border of Okhema waged for much longer than Phainon would have liked. By the second quint of the Lucid Hour, he was finished. And by the fourth quint of the Action Hour did he find himself at Okhema’s city gates.

With sweat beading upon his forehead, Phainon huffs and puffs as he drags the heavy carcass of the boar king that once resided in the forests of Okhema’s northwest border.

Aglaea had expressed her displeasure countless times when news of the boar king wreaking havoc upon her defenses were made known by the golden threads. Since Phainon was already in the area, he took it upon himself to hit two birds with one stone—ease Aglaea from her worries, and hunt for a decent meat source so Mydei wouldn't have an excuse to claim the lack of it.

The carcass is as wide as three fully-grown dromases standing closely side by side, and as tall as a two-storey building. To say that Phainon takes delight in having to drag it by a rope in such a long distance would be an utter lie. He wonders how Mydei would react to the sight of it.

The shadow of the boar king's carcass looms over the path as Phainon makes his way further into the city. The civilians passing by halt in their daily ministrations to point and stare out of pure astonishment, heads poking out of the windows of their homes to witness the scene, and some even had their teleslates out to record Phainon dragging the massive thing by his lonesome.

Phainon pays them no mind, only smiling occasionally at those who call his name in greeting. He's too exhausted to even talk, and if he stops to rest while in the middle of this arduous task, there's no guarantee that he'll be able to continue afterwards.

His body aches from the exertion, the rope he holds on to that is tied to the boar king rubbing his palms raw and causing blisters to form in its wake. Rapidly blinking away the sting of sweat as it drips down onto his eyes, Phainon reminds himself once again of why he's doing something so outrageously over-the-top.

Given the time of day, Mydei should be by the training grounds with the soldiers of the Kremnoan detachment. It's not that far away now. If Phainon doesn't collapse on the way, he might arrive just after the commencement of the Action Hour's final quint.

His calculations were not far off. As the bell tolls signalling the beginning of a new quint, Phainon is already by the entrance to the courtyard that led to the training grounds. There were Kremnoans stationed by the path and they, too, balked at the sight of the massive boar that Phainon was dragging.

"Good day," Phainon greets, trying to keep his voice steady as he wipes the sweat on his face with the back of his hand. "Where's your prince?"

"His Highness is currently keeping the children occupied while the soldiers take their break," one of the bewildered Kremnoan replies. "You can head on in, Lord Phainon. His Highness would be pleased to see you return with such an impressively glorious catch."

Phainon would beg to differ about Mydei being pleased to see him in this state—unrefined and sweating buckets, on the verge of collapse.

With a grunt, Phainon resumes his journey of dragging the carcass further in until he reaches the vast area where warriors hailing from different nations who had now sought refuge in the holy city keep their combat prowess sharp and refined.

Upon Phainon's arrival, the bustle of activity gradually stops as the warriors gawk at what he had just brought.

"Did Lord Phainon catch that by himself?"

"My goodness! As expected of a Chrysos Heir!"

"That beast is enough to feed a hundred men for a month!"

Phainon scans the murmuring crowd for any signs of a blonde haired, half-dressed man in red. By the group of children near the well, Phainon's gaze met that of Mydei's who looked equally as stupefied as the rest of the people in the area.

Gritting his teeth, Phainon resumes to pull upon the boar king's heavy weight behind him until he stands right in front of the other. The shadow cast by the huge carcass looms over Mydei, a rather comical sight that makes him appear quite small.

Phainon bites back a laugh at Mydei's clear astonishment, uncharacteristic and precious.

"Heard you ran out of meat so I brought some back," Phainon says cheekily, trying to keep his voice stable enough to appear as if he's not moments away from biting the dust.

Mydei continues to stare at the fallen beast behind Phainon with eyes as wide as saucers and lips slightly parted.

When Mydei finally humors Phainon with a reply, all that comes out of his lips is an angry, "*What* are you playing at, Deliverer?"

The response is not unexpected. Phainon knew Mydei would take offense now that he lacked the liberty of making excuses to continue tormenting Phainon with outrageous meals.

"Don't you like it?" Phainon teases, a hand firmly tapping the boar's snout as he grins proudly. "He's very hard to catch, you know. But I still prevailed in the end, *obviously*. Now you can't skimp out on the meat when preparing my food."

Mydei's frown only deepens, his gaze darting between Phainon and the boar king. The furrow on his eyebrows conveys that he's thinking way too hard about something. How Phainon wishes to have but a mere glimpse at the inner workings of Mydei's mind.

After a while of gaping, Mydei starts talking again. "You—" His voice wavers. "Are you *sure* about this?"

Is Phainon sure that he's willing to eat boar meat up until the time where the methods of preserving it have run its course?

"Deadly sure," Phainon affirms with a nod.

He knows of Mydei's creativity in the kitchen. The man can craft a dish using the same ingredients and make it different every time. Phainon is convinced he won't ever get tired of eating just boar meat.

At his answer, he hears the murmurs grow louder, distinctively coming from the Kremnoan soldiers that are currently witnessing the exchange. Before Phainon could glean on what they're discussing hushly amongst themselves, his attention was caught by the sound of Mydei clearing his throat.

"You…" Mydei sighs. He looks flustered for some reason. Perhaps it was due to the exertion of training. "You can't take this back, Deliverer."

Phainon wonders why Mydei even expected him to return a *dead, massive,* and *heavy* boar king back to its home forest when Phainon almost keeled over from the exhaustion alone of hauling the boar to the holy city by foot without assistance.

"Do you actually want me to die?" Phainon asks incredulously. Mydei doesn't hate him that much, does he? Regardless if they argue on the daily, they're still friends—Phainon's closest one, even.

Mydei only rolls his eyes at the dramatics. "I suppose you do possess some modicum of honor and self-preservation."

He then brushes past Phainon in favor of inspecting the catch, poking at the meat and examining the kill method—of which Phainon made sure was clean and humane. After a brief nod and a satisfied hum, Mydei turns his attention back at the hunter who gloats in the success of his hunt.

"This is acceptable," Mydei remarks. Phainon feels himself preen at the praise. "Come and assist me with cutting this up and I shall make you something *decent* with it."

The victorious smile that graces Phainon's lips can't be helped at all. *Finally*. All of his hard work had not been in vain. Today marks the end of his suffering.

The Kremnoans offer their assistance in transporting the boar to the Marmoreal Palace, of which Phainon is eternally grateful for. The perks of being friends with a prince is not something to be taken for granted indeed.

Once the flesh was separated from bone and the meat divided into an astounding number of sections, it was then salted, smoked, pickled, and whatever other methods Mydei could come up with on the fly to ensure that the meat would last months in the cellar.

After such an extensive labor, Phainon is rewarded with a piping hot, boar meat stew that had been slowly cooked in a clay pot over an open flame, mixed with fresh herbs and spices as well as a generous variety of vegetables.

The taste alone is enough to make up for the three months of eating literal scum. Phainon then conveys his sentiments to Mydei who sat across from him with a smug expression as he watched Phainon utterly devour the meal he prepared.

"Cross me again and you'll suffer the consequences," Mydei threatens without much heat.

“Not if I have my dinner beforehand at the Marmoreal Diner,” Phainon chimes, relishing in the savory taste of the stew that lingers on his tongue. “Kyros agreed to stay open until the first quint of the Parting Hour just to accommodate me.”

Mydei’s scowl doesn’t go unnoticed as he leaves his seat and stomps away, grumbling Kremnoan curses under his breath.

The next day, there’s a dead bug on Phainon’s plate.

Thankfully, with enough coaxing, Phainon is able to convince Mydei to serve him something else. Mydei then re-emerges from the kitchen barely even a moment later with a plate containing slices of boar meat sausages paired nicely with grilled zucchini, eggplant, and tomatoes, as well as a generous serving of orzo pilaf, seasoned with fresh herbs and a light drizzle of lemon juice.

Phainon surmises that Mydei couldn’t have possibly managed to put together such an elaborate dish in that little amount of time. The only possibility is—

“Mydei, did you already have this prepared beforehand?”

Mydei’s glare is sharp and searing. “Shut up and start eating before I stuff this up your arse and make you undergo a reverse digestion.”

Tearfully, Phainon obediently does as he’s told.

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Despite the Month of Balance being a time where crime is not so rampant, it doesn’t mean that humans, who are made in Kephale’s likeness, possessed Their flawless nature. The urge to do wrong is innate in every person, and every tip against the balance of good and evil only serves to insult the Scale of Justice’s principles.

News of theft has been running rampant all across the holy city and the alleged offenders are none other than the group of people who harbors most, if not all, of Okhema’s prejudice—the Kremnoan detachment.

Dragging along a cart filled with supplies behind him, Phainon makes his way towards the settlement that housed Mydei’s people. Three months in and they seem to be adjusting relatively well. Dwellings were built substantially with clay and wood, the sight of tents are sparse indicating stability, farmland is thriving with fertile soil and bountiful produce, and animals are aflock and herded behind fences.

Despite the seemingly harmonious atmosphere, Phainon could sense the heaviness of anxiety and tension in the air.

As he trudged down the path, Phainon could feel the eyes of the Kremnoans upon him, the skin at the back of his neck prickling at the attention. On a regular day, they would've said something in greeting, or perhaps even stop Phainon on the way for a quick chat.

None of that happens, Phainon's amicable relationship with the Kremnoans regrettably placed behind the agitation stemming from the injustice of their current circumstance.

Thankfully, he was able to spot Mydei shortly after his arrival, standing in front of a house and engaged in conversation with a woman carrying a small child. He could tell that Mydei already knew of his approach by the way his shoulders have become tense and how he subsequently bade goodbye to the woman once Phainon was within earshot.

"What are you doing here, Deliverer?" is Mydei's way of saying hello.

"I heard the people of Okhema are giving you trouble," Phainon answers.

Mydei scoffs. "Well, what did you expect when that thrice-damned ornament keeps on spreading falsehoods about me and my tribe? I swear by Talanton, the thievery case going around was not our doing."

Of course it's not. Kremnoans are no followers of Zagreus. They have honor to uphold and wouldn't resort to such underhanded methods just to ease their daily lives. If anything, the Kremnoan detachment ought to be the furthest from being considered as suspects.

"I already spoke to the Verax Leos about that," Phainon assures. "Aglaea is making sure that your name is being cleared at the moment."

Mydei only scoffs. He then catches sight of the cart behind Phainon, filled with crates containing produce, meat, clothes, and even weapons. The furrow in his eyebrows only grows all the more prominent.

"What's this?" Mydei asks, almost a demand.

Phainon scratches his nape sheepishly. "These are for you and your people. Consider it to be recompense."

Mydei huffs, seemingly offended. "I don't need *you* spending your riches so excessively on something you need not care about," he hisses.

"Why wouldn't I care? I know the state of your tribe is important to you. You're important to me so, by extension, this issue bothers me just as much," Phainon says, hoping that his sincerity would seep through. "I even had to go around scolding the vendors for denying you purchase."

The look of conflict on Mydei's face is evident, poised to turn down Phainon's efforts to help. Phainon wishes that Mydei would just set aside his pride and stop shouldering all of his burdens alone. Accepting assistance is not a sign of weakness, after all.

Perhaps Phainon's sentiments are able to be read through his face, or maybe Mydei just knew what Phainon would say the moment that he so much as dismisses the aid being graciously

handed out without him having to ask.

“You have my thanks,” Mydei says, his resignation palpable enough, well aware of how persistent Phainon could be and deemed that he neither possessed the time nor the energy to deal with that. “Rest assured, I will pay you back.”

Phainon smiles wryly. They’ve been over this back and forth before. “You need not to.”

“I insist,” Mydei says, a hand on Phainon’s shoulder in a flash.

The sudden contact catches Phainon off-guard for Mydei is not known to initiate physical touches so often. Despite the formidable gauntlet Mydei wore, the touch remains to be gentle, his body’s insistence to express gratitude betraying the tough exterior he intends to put up. Phainon can’t help but find this involuntary gesture endearing to a fault.

Given Mydei’s expression, it seemed likely that he, too, knew not of the answer for such an uncharacteristic act. He then withdraws his hand immediately. Phainon hopes that his own displeasure at the loss of contact is not that perceptible to be observed so easily.

Mydei coughs, face and ears coloring beautifully in varying shades of pink and red. “My apologies.”

“It’s okay,” Phainon says, wondering why he sounds so out of breath all of sudden, rendered weak by a mere hand on his shoulder.

Mydei’s hand.

“I didn’t know what came over me,” Mydei continues.

Phainon nods. “Yeah. I know.”

Mydei frowns. “You *know?*”

“No! I—” Phainon makes an attempt to rearrange his thoughts and hopes desperately that his words don’t come out so garbled. “I mean, it’s alright.”

“What is?”

“This.”

Phainon does a nondescript gesture referring to the space between him and Mydei. He wanted to convey that it’s alright for two men to engage in platonic shoulder pats. They’ve sparred countless times before, now familiar with every crevice and valley of muscle, how it tenses with every movement, the strength of every jab.

A hand on the shoulder should be the last thing to cause alarm. It is rather unnecessary to stress about, and frankly, doesn’t make quite a lot of sense.

Even if Mydei looked as if he had a lot of questions in his mind, he opted not to pursue the matter anymore, a sigh escaping his lips.

“Forgive me for my lack of interest in inquiring any further details that would serve as an explanation to your confusing replies of profound brevity,” Mydei states drily. The formality in the way he spoke hints that something is amiss. “If that is all, Deliverer, I must excuse myself now for I still have supplies to distribute.”

Mydei walks over to the cart, his gait lacking the signature self-assured swagger and appearing more exhausted than anything. The odd sight causes concern to spread within Phainon like a ripple in the water. Unable to help himself, he catches Mydei’s arm in his hand, keeping the other in place.

Now closer in their proximity, he is able to notice the dullness in Mydei’s eyes of gold, the paleness of his complexion, and the slump on his shoulders. He looked indubitably spent, the dark circles beneath his eyes more prominent than usual.

“Mydei, when was the last time you slept?”

Mydei doesn’t even try to wrestle his arm out of Phainon’s hold. He has simply given up. Phainon wonders about the extent of his weariness, or perhaps Mydei is simply calling it even between them from when he inadvertently initiated physical contact from earlier.

None of those reasons are favorable in Phainon’s opinion. It is a selfish and depraved thought that Mydei simply allows himself to bask in Phainon’s touch just because he wanted to. Impossible and unprincipled, Phainon wonders just where these thoughts are coming from.

“Two days ago,” Mydei answers, pulling Phainon out of his restless spiral.

Two days ago, Phainon thought to himself. Mydei did not know rest since two days ago.

Before Phainon could even begin to express his disapproval, Mydei continues, “That woman whom I was talking to earlier is with child. Due to the rumors flying around about my tribe engaging in thievery, she and her husband were unable to procure adequate sustenance to ensure the health of their family and the baby she’s carrying. I’ve been helping them and many others in need of my assistance since, and have yet to take a rest.”

“If that’s the case, you should go back to the Marmoreal Palace,” Phainon urges, unable to hide his distress. He never expected the consequences of the rumors to be so dire. “I’ll send someone to distribute the supplies in your stead.”

“Save your breath, Deliverer. No Okheman would be willing to help us.”

“By *my* word, they *will*,” Phainon declares through gritted teeth. “And *I’ll* be making it clear that there’ll be no room for any sort of opposition.”

He notices a brief sign of discomfort grace Mydei’s features, gone in an instant in a mere blink of an eye. Phainon then realizes belatedly that his grip on Mydei’s arm had tightened significantly.

Phainon lets go of Mydei, the feelings of shame and regret unpleasant and bitter, but not entirely unfounded.

“Mydei, I’m sorry.”

“I’m far from being fragile, Deliverer,” Mydei replies, his tone light and without a hint of resentment. “It was nothing. Your grip is still far too weak to cause me pain.”

Phainon allows himself to laugh, relief bathing him anew and causing his misgivings to be washed away when Mydei throws him a small smile, radiant despite his obvious fatigue. Perhaps Phainon had been worried for nothing. Mydei is ever so kind, ever so benevolent.

The bell tolls from afar, signalling that the first quint of the Parting Hour is upon them. Only then does Phainon remembers his initial commitments before he made his way to the Kremnoan detachment’s settlement by the city’s outskirts.

He turns to Mydei. “I’ll send someone to help.”

This time, Mydei does not argue. “Very well.”

“I would be more inclined to help you myself but—” Aglaea’s blank expression makes its way in Phainon’s mind, reminding him of his duties to Amphoreus. “Aglaea is sending me away on another mission.”

Phainon knew that Mydei understood more than anyone that duty should always come first above anything else. He hopes that Mydei won’t hold his absence in these trying times against him.

Mydei doesn’t, as expected. And Phainon almost wishes that he’d put up some sort of protest if only to get Phainon to stay. It would be an entertaining display, for sure.

“You’ve done enough by providing my people with these supplies,” Mydei says, nodding at the cart. He then turns to Phainon. “May Janus bless the paths you take, may Talanton guide your blade fair and true, and may the sane Nikador allow you to keep your courage even in the face of many dangers.”

Phainon huffs out a breathy chuckle, almost out of disbelief more than anything. He never imagined Mydei to wish him luck in such a way. This is a first.

“Why, with your blessings, I’m most certain that I’ll be able to slay the most powerful Titankin there is!” Phainon proclaims, his confidence abound that he barely remembers to keep it in check lest he appear vain in front of the man who abhors it more than anything.

Mydei doesn’t seem to mind, finding amusement in the situation instead.

“Foolish,” Mydei admonishes with fond futility. “It is unbecoming to be a man who is all talk and no action. Go ahead and bring back the proof of your successful endeavor, I dare you.”

Phainon only grins. “Is that a challenge?”

Upon Phainon’s return the next day, he gifts Mydei the proof that he seeks—a magnificent trophy he procured from slaying the most exalted Titankin he encountered during his mission.

The golden wheeled blade that was once carried by the minacious Furiae Praetor shimmers against the light of Kephale's Dawn as Mydei takes its heavy weight in his hands to examine carefully.

The scratches on its surface is as a manifestation of the purpose it has served at the hands of its former master, one of which Phainon considers nothing less of a formidable adversary.

"A Harbinger of Strife," Mydei notes breathlessly.

"No need to be so impressed," Phainon teases. "I do believe that you're equally as capable of accomplishing the same feat yourself."

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Only the Furiae Praetors who have earned Nikador's recognition are permitted to carry a Harbinger of Strife." He readjusts his grip on the object. "And you even managed to extricate it so fully without compromising its delicate shape."

Phainon feels as if he ought to be scared. Something's not right. "What's up with you today?"

"What do you mean?"

"You're being too nice," Phainon answers earnestly, faking a shiver as he wraps his arms around himself out of defense. Even if Mydei's praises are music to his ears, he can't deny that there's something unsettling going on at the moment. "Are you sick? Have you been drinking the water from the baths again?"

Mydei's aggrieved expression is so pronounced that it's almost funny, rendered speechless at Phainon's outrageous accusation.

"You—" He scoffs before resolutely turning his back on Phainon, poised to take his leave. "*Insufferable*. I can't believe that it's *you*, of all people."

Phainon watches with bewilderment as Mydei stomps away, carrying with him Phainon's trophy that's held so tightly by his hands that one might assume he's loath to part with it.

Scratching the back of his head, Phainon is left to stand alone right where Mydei left him, mulling over their exchange with a frown. He ponders that perhaps Mydei was simply in no mood to indulge in his jests.

With a shrug, Phainon makes his way towards the Marmoreal Palace to report the success of his task to Aglaea whom he surmises must be wearing thin in her patience for he was supposed to return a quint earlier.

Mydeimos is hardly the person you should seek first and foremost after a mission, Phainon can already hear her say. *If you wish for Mydeimos to take up the mantle as the leader of the Chrysos Heirs, then by all means make your sentiments known. This duty of mine is not something I fulfill out of self-indulgence alone.*

Phainon readies his apology with dread. He hopes that Aglaea would choose to be merciful this time.

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How to Appraise a Suitor's Trophy

(Kremnoan Standard)

…only one worthy of Kremnoan's hand can challenge the most fearsome of opponents single-handedly…

…even a small fragment of a Furiae Praetor's headpiece is worth the value of a hundred Furiae warriors upon Talanton's Scale…

…ranks amongst the Furiae Praetors are determined by whether or not one carries a Harbinger of Strife…

*…**to present a Harbinger of Strife as a trophy, it not only signifies the might of the warrior engaging in courtship, but also bestows esteem and honor upon the desired lover**…*

— contents of a crumpled piece of paper found on the rooftops at the Marmoreal Market

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Mydei proceeds to ignore Phainon after the incident with the trophy for a span of a lonely three days and counting. And now, Phainon is in the middle of chasing down the ever-elusive crown prince of Kremnos amidst the bustling market.

The sight of blonde hair and crimson fabric serves as Phainon's only guide as he sets his gaze straight whilst maneuvering himself through the crowd, unwavering in his resolve to put a stop to this odd lack of communication.

He succeeds in the end, one hand reaching out to take hold of Mydei's gauntlet-clad arm before pulling him towards a secluded corner where the loud chatter of the market is less pronounced.

Even if Mydei looked less than amused upon being abducted in the middle of the day and in plain sight, he doesn't make a move to fight his way out of the Phainon-shaped prison that he's in despite his capability for it, exuding the calmness of a deep ocean.

"Hi," Phainon greets with a smile, trapping Mydei's head against the wall with his arms.

"Hmph," Mydei greets in return. "What are you doing, slinking around like you're up to no good? You even made sure that my participation in your schemes is a given."

Mydei is not entirely unreasonable in his accusations. Being pushed to the wall of a secluded corner where there's no other people to act as witnesses is not exactly a good look, all things considered.

Only then does Phainon realize how close he and Mydei are—the tips of their noses barely a hairbreadth away from each other, warm breaths ghosting upon their skin, Mydei's scent permeating his senses, and the fact that those golden eyes of his do resemble that of a lion's upon closer inspection.

This is dangerous, Phainon thinks, enthralled with the way every strand of Mydei's eyelashes flutters with the wind, the diamond-shaped scarlet mark beneath his right eye striking, a stark contrast against the flawless tanned skin of Mydei's face. There are no wrinkles in sight despite the owner's habit of keeping his facial expression in a perpetual frown.

With great effort, Phainon manages to step back, putting a respectable amount of distance between him and Mydei. The latter was bound to call him out for it sooner or later anyway.

"Sorry. Did I surprise you?"

"I can sense you coming from a twenty *pous* radius," Mydei replies monotonously. "What do you want, Deliverer?"

Always so direct. And yet Mydei found no fault in ignoring him without so much as a word.

"Just to talk," Phainon answers. "I haven't had the chance to for the past three days. I know you just got back from a mission, but it's too early to retire so I thought it would be a good idea to invite you to come and leisurely spend the final quint of the Action Hour together at the Marmoreal Diner."

The slight crease in between Mydei's eyebrows is a telltale sign that he's going to turn Phainon down on his offer. It was to be expected, and it only confirms Mydei's adamance to avoid him for some reason.

Phainon deflates at the lack of a quick response, eyeing his shoes instead. "If you're too exhausted, I won't take it to heart if you do reject my invite." He feels rather desperate. If Mydei still refuses to talk to Phainon today, then he might as well consider Phainon a stranger. "I'd be more than willing to escort you to your chambers, if you're amenable to the idea."

His words are left to linger in the air for what felt like an agonizing moment. Long enough for Phainon to be able to almost commit to memory the irregular pattern of cracks etched upon the stone floor.

The silence was thankfully broken by a long and heavy sigh.

Phainon looks up, ready to accept the fact that Mydei has finally reached the limits of his forbearance when it comes to dealing with him. The look of conflict on Mydei's face is not exactly the reassuring kind in Phainon's very anxious opinion.

“You don’t have to look so dejected,” Mydei says, a hint of a reprimand in his tone. “I haven’t even told you my answer yet and you’ve already gone on to play your part as a kicked chimera.”

“Why would anyone kick a chimera?” Phainon asks, suddenly feeling a strong sense of déjà vu. “They’re adorable.”

“Exactly.”

Mydei and his one-word responses.

Phainon scratches at his nape, a nervous habit. “You looked as if you were on the verge of declining my invite.”

“How so?” Mydei says, raising an eyebrow. “Are you perhaps claiming that you know me so well?”

“Enough to be able to distinguish when you’re purposefully avoiding me, yes.”

The satisfying manner in which Mydei’s facial expression morphs from genuine surprise to a deathly scowl needs to be studied. Phainon makes a mental note to discuss it with the wise philosophers who linger at the Kephale Plaza, for how could such a simple act of expression capture his interest so?

“Am I wrong?” Phainon asks, insistent, eyes shining with a faintly veiled amusement.

Mydei merely scoffs, a reply forgone in favor of avoiding Phainon’s gaze. Phainon knew Mydei enough that he would rather keep his silence than deny something that bears truth.

“To the Diner, then,” Mydei declares as he roughly shoves past Phainon, marching away with purpose.

It was a good call to have reservations arranged beforehand. It might be embarrassing to admit, but the moment Phainon had set his sights on Mydei who had just come back from his mission and was seen conversing with a Mountain Dweller by the city gates, he wasted no time and rushed over to ask Kyros to save him a table for two before proceeding to follow Mydei around in a subtle game of chase.

“Lord Phainon, I’ve saved you your seats as requested,” Kyros greets amicably with a bow upon their arrival to the Marmoreal Diner, subsequently guiding Phainon and Mydei to two vacant klines by the second floor.

Kyros then hands them the stone tablets depicting today’s special and best sellers before leaving them to decide on their orders.

Mydei was the first to speak, eyes scanning the menu for something interesting. His posture remains stiff and tall as he sat, denying himself the pleasure of relaxation.

“Did you plan this, Deliverer?”

“Have you tried the golden honeycakes?” Phainon asks in lieu of a reply, eager for a change of topic.

Mydei gives him a dry stare, brief but heavy with meaning, before once again turning his attention back at the menu. From the looks of things, Phainon need not to explain further for Mydei has clearly figured everything out without the need for elaboration.

“I haven’t tried the golden honeycakes,” Mydei answers.

“You should get a serving,” Phainon recommends sincerely despite the obvious tension between them. “I have no doubts that you’ll like it.”

He doesn’t bring up Mydei’s terrible sweet tooth into the conversation. There’s still a prophecy to be fulfilled, one that requires Phainon to stay alive to be able to see it through. It would be counterproductive if Mydei deems his life forfeit during the unremarkable, 23rd day of the Month of Balance.

Despite the withering glare that Mydei shoots at Phainon’s direction due to the unsolicited suggestion, the former still ends up ordering a plate of golden honeycakes when Kyros comes over to take their orders.

“So,” Phainon began, lying on his side to get a better look at Mydei after Kyros had left to prepare their meals. “Why are you avoiding me?”

Mydei reaches out a hand to grab his chalice atop the table, allowing himself a small sip of the pomegranate juice he ordered before saying, “Walk me through the process of how you managed to end up with such a conclusion.”

Phainon raises his hand, his fingers ready to count numbers as he lists down his reasons.

“You’re not replying to my messages. I waited for you at the training grounds yesterday as scheduled, but you didn’t show up. You switched seats with Miss Castorice during the *deipnon* of the past two days just so you won’t sit across from me—” Phainon pauses to catch his breath before resuming shortly. “And *earlier*, you kept ignoring my calls of your name and I had to chase you all across the holy city just to get you to talk to me.”

There must surely be some other details that Phainon had missed, but the ones he’d listed down are nothing short of his strongest arguments. Even Mydei is at a loss; Phainon is not the champion debater of the Grove for nothing.

“You’re very persistent,” is all that Mydei says.

The indifference makes Phainon hesitate for a fraction. “Mydei, it’s not like you to keep your grievances to yourself. If I did manage to offend you, you would’ve let me know of it by now.”

The lack of response only fuels Phainon’s anxiety even more. Even if he hides his discomfort underneath the mask of a smile that doesn’t quite reach his eyes to appear composed, the

thought of Mydei being so cross with him to warrant such extreme avoidance bestows a sensation akin to that of being gutted.

“Was it something I said that day?” Phainon continues, referring to their last conversation from three days ago, insistent to right any wrongs he’d done. “Was the trophy I gifted you not to your liking?”

This time, Mydei humors him with an answer. “Why would I consider a well-sought trophy such as a Harbinger of Strife to be anything of poor taste?” he counters, unable to conceal the befuddlement in his tone as if Phainon had just asked the most ridiculous of questions. “Rest assured, Deliverer. Your trophy is treated well, prized and taken care of in my chambers.”

That sounds like it’s a good thing. And yet—

“Then, why the sudden cold shoulder?” Phainon urges on. “Was it because I teased you for drinking the pool waters of the Heroes' Baths?”

“That was *one* time,” Mydei hisses, evidently recalling the drunken incident at the Marmoreal Palace after he and Phainon left the disaster that was the Feast of the Scarlet Month.

Phainon raises an eyebrow. To tease Mydei is an urge that comes easy as if it were second nature. “And it hasn’t happened again?”

Mydei straightens his back, poised to leave the kline only for Phainon to grab his hand, halting his retreat.

“Don’t go. Please,” Phainon says, *begs* with his eyes wide open and eyebrows furrowed in a manner that should appear quite pitiful, enough to warrant the compassion of a rigid crown prince. “I’m sorry.”

It takes some time for Mydei to be convinced, brushing away Phainon’s grip on his wrist as he once again takes a seat. Phainon allows himself to sigh in relief, lips curving into a smile that conveyed his gratitude.

“The amount of tolerance I need to possess to be in your presence, Deliverer, is *absurd*.”

“You still haven’t told me why you’re avoiding me.”

Mydei huffs, bringing a hand to massage his temples, almost as if the matter brings him great difficulty to address.

“I simply needed time to think,” Mydei answers. Rarely does he sound so unsure of his words, suddenly hesitant in the manner that he speaks. “Your presence would only serve to hinder my focus.”

Phainon blinks, taken aback. That was the furthest of an answer that he could ever expect. He thought the reason for Mydei's avoidance was perhaps due to his teasing that had gone too far, or any other Mydei-typical reasons to bear grievances.

Now that he knows of the truth, Phainon can't help but be relieved that he didn't directly cause Mydei any offenses. But that doesn't change the fact that Mydei sees him as a hindrance.

"I see," Phainon says, feeling numb and confused. How could he even begin to possibly make amends for this sort of thing? "In that case, I deeply apologize for… causing you distraction."

It almost sounds more like a question than an apology. What, exactly, is Mydei thinking about that requires such tremendous amounts of focus?

"It's fine," Mydei says. The assurance is dry as a rock, but knowing Mydei, it is as sincere as it gets.

"Is it really?"

"I despise having to repeat myself, Deliverer."

"I know."

Mydei shoots him a sharp glare. "And yet you continue to aggravate me so."

"Not aggravate," Phainon corrects. "It's called teasing."

"That so-called *teasing* of yours contributes greatly to my ire," Mydei retorts.

Phainon is familiar with this fact that he can practically consider it as one of his close friends. "And what are you going to do about it?" he challenges, the risk causing his blood to sing in his veins. "Hit me—?

Mydei makes a move to pin Phainon by the neck into the kline, straddling Phainon's waist and knocking over their table as he does so. The snarl on Mydei's lips was evident, Phainon can't help but marvel at how easy it is to rile this man up.

Despite the blatant display of strength (and abysmally short patience), the grip of Mydei's hand on his neck is not exactly bruising. More like a loose hold than anything, but enough to keep Phainon in place.

"Goodness," Phainon muses, tapping Mydei's gauntlet-clad wrist with his hand, a show of surrender. "It was in jest! Mydeimos, let's not fight."

"Do not challenge me for a good time so casually, Deliverer," Mydei says lowly before releasing his hold on Phainon's neck. "You know better than anyone that I'm *always* up for it."

The words fly over Phainon's head like a flock of migrating birds. Without context, Mydei's words would have been enough to render a respectable man (Phainon) to his knees. Not to mention, their current positions—incriminating to a fault.

Phainon could already feel his face starting to heat up tremendously due to his proximity to Mydei's exposed abdominal muscles that could pass off as a sculpture of the gods.

But before he could ask Mydei to *please* get off of him lest any untoward *incidents* were to take place, the sound of someone clearing their throat is enough to capture both of their attentions.

Kyros, pale-faced and visibly unsettled, has arrived with their meals—two orders of golden honeycakes, piled up high and slathered generously with golden syrup upon each ceramic plate.

"My lords," Kyros addresses, strained. And then he looks at the toppled table, both of Phainon and Mydei's drinks spilled on the floor and the fruit platter a scattered mess. "My table."

Mydei (*thankfully!*) scrambles off of Phainon to right the table, tidying up the fruits back into the plate before gazing forlornly at his spilled pomegranate juice.

Kyros then places their orders onto the surface gingerly, rushing off after a hasty mutter of, "Enjoy your meals."

Mydei sighs as he picks up his fork. "How am I supposed to enjoy this without a drink?"

"You could try licking the floor before your spilled drink could evaporate for Aquila to partake in," is Phainon's rather intelligent response.

Sharp red crystals immediately surround Phainon, threateningly deadly in the way that they formed around his kline. He gives Mydei a wry smile.

"Put your crystals away, Mydei. You're going to scare the other patrons."

With a dark scowl, Mydei opens his mouth to protest, only for Phainon to take the opportunity to feed him a bite-sized portion of his golden honeycake. The diversion is shortly proven to be effective as the boiling anger that graced Mydei's handsome features are then reduced to a simmer the moment that the sweetness of the dessert permeates his taste buds.

Phainon beams victoriously when Mydei began to chew slowly, the red crystals surrounding Phainon subsequently dismissed once and for all.

"Good, right?" Phainon says.

Mydei swallows before replying. "Indeed."

Phainon, way too pleased with himself to the point that he has abandoned all reason, takes another portion of his honeycake and tries to feed Mydei another bite for a *second* time.

"Here, have some more."

This time, Mydei swats his hand away, face flushed in a pretty shade of pink. "Have you lost your *mind*, Deliverer? Do conduct yourself with propriety while in my company or you'll end

up embarrassing us both."

Phainon pouts. Mydei calling him an embarrassment is taking it too far, dare he say. "What do you mean? No one's even watching—"

He then turns his attention to the rest of the patrons who were… *definitely* watching, and have *definitely* witnessed the entire exchange. Phainon wonders when exactly it was that they managed to draw so much attention to themselves.

Clearing his throat, he then returns his gaze back at Mydei. "Fine weather, isn't it? As Chrysos Heirs of reputable status, we should talk about something… thought-provoking. Because that's what we do in our free time, yes. Engage in the struggles of the mind."

The tips of Mydei's ears burn a fiery scarlet, almost as red as the marks on his exposed skin. With a groan, he buries his head in his hands. "You are a dead man walking."

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Lord Phainon and Prince Mydei are always seen together, their interactions as fickle as Phagousa's tides.

One moment they are on the verge of killing each other with a complete disregard to the public's safety and surrounding buildings. In the next, they seem to be passionate lovers who are unable to keep their desires to themselves. Finally, they are also bosom buddies who feed each other honeycakes.

So, what indeed is the true nature of their relationship?

— from Akmonides' note, sold out within the first quint of the Action Hour

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Phainon was just about to take his leave from Aglaea's office after a discussion in regards to the Titankin's hostility at the borders of Okhema when suddenly, she calls for him again.

"Yes?" Phainon asks, turning around.

Janus had already opened the door for him but Aglaea still beckons him over.

"I've nearly forgotten," she says, gesturing for a Garmentmaker to hand her a scroll. "I wanted to give you this."

Phainon retraces his steps until he is in front of Aglaea's marble desk once again. He takes the scroll in her hand, unfurling it just enough to see what the subject was that is detailed within. The title is etched in bold letters at the very top.

Kremnoan Traditions: Culture and Customs throughout History

"Did you want me to give this to Mydei?" Phainon asks, confused as to why Aglaea was handing him something he had no relation to. Perhaps it is a suggestion for some light reading? It won't hurt to know more about Mydei's origins. Mydei is a good friend, after all.

Aglaea purses her lips, an obvious no if Phainon were to ever see one. "A Kremnoan would be slighted if you were to give them a scroll encapsulating their daily life and culture. It would imply their ignorance," she explains. "I trust that you're familiar with Mydeimos enough to know how he'll react."

Phainon tilts his head to the side, feeling foolish. "Oh. Uh, yes?"

Aglaea nods. "Excellent. You may leave now."

Perhaps Aglaea didn't wish to invoke Mydei's ire by giving this scroll to him and has thus entrusted the dreadful job to someone who could take Mydei in a fight instead.

It is still baffling, however, for why does Aglaea wish to give this scroll to Mydei? A prince who most likely knew of its contents by heart?

Before Phainon could even ask, Aglaea's Garmentmaker was already leading him to the door. Left with no other choice, he then leaves Aglaea's office feeling bewildered by the exchange.

Back in his quarters, he places the scroll on his desk alongside a dozen rolled others, making a mental note to give it to Mydei at the earliest convenience.

Little did he know, from that moment on, it would be the last time that his fingers would brush against the yellowed parchment as he took his leave once again. He got a missive from Theodoros saying that he had new artifacts and relics brought in during the Lucid Hour and would be honored for Phainon to do the first appraisals.

As the door to Phainon's chambers slam shut signalling his departure, the wings of the lone butterfly perched on the windowsill twitches impatiently. The Mnestia Titankin then latches on to a golden thread that flutters by, disappearing into the light of Dawn as it makes its way to report back to its master.

Chapter End Notes

more courting rituals in the next chapter!! bc this one got long enough and i can't cram it all in one go ;3

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

as always, thank you so much for reading!! and for all the kudos and comments aaa <3 much love to you guys :3

Chapter 5: wandering eyes, lingering moments

Chapter Summary

> Phainon finds his rationality to be at odds with himself most of the time. Perhaps Oronyx's influence is to blame, for it is the Month of Evernight where feelings tend to take the reins and reason is cast aside.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

fate season, month of evernight

6 months before the present time

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Recount tales of your valor and it shall express your might. Your history of renown bears weight, and a future of equal glory shall await.

...let it be known: no lover desires incompetence. Bare your strength and be proud. ***Your story defines your worth in much more value than the heaviest of treasures upon Talanton's Scale.***

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Chapter 3: Tales of Valor, Significance of Legacy

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Mydei is never seen bathing in the Heroes' Baths, much less with other people. Phainon recalls the other saying that he didn't wish to appear so vulnerable in public, preferring the solitude that the baths in his own chambers offered.

"I don't wish to parade myself without my armor," Mydei answers the first time Phainon asked him why he's never seen him bathe, subsequently surprised at Mydei's need for privacy. "And why should I inconvenience myself by coming to the Heroes' Baths when the ones in my chambers are filled with the same golden waters?"

"Baths are meant to be an affair shared with others," Phainon debates. "You're missing out on the daily symposia! Even Aglaea holds her assemblies in the Heroes' Baths sometimes."

Mydei huffs, evidently growing irritated by Phainon's pestering. Admittedly, it is true that they've been doing this incessant back and forth for a while now and Phainon hasn't let up in the slightest.

Is it wrong to promote some sense of camaraderie? Every Chrysos Heir that Phainon has managed to establish a connection with, except for Professor Anaxa, is a *woman*.

Lady Tribios is a child (in this case, children), Aglaea is scary, and Miss Castorice is… well, she's a close friend but she's rarely seen by him.

When Mydei arrived at Okhema, Phainon had been led to have hope that he might finally have his own brother-in-arms, specifically, someone to share the woes of battle with during a relaxing bath after training.

It was ever so unfortunate of a revelation that the man is stubborn as a bull and very difficult to get along with during the early days of their acquaintance.

"Even if I'm not in attendance, Aglaea still makes sure that I am up to speed with whatever has been discussed."

Phainon crosses his arms. "Joining us in the baths once in a while than having Aglaea debrief you separately would be a more *economical* use of her time."

That's a winning argument if Phainon has ever managed to come up with one. He knows that Mydei at least has some semblance of respect towards Aglaea regardless of the Okheman-Kremnoan feud. But then he forgets that it is *Mydei* with whom he now argues against.

"I can *economically* shove my foot up your arse if you don't give this matter a rest right now."

Phainon is rendered defeated as he stares forlornly at Mydei's retreating figure. If Mydei were to have studied alongside him at the Grove, he doubts if he would have been able to maintain his streak in being the debate champion.

The man simply follows no rules at all, and that was the last time the topic was ever brought up.

It had been during the Month of Fortune, a lot has happened since then. Phainon already knew that Mydei was in a foul mood that day and still decided to push the latter's patience to the brink. Now that he thinks about it three months later, he did sound way too persistent.

You know what they say: if you poke the lion, be prepared for its mighty roar.

But as of this moment, it was ever a surprise when Phainon sees Mydei's approaching figure at the Heroes' Baths, wearing only a flimsy robe that the bath attendants have provided—the fabric thin enough to show the skin beneath. His hair was tied in a low bun, the single lock of braided hair the only thing that rests upon his shoulders.

It's rather unfortunate that only Phainon is around to be present in this momentous occasion: Mydei's first public bath appearance.

“Fancy seeing you here, Your Highness,” Phainon jibes when Mydei dips a foot into the pool. No testing the temperature or anything of the sort, just direct submersion. Truly, what a man. “I see you’ve finally thought it nice to deign us commoners with your glorious presence.”

“Shut up,” is all that Mydei says before taking a seat across Phainon.

The action renders Phainon surprised. He half-expected Mydei to occupy another table and not share the one he currently uses. But Phainon appreciates the company, nonetheless.

“Has today’s Spring Theater Show started yet?” Mydei asks, taking a piece of grape from the fruit platter.

The juice that drips from the corner of his lips as he takes a bite does not escape Phainon’s notice. “Didn’t expect you to be a fan of such things.”

Mydei dabs at his lips with a napkin, the delicate action contrasting with the way his eyes are narrowed into dangerous slits, a sharp glare thrown at Phainon’s direction.

“You take me to be a philistine?”

“I dare not,” Phainon replies. How easy it is to rile this man up. “It hasn’t started yet. If I am not mistaken, today’s show should be a poetry recital with lyre accompaniment.”

Mydei only hums, sinking further into the waters as he rests his back into the cushion. It’s quiet after that. Phainon, for once, can’t think of anything more to say.

I’ve waited for so long to have you join me in the baths. Too desperate.

Isn’t it nice to bathe with someone? Too presumptuous.

We should do this more often. Too demanding.

Sometimes, the best course of action is to maintain silence. Now is one of those times.

Mydei, ever so oblivious with Phainon’s conundrum, has his head leaned back against the tiled edges of the pool, eyes closed as he relishes in the sensation of the warm waters lapping at his skin.

Phainon allows his gaze to rest upon the curve of Mydei’s neck, the way his throat bobs lightly with every swallow. Rivulets of water slide down the flawless skin of his fair face, tracing a mesmerizing path down to his well-defined jaw, and down once more, dripping onto the exquisite jut of his collarbone, lingering at the valley before ultimately flowing down the exposed skin of his tanned chest.

The wet fabric of the robe is flimsy enough for the streaks of scarlet etched upon Mydei’s skin to come into view, easily seen in its entirety without much of a hindrance for once. Perhaps it’s a good thing that Phainon is the only one present.

“Are you quite done with your staring?”

Phainon jolts at the sound of Mydei's voice, and he feels his face color in shame at being caught.

"Just admiring that immortal body of yours," he replies, a poor attempt to sound unfazed.

Upon hearing this, Mydei's eyes flutter open, pools of gold taking in the sight of Phainon's flushed face before his gaze ultimately drops down to carefully consider the well-defined muscles of Phainon's torso, equally exposed.

Mydei takes his time to look, deliberate and lingering. And then, he says, "You're not so bad yourself."

Now, what is Phainon supposed to think about *that?* How is he supposed to take Mydei's words that were said so directly and without a hint of hesitation? Was that even a compliment? Did Mydei just say he has a nice body right to his face?

Before Phainon could think any further and consider his poor brain to already be forfeit, the soft and crystalline sound of melodic notes plucked from the lyre echoes all throughout the Nerid Spring and up the Heroes' Baths.

The show has begun, the chatter has quieted down. A woman's voice orates the lines of a poem, her words clear and loud, her tone pleasantly canorous:

When Kephale's golden blood did flow,

Across nations where only darkness evil did bestow,

There emerges a beacon bright, born of dawn,

In Aedes Elysiae, a source of hope is gently drawn.

Phainon tenses in his seat. He had no idea that the show would be about him. Worse, he can already feel Mydei's gaze upon him.

"This is embarrassing."

"What is?" Mydei asks.

It's relieving for Phainon to take note that Mydei didn't sound the least bit taunting. Or perhaps that's just wishful thinking. "Don't tease me for it. I don't exactly fancy listening to odes written in my honor."

Mydei seemed to be considering his response carefully. "The Kremnoans have a tradition, rooted in the axiom that hearing of one's feats of valor through song and dance is considered august. Not to mention, it allows the audience to learn more about the poem's subject." His

gaze is searing as it meets Phainon's, unreadable. "See if they're worthy of the tales being told."

Fitting, Phainon thinks given how much Kremnoans value glory and renown. But something about Mydei's statement catches his attention. "I had no idea Kremnoans could sing and dance. Forgive me for assuming that you refrain from such merriments."

"War is miserable enough as it is. A little indulgence wouldn't hurt, and it helps boost morale."

Phainon allows himself to smile, tilting his head slightly to the side as he says, "Will I be able to hear you sing someday?"

Mydei furrows his eyebrows, poised to retaliate. "Not if I can help it."

"Why not? You could sing the songs composed in your name, detailing your merits. If you have any."

"I wouldn't know," Mydei says with a huff. "Just like you, I also don't have a penchant for indulging in leisures that feed the ego."

"Given your status, I'm sure that just a couple of questions to the right people and I'd have a whole program dedicated to the crown prince of Kremnos."

Mydei rolls his eyes. "I wouldn't stop you from doing as you please. But right now, I'd appreciate some silence, Deliverer, for I have already missed quite a relative amount of stanzas."

Phainon laughs. "You don't sing. How about a dance, then?"

A splash of water on his face is all it takes for Phainon to settle down.

Eyes like brilliant sapphires where no malice creeps,

Held light within, salvation no longer sleeps.

Hair as fair as the winters of Aidonia's scapes,

The noble air of Deliverance etched upon his striking face.

"Lord Phainon."

Phainon jolts from his seat. A bath attendant carrying a tray of cold towels and vials of fragrance oils has approached, kneeling at the edge of the pool.

"You seem a bit flushed," she says. "Is the temperature of the waters too excessive?"

Phainon could see Mydei smirk from his periphery. Clearly, the waters had nothing to do with his flushed countenance. “I’m quite alright, thank you.” He gestures at the tray. “Are those the oils I’ve requested?”

“Yes,” the attendant answers with a nod before handing Phainon the tray. Just as Phainon places the item onto the table, the attendant turns her attention towards Mydei. “Lord Mydei, will you be needing some fragrance oils as well?”

Mydei nods. “Please.”

“Any preferred scents?”

Phainon’s ears perk up, keen to listen.

“Pomegranate, jasmine, and vanilla.”

Those three words alone served as an answer to the question Phainon has been mulling over for *months* on end. Perhaps he’d procure those same scents and indulge in them in the privacy of his own chamber’s baths.

His sword is swift, it’s justice pure,

A strength that no evil could endure.

With every swing of the blade did the Black Tide’s forces fell,

And peace in Okhema began its distant swell.

As Phainon uncorks his own vial of fragrance oil—his usual scents of bergamot and rosemary diffusing into the steaming air—he could feel Mydei’s eyes upon him, watching his every move.

“It might take a while for your requested oils to arrive,” Phainon says. “I have more than enough for the both of us, if you can’t wait any longer.”

Even if Mydei had seemed to be seriously considering the offer, he still ended up declining, the tips of his ears tinged a slight pink most likely from the heat of the bath.

“I’m alright,” he replies. This time, he chooses to avert his gaze, focusing them instead upon the fruit platter. “It would be an act of disrespect to the bath attendant who went her way to fetch the oils for me.”

Phainon merely shrugs. “Suit yourself.”

He allows the oil to drip upon his fingers, careful not to spill onto the pool, before applying just the right amount of little from the base of his jaw and his neck, slipping his robe to the

side to rub some of the fragrance oil upon his shoulders and chest.

As he does so, that familiar searing sensation on his skin returns. Phainon looks up from his ministrations and finds Mydei's attention solely on him once again.

"Are you quite done with your staring?" Phainon jeers, a teasing repetition of Mydei's words from earlier.

Strangely, Mydei doesn't find offense in it. In place of a scowl was a subtle smile, barely there and almost inscrutable. His answer causes Phainon to falter.

"No."

His name shall echo in Oronyx's Miracle,

A tale of courage born from a single oracle.

A hero, who by fate's own hand,

Delivered hope to The Eternal Land.

The final note of the lyre is heard just before the audiences soaking in the Nerid's Spring burst into a resounding applause.

Phainon allows himself a moment's exhale to recollect his bearings, grateful that the source of his embarrassment is over at last. Perhaps he should pay more attention to the scheduled program's details the next time he comes to the baths. If he did, he could have opted to sit this one out and stayed in the comfort of his own chambers instead.

"Impressive."

Phainon turns to Mydei who had just ceased his clapping. "Spare me."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "I'm being candid."

There's no room for arguments for Phainon knew better than anyone that Mydei always means what he says. Instead of further wallowing in his mortification, Phainon settles with a polite, "Thank you."

The attendant arrives with Mydei's tray of fragrance oils just as another tune from the lyre begins to play. This time, the poems being sung below held neither the attention of the two Chrysos Heirs.

Once the attendant has left, Mydei then proceeds to uncork one of the vials, the familiar scents of pomegranate, jasmine, and vanilla permeating Phainon's senses.

He watches with rapt attention as Mydei lets a drop of oil fall upon his fingertips, his rarely seen bare fingers long and defined with veins running up from the back of his hand to his forearms, seamlessly intertwining with streaks of scarlet etched upon his skin.

Phainon finds that all manner of reason has left his body, his throat unbecomingly parched as Mydei tilts his head to the side, baring his neck even more—an elegant and exquisite angle, flawless tanned skin exposed and vulnerable with his hair out of the way.

It is a siren's call, one that Phainon is unfortunately *not* particularly immune to.

Mydei's two fingers rub at his pulse point, spreading the oil and leaving the wet skin to glisten against the light. Phainon, with his hands gripping the edge of the seat cushions, follows the languid movement of Mydei's oiled fingers as it glides across his throat and to the other side of his neck, rubbing circles at the base of his jaw.

Withdrawing his hand, Mydei pours more oil upon his fingers before continuing his hypnotic ministrations, passing through collarbones and tracing the streaks of scarlet, almost like an afterthought—a path well-traveled—before slipping his robe to the side to apply the sweet fragrance to his muscled shoulders, followed by the vast expanse of his chest…

And then his fingers slide lower, *dangerously* low. Phainon realizes that he had completely stopped breathing the moment that Mydei's glistening forefinger ghosts over a nipple, stiff and—

"—wel?"

Phainon frantically blinks the haze away. "I'm sorry, what?"

Mydei sighs, unable to hide his annoyance that Phainon hasn't been paying attention. "Can you hand me your spare cold towel? The bath attendant forgot to provide me with one."

"Oh." Phainon nods. "Right. Yes. Of course."

He scrambles to take the towel upon his tray, knocking over his uncorked vial in the process, the oil spilling onto the pool below.

Aglaea is going to kill him.

Phainon chooses not to dwell on it, handing the cold towel over to Mydei by leaning across the table instead of simply making his way around it because—

Well.

Phainon bites back a groan when he feels his clothed cock brush against the edge of the rounded table. He can't believe that he is shamefully half-hard after witnessing the downright unholy vision of Mydei anointing himself with oil.

He then subsequently *almost* loses his mind the moment that the skin of Mydei's bare fingers ghost against his when he takes the cold towel. Mydei thankfully doesn't seem to notice anything amiss, blissfully unaware of Phainon's depravity.

I'm so screwed, Phainon thinks grimly. Perhaps a reconnection with nature is due.

Willing himself to calm down, Phainon closes his eyes and begins reciting Nousporism mantras in his head. Professor Anaxa would be proud considering that Phainon was able to memorize all three thousand of them, and they sure have come in handy in a dire time such as this.

By the ninety-seventh mantra, his cock has finally returned to being respectably flaccid. His dignity may not have been restored, but at least it wasn't tarnished any further than it already was.

He opens his eyes and finds Mydei running the cold towel across his back, his raised arm appearing strained by the movement.

"Do you need help with that?"

Mydei's shoulders tense upon hearing Phainon's offer before lowering his arm. His face is flushed in pretty shades of pink and red, and his voice comes out strangely shaky though admonishing, resolutely avoiding Phainon's gaze as he speaks, "You are hasty, I'll give you that."

Phainon frowns at Mydei's words. Did Mydei assume that he was rushing him by offering his assistance?

"I'm sorry?" Phainon says, feeling the need to apologize all of a sudden.

"Worry not. Your intentions have not gone unnoticed. I just…" Mydei trails off. "I just need some more time."

That's no problem at all. It's not like Phainon needed the spare cold towel anyway.

"Of course," Phainon says. "Take all the time you need."

Phainon could pinpoint the exact moment Mydei had relaxed upon hearing those words. He gives Phainon a grateful smile for his patience. Maybe it was a good decision to come to the baths after all.

"I appreciate it."

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Kin is important in Kremnos. *In order for the suitor to gain the trust of the courted's kin to be deemed as worthy, one must engage in a fair duel.*

During the fight, honor is an essential virtue to uphold apart from courage. For in Kremnos, ***an honorable opponent is more trustworthy than a deceitful ally.***

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Chapter 4: A Test of Character

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Phainon was in the middle of lance practice (Mydei's recommendation because, as Mydei had so *kindly* remarked, "You suck at this.") when a Kremnoan soldier approaches him.

"Greetings, Lord Phainon."

Phainon wipes the sweat accumulated on his forehead with the back of his hand before turning to the Kremnoan soldier with a smile. He's seen her many times before.

"Good day, Miss Eris."

Eris gives him a light bow at the acknowledgement. "His Highness wishes to invite you to the settlement later today, the first quint of the Curtain-Fall Hour to be precise."

Phainon frowns upon hearing such a conventionally late meeting time, a bit uncharacteristic of Mydei for he always considered the availability of both parties, as well as a time that occurs not later than the Parting Hour, before initiating an invite.

"Did he say why?"

The soldier seemed a bit taken aback by this question. "Lord Phainon, you jest," she says, amusement simmering behind her almond eyes. "It is finally the time for *that*, and His Highness wishes for you to participate."

Phainon wonders what *that* even means. Perhaps he should just ask Mydei when he sees him later on. "Of course. I'll be there."

Eris bows again to take her leave without another word, leaving a befuddled Phainon alone in the training grounds.

Later that day, he makes his way to the Kremnoan settlement located around the city's outskirts. By the entrance, he sees a young Kremnoan boy, perhaps as old as thirteen years, seemingly waiting for him.

"Lord Phainon, you've arrived!"

Phainon can't help but smile at the sight of the boy rushing towards him. "Your prince made it clear that I am to come."

The boy grins. "I'm so happy that it's you. I have never once liked those other Okheman warriors who also wanted His Highness' favor."

As a respectable figure in the battlefield, perhaps not only the Okheman warriors, but those from the other nations as well, wanted Mydei's recognition. If Phainon hadn't been a Chrysos Heir, he doubts that Mydei would even deign to sneeze in his direction.

"Those Okheman warriors have talent as well, you know," Phainon says, trying to put a good word in. Not to mention, some of those Okhemans fought with him against the forces of the Black Tide. Phainon considers them as his friends. "And they're nice, too."

The boy only shrugs, barely even considering it. "Not really. Father says you're the only person in Okhema who has actively helped us, while Mother says that she's glad His Highness has a good eye in choosing someone worthy."

"Is that so?" Phainon never thought that the other Kremnoans saw him in such a good light given that they tended to harbor a poor opinion of those residing in Okhema. "I'm very honored. Do convey my sincerest gratitude to your parents, young man."

"My name is Maleos."

"Alright, Maleos," Phainon says, etching the boy's name in his memory. "Lead me to your prince. We shan't keep him waiting."

Maleos leads Phainon towards the blood-red marquee set up right in the middle of the settlement whilst animatedly recounting stories about his tribe and how much he wants to become like his Prince Mydeimos when he grows up.

Phainon can't help but smile fondly. Prince Mydeimos this, His Highness that— Indeed, Phainon understands Maleos on an almost spiritual level, dare he say. Mydei is indeed impressive in *any* and *every* regard.

"His Highness is waiting inside," Maleos tells him now that they're standing by the entrance of the marquee. For some reason, Phainon begins to feel nervous. "I'm too young to be allowed entry, so this is the furthest I could be of escort to you, Lord Phainon."

"You've been a great help," Phainon reassures, ruffling the boy's hair gently before giving him a shiny gold coin. "Why don't you buy yourself something nice as a reward? If you go to Chartonus, just show him this coin tomorrow and he'll fashion you a wooden sword in return."

Maleos grins, eyes sparkling with enthusiasm upon hearing the word 'sword' leave Phainon's lips. A Kremnoan through and through.

"Many thanks, Lord Phainon!" He bows and makes a run for it. "I wish you the best of luck!"

Best of luck? For what?

Phainon finds his answer the moment that he pushes at the flap leading into the blood-red marquee to enter, only to stop cold upon seeing—

Rows and rows of Kremnoan soldiers dressed in their full armor of gold and red, standing at attention and facing him with their lances ready and their shields on guard. He couldn't see

the soldiers' expressions due to the helmets they wore. But one thing is for sure: they are not here simply to express the discipline of an army, but to *fight*.

Phainon furrows his eyebrows in confusion. Behind the rows of warriors is Mydei, seated atop an elaborate chair made of wood and stone, a chalice in one hand as he rests his head with the other.

Their gazes meet.

"Mydei, what—?"

"Warriors of Kremnos," Mydei calls out, his voice reverberating throughout the enclosed space. "My kin, you are not to hold back."

The Kremnoans erupt into a ferocious cry, charging towards Phainon all at once. Still baffled by this turn of events, Phainon manages to summon his greatsword at the last minute, parrying attacks with no intent to hurt.

He knew these people. He would never hurt them. But why—?

Evading the attacks from every angle, Phainon was able to successfully disarm one soldier. And then the strangest thing happens: instead of a reluctant defeat, the soldier removes his helmet—Phalces is his name, as Phainon would remember—and *smiles*, moving closer to pat Phainon firmly on the shoulder before stepping away from the fight.

To say that Phainon is thoroughly befuddled is an understatement, but now he understood the rules of this sudden game. Disarming the warriors would do the trick. One down, a… hundred? Two hundred? No, *three* hundred more to go.

The rest of them are defeated smoothly. Even if they fought with all their might, they are simply of no match for Phainon who could go head to head with their leader himself.

Everytime he manages to disarm a warrior, they remove their helmets—Phainon recognizes them all: Leandros, Ideaus, Deinias, Pervica, even Eris. And after every defeat, they either bow deeply, shake Phainon's hand, or give Phainon a firm pat on the shoulder. One—Evagoras, also an avid treasure appraiser—even pulled Phainon into a crushing hug.

"You're worthy," he says.

Before Phainon could let the words sink in, Evagoras had already pulled away and went to the side to join his defeated companions. A barely dodged attack to his head reminds Phainon of the situation at hand.

One by one, the three hundred warriors participating in the fight were steadily reduced in numbers as Phainon defeated them by his lonesome. A kick to the shin, a well-executed maneuver, a jab to the ribs.

And now, Phainon directs the tip of his greatsword upon the throat of the last Kremnoan warrior who was now on the floor with his lance some ways away and his shield broken into two.

“Do you yield?” Phainon pants, unable to conceal the fact that he’s very much out of breath after such a rigorous undertaking.

He shouldn’t have trained too hard earlier today if only to preserve what energy he had left before coming here. But then again, he had no idea that *this* was what awaited him. Three hundred warriors later, and Phainon is finally able to recognize the last of them.

Praxis, a formidable opponent and one of Mydei’s most trusted *lochagos*, finally removes his helmet. He gives Phainon a firm nod. Just like the others who were defeated before him, there was no hint of spite on his face. Only relief.

“I yield.”

Phainon sighs, unable to help a smile. It’s finally over.

He dismisses his greatsword into specks of gold before helping Praxis up from the ground. Praxis gladly accepts the assistance, pulling Phainon into a hug of his own.

“Honorable,” Praxis murmurs against Phainon’s ear. “His Highness chose right.”

Before Phainon could come up with a reply of his own, Praxis had already withdrawn and joined the others. And now, a path had opened for Phainon, one that led up to the lone man lounging on the makeshift throne.

Mydei looked pleased. Phainon must have provided him with a great deal of entertainment after taking down all of his men with just a sword and a confused mind.

“That was fun,” Phainon began, raising a challenging eyebrow at Mydei’s direction. “Am I to fight you next?”

Some of the warriors burst into low chuckles upon hearing the jest. Even Mydei’s lips curl into a smirk.

“Now is not the time for that, victorious Deliverer,” he replies, standing up from his seat to approach Phainon. Something about his air at this moment renders Phainon weak in the knees. Or maybe the exhaustion has finally caught up to him. “Today, we feast!”

The Kremnoan warriors all erupted into cheers at the declaration, crimson pennants bearing the symbol of Strife thrown into the air as they hoist Phainon up in arms in some sort of bizarre celebratory gesture, yelling one single line over and over:

“*Worthy is he, the Deliverer of Okhema!*”

Music and drunken singing could be heard from within the marquee whilst Phainon indulges in his solitude, seated at a nearby bench by the entrance to the huge tent that once held battle, and now celebration.

He's already quite buzzed after a single cup of pomegranate juice, that he only belatedly realized had been mixed with liquor. Not wanting a repeat of the incident back during the Feast of the Scarlet Month, Phainon excuses himself in favor of getting some fresh air, hoping that it would sober him up.

"I've been looking everywhere for you."

Phainon looks up and meets Mydei's eyes of pure gold. He scoots over the bench to make space just in case Mydei wanted to join him.

"Idaeus thought it would be funny to get me drunk," he says in lieu of a reply.

Mydei takes the offered seat, handing Phainon a drink. This time, the cup contains Mydei's signature mix of pomegranate juice and milk. Phainon readily accepts the honey brew with a mutter of thanks, most eagerly partaking in the drink and allowing the sweetness to linger in his tongue, washing away the bitterness of alcohol.

"Idaeus is a scoundrel," is all that Mydei says, a hint of fondness in his tone despite his words. "If you don't see him pour you a drink directly coming from a barrel, best be warned that it would be laced with something."

"Duly noted."

And then silence.

"Do you need help in tending to your wounds?" Mydei asks after some time has passed.

Phainon didn't even realize he'd been injured until now. But nothing too dire, just a few cuts here and there. And his clothes would have to be taken to Aglaea to be mended. Not wanting to inconvenience Mydei unnecessarily, Phainon was poised to decline the generous offer.

But then he sees the softness in Mydei's expression, vulnerable and willing. If Phainon were to turn him down right at this moment, there'd be no telling when an opportunity of this magnitude comes a second time. If it would even come at all.

Phainon opens his mouth to speak, "I would be very grateful."

The smile on Mydei's face is enough to brighten the entirety of Amphoreus even without the help of Kephale's Dawn or Aquila's sets of Eyes. Hence, did Phainon come to realize he'd made the right call.

Instead of the infirmary located in the Marmoreal Palace, Mydei leads him to the Room of the Flame Lily—his very own chambers—to be patched up.

"Sit on the bed while I get some bandages," Mydei tells him.

Phainon couldn't help himself. The urge to tease is too strong. "Still no chairs?"

"The bed is more than enough for you and I."

And then Mydei leaves.

Dumbstruck at the unexpected reply, Phainon is left to stand in the middle of the room without so much as a hint of movement. He's not even breathing, turning Mydei's cryptic words over and over in his head until he's on the verge of insanity.

The bed is more than enough for you and I.

Titans both merciful and cruel, does Mydei have *any* idea what his words could entail? Is Phainon not a man in his eyes to not be affected by such? Does Mydei perhaps see him as a statue? Devoid of emotions and desires of the flesh?

"I'm going crazy."

"Already?" Phainon jolts. Mydei has returned carrying a tray of bandages, a bottle of antiseptic, as well as pieces of clean cloth. "A few cuts and bruises is enough for you to lose your mind?"

Phainon frowns at the taunt, readying his admonishments. "Mydei did you know?

With careless lips, a casual tongue may weave,

Phrases that fly like arrows, swift and sure,

Unknowing that those words uttered with no hesitance,

Pierce the silence, and leaves a man to fruitlessly navigate his own obfuscation."

Mydei gives him a blank stare.

"*What* in Nikador's name are you spouting out now?" he barks, utterly taken aback by the sudden attack of Phainon's *exquisite* poetry. "And didn't I tell you to sit on the bed? *Haikas*."

"*Hai*-what now? Are you cursing at me?" Phainon demands.

The word does sound Kremnoan. Phainon swears that he has heard Mydei say it before in a manner that was undeniably vindictive. Now had been the first time he uses the word whilst addressing Phainon.

But strangely enough, he did not seem to sound like he's cursing Phainon's ancestors from Aquila's high heavens and down to Thanatos' realm below.

Instead of an answer, Mydei impatiently says, "Strip and take a seat, or I'll make you."

Phainon wonders where the man with the soft golden gaze from earlier, asking if Phainon wanted to be tended to, had gone.

Begrudgingly, Phainon first undoes the belt that keeps his pauldron and cape in place, followed by shedding away his overcoat and undershirt, leaving him with only his pants and shoes, his torso exposed to the cold air.

Mydei's searing gaze bears down on him. Though not exactly uncomfortable, Phainon can't help but fidget from the attention.

He moves to pick up his clothes from the floor in favor of having something to do aside from just standing straight for Mydei to unabashedly gawk at him. Something about this encounter is different from the one in the baths just a couple of days ago, for such a state of undress is to be expected.

This, however, to be alone together with Mydei in his chambers—

"Where should I put this?" Phainon asks, referring to his clothes, his voice inadvertently coming out hushed, like he does not want to be found out.

"Just leave it anywhere," Mydei replies, equally strained for some reason.

Phainon lays his clothes upon the kline in a presentable looking pile before taking a seat next to it. Mydei follows suit, occupying the space on Phainon's right, the mattress dipping from their combined weight.

In the silence, Mydei soaks a cloth in antiseptic. "Turn your body towards me."

Phainon obediently does as he's told without much fuss for once, allowing Mydei to apply the burgundy liquid to the cuts that littered his chest and abdomen, dried golden ichor staining his skin.

They're way too close, Phainon could feel every instance of Mydei's warm exhales against his collarbone, the slight caress of blonde hair against his bare skin, and that scent—sweet, drawing him in, inherently *Mydei.*

"You have a lot of scars," Mydei notes, pulling away to procure another piece of clean cloth, soaking it once again in the antiseptic.

"Fought a lot of battles," Phainon replies sheepishly. "Not everyone could be as flawless as you."

Mydei huffs, though he doesn't seem to take offense, resuming in his ministrations. "You speak of my curse as if it were a blessing."

"I was simply remarking on the existence of perfection."

"And you deem me perfect?"

Mydei looks up, the tips of their noses almost touching. Gold meets azure in an unblinking stare, expecting an answer that only Phainon could provide.

He allows his gaze to drop to Mydei's lips, soft against the light of Kephale's Dawn that seeps from the drawn curtains. And Phainon is left to wonder in a moment's irrationality, if he would ever be granted the honor of knowing how they would feel against him, how they would taste.

The memory of it would no doubt be engraved beneath Phainon's eyelids, allowing it to play before his very eyes even in his slumber.

Depraved.

The Month of Evernight is notorious for making people replace any reasonable thought into one that is of the contrary. The instinct to lean in and take Mydei's lips for his own is hardly appropriate, but Phainon wouldn't deny that if he were a lesser man, he would have already done so.

But in this moment, Mydei's question still hangs in the air, and Phainon had yet to respond to it.

"Yes," he says. Honest, for how could Mydei deserve otherwise. "You are." *Perfect*.

Mydei's eyes widened for a fraction upon hearing the ardent declaration. It was clear that he didn't expect Phainon to admit to it.

"You chastise me for having a casual tongue just moments prior. And yet here you are, making me feed you with your own medicine."

Phainon licks his lips. "The difference between you and I is that my words hold only one meaning."

"I'm far from being perfect, Deliverer," Mydei says firmly, and yet he leans in all the same, as if he too desired to be closer than what is considered acceptable between two friends. "You of all people should know that. I don't want there to be any regrets between us."

Phainon can't seem to find an appropriate response. If he told Mydei that it is his imperfections that make him perfect, a classically cheesy pick-up line that the youths in the Marmoreal Market build upon, a punch on the face is what most likely awaited him despite his intentions to simply convey the truth.

The moment then dissipates due to Phainon's silence. Mydei pulls away, hastily unrolling the bandages without much finesse. Phainon didn't dare point out that the wounds on his arms have not yet been treated. But maybe having some mercy on them both would be a better course of action.

Phainon is just as disconcerted as Mydei is, and neither of them possessed the proficiency in hiding behind veils of composure in a moment such as this—intimate and tender, if Phainon is bold enough to call it as such.

Mydei wraps his torso with layers of bandages, the cold metal of his gauntlets ghosting against Phainon's skin in a sharp kiss.

Phainon wishes for Mydei to have taken them off. Phainon wishes for a lot of things, in fact.

“All done,” Mydei says eventually, sounding every bit of breathless despite doing something that hardly requires any effort, taking the tray and leaving Phainon’s side in a mere blink of an eye.

Phainon inspects Mydei’s handiwork. “Thank you, Mydei.”

Mydei only nods. Tersely, he says, “I’ll take this back to the infirmary. You should head back to your chambers, Deliverer. It’s late.”

The moment that the door closes signalling Mydei’s departure does Phainon begin the process of clothing himself. He dared not wait for Mydei’s return for he would be overstaying his welcome by then.

Phainon allows himself one final glance around Mydei’s chambers—still ever so sparsely decorated, with the exception of the Sabany-style amphora Phainon had gifted him months ago and now housing a sizable bouquet of forget-me-nots, the blue petals a stark contrast against the red of the room.

Something shiny in Phainon’s periphery catches his attention. On Mydei’s pillow is a lone strand of blonde hair, akin to that of Aglaea’s golden thread with how it shimmers against the light.

With a burning face and an aching heart, Phainon gently takes the strand between his fingers. A piece of Mydei, inconsequential enough for Phainon to have without seeming too selfish.

With hurried footsteps, Phainon takes his leave, his rational thoughts left asunder.

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We clothe ourselves in red to hide the blood and weakness during battle. And during recuperation, our bodies are coated with swaths of white cloth and bandages—much like how our open wounds bursting with crimson blood pales upon healing, and turns to scars.

These are badges of honor, of battles well-fought. Do not shy away from showing them, for a desired lover is sure to be impressed.

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Chapter 6: Show of Scars, Proof of Might

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Phainon keeps himself busy after his run-in with Mydei. He takes up every mission before Aglaea even had the chance to assign them to someone else. And now, due to his insistence, he is drowning in a multitude of overdue post-mission reports.

Even if the task of detailing every single encounter he had with Nikador's Titankin, as well as the occassional forces of the Black Tide, is tedious enough to a fault, it helped Phainon keep his mind off of things.

Specifically, Mydei and the lone strand of blonde hair that's now wind tightly around his forefinger. It glimmers every now and then, reflecting the light coming from the balcony with every movement of his hand as he wrote.

The only sound to be heard in the room is the frantic scratching of the quill's end against the parchment paper. If Phainon fails to submit his reports today, Aglaea would most definitely have him sort through Okhema's state of affairs and arrange every document by date, by priority, and in alphabetical order. Worst, she'll have him memorize it.

Phainon shudders at the mere thought of it, only to almost fall out of his seat when a loud knock comes from his door.

"Who is it?" Phainon calls out. He was not expecting any deliveries today.

The voice from the other end is deep and smooth. Unmistakable. "It's me."

Phainon felt as if his soul had just left his body, turning his head around so fast to look at the closed door that it feels as if he stretched a muscle, or something.

Titans dead or alive, Mydei *cannot* be outside of his door right now. Phainon looks around at the state of his room—his kline is unmade, antiques are scattered about, his desk is a mess of scrolls and stone tablets, and—

And!

Horrified, Phainon slowly directs his attention at the wall across his kline where a portrait (fashioned from a billboard) of Mydei's stoic image advertising Marmoreal Diner's golden honeycakes hung indisputably.

Phainon is going to die.

He bolts out of his seat in the next moment, hastily moving to tidy up his kline, shoving his collection of antiques underneath before rearranging his desk to make it appear productively used but still presentable.

"Deliverer."

Phainon huffs, pushing a giant amphora to stand in a corner instead of in the middle of the hallway. "Wait just a moment!"

He then scrambles to climb atop the dresser, knocking off and breaking the relics and trinkets he had displayed upon its surface; they're cheap and fake, so it's fine. What's more important

right now is that he get Mydei's portrait off of his wall or he *dies*.

Phainon grips the edges of the once-billboard, shifting it slightly in an attempt to unfasten it from the hook. But the thing doesn't budge, curses slipping out of his lips frantically in sheer panic.

"A moment has passed," Mydei announces, muffled from the other side of the door. His beautiful voice, for once, a dreadful sound. "I'm coming in."

Janus' lock begins to turn, and in a last burst of panic, Phainon pulls at the portrait using all of his strength as the Deliverer of Okhema. But the object is regrettably just as stubborn as the subject himself.

Even as a billboard, Mydei is ever so immovable.

Phainon's grip slips and he all but tumbles down ungracefully onto the floor in a heap of defeated shame and broken dreams as his dresser falls alongside him in a loud and unmistakable *crash*. He barely manages to roll away just in time before he is caught beneath the dresser's crushing weight.

The door to his chambers open, and Mydei arrives, witnessing the spectacle before him with unbridled shock.

"..."

Phainon wants to die.

His gaze meet that of Mydei's, brief for the latter chooses to examine the room against Phainon's wishes, pools of gold finally landing on the root cause of the mess—the Marmoreal Diner's advertisement featuring Mydei:

Be Golden like Lord Mydei! Order our Golden Honeycakes and you'll feel Golden, too!

Mydei's mouth was rendered agape.

"..."

Phainon breaks the painful silence. "It's not what it looks like."

"How am I supposed to interpret this, then?" Mydei asks in turn.

Still on the floor and feeling winded, Phainon uses what little is left of his brain to make up an acceptable reason.

"The, uh, children are… making fun of you!" It's a lame excuse given that every kid in Okhema is a Prince Mydei fanatic. But it's too late to take back his words now. "Yeah, that's right! I only wanted to preserve your dignity, which is why I had to hide this away."

Mydei obviously didn't believe him. It was clear in the way he regards Phainon with a look of disbelief and barely concealed amusement.

“Right.” Mydei nods slowly. “And you chose to hang this on the wall across your kline like a glorified painting? Did it escape your mind that a billboard is supposed to stand on the floor and be exposed in a market for patrons to see?”

Not in the privacy of your own chambers, is left unsaid. But the words are loud enough to render Phainon’s heated face to flush some more. He must look ridiculous right now.

“It’s…” *I need to die. It’s a must at this point.* “I had to put it somewhere pleasing, at least.”

Now Mydei is smirking. He’s just taunting Phainon now, is he? “And this is the solution you’ve come up with? What if someone else comes in here and sees? Are you not embarrassed?”

Phainon is embarrassed for getting caught. But to consider Mydei’s portrait (billboard) as an embarrassment is the furthest from the truth. Advertisement or not, Mydei’s unsmiling image looks just as radiant as any other portrait painted by an artist of renown.

“I don’t host visitors in my chambers,” Phainon replies. “You’re the only one.”

Mydei takes his time to form a reply after that. Perhaps constructing lines of teasing remarks in his profound mind. Phainon has simply given up at this point. Mydei could gloat in his victory all he wants.

Only, in an unexpected show of mercy, he doesn’t.

“Very well,” Mydei eventually says before walking towards Phainon’s limp body laying on the floor. He crouches down, helping Phainon up to a sitting position, a strong hand supporting Phainon’s back. “Are you alright?”

Phainon buries his face in his own hands. “Let’s just forget this ever happened.”

A soft laugh resounds, beautiful and clear like the notes of wind chimes swaying with the wind. It’s enough to tempt Phainon out of his hiding, just so he could witness the most captivating sight he’s ever had the pleasure to behold.

Mydei lightly coughs in an attempt to regain his bearings. “Thank you for… preserving my dignity, Deliverer,” he says. “But it truly wasn’t necessary. Kyros paid me a hefty sum to use my image as an advertisement for his golden honeycakes. I only agreed to do it because the product is something I genuinely enjoy, and I see no problem with having my name used to verify its quality.”

Phainon wanted to say that he *also* paid a hefty sum to buy the billboard the moment that he’d seen it while he was out appraising Theodoros’ new treasures.

Why he’d done so, he has no idea. But he would never forget the way other people had eyed Mydei’s picture with something other than respect and admiration.

Instead of replying and further incriminating himself, Phainon stands up and leads Mydei to the balcony where the mess that is his room is out of sight, and hopefully, out of mind. He

offers Mydei a seat on one of the smaller klines. Only then does he notice that Mydei was carrying something with him.

“I wanted to give you this,” Mydei says before Phainon could even get the chance to ask, handing him the package.

Phainon takes it, undoing the string that keeps the brown paper in place, peeling it away to reveal a silken, purple fabric from within. Intricately embroidered with patterns not native to Okhema, but the artistry could almost rival that of Aglaea’s.

He holds the garment up high to examine it fully, revealing an elaborate chiton that must have cost a small fortune. So Mydei came here to give him clothes.

Still amazed by the handiwork, Phainon can’t help but ask, “Did Aglaea put you up to this?”

“Aglaea?” Mydei frowns. “No. Why would she?”

And thus begins Phainon’s passionate retelling of the time where Aglaea threw his entire wardrobe into the open flames, followed by a detailed account of her stripping Phainon of his favorite yellow tunic and purple trousers before having Chartonus use it as fuel for his forge.

Once done, Phainon was out of breath and a moment of silence encompasses them. Mydei has an unreadable look on his face. Perhaps he sympathizes with Phainon in this regard, they are close friends after all who have shared Aglaea’s fury in more than one occasion.

Eventually, Mydei clears his throat. “Anyway, that’s an… authentic Kremnoan chiton made from the finest of silken fabrics and embroidered by delicate hands of utmost talent. The silk itself was woven all the way from Pyria.” Mydei averts his gaze, directing his attention at the imposing view of Kephale instead. Hesitantly, he adds, “It’s not a lot, but these are the only ones I could salvage after the war.”

Phainon allows himself to smile, appreciative of Mydei’s efforts. “It’s beautiful. Thank you, Mydei.”

Silence.

“I have its matching set,” Mydei blurts out without much preamble. “I shall wear it the day after tomorrow.”

Phainon is unable to hide the questioning frown that graces his face. “I… see.”

Silence once again.

“May I ask why you’re suddenly giving these to me?”

“So you could make yourself look presentable. My teacher wants to meet you.”

Ah. Lord Krateros, if Phainon wasn’t mistaken.

Phainon has met almost all of the Kremnoans that have come to seek refuge in Okhema. But Lord Krateros has always denied him audience. Come to think of it, Phainon has no idea as to why that is.

He's heard Aglaea mention him a couple of times before in passing, her tone laced with a subtle disdain. But the bitterness would never compare to how it would be if she were talking about Professor Anaxa.

"I'm honored," Phainon says, eager to put a face to the name. However, Mydei's initial statement doesn't go unnoticed. "You're starting to sound like Aglaea, fussing over my appearance. Am I not handsome enough for you?"

Mydei doesn't let the words linger in the air for more than a moment before uttering his reply. "You're more than handsome enough to satisfy me."

Now, *what* in Kephale's name is that even supposed to mean?

And then Mydei leaves his seat, walking the few steps to stand right in front Phainon, the light from Kephale's Dawn bathing him in what Phainon would consider a devastatingly gorgeous sight.

"If you can indulge me—" Mydei reaches a gauntlet-clad hand out, combing back Phainon's unruly strands of snow-white hair to expose more of his shell-shocked face, ending up cradling the back of his head. Gentle regardless of how forward. "—I'd like to see you in these sometime."

Phainon is willing to indulge Mydei in absolutely *anything*. If Mydei asked him to jump off the balcony in this moment, he most likely would. But not before asking how many flips Mydei wanted him to do. Five flips in midair is Phainon's known record. If Mydei were to ask him to do ten, who is he to refuse?

"Yes. Of course."

A hint of red dusts Mydei's cheeks. Even flustered, Mydei still looks stunningly put-together. He then withdraws his hand to Phainon's dismay. All good things must come to an end, after all.

"I look forward to seeing you in it," Mydei says. "I shall take my leave now. Do *not* see me for the rest of the day."

In a rare sight of hurriedness, Mydei bolts back into the room, leaving Phainon still in his daze at the balcony. Phainon could hear Janus' locks turn followed subsequently by the slam of his door.

None of Mydei's behavior today made sense. The garments, the direct compliment, and a warning not to see him?

Phainon allows his fingers to run through the silken fabric, mapping out the carefully threaded embroidery with muted fascination, Mydei's wishes echoing in his ears as he does

so: *I'd like to see you in these sometime.*

Collapsing back to the kline, Phainon stares ahead, eyeing Kephale's figure in the hopes that They hold the answers.

"Oh, Mydei. Must you always be a mystery?"

The bell signalling the beginning of the Parting Hour tolls all around Okhema. Phainon had once again missed the submission of his reports to Aglaea. She would no doubt call him out on it during today's *deipnon*.

Sighing, Phainon makes his way back into his room. Still a mess despite how much he tried to make it look presentable. Mydei's unsmiling image stares down at him as if in judgement from within the frames of his makeshift portrait.

Phainon glares without the anger. "This is all *your* fault, you know."

The Mydei-featured advertisement merely taunts him with golden honeycakes as a way of reply.

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To put up a united front, it is important for the King and Queen of Kremnos to wear complementary garments.

...Red is traditional for wartime. Gold is only to be worn during special occasions. White is appropriate in a time of recuperation. Black during the Month of Mourning...

*... **~~Purple is used for courting.~~***

> *Purple is no longer worn for it is often associated with Bartholos, who is a devout follower of Zagreus, and could only signify trickery and deceit. – **Ptolemy**, annotation date: [redacted]*
>
> ***How so? I find purple to be fitting. This reasoning is shallow. – M.***
>
> *I never knew Mydeimos would be interested in matters related to courtship. – **Leonnius***
>
> *Are we even supposed to write here? – **Peucesta***
>
> *Heh. Ptolemy is going to throw a fit. Should I make him a vial of sleeping drought? – a most apologetic **Perdikkas***
>
> *It seems that Mydeimos does have the heart in him to be romantic, after all. – **H.***
>
> *The five annotations above are to be disregarded. Future readers of this tome, please refrain from vandalizing important texts, unlike some people. (You know who you are!) – **Ptolemy**, annotation date: [redacted]*

— annotations found on a page of Kremnoan Royal Etiquette: Volume 1

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Chapter End Notes

i divided the month of evernight into two chapters because A LOT happens yall. i can’t even make this shit up.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

as always, thank you so much for reading you guys <3 i hope you enjoyed this chapter. this was honestly a fun one. your comments and kudos mean the world to me aaa take care now and much love :3

Chapter 6: harsh words of the living, one yearns for the dead

Chapter Summary

> Phainon goes to meet two of the most significant people in Mydei's life. One expresses a love so tough, bearing the weight of responsibility. The other, a love mired in grief, finally eased in the afterlife.

Chapter Notes

> ***written before the 3.2 update***
>
> special thanks to lilure for a wonderful phaidei sketch from this chapter 💗 do check it out if you haven't yet!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

· · ─ ·𓂃· ─ · ·

> *Once the courted has chosen the right suitor to entertain,* ***the next step is to introduce the said suitor to family members whilst wearing courtship garments.***
>
> *...parents come first, followed by immediate relatives, followed by distant relatives…*
>
> *...**in the event where family is unavailable, a guardian is a most suitable replacement, or a very close friend.***
>
> *— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Chapter 8: Introductory Rites*

· · ─ · ─ · ·

Phainon stares at his reflection through the mirror, fixing the folds of his chiton by his shoulder that's clasped neatly with a golden brooch. He then readjusts his *himátion* for the nth time to make it seem as if it had been draped over his shoulder in a deliberately elegant manner. It would be counterproductive if he leaves the room looking worse than one of Aglaea's many mannequins.

It's been a while since he had forgone his usual armor and wore something more formal. He can't even remember the last time he wore a chiton this elaborate, and feels just a bit more defenseless despite his greatsword being capable of being summoned at a moment's notice.

But he promised to indulge Mydei. Thoughts of danger had to be put aside for now.

Phainon lightly shifts the belt, something Aglaea had generously lent him, for he sought her counsel just the day before on how to make sure that he'll be able to carry himself appropriately whilst wearing such an extravagant garment.

("This belt—" Aglaea began, shoving a gold-plated belt, embellished intricately with lapis lazuli, upon Phainon's awaiting hands.

Phainon didn't even have enough time to properly appraise the item when his hands were being made to hold more accessories that are worth ten times more than his modest salary as a Chrysos Heir.

"—these *perónai*—" Aglaea then procures an ornate set of pins from her own jewelry box, also shoving it into Phainon's now occupied hands who made sure he caught it all in time and didn't drop a single one.

Two brooches seemingly to be of pair are typically worn to keep the fabric in place upon his shoulders. Another one, more opulent than the other two, is for Aglaea to place wherever she wishes for decorative purposes. The three pins all possess a circular design with detailed engravings of the sun; a typical pattern in a land that worships the Throne of Worlds.

"—this *himátion*—" Aglaea flings a navy blue fabric, embroidered with patterns sewn in threads of gold, towards Phainon's direction without looking back.

The *himátion* lands squarely on Phainon's face, drooping over his head and shoulders, making him seem like a reluctant ghost in navy blue who has come to haunt Aglaea's closet of well-sought fashion treasures.

"—and these sandals— Oops."

Behind the fabric of the *himátion* was Phainon's bleeding nose who had just sustained a fatal injury from being hit by the heavy heel of a sandal, no doubt also made with *gold.*

"I'm alright," Phainon reassures, more to himself than at Aglaea, his voice muffled from underneath the fabric where the golden ichor oozing out of his nose have begun to seep through.

He hears a click of the tongue. It's either Aglaea is displeased that the *himátion* is ruined, or the fact that Phainon was not able to catch the sandals in time. Phainon, despite being of a bigger frame and stature, trembles from the anticipation of her wrath.

"Get yourself patched up first," Aglaea tells him. Her mercy causes Phainon to relax. It's a small blessing that Aglaea couldn't see the relief in his face. "Return at once for we still have a lot to cover. If you are to present yourself beside Mydeimos, then you should look the part."

That's a dig at Phainon's sense of fashion if he ever heard one. He will never understand how a man who paraded himself half-naked possessed a better sense of fashion than him.

But then again, Mydei could wear literal rags and still look beautiful. No, Mydei is just beautiful no matter what he wears. Mydei and beauty go hand in hand together, inseparable and intertwined.

Cotton, linen, wool, or even silk of any and every color and kind, and Mydei would still be able to make it work. And then Phainon's mind traitorously wanders into a more dangerous territory, spurred on by the sight of Mydei in the baths from the previous week.

That is, Mydei without all the grandeur. Bare, flawless tanned skin out for display and Phainon is *finally* able to see where the various streaks of scarlet etched upon him ends—

Aglaea clears her throat and Phainon is left to scamper out the door, making haste towards the infirmary. Regardless of the rough treatment and barely concealed shade, Phainon is very thankful for Aglaea's help.)

Despite not having enough sleep for Aglaea had kept him awake four quints into the Curtain-Fall Hour, he can still say that he looks good. Hopefully.

He then allows himself a one last once-over—the last of *many*—before deeming that he looks presentable enough, nodding at his reflection with an air of pride.

Ignoring the two stubborn strands of hair atop his head that refuses to go down no matter how much he coaxes it with softened beeswax to keep it in place, Phainon then makes his way out of the door and leaves his chambers before the nerves start to kick in.

He had initially expressed his wishes to Mydei to be granted permission to wait outside the room of the latter so they could both go together to meet Lord Krateros. Mydei had agreed shortly, and that was the last of their conversation from the day before.

As he descends the flight of stairs to head towards Mydei's chambers located two floors down from his, Phainon readies what he's going to say in front of the man that Mydei holds a profound respect to.

Not much is known about Lord Krateros' personality. His feats in Kremnos Phainon is well aware of for he could simply walk up to a random Kremnoan and they'll be able to give him the answer he seeks.

Trusted by the former regents, former master primus of the Watchers, a warrior who embodies Nikador's virtues, a severe man with years of experience behind him—all of these point to the fact that Lord Krateros is not to be taken lightly, and Phainon has no intentions of making a fool of himself in front of Mydei's most respected mentor.

Coming face to face with the door to Mydei's chambers, Phainon raises his hand to knock thrice.

"I'll be out in a moment," came Mydei's deep voice from within.

Janus' locks turn shortly afterward, opening the door to grant someone from the inside passage to leave the room. And Phainon—

Well. Phainon loses his ability to *think*.

Swathed in purple, Phainon's initial thoughts that Mydei would look good in anything *and* everything are not without merit.

Regardless of how unusual the sight is for Mydei only ever wore red, he managed to make a color, one that Phainon didn't even bother to think twice of before, to have bewitched Phainon's senses. Devastatingly so.

Phainon can't even will himself to look away.

Okhema could be in dire peril right at this moment and Phainon would still choose to behold the mesmerizing beauty in front of him, that is of Mydei in a *purple chiton*. Though lavish, at the end of the day, it is still *just* a chiton. Not exactly an article of clothing one should lose their mind over.

Mydei fashions the chiton to be of similarity to how he usually wears his clothes—draped over one shoulder and leaving the rest of his magnificent torso bare, displaying the pattern of scarlet streaks etched across the expanse of his tanned skin, muscles rippling with every minute movement as it reflects the light from Kephale's Dawn.

The amount of jewelry he wore remains to be the same and yet different: an elaborate necklace made from gold, showcasing intricate craftsmanship and adorned with amethysts of varying sizes and shapes; a bangle to match around his exposed arm, whose purpose is to seemingly make the shape of his biceps even more accentuated; and, a pair of gold rod earrings with an amethyst at the base, a stark contrast to the large hoop ones he typically wore.

Phainon wonders if Mydei's collection of jewelry rivals that of Aglaea's.

Accessories aside, Mydei even chose to appropriately go without his gauntlets this time, allowing Phainon the rare sight that is his bare hands—fingers exquisitely long and defined, nails neatly trimmed with the blunt edges shaped in a gentle curve, and veins running up to his forearms, fading with every subtle flex of muscle.

Phainon smiles, feeling breathless. "Hello." And then, unable to help himself, he adds a lame, "You look very nice."

To think that he and Mydei are wearing matching chitons makes Phainon feel unbearably warm. Not to mention, they're going to walk around in public together. Phainon only aims to hope that his own meager self wouldn't dare sully the radiant beauty that he accompanies.

The radiant beauty in question hasn't uttered a greeting in return, choosing to assess Phainon with eyes of molten gold, traveling from the ornate sandals below, lingering at the exposed skin of Phainon's arms, and then up to frown upon the two strands that refuses to be conquered atop Phainon's head.

After the assessment, Mydei merely says nothing. Now is as good a time as any to tease him for it, is Phainon's thought process.

“Not even a compliment?”

“So you asked Aglaea for help,” is Mydei’s chosen reply. “A wise decision.”

How Mydei was able to come up with that conclusion, Phainon has no idea. But it’s not entirely a lie, per se. “That I did,” he admits. “Funny thing is, I distinctly recall her saying that I look hideous in purple.”

“Only if you wear purple trousers and distastefully pair it with a yellow tunic,” Mydei says, amusement shining in his eyes as he recounts the anecdote Phainon shared with him just two days prior detailing his fashion failures. “You shouldn’t fault the Goldweaver. She was only stating the truth.”

Phainon slumps. “So you *do* share her sentiments in regards to that issue.” He sighs dramatically, feigning despair. “I can’t believe this. To think that my *dearest* friend and equal would turn his back on me.”

“Rest assured, if it was your intention to look ridiculous, you have my full support,” Mydei says. He doesn’t even bother to hide the snicker in his voice this time. “Unfortunately, you’re just dismally horrible at dressing yourself.”

For his sense of fashion to be criticized by a man half-naked was not in Phainon’s list of affairs for the day.

Mydei mercilessly continues, “I may be Kremnoan, but I do pity the eyes of the unfortunate Okheman citizens who would bear witness to what one might call an *abomination*.”

“Your words are as sharp as knives today,” Phainon says. He would loathe to admit that he’s whining. “What happened to the man who had so softly called me handsome?”

The effect is instantaneous. Mydei’s ears burn bright red as he turns away. “Seeing as your ego is through the roof from such simple words alone, I shall keep it in mind to share my compliments sparingly.”

“Mydei, you should know by now that your words are never simple,” Phainon says, a teasing smile on his lips as Mydei makes a figurative retreat. “Not to me, at least.”

Mydei only scowls without much heat, a poor attempt to appear slighted despite his flushed countenance. “Enough with your nonsense.”

He gives Phainon’s bare arms another look, as if the constant lingering of his gaze was not enough to keep its image ingrained in his memory.

“Wait here. I have to retrieve something from my chambers.”

Before Phainon could reply, Mydei vanishes into his room in a flurry of purple, emerging only moments later with two arm bangles in hand.

No amount of mental fortification could prepare Phainon for what follows: Mydei’s *bare* hand upon him, radiating heat from where it touches the skin just above his elbow. The cold

surface of the gold bangle a stark contrast from the warmth as Mydei clasps it onto his arm, allowing it to rest comfortably on a spot that won't hinder the flex of Phainon's bicep.

Phainon allows Mydei to do the action a second time for his other arm, his breath coming out short and irregular when he realizes just how close he and Mydei are.

From this angle, Phainon could almost count every strand of Mydei's eyelashes, pinpoint every flawless pore, marvel at the streak of red that lines his right eye, and the diamond-shaped scarlet mark that kisses his cheekbone remains to be a mesmerizing sight as always.

Mydei is beautiful, and Phainon's fingers are left to itch by his sides, longing to card them through those silky strands of blonde hair—to pull Mydei even closer so that he may commit to memory every other detail of Mydei that he might have missed from this painfully near yet still so far away of a distance.

Phainon's breath catches when Mydei's eyelashes flutter as he blinks, eyes meeting his and Phainon has never seen such enchanting pools of gold despite having witnessed Kephale's mighty figure bleed it on the daily.

"All done," Mydei says, barely a whisper for they're so close they might as well see into each other's minds.

The hand on Phainon's arm lingers, the hold is loose and never once did it tighten. Almost as if Mydei only wished to touch, the opportunity to take some more—perhaps pull, grip, or knead at the muscle—entirely out of the question.

Phainon reminds himself to breathe, gaze tracing the curve of Mydei's lips, pink and soft and —

"Thank you."

"You're welcome." Mydei pulls away, assessing Phainon fully now with the addition of the new accessories. He nods in approval. "Keep the bangles, Deliverer. They look better on you."

The warmth Mydei leaves in his wake is something that Phainon chases, the scent of pomegranates and sweetness lingering in the air. It's a loss that never fails to leave Phainon aching, desperately wanting for more.

Krateros agreed to meet them in a gazebo located east of the Marmoreal Palace. Upon their approach, Phainon could already make out a figure donning a red Kremnoan armor, and a back that stood tall despite his old age. He alone indulges in the shade the gazebo provides.

"About time you showed up," Krateros says, still with his back turned from the newly arrived pair. The gruffness of his voice causes the fine hairs upon Phainon's nape to stand out of sheer nervousness. "You ought to know, this old man is not exactly keen on waiting."

“Forgive us for the delay, master,” Mydei apologizes. “We were… held up on the way.”

‘Held up’ would be a good way to call whatever it was that had occurred earlier.

Krateros finally turns around. His left eye had already turned pale, a scar running through it. His right eye, on the other hand, is piercingly dark, unsubtly regarding Phainon up and down as if assessing his worth.

With his arms crossed, Krateros’ lips remained sealed, his opinions a well-guarded secret, one that Phainon could only ever hope to know.

“Master,” Mydei began, breaking the tense silence. “This is the man I’ve spoken to you about. Phainon of Ae—”

“No need for introductions,” Krateros cuts off coolly. “Especially not when every living soul in Okhema speaks of his name and sings his praises.”

If that was Krateros’ attempt at a compliment, it sure didn’t feel like one. Phainon could even sense the discomfort radiating from Mydei in palpable waves. There’s an unspoken dissonance here that Phainon is not privy to, but he knows well enough that he is far from being given the right to pry.

“It’s a pleasure to finally make your acquaintance, Lord Krateros,” Phainon says, keeping his voice light as he extends his hand for a shake.

Krateros merely stares down at the offending limb, much like how Mydei did in their first meeting back at the Vortex of Genesis. Phainon wonders if this was just something that Kremnoans do normally.

Before Phainon could so much as lower his hand, Krateros had once again turned his back on the pair. “If that is all, I’d like to be left alone now.”

“It’s unlike you to barely say anything,” came Mydei’s voice. Though his tone still remains respectful, a hint of impatience belies his words.

Krateros scoffs. “What’s there to say? I told you already, Mydeimos. You can do whatever you want with *whomever* you want, as long as the throne of Kremnos does not sit empty for too long.” He barely turns his head around when he says, “Does that man beside you even know of the responsibilities you carry?”

“It’s not something he should pay any mind to,” Mydei replies through gritted teeth. “Phainon has enough on his plate already.”

Phainon frowns upon hearing this. And here he thought Mydei was beginning to slowly open up to him. It seems that the distance between them remains to persist, even after all this time.

His thoughts are cut short when Krateros bursts into a humorless laughter, turning around for the second time. The smile on his lips barely even reaches his eyes.

“You hold so dear this... *hero’s* innocence?” Krateros asks.

Though the question was obviously directed towards Mydei, his dark eye was centered solely upon Phainon, boring holes if it were possible. Phainon tamps down the urge to fidget under the scrutinizing gaze.

“Young man,” Krateros begins, addressing Phainon this time. “If you are to be of any use, convince Mydeimos to take up Kremnos’ crown instead of allowing his own people to waste away in this foreign land, left to wander like sheeps without a shepherd until a pack of wolves devours us whole.”

This time, Phainon is unable to hide his discomfort under the veil of placidity. He and Mydei have never once discussed the latter’s claim to the throne. Mydei never brought it up, and Phainon knew better than to impose. If Mydei wished to speak of it, he would already have.

A sigh resounds.

“And here I thought you’d be amenable for a proper conversation without bringing up the crown,” Mydei says at last. The despondency in his tone doesn’t go unnoticed by Phainon’s hearing, attuned to every single one of Mydei’s inflections. “Even now and in the presence of an uninvolved party—a *guest*—you still choose to speak of this.”

“*Uninvolved?*” Krateros demands, the volume of his voice rising with every drop in his absurdly low patience. “Why, the moment you presented him in front of me dressed in those garments, he is as good as involved with the rest of us Kremnoans that you’ve doomed in this so-called *eternal land*.”

In an attempt to diffuse the situation, Phainon stands in front of Mydei like a habit whenever the latter is about to engage himself in a fight. This time, however, it is not the poor soul of a random (provoking) citizen that Phainon wishes to protect from (a provoked) Mydei’s ire.

No. At this moment, it is Mydei of whom Phainon shields from his mentor’s sharp words. Though futile, Phainon will die trying.

“Lord Krateros, you’ve said enough.”

Krateros raises an eyebrow. “What gives you the right to discern whether or not I’ve said enough?” He takes a daunting step forward. Phainon holds his ground. “You have proved *nothing* to me, boy. And by the looks of things, you know *nothing* as well. Aside from your prowess in battle, I honestly fail to see anything else of substance.”

Phainon would admit that it is better to hear Krateros belittle him than having to endure him directing his harshness towards Mydei. And just when Phainon readies himself for more insults hurled his way—of which he is so painfully familiar with, courtesy of his overbearing mind who never fails to remind him of his lack of worth—a warm hand encloses upon his wrist, tugging lightly.

Mydei would never beg. But at this moment, Phainon has to admit that this is the closest thing he’s ever seen Mydei allow himself to do such a debasing act.

“It seems that we have to do this another time, then,” Mydei says, distant in the way he regards Krateros. He doesn’t meet Phainon’s gaze when he mutters, “Let’s go, Deliverer.”

Phainon’s heart aches. Mydei may be a man of few words, but he never once sounded so quiet when he spoke. His voice always reverberated with power, eager to be heard by anyone and everyone who would listen. For it to be reduced to such meekness—

The hand on his wrist falters. This time, Phainon takes Mydei’s hand in his own, holding tightly and refusing to let go even if Mydei shoots him with a confused expression as if to ask*, What are you doing?*

Phainon ignores him, redirecting his attention back at Krateros who eyes their intertwined hands. The severity in his face seemed to have uncharacteristically softened for a bit from the sight, but returns the moment that Phainon speaks.

“Lord Krateros, I can’t help but be led to believe that this conversation is unbecomingly one-sided.”

Krateros crosses his arms, his tone akin to that of a tired adult humoring a small child when he says, “Is that so?”

“It *is* so,” Phainon insists. “You’ve spoken your wishes, but you adamantly oppose to hear that of Mydei’s.”

“His wish is for what’s left of Kremnos to stay under that blonde usurper’s rule,” Krateros retorts. “Forgive me for not wanting to hear *any* of it.”

And though hearing Aglaea being addressed so demeaningly puts a bitter taste in Phainon’s mouth, he presses on.

“I may not know of the complications your tribe faces and won’t defend Okhema’s prejudice against you, but *please* heed my warning: it is not safe outside the holy city. You may wish to return to your home lost in the sea of fog, but it will only serve to endanger you,” Phainon explains. “Okhema is the safest place for you and your people. Mydei knows this and he brought you all here for your own good. He has thought of nothing but the *future* of the Kremnoans.”

“The *future* of the Kremnoans will only be fulfilled once he ascends to the throne! He is the crown prince of Kremnos—”

“Even if that is so, Kremnos still remains to be lost due to Nikador’s madness. If you have a better solution for us to be able to track it down faster, do share.” Phainon hardens his stare. “But until then, you are not to harass Mydei about something he clearly wishes not to speak of *yet*. Give him time.”

“And why would he avoid such a discussion?” Krateros asks in turn, eyebrows furrowing. “Because he refuses to be king?”

“Mydei is free to decide for himself in regards to what he wants. King or not, he’s never relinquished the responsibility he has so selflessly carried to ensure the safety of his people. What difference would there be if a crown is involved? A royal title?”

Mydei’s hand in his grips him tight, aghast. “*Deliverer—*”

“You speak so freely of your own opinions,” Krateros muses, more surprised than angered. “This is the man you hold so high of a regard, Mydeimos? You’re growing to be likened to those weak *Okhemans* who choose words rather than blades to prove a point.”

“Phainon is my equal,” Mydei says. This time, his voice does not waver. Phainon could feel his heart race upon hearing such a firm declaration. “He is as talented with a blade as he is with his words. Do not regard him so lowly.”

Krateros merely huffs. “Forgive me if I do when this man is clearly *tolerating* your whims! He knows not the best for you.”

“And you do?”

The attention of the other two lands on Phainon.

Krateros reddens at the question. *“I beg your pardon?*”

“*You* know what’s best for Mydei? Not me, and not even Mydei himself, but *you?*” Phainon reiterates with a white-lipped smile. “How I wish I would never possess such pronounced confidence and pride for it would be my downfall.”

In a blink of an eye, a hand had already made its way around Phainon’s neck, pinning him to the ground in a manner most swift as it is violent. Phainon groans from the impact, ears ringing as he is met with the darkness of Krateros’ sharp eye.

“Master!”

Mydei tries to separate Krateros from Phainon. Krateros doesn’t even fight, allowing himself to be pulled away on his feet and Phainon is left to gasp as he tries to regain his bearings whilst sitting up.

“Have you gone insane?” Mydei exclaims, rounding up on the older. “To harm a Chrysos Heir warrants an extreme punishment! The golden threads will *not* show you mercy!”

“Death would be a better mercy than to see you frolic around with this utterly naive *hero!*”

Phainon feels his nose drip warm golden blood. “I may be so. But I know better than to force my ideals onto someone else.”

Mydei turns to glare at him. “Phainon, *enough—*”

“Do *not* speak to me so directly, you *foolish child!*” Krateros spits, drowning out Mydei’s admonishments. “His mother, *Queen Gorgo*, entrusted me to make him king! To usher Kremnos into a new era of Strife!”

Phainon falters upon the mention of Mydei's mother.

"I am not simply *forcing* my ideals on him! It is his fate! A fate he is so adamant to look away from just so he could run around with you people who bear Kephale's golden blood in your veins!" Krateros' voice breaks, almost desperate. "Do not act as if you know everything, *boy*, because you *don't*. And all you have to blame is Mydeimos who chooses to shield you from the weight that the bloodied crown would eventually bear upon his head."

Mydei helps Phainon up from the ground, a flash of concern on his face that Phainon catches briefly before Mydei turns around to address his teacher.

"That's enough, *Krateros*," Mydei states, bitingly cold and yet vulnerable all the same. "It seems that we've both disappointed ourselves today."

Krateros scowl gradually softens into that of resignation, opting to look away as his lip quivers. Whether it be from the sheer frustration of words unspoken, or from biting back emotions so profound, Phainon doesn't know.

It doesn't help the guilt that worms its way into his gut. Perhaps he really did speak out of turn this time.

Mydei continues, "I hope that the next time I'll seek your audience, it won't end so sourly." To Phainon, he says, "Let's go, Deliverer."

The breeze that blows through the Garden of Life is sweet and tranquil. Sitting on the bench at a secluded corner and contemplating earlier's exchange, Phainon can't help but think—

"I guess your teacher hates me now, huh."

Beside him, Mydei only sighs. "Hatred is not something my teacher wallows in," Mydei says. "He is simply set in his ways due to his old age. I should've spoken to him beforehand. You will have to forgive him, Deliverer."

"There's nothing to forgive," Phainon replies, sullen. "I could sense that he didn't mean any ill will towards you."

Mydei sighs again. "I assumed that he would've already calmed his mind since our last conversation."

Last conversation. Phainon didn't want to pry about what they talked about for Krateros' anger to persist even now. But then he forgets that Mydei could read him like an open book, his curiosity written so evidently on his face.

"I told him that I have no intentions of inheriting the coreflame of Strife," Mydei answers to a question unasked.

Phainon stills out of shock. “W-*What*?”

“It was never something I wanted. Never will. Divinity does not equal regency, not to me. And I desire neither.”

“But I—” Phainon attempts to form coherent sentences. “I always thought…”

Since Mydei was the crown prince of Kremnos, he was the most fitting of the Chrysos Heirs to inherit the coreflame of his Titan. Strife was always supposed to be in Mydei’s hands.

Before he met Mydei, Nikador’s coreflame was something Phainon had worked ceaselessly towards. Spurred on by his desire to avenge the death of his loved ones, a tragedy brought on by the Black Tide, Phainon wished to be at the forefront of fighting against it.

However, the only way he could do that was to possess Nikador’s coreflame who acted as the Guardian of Amphoreus, the one who moved Their mobile nation to quell the disastrous darkness. Phainon was so sure that the coreflame would be his—

Until he met *Mydei*.

Only then did he realize his own inadequacy, for Mydei was always the worthier one to embody Strife.

“Have you told anyone of this?” Phainon asks, keeping his voice low just in case anyone were to hear.

“Only the Goldweaver,” Mydei answers. The way he seems so unbothered is off-putting. “I told her directly about this when I first arrived at Okhema just so she wouldn’t harbor any expectations of me. And now, I’ve told you.”

That was months ago. Phainon wonders if Mydei had come up with such a decision even *before* he came to Okhema. This is clearly not something that Mydei had simply decided upon in such a short notice.

“So you’ve made up your mind,” Phainon says, feeling helpless all of a sudden. “And Lord Krateros took the news poorly, I assume?”

“Poorly would be an understatement.” Mydei rubs his temples, as if recounting such a memory brought him a great headache. “I had to take him to the infirmary or else his old heart would’ve stopped beating right then and there. It would humiliate him to the afterlife if he died in such a lame manner instead of on the battlefield.”

Despite everything, Phainon allows a soft laugh to escape his lips. The image of a disgruntled Mydei escorting a raging Krateros to the infirmary is quite entertaining indeed.

“He does seem like the type to mind such matters, especially when battle and death are involved.”

Mydei huffs. “He is a Kremnoan through and through, stubbornness and all.”

Phainon nods for he does agree that Kremnoans (Mydei) do possess a distinct stubbornness to them.

“It is because of his embodiment of our virtues that my mother chose him as my mentor, to be the one to guide me on my path to the crown.” Mydei stares at the palm of his hands. “I trust him with my life. But as you can see, there are times where we fail to see eye to eye, and I’m left to ponder my thoughts on my own instead of seeking his counsel.”

Phainon always knew that Mydei prefers to carry unspoken burdens on his own. But right now, Phainon can’t help but think that this is Mydei’s way of finally asking for help, of finally opening up and allowing his troubles to be shared with those who care for him.

“You know, I’m always here to listen.”

Mydei looks up, the surprise in his face evident just before he masks it with a taunting smirk. “You’ll spare time for me at the expense of your Deliverer duties?”

“Hearing the woes of a dearest companion counts as a good deed, does it not?” Phainon simpers, a smile of his own.

Mydei scoffs, though far from being aggrieved. “It hardly counts as woes. It’s more like…” He trails off, thinking it through with his eyebrows furrowed. “More like an obstacle that I have yet to overcome.”

“And I have no doubts that you will.”

“Is that so?” Mydei jeers, almost like a challenge. “My story is not a happy one, Deliverer. Are you sure you’ll be okay to lend an ear? Word around the street is that you’re known to burst into tears upon hearing of sad and gruesome tales that involve deaths.”

“Deaths?” Phainon doubles down. “Why, if the death of a most treasured friend is involved, then you’ll find my dignity flying out of the window.”

Mydei has the audacity to smile, but the distraction of such radiance would not hinder Phainon. Not this time.

“What a wretched friend that is, dying so easily. You must’ve been in shambles.”

Phainon leans in just a little bit, their foreheads almost touching, and allows some semblance of sincerity to seep through despite the exchange of jests.

“Indeed,” he agrees, allowing himself to get lost into the pools of gold that serve as Mydei’s eyes. “What a wretched friend he is, for allowing me to witness his demise and breaking my heart in the process.”

It is very easy to pinpoint the exact moment that Mydei loses his composure. Eyes widening for a brief moment before he leans away, choosing to avoid Phainon’s gaze in the process.

“I was only gone for but a brief moment,” was the lame excuse that Mydei had chosen.

Phainon disagrees. “It felt like an eternity.”

“You exaggerate. We’ve both established months ago that death is—”

“Out of your reach, yes,” Phainon continues for him, a wry smile on his lips. No matter how many times they have this conversation, or even speak of it in jest, it doesn’t change the fact that whenever Mydei dies, Phainon would be in anguish. “One could only imagine how you were able to come to know of such a curse.”

Mydei tenses beside him. “It’s not as bad as you’d think.”

“Enlighten me, then,” Phainon says softly. And then, he adds, “Only if you want to.”

This is the second time during the conversation that he urges Mydei to confide in him. If Mydei still chooses not to speak of it, he won’t push any further. Even if the history of Mydei’s curse is something that sparks Phainon’s curiosity, Mydei’s comfort comes first and foremost.

“I did promise you that I would tell you my story someday,” Mydei says eventually.

“I fail to recall when you made such a promise,” Phainon replies in an attempt to lessen the weight, for he knows how much Mydei values the fulfillment of any and every promise. “Only that you’ll do it as a form of thanks for me trying to save you back at the Abyss.”

“Is that so.”

“Are you doubting me?”

Mydei turns to him. “I have never.”

Phainon feels his heart beat faster. “You can trust me.” *I’ll listen.*

“I know.”

A quietude settles between them, expected and comfortable in a sense. Phainon allows Mydei to think it over, and waits patiently; the soft gust of the breeze is enough to blow away any lingering unease.

“I’ve spoken to you about my mother before,” Mydei says after a while.

Phainon nods, remembering their drunken time at the Heroes’ Baths. “You have.”

Mydei takes a deep breath, almost as if he were steeling himself, settling his gaze upon the Garden of Life where citizens come to gather and exchange thoughts, lounging alongside docile chimeras, and basking in Kephale’s Dawn atop the gigantic lily pads.

Though the view ahead of them is almost utopic, Mydei’s story, as Phainon would come to know of, is far from it.

“When I was but a mere infant, my father threw me into the Sea of Souls with nary a remorse for the death of his only son,” Mydei recounts to an avid listener of one. “It’s a sacrifice for Nikador, he said. A way of ensuring that the legacy of Kremnos wouldn’t end in my hands as stated by a prophecy.”

He turns to Phainon. Despite his words having nothing to smile about, Mydei’s lips wore but a shadow of it.

“I was then left to be swept away by the currents of the Sea of Souls, but not once did it lead me to the Shores of Death. *That* was how I came to know of my curse.”

Phainon smiles wrily. “This is what you consider to be ‘not as bad as I’d think?’”

Mydei shoots him a dry stare. “Would you have preferred it if Thanatos presented Themselves before me and told me that They had forsaken me to a fate that didn’t know Them?”

“No,” Phainon answers right away. “I actually would much rather you don’t experience either of those horrible circumstances.”

“It’s already done, Deliverer. I drifted at Sea for nine years. The souls of the dead could reach the Shores in just a few hours after their demise, if I’m not mistaken. It is the place where one shall walk the Path for three winters, pass the Three Gates of Judgement, before subsequently ending up in one of the Three Destinations depending on the soul’s behavior during its time in the land of the living.”

Only one harrowing detail catches Phainon’s attention. “You drifted at the Sea of Souls for *nine* years?” He knew better than anyone that there’s a lot of details being omitted here. “How did you even manage to leave such a place?”

He imagines a young Mydei, ceaselessly fighting off the waves just so he wouldn’t sink to its depths. Phainon wonders if Mydei encountered the souls of the dead during that time, his childlike innocence long since been tarnished by the concept of death, loss, and betrayal.

“All I remembered was the sight of a bright star—the brightest out of anything I’ve ever seen, guiding me away from the currents,” Mydei answers distantly, as if recalling the moment requires great focus. “Next thing I knew, I was already upon the shores of Carmitis.”

“Did you return to Kremnos?”

“Why would I?” Mydei asks sardonically. “I have no ties to that cursed land. But some Kremnoan exiles did get wind that I survived the old king’s sacrifice, and they chose to follow me in my journey across Amphoreus. Thus, the detachment was gradually formed, and I have gained new allies in the process for a lone warrior can never be victorious in a war that wages for far too long.

“They filled me in as to what had happened in Kremnos during my absence. Including how my father killed my mother in an unfair duel, how she died to defend my claim to the throne,

and how she wished for me to be king—of which you are now aware of, given that my master had so explicitly made you know of it."

"By pinning me to the ground," Phainon quips.

"He does that sometimes."

Phainon nods slowly, the throb at the back of his head and the tight, ghostly sensation around his neck a lingering reminder of Krateros' strength.

If Aglaea had caught wind of such events, she—and perhaps even the Okhema Council of Elders, despite their blatant opposition towards the Chrysos Heirs, but would still jump at any opportunity to oppress the Kremnoans—would make sure that Krateros won't be able to walk around Okhema without an escort.

Phainon keeps in mind to put in a word with Aglaea to be lenient with Krateros' punishment. The woman is capable of merciless feats after all.

"You mentioned before that you killed the old king," Phainon says cautiously, referring to the conversation of their first meeting of which not a single detail has faded in his memory. "Did you do it to avenge your mother?"

"I won't deny it," Mydei answers. "But I also did it to stop Eurypon from further leading Kremnos into ruination."

Mydei then turns to the skies, his gaze faraway.

"And now, I've left my people in the hands of foreigners, my nation lost, and our Titan wreaking havoc with neither rhyme nor reason as we speak. Sometimes, I wonder if I made the right choice."

Phainon lets the words hang in the air, choosing how to appropriately respond but comes up with a blank. In the end, only Mydei knows the true extent of his feelings and the consequences that his choices have left for him to handle.

The only thing Phainon could provide in this moment of vulnerability and openness is a listening ear.

He knew that Mydei had a reason for doing what he did: to keep his people safe, to avenge his mother, and to put an end to his father's schemes. His past is nothing but a culmination of pain. Even if Mydei had said nothing of it now, Phainon is sure that he's lost a lot of significant people during his journey before he arrived at Okhema.

If Mydei is ready to tell him about it, Phainon would make sure that he's there when Mydei does. And just like now, he'll shoulder the burdens that Mydei carries even for just a temporary moment, if only to alleviate Mydei's sense of isolation and loneliness.

"You're being really quiet," Mydei notes after a while with a slight hesitance. "Have I managed to scare you off, Deliverer?"

Phainon scoffs lightly. “You think of yourself to be *so* formidable…” He then gives Mydei a reassuring smile. “You’ll never scare me off. I was simply choosing to maintain my silence to give you room to establish your thoughts.”

And though Mydei looked offended by Phainon’s initial statement, he eventually relaxes, the aggrieved lines on his face softening as he wordlessly conveys his gratitude.

“Surprisingly wise of you, Deliverer,” Mydei muses. “Even if you always put to use that idiotic mouth of yours, it does make me wonder if you run around sharing the profound effects of silence like a philosopher in your free time.”

“Not at all,” Phainon replies with a nondescript wave of his hand, a movement that he notices Mydei following closely, a glint in those gold eyes. “A philosopher has to be proficient in defending their stance from those who dare to question it. I’d say such a quality is not something I possess.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow, able to see through the false modesty so quickly. “I heard from Castorice that during your time in the Grove, you represented your school—the Nousporists—and became the debate champion ten times in a row.”

Phainon grins, not finding it within himself to deny it. “Do I sense a compliment coming in?”

“You wish,” Mydei retorts with a light elbow to Phainon’s ribs.

Regardless of its playful nature, the action still successfully causes Phainon to suffer severe emotional damages, his heart beating wildly from within his chest and his tongue indubitably tied.

Due to his silence, Mydei continues to press on, “But I must admit, I find your responses quite delightfully entertaining on a good day. Downright infuriating at most, though.”

Phainon regains his voice upon hearing the compliment, utterly rejuvenated. “It’s only because you make it so easy for me to tease you that I’m able to respond so wittily.”

“So your intelligence relies on tomfoolery. Not a philosopher, but perhaps a jester would be more suitable. You should join the Clowns of Zagreus when you have the time. I heard they’re currently a member short and needed someone to juggle apples, or something.”

“Absolutely not,” Phainon says, feigning offense. But deep down, he preens at the fact that Mydei finds him funny. Plus, he can’t exactly juggle apples. For Mydei to think that he’s capable of such a feat sounds like a high praise if he’s ever heard one. “I would much rather prefer to be *your* Deliverer.”

Mydei’s posture tenses, a slight shift in the air as his eyes of gold flickers. “*My* Deliverer, huh. That sounds incredibly selfish of me, to have you all to myself.”

“I wouldn’t mind,” Phainon says with a shrug, feeling his face heat up in the process at the thought of Mydei claiming him for his own. “You’re the most selfless man I know. At least, allow yourself to want something for a change.”

Phainon had fully expected for Mydei to respond with a jab of his own about the faults of indulging oneself too much. And so, when Mydei leans in unprompted, Phainon was caught so off-guard that he almost falls off the bench.

Mydei finds amusement in this, as seen with the way his lips are curved in an unmistakable smile, the corners of his eyes crinkling, and every little shift in his expression is for Phainon to behold.

They are so close, Phainon could barely *think*.

A brush of a hand against Phainon's own causes him to jolt at the touch, the action allowing him to further lean into Mydei's space until the tips of their noses briefly brush against each other, their lips a hairbreadth's distance. If the breeze were to blow harder, they would be—

"I *do* want," came Mydei's voice, interrupting Phainon's indecent spiral of thoughts. "*Achingly* so, Phainon."

Mydei's finger traces Phainon's, drawing circles and lingering pointedly at one spot where—

The sudden realization hits Phainon like a dromas whose passenger urges it to make haste. All this time, Mydei's finger has been tracing the lone strand of blonde hair securely tied around Phainon's own, like a makeshift ring crafted out of a moment's thoughtless impulsivity.

Phainon's blood runs cold as embarrassment creeps upon his very being, aiming to drown him within its merciless tides.

"That's—"

"I don't mind," Mydei tells him, tracing more deliberately this time, as if to test the strand's durability around Phainon's forefinger. "My eyes are sharp. You'd be a fool to think that I wouldn't notice."

Phainon can barely hear Mydei's words with how loud his heart is beating, all that blood and none of it chooses to supply his poor excuse of a brain who refuses to function in dire situations such as this, rushing to his groin unanimously instead.

Faintly, he is able to say, "Forgive me all the same."

What must Mydei think of him now?

"Where was this shyness when you went ahead and did something like this?"

Phainon clenches his eyes shut the moment that he feels the tip of Mydei's thumb slowly creep upon the sensitive skin of his inner forearm, the rest of Mydei's warm, soft, and *bare* hand enclosing around his wrist in a loose grip, slowly caressing up and down as if to soothe Phainon from his humiliation.

It's futile. The movement only spurs the endless visions Phainon has kept hidden within the deepest crevices of his mind, powerless in his thoughts as the image of Mydei, doing the

exact same motions, held not the chasteness of his arm, but *something else*.

"*Mydei—*"

Mydei's grip on his wrist tightens, and Phainon almost whines at the suddenness of the sensation, feeling his head go light, his body weightless.

"Deliverer, you're about to—"

The thump his body makes against the ground is a delayed sound. Only after a moment's reprieve from Mydei's wicked touch was Phainon able to come to terms that he's fallen off, his back on the grass and his legs still propped upon the stone bench.

"—fall, I was going to say." Mydei stares down at him with pure astonishment. "Are you alright?"

The audacity of this man who knows not of the concupiscent effects he has on Phainon's poor, *poor* heart.

Ignoring the ache between his legs and the burning hot feeling on his face, Phainon answers with a breathless, "Yes."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Do you need help?"

"You're mocking me."

"This hardly counts as mocking, Deliverer. If you wish to lie on the grass like so, you should've brought a mat with you."

Phainon curses himself for thinking that Mydei was offering to help with… his *other* problem. He is so screwed that it's not even funny. And Mydei, the beautiful and muscular minx that he is, is beyond oblivious to Phainon's plight.

"Sure. I'll keep your suggestion in mind," Phainon replies with a glare, not exactly sure why he's even angry.

Mydei only sighs. "You need not to be embarrassed. I already told you, I don't mind."

You should mind, Phainon wanted to say. It would have been better if Mydei called him out on the strand of hair tied around his finger, challenged him to a duel, or yell something along the lines of, *I will kick your arse, you lecherous Deliverer!*

But then he takes note of the slight hint of a blush coloring Mydei's cheeks, and all of his initial gripes vanish into thin air like it was never there in the first place.

"In fact," Mydei continues, "This stunt of yours reminds me of something."

Still on the ground, Phainon is compelled to ask, "What is it?"

“I don’t usually wear rings, and neither do I bother to collect them,” Mydei says. “But I had a signet ring once.”

“You did?”

Mydei nods. “It belonged to my mother, given to her by my father to signify their union despite Kremnos not adhering to such a, uh, *Mnestia-approved* tradition. She gave it to me shortly after my birth as a token of our lineage, in the hopes that I may one day inherit Kremnos’ legacy. It kept me company whilst I was drifting across the Sea of Souls.” Mydei pauses, a purse on his lips making him seem troubled. “Unfortunately, it’s likely that I won’t be able to see it again.”

Phainon frowns. Even if his mind still reeled due to earlier’s events, he makes an attempt to show that he’s listening—sitting up at last, his attention piqued. “How so?”

“Due to the unforgiving tides, my mother’s signet ring was lost to the depths of the Sea,” Mydei explains morosely. “It is a regret of mine for not having been able to guard it properly. I was simply too young to do so. Even then, it’s hardly a reasonable excuse to justify my carelessness.”

“You shouldn’t blame yourself so easily for the loss of it,” Phainon admonishes greatly. “We both know you didn’t do it on purpose.”

Mydei scoffs, as if Phainon’s words were something he’s heard about countless times and has now grown tired of. “Still doesn’t make me feel better, Deliverer.”

“Would the return of your mother’s signet ring make you happy?”

An unreadable expression graces Mydei’s features, almost pained but not quite. More melancholic, if anything.

“Perhaps. It might provide me with the answer that I seek.” Mydei looks away, his gaze landing on nothing in particular, as if he aims to take into view something that’s so far away. “Or maybe, I’m just like any other filial son out there—yearning for the traces of his dead mother.”

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The flimsy raft tied upon the dock sways with the crashing waves. Phainon feels the doubts beginning to settle in, eyeing the deep dark turbulent surface of the very waters that led to the Sea of Souls.

“Chartonus, I think we’re going to capsize with that thing,” Phainon notes grimly, turning to the calm Mountain Dweller beside him.

“Capsize, we will not. Of cypress wood, the raft is made.”

Phainon nods. “Right. I suppose we should start praying for Phagousa’s blessings of a successful voyage, just to be safe.”

Chartonus heeds not of Phainon’s doubts of his creation. “No dominion, the Chalice of Plenty, from here on out.”

Another splash of a towering wave crashes onto the wooden dock, soaking Phainon from head to toe. It is at this moment that Phainon realizes that he perhaps should’ve headed back to his chambers to change into his usual garb of protective armor, instead of simply rushing to the blacksmith to beg Chartonus to make him a raft so he may sail across the Sea of Souls in a quest to find Mydei’s signet ring.

And now, the once precious Kremnoan chiton sticks uncomfortably against his skin, the purple silk undeniably soaked. Phainon would have to grovel on his knees to ask Mydei for forgiveness if he does end up ruining the elaborate garment.

“Lord Phainon, it is ready.”

Phainon turns around and sees Castorice holding a basket filled with white asphodel flowers. It is artificially made, oozing with Castorice’s distinct power, one that bears the heavy aura of death.

“This will help mask the scent of life on you,” is Castorice’s explanation.

Phainon takes the basket, careful not to let his hand touch with Castorice’s, for the moment that he does, he *will* be sailing the Sea of Souls whether he likes it or not—not as a living being, but a dead one.

“Many thanks, Miss Castorice, for putting this together in such a short notice.”

Castorice shakes her head with a smile. “You are most welcome, Lord Phainon,” she says softly. “However, I do regret that I could not accompany you in this endeavor despite my knowledge of Death.”

Phainon understands. He knew well enough that the presence of dead souls would only strain her. It was ever so fortunate that Chartonus, amidst his many talents, was also proficient in matters regarding Death and knew the way to the Sea of Souls. Hence, Phainon need not to embark on this journey alone.

“It is alright, Miss Castorice,” Phainon assures. For how many times he’s already done so, he lost count. “You’ve been a great help.”

Castorice fiddles with her fingers, her gaze darting between Phainon, the raft, and the treacherous Sea.

“Remember, Lord Phainon, you *will* encounter the souls of the dead along the way,” she says, almost like a warning. “One of you will have to stay on the raft to ensure that it remains docked upon the Shores, and that no rebellious soul will use it to sail back to the land of the living.”

The thought alone causes Phainon to shiver, he can't even blame the cold winds that kisses his soaked skin to have caused the goosebumps to erupt. Never was he fond of ghost stories —tales of the dead coming to haunt the living due to a variety of excuses sounds worse than having to stomach Mydei's horrendous cooking, like he had done so before and thankfully, never again.

Phainon is having *none* of that.

"Stay and guard, I will do," Chartonus offers.

"Thank you, Chartonus," Phainon says sincerely. This way, he would be able to dedicate all of his focus in locating the signet ring.

Castorice watches with barely hidden concern as Phainon and Chartonus board the raft, its surface tipping slightly from their combined weight, as well having to catch the incessant waves coming from the raging Sea.

Before Phainon could undo the knot to free the raft from the dock, Castorice approaches him with slow and deliberate steps.

With a somber tone, she says, "One last thing, Lord Phainon."

Phainon straightens. "What is it, Miss Castorice?"

"*A set of rules I must give, know which of these you must heed. The dead have died and the living must live, not all warnings given shall you need.*"

The waves are ever so merciless, continuing to surge as if aiming to conquer the meager vessel of wood and rope that Phainon and Chartonus cling upon.

As Phainon holds on to dear life, Castorice's voice echoes in his head:

"*The Sea of Souls is not without an end, for the seabed houses the spirits of the damned who have never made it to the Shores of Death. Do not swim in these waters, for spindly hands will eventually find you and lead you to your demise.*"

It makes him wonder how arduous of an undertaking Mydei had experienced for having spent the first nine years of his life in these dangerous waters.

The thought of Mydei being dragged down until all that's left for him to do is to drown leaves a nasty taste on Phainon's tongue, as well as an ache of helplessness in his gut. Though undying, Phainon can't help but think of how many deaths Mydei had suffered in the hands of such relentless tides, fighting the souls of the damned that emerged ceaselessly from beneath the waters.

Mydei was but a mere child, and yet all he knew was survival.

“Not long now, the calm Sea!” Chartonus calls out, uncharacteristically loud to go above the thrashing noise of the unceasing waves. “Phainon, for a bit more, you must endure.”

Phainon need not to be told twice.

True to Chartonus’ word, less than half a quint must have passed before the peaks of the towering waves began to shrink as a hush fell over the water’s surface. The suddenness of it all made it seem as if they had entered an entirely new dimension, past the thinnest of boundaries that separated the world of the living and the dead.

Phainon is finally able to sigh in relief, basking in the sight that is the endless stars reflected by the undisturbed, *actual* Sea of Souls. The view alone is enough to rival that of the Vortex of Genesis.’

Despite the urge to dip his fingers into the water, Phainon chooses to keep all of his limbs within the raft. The last thing he needed was for some hand of a corpse to come pulling him into the water’s depths by the wrist.

“It glows, asphodels,” Chartonus tells him, handing Phainon the basket that had thankfully survived the earlier’s ordeal, finding shelter within Chartonus’ *himátion*. “The Shores of Death, not far.”

“*Not only will the asphodels conceal your living nature, it will also act as a guide to the Shores. See it glow, and you’re not far off from your journey’s destination.*”

Phainon finds a smile making its way to his lips. This quest was not for naught, after all. He’ll have to thank Castorice generously once he returns to the land of the living.

Cruising for a bit more and mapping out constellations, Phainon is finally able to see a trace of land from the distance.

“Chartonus—”

“The Shores of Death, it is.”

Phainon’s pulse spikes within his chest. He wonders if he’ll be able to find Mydei’s signet ring. Castorice did say beforehand during their preparation that the odds of the ring drifting off to the Shore was high, for every soul and treasure are bound to end up on it.

For the entirety of Mydei’s time since departing from the Sea of Souls, the ring must’ve no doubt settled upon the dull-colored, sandy beaches where their raft moors upon at the moment.

Taking a couple of glowing asphodels, Phainon jumps off the raft, his feet dipping into the soft and cold sands. Despite the waters lapping upon its surface, the sand remains to be dry.

“I’ll be off now, Chartonus.”

Sat upon the raft with glowing asphodels of his own, Chartonus says, “Of the least human, you should be. To the dead, these Shores belong to. In check, keep your emotions.”

Phainon nods, thanking Chartonus for the reminder. Willing to calm himself down, he then sets off to explore the Shores of Death, keeping an eye out for anything that glimmers on the gray sands.

"*Stray from the waters and walk the Path, the Three Gates of Judgement one must pass in three winters' time. Only then will a soul reach its final resting place, the Three Destinations —one for the heroic, one for the mundane, and one for the inherently evil.*"

Though Castorice chose words so vague for ceremonial purposes, Phainon is not foolish enough to not know that such a rule is something the living should not follow. And so, while scouring the sandy beaches for any signs of the signet ring, he also makes sure that the waters to the Sea are merely a couple of paces' distance.

He spots something shimmering and begins to dig, unable to hide his disappointment when the object buried in the sand is not a ring, but a single copper coin.

"Good sir."

Phainon jolts, turning around so quickly and comes face to face with—

The man's body before him shimmered with an eerie translucence, faint outlines barely hinting at a face. A *soul*.

"*Do not speak to the dead unless spoken to first; the living could only converse with three souls their entire lifetime. To communicate with a fourth will allow you to become a soul yourself, if you so wish to engage freely with them.*"

Phainon swallows, willing himself to calm down and not appear suspicious. "Hello."

"Will you please direct me to the Path? I find myself quite lost."

Phainon himself has no idea where the Path is. But before he could respond by pointing to a vague direction, another soul came sauntering forth.

"Why are we crowding over here?" the newly-arrived soul asks, possessing the voice of a young woman. "We should make haste to the Path instead of lingering."

"Ah, I was just asking him for directions. I had no intentions to linger, believe me."

"Mister," the woman addresses Phainon. "Will you not be walking the Path just yet?"

No, Phainon wanted to say. But if he responds, he'll only be able to talk to one other soul for the remainder of his lifetime. He's not sure if he should waste his chances so thoughtlessly.

In lieu of a reply, Phainon simply turns around, ignoring the confused calls of the two souls behind him. He's not here to socialize. He's here for Mydei's signet ring.

Just as he was about to resume his search, the sound of a bell tolls from the distance.

"*Oronyx has no dominion in the Sea of Souls. But three tolls of the bell is all the time a living person can have in a realm meant for the dead. Take too long, and you already know what will happen.*"

The panic begins to settle in. He had been too lax in his search. If he fails now, there's no guarantee that he'll be able to make the trip a second time. Thanatos will not take kindly to those who trespass Their realm so casually.

Scouring the beaches with a bit more desperation, Phainon digs up any and every shiny thing he could find, paying no mind to the souls that come up to chat with him, ask for directions, and some even had the audacity to provoke.

The second toll of the bell echoes across the Shores of Death. Phainon feels the hope within him dwindle, failure becoming the forefront thing in his mind followed closely by surrender. If he doesn't make it back in time to the raft before the third toll resounds, he'll be as good as gone.

Such a time of direness makes Phainon question why he's even doing this—making a journey to the Sea of Souls just to reach the Shores of Death, all for Mydei's signet ring? Did Mydei even ask him to do such a thing?

Phainon's purpose as a Chrysos Heir who wishes to see the prophecy fulfilled would all be meaningless if he's not able to return to the land of the living in time. He hasn't even been able to bid goodbye to everyone else.

Not even to Mydei.

Would the return of your mother's signet ring make you happy?

Perhaps.

Was their conversation at the Garden of Life going to be their last? The thought makes Phainon's heart twinge uncomfortably.

He wanted to provide Mydei with some semblance of comfort. The signet ring clearly meant so much to him. For Phainon to entertain thoughts of abandoning such a hopeless endeavor, does it not speak volumes of his ability to commit to something? The lack of it, that is.

Before Phainon could lose his mind from the internal debate, a soft singing interrupts his thoughts, faint, barely a ghost of it in the wind. At a moment's impulsivity, he follows the sound until it grows louder, clearer—

There's a huge rock by the waters. Sat on top of it was the singing soul of a woman. Despite such a wispy form that's ever-changing with every subtle shift, Phainon could still see the regal manner of which she carries herself.

With the waters of the Sea reaching up to his knees, Phainon allows himself to approach, noticing belatedly the words of the song the woman sings to be foreign, almost archaic. Strangely, a sense of jamais vu could be felt.

Playing the role of a mesmerized listener, Phainon waits for the song to end, hoping that the woman would take notice of him and strike a conversation first.

But Phainon was not able to hear the end of the it for the woman halts her singing abruptly. Her misty eyes land on Phainon, blank and devoid of life.

Only upon closer inspection does Phainon realize that the woman was wearing what looks to be armor. The design itself is familiar but old-fashioned. If the souls that linger upon the Shores aren't so gray, Phainon would've known which nation she once belonged to from the color of her cape alone.

"Warrior, you seem too mighty to have perished so soon," the woman says, acknowledging Phainon's presence at last. "You carry a strange air with you. Very strange. I have never conversed with the other souls, but you have my curiosity. Tell me, how did you meet your demise?"

Phainon already has an answer ready. "I died fighting against the forces of the Black Tide."

The woman doesn't seem surprised by this. Or perhaps it is because she's dead that her emotions barely even surface.

"So it would seem," she says. "You died an honorable death, warrior. As expected of someone who dons such esteemed Kremnoan garments. Funny, I seem to have worn something of the sort when I was still alive, but the patterns on the silk were quite different."

Sensing a fond familiarity settle within him, brought forth by a certain man he is closely acquainted with, Phainon couldn't help but ask, "You're Kremnoan?"

"Born and raised," the woman answers. "And I would assume that you're not. You don't look Kremnoan despite the chiton you wear. Which nation do you hail from?"

"I'm from Aedes Elysiae," Phainon answers, mentally preparing himself to answer a specific set of questions just in case the woman expresses her doubts about his origins. "It's just a small village eradicated by the Black Tide long ago. Okhema had served as my home since then."

The woman nods in understanding. "The Black Tide… the root cause of all suffering. Despite my lineage, I can't help but hope for a much more peaceful time where such darkness didn't exist." She turns her gaze to the distant horizon. "My son would be with me, then. If he wasn't taken away from me so early, he would probably be of the same age as you."

Phainon frowns. "That must have caused you a great amount of pain, to be separated from him."

"It has, and always will. I met my end soon after our separation in the hands of my husband, who had gone mad due to his selfish desire for power. Even if death has dulled my emotions, my love for my son persists."

"Where is your son now?"

Phainon wonders the reason why the woman still lingers at the Shores given that her son seems to have already walked the Paths. But the sad smile on the woman's lips is enough to render Phainon confused.

"I don't know," the woman finally answers.

"But I thought—?"

"That he's dead, yes." The woman nods. "I thought so, too. When a mere infant is thrown into the Sea of Souls, survival is not possible. But as you can see, I am here…" She trails off in favor of fiddling with her ghostly hands. Phainon sees something that gleams albeit briefly. "...and he is not."

The blood in Phainon's veins run cold at the sight of the ring upon the woman's finger, the symbol of Strife unmistakably etched upon its surface. The gold catches the dim light of the stars and Phainon's mind goes admittedly blank. His throat tightens, heartbeat racing uncontrollably.

That's—

"Is something wrong, warrior?" the woman asks, a hint of concern in her otherwise impassive tone. "You seem different all of a sudden."

Phainon recalls Chartonus' warning, mingling with Castorice's own:

"*The dead do not have emotions, and emotions carry the scent of life. Asphodels are able to conceal this to an extent, but it holds no water in the face of extreme vehemence.*

If a soul catches but a whiff of life, they will know that the living is amongst them. They will want you to take them back."

"I'm alright, ma'am," Phainon manages to say, the beating of his heart—the symbol of his life—a roaring sound in his ears amidst the profound silence. He then gestures at the ring that the woman wears, hesitant for he could be mistaken. "That ring…"

The woman raises her hand, showing him the ring without so much of a reluctance. The gold seemingly floats in the air with how translucent the woman's finger is.

"This is a signet ring given to me by my husband," the woman explains, the bitterness in her tone is subtle, but still there nonetheless. "I gave it to my son before he was thrown into the Sea in the hopes that Nikador's blessing would ensure his survival.

I still hope for it. Thanatos has yet to force my stubborn soul to walk the Path after forgoing it for many winters now. But until then, I shall stay here and wait for him." She lets out a soft sigh. "*Mydeimos*, my child. Why must you make your mother worry so?"

The relief that his search had not been for naught is immediately replaced with an unbearably helpless grief—to mourn in place of a son far away, to hope in place of an unfeeling ghost of a mother.

“Your majesty.” Phainon drops to his knees in front of Mydei’s mother, the waters of the Sea lapping up to his chest and soaking his chiton. But for now, he ignores the discomfort.

The soul of Queen Gorgo bears most of Mydei’s features. Though the form is mostly absent and fickle, Phainon could make out a pair of slanted eyebrows, slender almond shaped eyes with lightly colored irises that would no doubt be the same shade of molten gold that Phainon craves to see in every waking moment, the thin curve of the lips, the fine shape of a nose—

Phainon feels his heart ache.

“Mydeimos is his name, you say?”

Gorgo nods. “Yes. His name would’ve been etched in history. If only his father had not forsaken him, if only *I* had not failed to save him.”

Phainon steels his resolve and begins to recite, from memory alone, a story he’s heard orated at the Nerid Spring countless times. Not once did he ever grew bored of it:

“*The blonde warrior with nary a place to call home is an extraordinary one, they say. He led a lone army of exiles, of warriors cast away from their very place of birth.*

Together, did they find solace—waging campaigns all across Amphoreus, all of them victorious for a glorious leader of profound might is among them.

Immortal is his body, the curse of golden blood we’ve come to know. No arrow or blade could strike him down, a deathless beast who bestows what he can’t have to his adversaries.

And as the final Kremnos Festival was held, a lone champion of renown emerged. Straight and true did the head of his lance pierce to the heart of the king who no longer knew reason —a father who knew no son of his.

Mydeimos the Undying, his name is often sung. Out of fear or praise, it matters not to him.

His history is enveloped in a thick shroud of mystery. A single line from an anecdote of his past, none dared get too close to know.

For the eyes of a lion are sharp and formidable, he sees all that comes near as his prey.”

Once Phainon was finished, he looks up to see Gorgo’s eyes widen with sheer disbelief, lips parted slightly, seemingly unable to convey her words.

“How—?”

“He survived, Your Majesty,” Phainon says. “He avenged your death and led the Kremnoans to safety—to Okhema.”

Gorgo's eyes glisten. "You know him." It was not a question.

Phainon nods. "He's a dear friend of mine."

"But how could I believe you?"

It is not unexpected for a mother to want evidence that her son is alive and well. Phainon could only imagine how long she's waited for any news or traces of Mydei, just as Mydei longed for traces of her.

Eyeing the signet ring worn around Gorgo's finger, Phainon then turns his attention to the one he wears. A strand of golden hair that once beheld his mortification, and now only comfort—relief that he'll be able to provide the proof a mother seeks despite everything.

He carefully slips the strand of hair off of his finger, careful not to lose sight or hold of it, before presenting it to Gorgo as an offering.

"As an ally of your son," Phainon began, wistfully watching as Gorgo took the strand of golden hair from in between his fingertips. "Why would I lie about something of this magnitude in the presence of the mother he holds so dear?"

Gorgo's gaze darts between the strand and Phainon, light gray eyes flickering as she does so, cradling the strand close to her dead heart. Phainon has no doubts that if she were alive, tears would have fallen by now.

He wonders if Mydei, who expressed quite the opposition to the sight of Phainon's tears, would allow an exception when it came to his mother.

He definitely would.

"Mydeimos," Gorgo cries softly. "Oh, Mydeimos. How is he? What kind of person has he grown to be?"

"Mighty," says Phainon without an ounce of hesitation. "Strong and honorable. He's also caring and kind, a bit stubborn at times for I tend to bring out the worst in him. He…"

Phainon trails off. There's *something* in the way that Gorgo regards him with those unblinking, ghostly gray eyes of hers. A subtle and unreadable emotion, albeit impossible for the dead to be capable of expression, belies the wispy gaze.

She is expectant, wishing for Phainon to continue his sentence. And he does.

"He means a lot to me." A weight has been lifted off of his chest. "So much more than words could ever hope to describe. He's my equal."

Gorgo's lips curve into a smile, somber for how could a dead soul express joy?

"An equal, you say?" she muses. "Your eyes don't lie, child."

Phainon watches with muted surprise as Gorgo slips the signet ring off of her finger, taking in how the gold glistens for but a brief moment, before reaching out to give it to Phainon.

Before Phainon could accept the very object that spurred this journey, Castorice's voice echoes in his head, clear and foreboding:

"*No matter the treasures the souls of the dead are willing to offer, never accept. Unless—*"

"This is what you came for, isn't it?" Gorgo asks.

Phainon's hesitation only multiplies tenfold. He knows he doesn't have much time left to deliberate Gorgo's offer, but if he so much as accepts the ring in such a manner, his return to the land of the living would be forfeit.

Mydei will never reunite with his mother's lost signet ring, and Phainon would come to know of a fate without Mydei in it.

Sensing his plight, Gorgo leans down and takes Phainon's hand in hers, forcing him to accept the ring. Phainon chokes on a gasp.

"The strand of hair you gave me is more than enough of an exchange for this," she assures. "For the souls of the living could only dare to accept treasures from the dead when they've offered something of equal value in return."

Her words barely register in Phainon's ringing ears, his mind a downright mess.

Faintly, he says, "How did you—" *Know that I'm alive?*

Gorgo's smile hasn't faltered once, her hold on Phainon's hand tightening but Phainon could barely even feel it.

"Your hand is warm and your heart beats with a steady cadence, echoes of a name we both know to whom it belongs to." Gorgo encloses the ring into Phainon's awaiting palm. "You'll give this to my son when the time is right, will you?"

Phainon feels the weight of the ring in his hands, the cold metal kissing his feverish skin. Gorgo's bidding somehow strikes him as strange. "Am I not supposed to give this to him right away?"

Gorgo sighs. "Foolish child," she admonishes lightly, a stark contrast in the manner to how Krateros had addressed him as such. "Now is hardly the right time for it. If you are to put a mother's dead heart at ease, it would be best for you to wait."

"Then, *when* is the right time?"

"You'll know it soon enough. The haze of hesitance will have to dissipate before you find your answer. But based on our rather brief conversation, I'd say you're halfway into the journey of discovering it yourself."

Phainon frowns at the vagueness. But before he could protest and ask more questions, Gorgo's smile fades away, only to be replaced with a profound seriousness.

"The bell that moves along the slow march to the Three Gates of Judgement is about to toll once again," she says. "If you stay here for it, then you might as well escort me to the Path for you're about to walk upon it yourself."

"I—"

"Go now, warrior."

"My name is—"

"That is not your name," Gorgo tells him softly. Her smile returns. "Go now, and don't keep my son waiting for too long. I thank you immensely for the good news you have brought."

Phainon's protests dissipate. "It was an honor, Your Majesty."

"Watch over Mydeimos for me."

"I already do," Phainon assures. "And will continue to do so until my very last breath."

Gorgo seemed content with this. "With your words, I am able to rest."

She scoops up the water from the Sea with her hands, and drinks.

"*To drink the waters of the Sea of Souls would make you forget the life you have lived in your next reincarnation. If you are to accept drinks from the souls of the dead, let it be known that it only came from one source.*"

As Phainon rushes back to the raft before the third toll of the bell could resound, his mind ceaselessly replays the conversation he just had with the late queen of Kremnos.

With the signet ring held tightly within his hand, it was at that moment then does Phainon come to realize that Gorgo only ever spoke of affection towards her son.

Not once was the crown, or Mydei's claim to the throne, ever mentioned.

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It was storming as he awaited in front of the empty smithy of the Okhema's Grand Craftsman. The sign that says, *Return, I will* is the only thing the man in the crimson hood sets his eyes to.

Irises of gold belie a hint of confusion and impatience for how could Chartonus abandon his post when the day hasn't even ended? It is unlikely for the Mountain Dweller, who displays

passion in his craft, to take sudden breaks.

Thunder strikes and the rain pours harder, and the hooded man can't help but recall a distant legend a good friend of his that's now long gone recounted to him, a story from one of his many books.

It was said that rain could still fall even without the influence of the three Titans who controlled the weather, namely: Aquila, Phagousa, and Georios.

The exception only occurs when a living soul returns from the realm of the dead. The hooded man only recalls of such a storm when he himself emerged from the Sea of Souls after nine years of drifting in its currents.

And now, he wonders if that distant legend bears some semblance of truth right at this moment, given that storms of this magnitude are rarer than even the finest of treasures and the most auspicious of circumstances.

The Marmoreal Market is empty for the patrons have gone and sought shelter within their homes, or the Marmoreal Palace. The man in the hood crosses his arms, uncaring of the storm for his resolve is set and his mind consisting of only one thought:

One man as radiant as a thousand suns, of which he is more than willing to experience a thousand deaths for.

A smile makes its way upon his lips despite the gloomy weather, and he hopes that no unwanted eyes dare to witness it. Fondness and affection coursing through him, formerly unwelcome for how could he allow himself to indulge in such trivialities of the heart?

Now, all he feels is warmth, spurred on by the thoughts of a man he never once expected to fulfill the role of his would-be beloved. He never even entertained such notions before. But a dazzling man such as he—with his eyes the color of skies, and hair as pure as the first snow—the hooded man finds himself making an exception.

Heavy footfalls coming from behind him interrupts his thoughts. Chartonus appears in his line of sight, a basket of asphodels in hand. The hooded man frowns but does not pry.

"Mydei," Chartonus greets, igniting the furnace as he does so. "Here, for how long, waiting?"

"Not long," the man in the hood responds.

"Apologize, sincerely, I am."

"There is no need." Gold eyes linger to the basket of asphodels. "You were due a break, anyway. Despite the storm, waiting is but a trivial consequence to your masterful service."

Chartonus hums. "Your patronage, I always thank," he says. "Anything you need, of service, I will be."

The man in the hood merely smiles, eyes of gold flickering against the flames of the furnace.

“I’d like to put down a commission,” he says before procuring a bag of gold nuggets from within his cloak, presenting it to Chartonus. “A matrimonial dagger, if you please. Of Kremnoan design.”

Chartonus is quiet as he takes the heavy bag, placing it upon Talanton’s Scale. “My sincerest congratulations.”

“Thank you, and…” A gauntlet-clad hand reaches out, a pair of ruby and sapphire nestled atop the palm. The cut of both gems are of carefully equal shape, almost complementary to each other. “I’d like these to be embedded in the hilt. As for the initials, you already know which letters to use.”

Chartonus nods. “Which letters, well enough, I know.”

Chapter End Notes

meet the family but make it more dramatic.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

thank you so much for reading, and for all your kudos and comments!! fuck eurypon, deadbeat dad fr. also, krateros redemption soon :c

Chapter 7: unquenchable thirst, strained to the breaking point

Chapter Summary

> Phainon thought that a week of farming would be just that—a week of mindless days in the field. And then he adds Mydei into the equation. Suddenly, farming is the least of his worries.

Chapter Notes

> special thanks to Sarikha_15 for a wonderful phaidei sketch from this chapter, and _yn319 for their amazing scene animation also from this chapter that i myself can't just stop watching.
>
> do check them out if you haven't yet!! 💗

See the end of the chapter for more notes

pillar season, month of cultivation

5 months before the present time

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Kremnoan braids are sacred to royalty. *Braiding hair is a tradition that has been upheld with every new generation of kings. To have a lock of hair braided is to honor one's ancestry even if bloodlines matter not when it comes to inheriting the throne of Kremnos.*

…it is inadvisable for a Kremnoan non-royal, as well as a person of non-Kremnoan descent, to tamper with these braids for it could be seen as a sign of disrespect…

*…**a spouse is, as always, considered as an exception**.*

> ***I see. – M.***
>
> *I told you it's not wise for me to braid your hair, Mydeimos. –* ***H.***
>
> *Mydeimos did what now? –* ***Leonnius***

His Highness is quite the rebel. Or is there a reason for such a request to be asked from our dear Hephaestion? Heh. – ***Perdikkas***

Keep your heads clear of filth, or you'll find your honey brew devoid of any sweetness. – ***H.***

Show mercy, Hephaestion. – ***Peucesta***

WHY IN NIKADOR'S NAME ARE YOU ALL WRITING HERE!

Apologie s P t lmy– ***Per d i****k as*

May Perdikkas find peace in the Sea of Souls, struck down by the wrath of one esteemed Sir Ptolemy. Date of death: [redacted] – ***Leonnius***

YOU'RE NEXT.

Can someone help me braid my hair? – M.

...I'll teach you. – ***H.***

STOP VANDALIZING IMPORTANT TEXTS! THIS IS YOUR FINAL WARNING! – ***Ptolemy****, annotation date:* [redacted]

— annotations found on a page of Kremnoan Royal Etiquette: Volume 2

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The Akashians—people hailing from the fallen city of Akashic—have moved to Okhema some years prior, almost a decade now if Phainon is not mistaken. He remembers hearing of their plight caused by the Black Tide while he was still studying in the Grove, and even sneaked away from his lessons just so he could help the Akashians get settled in the holy city.

The survivors were all followers of Georios. Considering that their city was built around a temple made solely for the worship of the Pillar of Stone, they naturally had several festivals and rituals ingrained in their culture.

Aglaea allowed them to still uphold their traditions in any way they could during their stay in Okhema, and even encouraged other citizens to observe and be respectful. If the Akashians allowed it, they could even participate.

The Akashians are kind-hearted people, a stark contrast to their savage history spurred on by the arrival of calamitous occurrences during the early days of Era Bellica. They allowed people of all nations to be of help and partake in Georios' bountiful blessings. Thus, several years since their integration into Okheman society, Okhema would hold the Revival Ritual on the eighth day of the Month of Cultivation.

The first week of the fourth month is an exhausting one. Vast fields located south of Okhema —where the land is flat and fertile with an ample water source—is used for the ritual. This

entails the need to till and fertilize the soil that takes up the most time during the first week, followed by the planting of wheat kernels.

Mydei and Phainon, as esteemed Chrysos Heirs, took the time off from their busy schedules to help the citizens speed up the process. Considering that Phainon had been consistently helping out the Akashians for years, Aglaea made it his job to show Mydei the ropes.

“I have an idea,” Phainon says, standing beside Mydei as they stare at the empty fields ahead of them.

Mydei only hums. “A ridiculous one, I bet.”

“Not quite.” Phainon shoots him a smile. Having Mydei around just made things more exciting. “Should we see who can till the land the fastest? I take the east fields, you take the west. Both three sets of ten *aroura* each, if I’m not mistaken. A good challenge, wouldn’t you say?”

“Only for a fool who thinks it’s possible, maybe,” is Mydei’s response.

The mentioned land is indeed too vast for merely two ordinary people to tend to it. But it should be known that Kephale’s golden blood runs in their veins—that alone should exclude them from being ‘ordinary.’

“You sound like you’re giving up already,” Phainon teases.

“I’m simply questioning the feasibility of such an undertaking.” He gives Phainon a deliberate once-over. “My body never tires. You, on the other hand…”

Phainon scoffs at the blatant jab at his stamina. But before he could come up with a retort, the sounds of distant chatter fills the silence behind them, accompanied by the clack of tools.

They both turn to the Akashians by the village square who were in the middle of preparing for a full day of tilling ahead. Most of them are of old age and have only a single ox to assist —the last of the three males they’ve managed to save after the Black Tide invaded their city. It was ever a pity that no females were spared, yet another species about to go extinct.

Phainon sees the exact moment that his intentions were understood by Mydei: the old should no longer work and instead, take the time to rest and leave the labor to the young ones. Or in this case, two *extremely* competitive Chrysos Heirs.

“I accept the challenge,” Mydei finally says with his arms crossed, having made up his mind in a moment’s realization. And then he takes it up a notch, as he always does. “We might as well just do everything ourselves.”

“Even if it’s *us*, a field this vast would take too long for only two people to work on,” Phainon says, fondness seeping through him, brought on by Mydei’s enthusiasm. “We can plow what has been decided upon and leave the rest to the others.” He squints at the field. “Should be about… five sets of ten *aroura*. I heard the detachment will be arriving tomorrow to help out?”

Mydei nods. “They are.”

“That’s good news. Some willing farmers from other nations are also amenable to lend their aid. With more people helping this year, we might be able to get the fields ready ahead of schedule…”

A hand on his shoulder startles Phainon from voicing his thoughts out loud. Mydei’s lips are curved in a smile middling between genuineness and teasing. He gives Phainon’s shoulder a light squeeze.

“Not bad, Deliverer,” he commends and Phainon feels his knees go weak at the praise. “I’ll let you have the honor of *delivering* the good news to the Akashians.”

The initial delight evaporates way too quickly as Phainon gives Mydei a dry look. The latter must think that he’s *so* funny for that.

~~Endearing~~. Annoying.

“Rest assured,” Mydei continues. “I’ll wait for you here and won’t start ahead of time.”

“Even if you do, I’ll still emerge victorious,” Phainon shoots back with a smirk of his own. “You can begin tending to the land, Your Highness. I won’t hold it against you.”

Mydei shoots him a glare. “Spare me the charity. I have no need for such.”

Phainon raises an eyebrow. “But isn’t this your first time tilling a field?”

“I’ve tilled fields before using the lands rendered defeated by the detachment,” Mydei explains, a tinge of irritation in his tone, perhaps thinking that Phainon’s words meant to underestimate even if Phainon’s intentions were anything but. “How did you expect me to feed a whole army in between campaigns?”

It was then that Phainon remembered that the Kremnoan detachment didn’t exactly have a place to return to, an exile order from their own land of birth had left them to wander the lands and seek renown elsewhere.

Perhaps Phainon’s teasing was a bit tactless this time, but an apology would only serve to provoke Mydei even further.

“Alright,” he says, keeping his voice light. Mydei’s tense shoulders relax, eager to direct the conversation elsewhere. “I’ll let the Akashians know that they’ve been relieved of their duties for today.”

Even if the Akashians were reluctant to have only two people prepare a third of the fields for planting wheat, they acquiesced in the end with Phainon’s incessant begging.

The elders merely shook their heads resolutely, wondering why someone was so eager to take up such a grueling task. But then again, the minds of the youth are something one of age could no longer comprehend.

“There’s a couple of *arōtra* in the shed, Phainon,” Demeas, the old Akashian chief, says with a smile, his face wrinkled slightly even more now than how Phainon last remembers it. “A simple thanks alone is not enough to convey my gratitude for your help all these years. I will always remember the favor you and Lord Mydei have done for us today.”

“As Chrysos Heirs, it is not only our duty to protect, but to also ensure the comfort of all citizens,” Phainon reassures. “Mr. Demeas, this is but a small compensation for the bountiful grain your land has provided for Okhema.”

Demeas merely laughs, a gruff yet pleasant sound. “My land is but a measly space that Lady Aglaea had so graciously lended to us. It does not compare to the land the Council of Elders hold authority over.”

“But it is a land blessed by Georios, nevertheless.”

The corners of Demeas’ green eyes crinkle. “You’ve always been a flatterer, son. I shall not hinder your work now. If you ever need anything, I’m afraid I won’t be available. You already know my wife—”

“Madam Marpessa.” Phainon nods. “I was wondering, where is she?”

“Out in the orchard, most likely,” Demeas answers with a distinct fondness in his tone accompanied by a light laugh. “Best expect that you’ll be snacking on apples later.”

Demeas’ eyes glinted with affection at the mention of his wife, and Phainon could only wonder how the old couple were able to maintain affections between each other even after more than five decades of marriage.

As a Chrysos Heir, Phainon dares not wish for the same idyllic fate to befall him, it would be selfish. Such is not something the duty-bound is meant to indulge in.

With a tight-lipped smile, Phainon excuses himself and heads to the shed, dragging two *arōtra* with him. True to his word, Mydei stood at the exact same spot where Phainon had left him earlier, arms crossed and posture tensed with impatience.

When he turns around to shoot Phainon a glare with those eyes of pure gold, Phainon once again chooses to remind himself of his duty—his thoughts should not linger on what could be, but on what *must* be: the coreflames restored, the prophecy fulfilled.

He doesn’t doubt that Mydei adheres to the same way of thinking. Given their age and status, if they really wanted to, they would have already taken in lovers. But Mydei has never once succumbed to such a distraction (as far as Phainon knew of), and likewise, Phainon had never considered anyone, or anything for that matter, to be worthy of dividing his attention from the Flame-Chase Journey.

Until now.

“I thought you’d keep me waiting until the Action Hour,” Mydei drawls.

“Just did some brief catching-up,” Phainon reasons, easing his mind off of thoughts that are nigh impossible, of desires better kept hidden. “Ready?”

Mydei only rolls his eyes and takes an *arōtron* by the handle from Phainon’s weak grasp. Heading to the west fields, he manages a taunting, “Good luck, Deliverer.”

Phainon stares at Mydei’s retreating figure, an unexplainable discomfort in his gut. Uncaring whether or not Mydei heard him, he says, “You, too.”

From the beginning of the Entry Hour to the first couple of quints of the Action Hour, the calloused skin of Phainon’s palms grow closely acquainted with the wooden handle of the *arōtron*, the supposed rough texture already smoothened by years of use.

Neither he nor Mydei opted to use the last remaining ox. Phainon would admit that without a draft animal to assist, the skill and strength needed to do the labor had multiplied tenfold. It was ever a blessing from Georios that the soil is less demanding, a testament to the care of the Akashian farmers who tended to the fields all year round.

Kephale’s Dawn shone warm light against him. That, as well as the heat from the exertion, was beginning to become unbearable. Sweat drips from his forehead, the fabric of his clothes sticking uncomfortably to his skin, and he wonders why he didn’t just remove his armor beforehand.

The muscles of his arms and legs are beginning to ache, and his back is overdue for a thorough stretching. Even if he’s tilled these fields annually, the frequency of the activity is much too few for him to grow accustomed to the exhaustion.

From far away, he could see the lone figure of a blonde man, tanned torso out for display, seeming to have forgone what little he wore to cover his middle. Mydei plows the field with purpose, a certain finesse in his movements only seen in bodies that have done each pronounced action countless times before.

Even from this distance, Phainon could almost imagine how those muscles rippled and tensed with every pull of his arms and push of his legs, maneuvering the worn-out *arōtron* with little to no effort. Despite the tool being innately stiff and heavy, Mydei is able to make the object appear pliant in his hands, like a body in submission, boneless and *willing*—

Suddenly parched, Phainon decides to take a break. He walks back to the Akashian settlement; mudbrick houses built closer together around a small courtyard that served as the village square. Phainon could count how many families lived in the place with both of his hands, the original Akashians were even lesser then, back when they first arrived at Okhema to seek refuge.

The village chief’s house is located up on a hill, a little further than the rest of the houses which were built a couple of paces from the wheat fields directly. Since the first time he’s

helped the Akashians till the land, it became standard procedure for Phainon to lodge in the village chief's residences—other houses are full and Demeas himself had insisted for how could he not afford a Chrysos Heir the hospitality befitting of their status?

The hike to the top of the hill seemed far more grueling than it should be, and to think that a married couple older than him lived there and made the trip several times daily. Perhaps he should ask Mydei to race him after a whole day's worth of working in the fields.

Setting aside the idea for later, Phainon finally finds himself in front of the village chief's doorstep, one hand poised to knock. Upon doing so, an old woman's voice from within beckons him in. He then pushes the door open and is greeted with the warm, sweet scent of something baking.

"Phainon, is that you?"

"It's me, ma'am," Phainon answers.

Hurried footsteps come from the kitchen. Demeas' wife, Madam Marpessa, wore a pink apron carrying a plate of sliced apples and an amphora filled to the brim with water.

"Goodness, you've gotten taller since I last saw you!" Marpessa gasps, placing the objects she's carrying upon a nearby table to assess Phainon more thoroughly. "Do my eyes fail me? You look more alive than last year!"

Phainon smiles. "Must be due to the waters from the baths. Aglaea recently made some adjustments."

"Even if that is so, I'm glad to see you doing well. I heard you brought a friend with you this year?"

"I have. His name is Mydei, also a Chrysos Heir," Phainon says. "Tomorrow, his tribe will come to help as well."

Marpessa's eyes shine with gratitude. "How blessed we are to have you heroes with us. Why don't you call Lord Mydei and rest for a while? You've been at it since the Entry Hour," she says gently, taking the plate of apples as well as the water-filled amphora from the table before handing it to Phainon. "Kephale's Dawn Device might be a symbol of Their mercy, but in the Action Hour, the heat it emanates does get quite unbearable."

"Thank you for your concern, ma'am."

"It's but a small thing," Marpessa dismisses just before her demeanor becomes hesitant. "Also, Phainon, you already know that our humble abode only has one spare room available —"

Phainon didn't need to seek out the wisdom of Cerces to know where this was going. His smile falters for a little, and he hopes that Marpessa hadn't noticed.

"—the other families are more than willing to accommodate you or the other lord, of course," Marpessa continues, her breathing gradually becoming uneven as she tries to fend off her

panic. “But, ah, Ismene has five children running around, Rhene’s husband has come down with a nasty sickness, Chalcon’s just recently *burned down half of his house*—”

“It’s perfectly alright, ma’am,” Phainon reassures. He can’t help but feel that he needed it just as much. “Mydei and I are good friends. I’m sure he won’t mind if we share a room.”

Phainon is the furthest from being sure.

Perhaps he should have consulted with Mydei prior to this before making such a claim. But if he doesn’t calm an anxious old lady this instant, the consequences might be dire. All things considered, if Mydei detests the arrangement, he could simply kick Phainon out and have him sleep on the fields.

The thought alone is miserable enough to have Phainon feel himself figuratively droop. He could only hope that Mydei would show him mercy.

Marpessa thankfully regains her bearings. “Allow this old woman to apologize for the inconvenience, nonetheless. I’ll have Demeas expand the house just so we could accommodate more people.”

To say that Phainon is looking forward to that would be an understatement. That is, if he’ll be able to survive staying in one room with Mydei for a *week* and continue his annual job of assisting the Akashians with their Revival Ritual next year.

Various emotions accompany Phainon as he makes the trip back to the fields, carrying a plate of apples and the amphora with him. He was so preoccupied by his thoughts, mingled with the urge to escape from Marpessa’s incessant apologies, that he even forgot to ask for cups.

He then takes refuge beneath a nearby tree, the shade it provided pleasantly cool. Setting the food and drink aside, Phainon takes this moment of reprieve to finally strip himself of his armor—his cape, coat, and inner shirt folded neatly beside him.

The wind feels nice against his sweaty skin, now finally exposed, and he allows himself a well overdue sigh of relief, closing his eyes as he rests his head against the tree trunk.

He had no idea how long he sat there, or if he managed to fall asleep from the sheer exhaustion alone—perhaps it was an attempt to escape his thoughts if only for a brief moment.

The sound of light and measured footsteps approaching catches his attention in an instant, however. Phainon would be able to recognize it even with his eyes closed.

“Tired already?” came a taunting voice.

Phainon blinks his eyes open and regrets it right away. Mydei stood over him, casting shadows upon his resting figure. His entire torso is laid bare without any hindrance for once—no fabric slung over one shoulder, no gauntlets, and the only jewelry he wore was the lone, large hooped earring hanging upon his left ear.

Wandering blue eyes are unable to keep still, taking in the sight of unblemished tanned skin marred in scarlet streaks, muscles defined, their form tastefully emphasized by the thin sheen of sweat that seemed to glisten against the light of Kephale's Dawn with every minute shift as he breathes.

"Hardly," Phainon answers, quietly frustrated with how strained his voice had sounded. "Just needed a little break to soothe tired muscles and…"

His eyes linger upon the dangerous sight of Mydei's nipples, dusty and sensuously perked. A formidable pair of attention seekers, in Phainon's modest opinion. The sight of one nipple (*Mydei's* nipple, specifically) on a regular day is enough to render Phainon's mind a mess if he allowed himself to dwell on it. *Two* nipples is an entirely different story.

The sight of it at the same time would spell a disaster for Phainon's dwindling self-restraint and his poor, poor, *poor* unconsoled libido.

"I was thirsty."

Despite his words, Phainon hadn't drunk a single drop from the amphora since coming to rest beneath the shade of the tree. Perhaps now is a good time to quench his parched throat, but he doubts a mere drink of water would be able to help in that regard.

Mydei only hums, oblivious to Phainon's sentiments. "You even got yourself a snack."

It takes Phainon a moment to determine what Mydei was referring to, shamefully realizing that the latter's attention was directed to the plate of sliced apples, gold eyes glinting with interest.

"Madam Marpessa prepared it for us," Phainon says, now also eyeing the plate. Only when Mydei is out of his sight does he see reason. "You have yet to meet her. When the *deipnon* comes around, you should introduce yourself."

"No need to wait for so long," Mydei says. Somehow he looked discomfited about something, the signs of it eventually emerging for Phainon to take notice. "I have to seek her out, actually. I'll join you in a while."

Phainon furrows his eyebrows, confused. "Did something happen—?"

Before he could finish, Mydei had already rushed off to the village. Phainon could only sigh for Mydei does have his strange moments from time to time. Endearing to a fault.

It takes a while for Mydei to return, and when he does, his frown had only deepened, shoulders visibly tensed. Phainon could only surmise what had gone down. It's not possible that Mydei didn't get along with Marpessa for she's the sweetest old lady Phainon has had the pleasure to meet.

"What happened?" Phainon asks once Mydei was within earshot, straightening up. "Are you alright?"

Mydei's distress is radiating off of him in palpable waves. Rare is a moment in which Mydei allows his raw emotions to seep through his typically reserved countenance. Phainon feels his skin prickle anxiously, anticipating Mydei's response with a thinly-veiled dread, ready to provide comfort if need be.

The answer to his question is not what he had expected.

"Do you have a hair cuff with you?" Mydei asks, a distinct edge in how he spoke that it's almost as if he just delivered the most harrowing of messages. Or in this case, asked the most grievous of questions.

Phainon's mind blanks. "What?"

Mydei's golden eyes flicker, narrowing in distraught. "It's just— My braid…"

The halted statement is effective enough to draw Phainon's attention to the lock of hair resting against the jut of Mydei's right collarbone, the length is longer than the others, cascading freely in distinct waves—a remnant of the braid now nowhere to be seen.

"It must've gone loose earlier while I was out on the fields and I failed to take notice," Mydei finishes.

Sensing that this is a sensitive matter, Phainon threads lightly, considering his words with care. "Do you need help looking for your hair cuff?"

Mydei shakes his head. "It's futile. The field is vast and the soil struck loose. The possibility of my hair cuff being buried in the ground is unfortunately high."

"Have you asked the villagers if they have spares?"

"That's the reason why I went earlier. I asked every man and woman, every child even. They —" Mydei exhales shakily, eyes clenched shut as his words trail off, no words needed to convey his failure.

Phainon feels his chest ache at the sight, the urge to simply hold Mydei close to comfort him competing with his need to find a solution *immediately*. The braid and the hair cuff clearly meant something for Mydei, far more significant than Phainon could ever hope to imagine.

He looks over to the vast, half-plown field and feels helpless. Just as he was about to take the jar of water to offer Mydei in an attempt to calm him down, his eyes caught the glint of something coming from his folded clothes on the ground.

Only then does Phainon find the solution he seeks.

Aglaea is going to have some choice words with him when he returns back to the main city, but Phainon pays the threat no mind as he takes the belt that held his pauldron and cape together, cleanly snapping the prong of the buckle loose.

With just the right amount of pressure, the metal prong bends just right, malleable enough to be formed into a somewhat circular shape to resemble a hair cuff. It still does not compare to

the one Mydei typically wore, though.

Phainon hesitantly shows his handiwork to Mydei who was watching with curiosity. It's a relief that his actions have captured Mydei's attention enough to distract him from his initial distress.

"Will this work?" Phainon asks.

Instead of an answer—either a simple yes, a scoff, a roll of the eyes, or a blatant: *No, Deliverer*—what Mydei did next was far beyond what Phainon could have foreseen.

Mydei steps closer until Phainon's legs, stretched straight upon the ground, were in between his muddied golden greaves. Just as Phainon was about to *ask* what Mydei was planning, standing so close with his crotch barely an arm's reach from Phainon's face, all words at the tip of his tongue ceased to exist the moment that Mydei drops on his knees and takes a seat atop Phainon's lap.

Prayers began to spring forth within Phainon's reeling mind in an attempt to keep his sanity from slipping. *O Kephale, thy mercy knows no bounds. Your Dawn humbles us, the darkness driven away—*

"You may do it," Mydei says.

There's a *lot* of things Phainon could do right now with Mydei on his lap, actually. Mydei needs to elaborate more upon his words this *instant* before Phainon's heart could forget how to do its sole purpose within his body—which is to pump blood and keep him alive apparently.

Unfortunately, it's doing a piss poor job at the moment and Phainon might actually just die with how close Mydei's voluptuous, muscular chest is to his face. Phainon wonders if Mydei has *any* idea how insane his body looks, how *tempting* it is for Phainon to just sink his teeth into the flawless skin, and taste his divine undying flesh.

He feels like he might faint right at this moment. The weight of Mydei upon him is something he didn't know he needed until he came to know what it's like. And now, he had no idea as to how he would be able to keep going on with his pitiful existence if he were to part with the sensation, if this moment were to come to its eventual end.

"Phainon."

Phainon looks up. "Yes?"

Mydei was frowning at him. Phainon should just die for ever causing Mydei displeasure. "You *do* know how to braid hair, right?"

Right. The braid. So *that's* what Mydei wanted him to do. Fortunately, Phainon won't exactly be a worthless, inconsequential being in the eyes of Mydei—of a god poised for worship sat upon a mere altar.

Phainon wonders what kind of heroic deeds he must have achieved in his next life to be chosen like this, for Mydei to sit on his lap like he belonged there. And he *does*.

“I know how to braid hair, yes,” Phainon answers. Even if his mind had forgotten quite a bit (the last time he braided hair was before the Black Tide destroyed his village), he’ll force his body to remember.

Mydei’s expression smoothens as he shifts a little closer whilst separating the wavy lock of hair from the rest, his ass nestling just where Phainon wants it—like a puzzle falling into place.

The brief sensation of Mydei against him causes Phainon to feel light-headed, a certain warmth stirring within him, and all he could do is dig the tip of his thumb into the makeshift haircuff, both of his hands frozen at his sides in a show of punishing restraint.

“What are you waiting for?” Mydei asks, a hint of impatience in his tone.

Phainon would like to wish for some consideration, at the *very* least. He is fighting for his *life* in this very moment, harder than he’s ever done while going against any formidable Titankin or forces from the Black Tide.

“Deliverer.”

“By the gods are you hasty,” Phainon murmurs, finally able to find the strength to raise his arms and comb his fingers through the wavy lock of hair. “I’m not going anywhere, and neither are you.”

Mydei huffs. “I was merely wondering what’s with the unnecessary delay. You’re always one to make me wait.”

“Perhaps an exercise in patience is due,” Phainon replies, deft fingers relishing in the softness of the blonde strands.

“Having a limited patience has its perks. People tend to waste your time less.”

Knowing that such discussions would be a losing battle, especially when it comes to Mydei, Phainon chooses a well-placed taunt instead of furthering debates in regards to patience. Specifically, Mydei’s lack of it (only when Phainon is involved).

“You always walk around with your hair braided. I’m surprised you know not how to do it,” Phainon says, expecting to get a rise out of the other.

“I know how to do it,” Mydei reiterates. “I just want *you* to do it for me.”

So the crown prince sees him as a servant, it would seem. Phainon ought to be honored as he tries desperately not to voice out his less-than-pleased sentiments of being reduced to a mere hair braider. The exceptions he makes when it comes to Mydei grows by the day.

His thoughts are then interrupted when Mydei leans in further into his space to allow Phainon even more accessibility and *really*, being closer is the furthest thing that Phainon needed right

now regardless of how much he wants it.

Mydei is warm, and every brush of his forearm against Mydei's chest steals away a decade from his lifespan. He doesn't even want to dive deep into how the thin layer of sweat clinging upon their skins are intermingling with every contact. The mere thought of it has Phainon's breath coming in short.

If he doesn't want to be reduced into a pathetic, panting mess just because Mydei sat on his lap and demanded that he braid his hair, he better not dwell on such gratifying thoughts. His dignity has already been left asunder, Mydei must never come to know of this. It would be a well-guarded secret that would follow Phainon to his grave.

Hot breath ghosts over Phainon's cheek in regular intervals as his fingers get to work, proof that Mydei does not see *anything* wrong whatsoever with the position they're in—calm enough to breathe normally, slow and deep. Phainon, on the other hand, is one shift of Mydei's hips away from a full-blown, panic-induced erection.

He tries to keep his focus, gently braiding three locks of hair together and making sure that he doesn't pull too hard, but just right to keep the braid tight enough to prevent it from falling apart too easily.

Mydei's eyes of gold are centered upon Phainon's face, and Phainon could *feel* it even if his attention was directed solely upon the task at hand. It's almost as if Mydei was acting as an overseer, making sure that Phainon knows what he's doing.

And Phainon does, for the most part. Braiding hair is simple, really and— *Oh*, Titans dead and corrupted—

That's Mydei's hand on his shoulder. Mydei's *bare* hand on Phainon's *bare* shoulder. What even is the purpose of his lungs if he can't breathe?

Phainon jolts at the sudden touch, all of his efforts to keep his rather excitable cock dormant within his pants rendered futile in an instant. His fingers still, *praying* to every single Titan that Mydei wouldn't feel the proof of his utter depravity.

(Mydei would definitely feel it eventually. He's literally *sitting* on it. Actually, Phainon should just die right now.)

"Sorry," Mydei says, not sounding sorry at all. "Is it alright if I steady myself?"

Mydeimos the *Undying*—crown prince of the Capital of *Might*, a formidable warrior of renown *all* across Amphoreus—needed Phainon's *shoulder* to steady himself. Less of a lion and more of a minx. Phainon is sure that the other is simply taunting him now, isn't he? He'd rather eat a dromas' fecal matter than rise to the bait.

Non-existent though his dignity might be, Phainon would still prefer it if he managed to save face during these *dire* times.

Regaining his bearings, Phainon resumes braiding, voice strained as he says, “As long as you don’t mind the sweat.”

Mydei only hums, clearly unbothered by such trivial things as bodily fluids. His hold on Phainon’s shoulder tightens albeit briefly without a single warning, his other hand settling just shy above Phainon’s external oblique.

Phainon had to bite his tongue hard in order to suppress a whine, messing up the braid in the process just as he was about to reach the tip, blonde hair turning crimson.

Mydei takes notice. “Do it properly, Deliverer.”

I’m trying, Phainon wanted to say. Unfortunately, he can’t trust himself to speak right now and opts for a half-hearted glare that poorly conveys his contempt.

Heart thumping loudly within his chest that he’s sure Mydei could hear due to their proximity, Phainon recombs the lock of hair with his fingers and starts the braid anew. This time, no distraction catches his attention for if he wants to survive another day, he needs to get Mydei off of his lap with a much needed haste.

Thankfully, Mydei remains mercifully still in the next moments, and Phainon is *finally* able to know peace, finishing the braid shortly after. Taking the makeshift hair cuff from where he placed it on the ground beside him, Phainon carefully locks the hair in place, keeping the braid secure.

Breathless and on the verge of melting out of sheer relief for surviving the ordeal, Phainon is able to say, “All done.”

Please get off of me or I’ll explode right now and neither of us would like that very much.

Mydei takes the crimson tip of the braid between his fingers to inspect Phainon’s handiwork, the touch of his thumb lingering upon the makeshift hair cuff.

“Impressive,” he says, a hint of a smile on his lips. “Thank you, Deliverer.”

“You’re welcome. Don’t lose the hair cuff this time.”

Mydei rolls his eyes at the obvious attempt to tease. Instead of a retort, he simply replies, “I won’t.”

He then makes a move to leave Phainon’s lap. But before he could extricate himself further, he stills. Phainon did not need to guess as to *why* that is.

Mydei stares him down, seemingly bemused by this turn of events. “You’re—”

Phainon would rather not hear the rest of Mydei’s much-needed report of his cock digging into his ass, now apparently more noticeable than before due to a slight shift in position.

In an attempt to hide his burning face and shame, Phainon curls his body forward, his forehead resting upon Mydei’s clavicle. In hindsight, he probably should have thought of

doing such a thing some more. Mydei's signature scent of sweetness mingling with the musk of sweat only serves to render Phainon dizzy with want.

Mydei tries to lean back and Phainon has to grasp upon the last remaining vestiges of reason he has left not to bite a groan into Mydei's skin at the sudden friction, his hands gripping Mydei's waist in order to halt any further movements.

Strained, Phainon warns, "Don't."

The brief sensation of Mydei accidentally grinding against him remains within his mind, a memory that is sure would never be forgotten. Phainon can't help but *need*.

Placing reason aside, he wonders what would happen if he indulged in a little selfishness, succumbing to the temptation at last if Mydei would so graciously let him—

"Please."

Mydei is quiet. However, the calmness he aims to put up is but a mere facade, preceded by the erratic beating of his heart from within his chest that Phainon could clearly hear, every thump reverberating through his very being, echoing, drowning out everything else.

Eventually, Mydei humors him with a reply. "Which is it? You tell me don't, and yet you beg."

Phainon huffs, tightening his grip upon Mydei's waist as a form of retaliation. Mydei doesn't even wince. This man and his insane, perfect, and indestructible *body*.

"Are you making fun of me?"

A hint of irritation belies his tone. And yet, Phainon thinks that he has no right to be angry at Mydei right now. If anything, Mydei ought to be the one who's throwing a fit, undoubtedly scandalized by such a shameful display.

Mydei sighs, warm air blowing against the crown of Phainon's head. "Why would I make fun of you for something like this? You've pulled far more ridiculous stunts before."

Phainon laughs sardonically, pressing his nose against Mydei's sweaty skin, keeping himself in check just in case he becomes compelled to think that licking the sweat off of a friend's skin is an acceptable act to do.

It's not.

"Surprisingly considerate," Phainon remarks, some semblance of truth in his words.

"Will a massage help?" Mydei asks. "I heard it has soothing effects for both the mind and the body."

Phainon's mind blanks. Faintly, he asks, "What kind of massage are we talking about?"

“Like this.” Mydei presses upon his shoulder, skillfully kneading upon the tense muscles there.

Working them loose is completely *out of the question* as Phainon merely holds Mydei closer, almost like a lifeline, desperately trying to keep his wits about him as he muffles a groan over Mydei’s chest.

He sounds more like a wounded animal than a man in relief. Considering the current circumstances, the former might be a more accurate description.

Mydei stops his ministrations. “It’s not helping.”

“It’s not helping,” Phainon echoes with a slow nod. “Just—”

Touch me.

“I’ll cease my movements,” Mydei placates in a rare display of benevolence. “Try to calm down, Deliverer.”

The notion of Mydei keeping still sounds way better than the massage. Perhaps Phainon’s future is not so bleak after all.

“Thank you.”

Phainon steadies his breathing, treating Mydei’s scent as an aid to his comfort rather than a fuel to his desire. The gust of wind that blows drowns out the sound of Mydei’s erratically beating heart, lulling Phainon’s in the process.

Even in an attempt to escape from the woes of wanting more than what’s deserved, Phainon’s thoughts of Mydei are here to stay. Reciting several thousand Nousporism mantras in his head won’t help this time. Mydei is too close not to acknowledge, too real in Phainon’s embrace.

He never thought that it would be possible—to have Mydei like this. Usually so untouchable, distant, *guarded*. And yet, Phainon is able to hold him like this without a knife on his throat, or a vocalized threat to his life looming over him.

In moments such as this, Phainon is once again reminded of Mydei’s kindness, and how unworthy he is to bask in the mercy of a friend that is willing to wait out a boner with him. A twinge of shame in his chest is enough to clear the fog of concupiscence, and reason makes its much-needed return.

As promised, Mydei keeps still on Phainon’s lap. They stayed like that for what seemed to have been a long time, enough for Phainon’s humiliating desire to ebb away in a steady flow, spurred on by thoughts of his worth—specifically, the lack of it—to even allow himself to indulge in such an opportunity.

Moments like these are meant to be fleeting. If Phainon were to put respect in both his and Mydei’s dignities, this ought to never happen again.

Mydei must have felt him soften beneath him, extricating himself from Phainon's hold carefully, as if aiming to not wake a sleeping animal. Considering that Phainon had so adamantly avoided Mydei's gaze the whole time, only now does he see the flush of red gracing Mydei's handsome face, either from the heat or—

"I… deeply apologize for the inconvenience I have caused you," Phainon is able to say, fighting the cowardly urge to hide once again. "I'll allow you to hit me, if only to make up for this."

Pools of gold glint as they regard Phainon with an indistinguishable expression. "No need to dwell on it," Mydei replies. In but a brief window of time, he's already on his feet, the distance between him and Phainon now more respectable. "I'll get going now. As for the apples, I'm not hungry."

In his daze, Phainon forgot that he and Mydei were supposed to take a break together. "At least have a drink before you go."

Mydei does not waste a second, extending a hand. "That would be ideal."

Phainon hands him the water-filled amphora. Due to the lack of cups, he is left to watch Mydei drink directly from the spout, head tipped back as dribbles of water follow a winding path down from his chin to his collarbones, and then the valley of his chest—

Mydei returns the jar. Empty.

"Thank you," he says briskly. And then he leaves.

Phainon is left to stare at Mydei's retreating figure, now making its way back towards the west fields. Only now does he come to know of his thirst, multiplying tenfold with no water in the jar to quench it.

By the final quint of the Parting Hour, a quarter of the fields in Phainon's claimed territory have been tilled. If he keeps up the pace consistently, he'll be done in three more days.

He even went ahead and checked Mydei's progress with his side of the field. They're about the same, almost a mirror of Phainon's work. Truly, equals in every regard even when it came to farming.

The incident from earlier was well forgotten until the *deipnon*, only to come invading Phainon's thoughts once again when Marpessa leads both him and Mydei towards their *shared* room.

Before, Phainon had been the only one to occupy it during his annual trip to the village for the Revival Ritual. Now with Mydei in the picture, that is unfortunately no longer the case.

“I’ve managed to prepare your lodgings while you two were out on the fields,” Marpessa tells them with a sheepish smile. “I would have prepared two klines for the both of you but, ah, there is no spare to speak of.”

“It’s alright.”

“It’s fine.”

Marpessa seems to relax slightly despite the clipped responses from the two Chrysos Heirs who stood tall and stiff in the middle of the room, both of their attentions centered solely upon the lone kline that is somehow big enough to accommodate them just fine.

“Over here is the bathroom,” Marpessa says, more to Mydei than Phainon for the latter already knew better than anyone the inner workings of the room and its adjacents. “Forgive us but a wooden tub is all we could muster. Rest assured, we’ve prepared the hot water beforehand, as well as some fragrance oils and towels.”

Mydei casts a brief gaze upon the direction of the bathroom, catching but a glimpse of the wooden tub mentioned. “Thank you for accommodating us, Madam Marpessa.”

“Indeed,” Phainon says with a nod, hoping that his smile could reassure an anxious old lady. “Your hospitality is very much appreciated, ma’am. Thank you for keeping our comfort in mind.”

Marpessa’s tense countenance relaxes. “My lords, how benevolent you are. I shall take my leave now, then, so you could rest.”

It is quiet the moment that Marpessa walks out of the room and closes the door behind her, uncaring of the now awkward atmosphere she had left behind upon her departure.

Phainon coughs lightly. “Do you… want to go in the bath first?”

Mydei was in the middle of examining the various stone tablets and scrolls arranged neatly upon the shelf. He doesn’t turn to Phainon when he says, “You go ahead. I’ll bathe when you’re done.”

“Alright.” Phainon takes one of the robes neatly folded upon the kline as well as a towel. Unable to help himself, he says, “Don’t fall asleep now.”

Gold eyes land on him in a sharp glare. “I won’t.”

Just after the first quint of the Curtain-Fall Hour was up, both Phainon and Mydei were able to successfully bathe without any incidents. And now, the issue with the two-person kline comes up.

It may be ideal for the both of them to just think less of it and go to bed, perhaps even place a pillow in between them to act as a boundary. But something about the way that Mydei is frowning upon the kline suggests that such a notion is the furthest from being likely.

Phainon's assumptions are deemed correct shortly after when Mydei opens his mouth to speak, "I'll sleep on the floor. You take the kline."

"If this is because of what happened earlier—"

Mydei cuts him off. "I simply think that it would be more appropriate if we don't share the bed."

"It's big enough to fit the both of us."

"Yes. But it would be wise to sleep separately, especially since—"

"Mydei, I'm not going to try anything with you," Phainon says, ignoring the ache in his heart upon knowing that he brought Mydei so much discomfort from earlier's events to render him so avoidant of merely having to *sleep* beside him.

They have done so before on multiple occasions—trips to the Abyss that lasted for longer than a day have them sharing a tent. It hadn't been a problem, then.

"You may take the kline," Phainon says. "I'll sleep on the floor."

"Absolutely not," Mydei replies with his arms crossed. "All my life, I've been sleeping in less than accommodating places. The floor is nothing to me."

Phainon sighs heavily. He's *so* exhausted from a whole day's work and all he wants is to rest so his mess of a mind would quiet down. "How about we take turns? I sleep on the floor today, you do so tomorrow."

Mydei ponders the arrangement for a brief moment, eyebrows furrowed in consideration. Eventually, he acquiesces. "Fine."

"Fine."

Mydei gives him the blanket and pillows so he could make himself comfortable upon the cold stone floor. Thanks to Marpessa's meticulous cleaning, the floor is impressively dust-free. Phainon wouldn't have to sneeze his nose off in his slumber.

"Sleep well, Deliverer."

Phainon startles. Upon the bed, Mydei's back was turned towards him, arms wrapped around himself for he doesn't have a blanket to shield his body from the cold.

Sitting up, Phainon rummages through his traveling bag for a spare coat. After finding what he's looking for, he walks over to the edge of the kline before draping the cloak over Mydei's frame.

"Sleep well, Mydei."

Before he could crouch back down to his makeshift bed, a warm hand encloses upon his wrist. Mydei's eyes glint warmly amidst the dim lighting of the room, Kephale's Dawn

blocked by the thick drapes that hang by the windows.

“Thank you,” Mydei says, lips barely moving.

The urge to tease is much too strong. “Can’t have you catching a cold now.”

“I don’t get sick.”

Phainon laughs. “Right. You and that invulnerable body of yours.”

Instead of a sharp jab at the callous remark over his curse, Mydei merely takes the jest in stride with a small smile, almost shy in a way.

Phainon is then reminded that Mydei’s hand is still on his wrist, a loose hold. A certain memory surfaces, one that involves a conversation from the previous month in the Garden of Life.

“You can’t sleep on the bed,” Mydei says softly, interrupting his thoughts. It *almost* sounds like an apology.

And yet, his grip on Phainon’s wrist tightens briefly, nothing but an ephemeral moment for Phainon to replay in his mind countless of times, something to accompany him in moments of solitude. He doesn’t allow himself to waver even now, keeping Mydei’s wishes in mind.

“I don’t plan to,” Phainon says, gently prying Mydei’s hand off of his wrist, allowing his touch to linger in the process. Whether it is an act of indulgence or defiance, Phainon could only hope to know the answer to it soon. “I’ll sleep on the floor.”

Mydei takes the hem of Phainon’s cloak and wraps it tightly upon himself, relishing in the warmth it provides. The sight alone makes Phainon’s heart skip a beat, but the words that Mydei utters in the next moment renders him confused.

“It was merely a reminder to myself, Deliverer,” Mydei says before rolling on his side and turning his back on Phainon, ready to succumb to sleep at last. “For if I forget, the significance of certain things would… carry so little weight.”

The words echo in Phainon’s mind for an uncertain amount of time, mingling with a dozen questions and doubts, restless even in rest.

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During the period of courtship, ***one is not permitted to lie together in rest until the union is sealed in blood.***

Such is a privilege earned through discipline, not a pleasure to be tasted in a moment’s desire. Let all those who walk the path of union do so with valor and dignity befitting of a Kremnoan.

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship, Endnotes and Addenda

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The Kremnoan detachment, as well as the rest of the citizens willing to lend their aid, arrives the next day with dromases and tents. The Akashians were more than overjoyed, warmly welcoming the newcomers as they helped them settle into their temporary homes.

Mydei instructs the detachment on what to do, directing them towards the fields untouched by his and Phainon's competition. Phainon, on the other hand, needs not brief the other citizens on the task at hand for they've been helping out the Akashians for years since their arrival in Okhema.

And thus began another full day of tilling.

By the fourth day, Phainon's initial calculations of when he'd finish with his section of land weren't that far off. Unfortunately, victory wasn't his to claim this time for Mydei had finished tilling the west fields a whole quint earlier than him.

"Congratulations on your loss, Deliverer," Mydei says when he walks over to the east fields just as Phainon lets go of his *arōtron*, lips curved in a taunting smirk as he presented his bare torso for Phainon to ogle upon like it's his second calling in life apart from the Flame-Chase. "Any speeches?"

Phainon scoffs. "I'll have you know, you were only able to win because you need not take any breaks to soothe sore muscles." And then he grumbles under his breath, loud enough for only Mydei to hear, "You and that inconspicuous body of yours."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Whine all you want. I still won."

"Does the winner have something he'd like for me to do?"

Mydei pretends to think about it, taking a moment before giving his answer. The distinct glint in those eyes of gold serves as a telltale sign that he's not taking Phainon seriously at all.

Eventually, Mydei says, "I'll have you wallow in your defeat for losing in a challenge you yourself proposed." He shakes his head as if in disappointment. "Can't have the loser doing any more work."

Phainon knew more than anyone that it is rare for Mydei to gloat about his victories. This win must've been something he really wanted to have, or maybe he just wanted to get a rise out of Phainon.

“Is that your way of provoking me, Your Highness?” Phainon jeers with a light laugh. “I’m not a sore loser like *someone* I know. Not mentioning any names, but I’m sure you know who I’m talking about. I’ll give you a clue: he’s blonde and mean.”

Mydei’s eyes narrow into slits. “You know other blonde men?”

“Just one.”

“So you’re calling *me* a sore loser?”

Phainon raises his hand in mock surrender. “Like I said, I didn’t mention any names. That’s *your* conclusion that *you*, alone, came up with.”

Mydei’s eyes flash dangerously. “You take me to be a fool, Deliverer?”

And just like that, Phainon has managed to turn the tides in his favor. No matter how hard Mydei tries to taunt him, Phainon remains to be the undefeated champion of taunts.

He simpers, “Then again, *your* own conclusion.”

In lieu of a reply, Phainon could only feel a surge of power emanating from the other. Kremnoans and their willingness to deal with problems using brute strength never gets old.

“You’re so fun to provoke,” Phainon muses, more impressed than anything. He knows that his words would only serve as fuel to the flame. “What, you want to fight?”

Mydei glares, hands now clenched into fists. “You shouldn’t take on challenges so easily, Deliverer.”

“Knowing that I’d win anyway, why shouldn’t I?”

All things aside, and pretty much expected for having poked the lion too much, Phainon was sure of one thing: Mydei was the first to lunge.

He tackles Phainon to the ground, the mud softening their impact. With a kick to the side and a well-placed jab towards Mydei’s face (swiftly dodged for Mydei have memorized every single one of Phainon’s moves by now, just as Phainon had done for his), he is able to slip free, a knee upon Mydei’s chest to pin him to the ground.

The position doesn’t last for long as Mydei sees an opening, tugging upon Phainon’s wrist. He bears down upon Phainon relentlessly, but this is hardly a cause for surrender as Phainon attempts to scramble up.

Their limbs are a tangled mess as they both try to push each other into the ground, tumbling into the dirt in a flurry of mud, skin, and yelled insults.

“You fight like a chimera!” Mydei manages, gagging when Phainon shoves a muddied fist into his mouth.

Phainon uses the opportunity while the other recoils to free his leg, uncomfortably bent in between Mydei's. "Of course you'd say that! You thought I wouldn't know about that cute channel you've been running in the teleslates—?"

"So you *are* DarkSwordmaster13!"

"How did you even—?"

"You were my first follower, you idiot!" Mydei swipes at him, pulling at his hair. "You said that my photostone quality was trash!"

Phainon swats Mydei's hand away. "*Still is trash!*"

His face meets the ground, a splash of mud everywhere as Mydei graciously dunks his head onto the dirt to keep his mouth shut.

Only now does Phainon feel the vibrations caused by a dozen footsteps who have now come to rush over. Eyes squinting over to the side, Phainon could make out the sight of both Akashians and non-Akashians approaching them hastily.

"My lords!"

"Quick! Pull them apart!"

"Those Kremnoans are not even trying to help!"

Phainon extricates himself from the mud and sullies Mydei's equally muddied face with his even more muddied hands. There's no doubt about how much of a mess they must look right now, limbs still locked tight in an awkward position, struggling to subdue the other in a peculiar wrestling match.

With great team effort, several pairs of hands finally manage to wrench the two Chrysos Heirs away from each other.

Another set of footsteps come running. Both Phainon and Mydei look up to see a pale-faced Demeas frantically assess the situation. "Wh— My lords, *what* happened?"

In lieu of a response, Mydei spits golden ichor to the side, the scratches on his soiled face healing in record time and fading into nothing. Phainon, on the other hand, is left to feel the sting of his cut lip.

The Kremnoans approach, finally deeming that their presence is needed. It was Praxis who spoke first, standing tall in front of the group.

"Nothing but a tussle between His Highness and Lord Phainon, Mr. Demeas," Praxis calmly informs the Akashian chief. "No need to worry. They've done much worse than this."

An Okheman farmer scoffs. "And what were *you* doing, just watching from the sidelines? With such a huge body, you sure put it to good use!"

“I know better than to interrupt,” Praxis says, a hint of coldness belies his amusement. “In Kremnos, spontaneous tussles keep relations exciting. I don’t blame His Highness for this, and Lord Phainon seems just as eager to indulge.”

“Well, you’re not in Kremnos now, are you?”

Upon hearing this, Praxis takes a step forward, the rest of the Kremnoan soldiers stopping him just in time before he could take another step more.

Lowly, he warns the Okheman farmer, “Watch your tongue.”

“Praxis.”

All eyes turn to Mydei who shakes his head, a gesture ordering his *lochagos* to stand down. Praxis obediently gives the matter a rest, his once snarling lips now pressed into a straight line.

Just before the tension in the atmosphere could grow thicker, Marpessa makes a frantic approach, dragging a young lady with her. Much like her husband, she too looked out of sorts at the sight of Mydei and Phainon drenched in mud.

“Goodness! My lords, you’re—” She turns to the young lady. “Prepare a hot bath for the heroes! How could I allow them to proceed in such a state?”

The young lady—Callista, Chalcon’s sister now that Phainon is able to remember her name—looked conflicted upon hearing the request.

“But, Madam Marpessa,” she began. “It’s only the fourth quint of the Lucid Hour. There’s only enough hot water for one bath—”

Marpessa was hearing none of it, preoccupied with hoisting both Phainon and Mydei off the ground in a surprising display of strength, uncaring if her clothes were dirtied in the process. For an old lady, she sure is strong.

“Youths with their short tempers,” Marpessa fusses, dragging the two Heirs away from the crowd and back to the village chief’s residence atop the hill. The whole way there, her nagging never once ceased, even as she led the two men two heads taller than her to their shared quarters. “Careful, now! After you bathe, I shall tend to your wounds. *Goodness!* And here I thought you two got along so well!”

She leaves them to stand in the middle of the bathroom, handing them each a *stlengis* to scrape off the mud. Phainon could only stare at the object in his hand, not knowing whether he should laugh or cry for being scolded at his age.

Aglaea may seem like a mother figure at times, but she’s too scary to be a mother. Madam Marpessa, on the other hand… He turns to Mydei who looked equally at loss from the nagging.

“Clean yourselves up before jumping in the bath,” Marpessa says to the pair of five-year-olds. Phainon may be a couple of decades older than that, but he sure does feel like a child.

“I’ll have clean clothes prepared for the both of you. *No* fighting now!”

They both startle when she slams the door shut on her way out. Phainon catches Mydei’s gaze in an instant, already looking at him. He bites back a laugh at the sight—Mydei soaked in mud does bring back some memories. He remembers eating some sort of cursed cement porridge when Mydei enacted his revenge.

“You can go and bathe first,” he says, ready to leave.

“Didn’t you hear what that young lady said?” Mydei tells him, halting his steps. “There’s only enough water for one bath. I doubt a *stlengis* alone could clean you up.”

Phainon grips the object in his hand, a strained smile on his lips as he turns around. Even if he already knew what Mydei’s answer would be, he still asks nonetheless, “Then, what do you propose we do?”

“Let’s just bathe together. It’s not like we haven’t done so before.”

They only ever did it once. At the Heroes’ Bath. In *public* where people are *meant* to bathe with others. The current situation, on the other hand, is different—it’s just the two of them.

Mydei does not wait for his reply, already moving to the far corner of the bathroom. Facing the wall to grant Phainon some privacy, he quietly begins to scrape off the mud using the *stlengis* starting from his face, down to his arms.

When Mydei’s hands find the waistband of his pants, poised to strip, Phainon takes it as his cue to find himself a corner of his own. Facing the wall as Mydei had done on the other side of the room, Phainon keeps his mind clear of *any* unwanted thoughts as he strips off his pants and boots, and starts scraping.

Phainon swears with both of his eyes closed that the water of the bath is *not* that hot. It’s just the right temperature, in fact. But if he so much as opens his eyes for a fraction, the sight of Mydei seated across from him would undoubtedly turn the pleasantly warm waters scalding hot, and Phainon should just burst into flames at that point.

The wooden tub is not that big, but it’s enough to have two grown men fit inside it. In a sense, it could work if one doesn’t mind the touching of bare legs beneath the water’s surface.

Right now, there are no robes to hide their dignities, only a small and flimsy towel around their waists. One wrong thought and Mydei would find himself having to deal with Phainon’s corpse after the latter drowns himself due to sheer humiliation.

Under *no* circumstance is Phainon allowed to have an erection.

“Pass me the fragrance oil.”

Upon hearing Mydei's voice, Phainon's resolve crumbles down a certain significant percentage. He still does as he's told, a hand reaching out of the tub to procure a small vial from the tray on the floor.

Still with his eyes closed, he hands the fragrance oil to Mydei, trying desperately to think of something else when he feels their fingers brush together, no matter how brief it was.

Just as Phainon thought that's the last time Mydei would say something, he's proven dreadfully wrong.

"What's your problem this time?" Mydei asks.

"I have no problems," Phainon says, a bit quick to answer. "In fact, I can confidently say that I'm free of them."

Mydei doesn't relent, legs pressing against Phainon's. "You haven't looked at me."

Phainon huffs out a laugh, strained and shaky. "Is it a requirement to do so while we bathe?"

"It's strange."

"Not for me."

A heavy sigh resounds. Phainon hears a *pop* as Mydei uncorks the vial of fragrance oil, followed by a shifting of his legs and the splashing of water, spilling onto the stone floor. For a moment, Phainon thought that Mydei finally ran out of patience in dealing with him and was about to leave.

Opening his eyes, the sight that greets him might as well send him into the afterlife. Mydei is on his knees, submerged from the waist down, water sluicing over his tanned skin, the streaks of scarlet striking as ever.

The tub is small enough that Phainon doesn't even have to reach out so far if he wanted to run his hands across Mydei's well-defined muscles, trace every winding path of those mysterious marks and see when and *where* they end. *If* they ever do.

But he doesn't do that. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae is a civilized hero of Okhema with *manners* —

"I knew you'd look at me."

Perhaps Phainon of Aedes Elysiae is merely just a flawed man. Nothing of note to write about.

"You're making a mess," Phainon says, a weak admonishment for he doesn't really mind. But if he keeps quiet for too long, Mydei is bound to make fun of him. "Now the floor is flooded."

Mydei rolls his eyes before holding out a hand to drip some of the oil upon his fingers. "The tub is too small. It hinders my movements if I apply the oil sitting down."

Phainon could already feel himself stir between his legs, eyes glued at the mesmerizing display of Mydei's body before him. He itches to *touch*.

"Would you like for me to leave?" Phainon asks. "So you could have more space?"

Mydei rubs the oil in between his fingers, testing its consistency and allowing the delicate scent of olives and fig to permeate in the air. Phainon tracks the languid gesture with an attention that could rival a predator stalking its prey.

"This tub is provided for the both of us to use, and you've barely washed," Mydei says in an infuriating non-answer.

As if to prove his point just in case Phainon failed to comprehend, he leans forward, reaching out with an oil-slicked hand to wipe away the speck of mud on Phainon's cheek. Mydei could slit Phainon's throat and it wouldn't have made a difference.

"You had dirt on your face," Mydei tells him, thumb rubbing circles on the alleged spot as if making sure that no mud is left to linger upon the skin. "You're welcome, by the way."

Before Mydei could withdraw his hand, Phainon's fingers encloses upon his wrist, a tentative hold, loose enough for Mydei to still pull away if he so desired.

Phainon counts in his head—seven erratic heartbeats, five trickles of water from the tub's edge to the stone floor, two bird calls from the outside—but Mydei makes no move to retreat, remaining as still as a statue, holding Phainon's gaze with an unnervingly calm facade.

But the flicker in his eyes tell a different story. A wordless question, perhaps even a challenge to do more than just this.

Phainon tugs lightly and Mydei, a warrior unflinching even in the face of death, falls like a blade of grass in Phainon's arms. Willing. Uncharacteristically so.

The bathwater sloshes from the sudden movement, spilling onto the stone floor. Neither of them pay any mind to the mess as Phainon allows the muted scent of the fragrance oil upon Mydei's skin to invade his senses. They're unfamiliar, for Mydei always preferred something much sweeter. And yet, Phainon finds himself inhaling deeply nonetheless.

He can feel Mydei's labored breathing against his neck, both of his hands braced upon Phainon's chest for balance. Instead of pulling away, Mydei asks, his voice barely even a whisper, "What are you doing?"

Sliding his hand above Mydei's wrist, relishing in the warmth that Mydei's skin provides, Phainon takes the vial of fragrance oil into his palm.

"Let me help you," Phainon murmurs softly, the corner of his lips pressed against the side of Mydei's face—a mere compromise for what he truly wants for he doesn't possess the courage to be more forward than he already is.

Only in battle is there no place for cowardice. But this is no battle, for the simple act of holding Mydei gives him peace.

The other is quiet, caged in between Phainon's arms, barely even a prison for they both know he could leave anytime. And he should, Phainon would let him. It would be simpler that way. Much more simpler than whatever this is, what it *could* escalate to—an unnamed entanglement, far more intricate than any trial either of them could face.

But instead of leaving, Mydei huffs out a soft exhale before relaxing fully upon Phainon's lap. If this position is about to be a recurring thing, Phainon ought to prepare himself better next time. It might be wishful thinking on his part, and he doubts he'd even get used to the sensation of having Mydei's weight upon him in a non-sparring circumstance.

A distinct pressure digs against Phainon's navel, unmistakable, warm for how could Mydei be anything else. It causes Phainon to lose all the air in his lungs at the revelation, a myriad of emotions springing forth, overwhelming and not enough at the same time.

Mydei leans forward ever so slightly, their wet bodies sliding against each other, the bathwater splashing some more. The tickling sensation of a warm breath ghosting against the shell of his ear is enough to render Phainon's mind blank.

"Go ahead, Deliverer."

Shivers erupt from within Phainon's very bones, tracing the path of his spine and sending goosebumps to his skin. His vision swims just from hearing those three words alone, struggling to regain his bearings as he spills the oil onto his fingers from where it's raised above the surface of the water behind Mydei.

The vial goes empty and Phainon throws it aside. The slippery liquid steadily drips from his fingers, to his palm, and down to his forearm. The remaining contents have spilled into the bathwater due to his immense distraction.

"Wasteful," Mydei remarks, lips brushing against the sensitive skin behind Phainon's ear.

Even though Mydei had said this, Phainon could feel the curve of a smile upon Mydei's lips well enough, pressed against a spot that renders him weak to know he doesn't really care for such trivialities. And neither does Phainon.

How could he care for anything else in this moment?

Instead of a reply, slicked fingers press firmly against Mydei's back, feeling up the muscles like the owner of such desperate hands wishes to etch every shape of the flesh in his memory. If asked, Phainon wouldn't even dare to deny it for the lie would be such a heavy burden to carry that he might as well speak of his ache with ardent truthfulness.

Mydei gasps, soft and quiet, and it only serves to fuel Phainon's impulses even more than what is typically considered acceptable. But such considerations have been placed in the back of Phainon's mind as a shaky breath escapes from his parted lips, pulling Mydei even closer, the dig of Mydei's arousal against him sending his mind reeling.

Thoughts of reason have ceased to exist. Phainon can't even find it within himself to stop and mourn the loss of it.

He continues with his ministrations, spreading the fragrance oil upon a firm shoulder, fingers tracing the path of scarlet, the jut of a clavicle—pressing lightly upon the slight dip in between muscle and bone—before coming to rest upon Mydei's pulse point.

Phainon allows a moment of stillness then, relishing in the rhythmic thrum of life coming from beneath the skin, a sensation Phainon wishes would always stay regardless if it's cursedly bound to remain. Its erratic pace mirrors the one that Phainon could feel against his chest, a swift thud of a heartbeat.

A teasing remark is at the tip of his tongue. For all the composure Mydei insists to show, Phainon is still able to catch the slivers of raw honesty that tends to slip undetected for the untrained eye.

In these many months that he's grown acquainted with Mydei, fluency in every minute gesture of the other—deliberate or not—is something Phainon is hoping to have an unparalleled expertise in, one that he's not willing to share with anyone else.

The wreath of olives should only be placed upon the head of one. And Phainon wishes to be the sole bearer of such an esteemed *kótinos*.

With his left hand, non-slicked, Phainon takes a handful of Mydei's silky strands of blonde hair, gently combing it aside to expose more of the unblemished skin of Mydei's neck.

A siren's call, as Phainon would like to call it. Far more dangerous than the ones that echo in the rocky shores of previously affluent bay cities. Now destroyed by the Black Tide's invasion, the sensuous curve of Mydei's neck remains to be the lone ineluctable temptation.

The sight is exquisite, glistening streaks of scarlet aiming to lure Phainon's attention. He succumbs to the bait without much thought, nosing lightly against Mydei's jaw, lips now brushing upon the sensitive skin, contradictory in a way that such a blatant show of boldness still manages to appear hesitant.

Phainon's hands then follow the path of Mydei's spine, reverently taking in the arch and feeling every jut of each vertebra beneath his desperate fingertips, only stopping its descent when he feels the loosened hem of Mydei's towel.

A moment of clarity strikes him, and Phainon finds himself asking, "Is this okay?"

Mydei makes a disgruntled sound to express his disbelief, pinching a small flesh on Phainon's shoulder in a show of petulance.

"You're asking me that *now?*" It's a relief that Mydei doesn't seem to sound cross with him despite his actions.

Phainon rests his hands upon Mydei's waist, trying not to dwell upon the fact that the knot of Mydei's towel had *just* come undone.

"Push me away," Phainon murmurs, almost a plea, against Mydei's neck. His teeth longs to sink into the unmarred flesh, and he wonders how long he could keep going like this.

"*Mydei*."

"The way you hold me makes it seem impossible."

There's some semblance of truth in that. And yet, "We both know you could easily slip free if you wanted to. You would have killed me by now for my impertinence."

Phainon's grip tightens as he tries to keep his hips still, the effort to stop himself from simply rutting his aching cock in between the cleft of Mydei's ass dissipating every single sane fiber of his being. There's only two flimsy towels between them, one of which had already failed to keep the boundary intact.

"I beg of you, *leave* if this makes you feel uncomfortable," Phainon pushes, a prayer of pain, a cry of want.

Several outcomes come to mind but the one that Mydei chooses catches Phainon off-guard.

"Spread the oil some more," Mydei mutters, the shell of Phainon's ear caught in between his teeth.

Mydei bites harder. The sudden sting of it has Phainon jolting against him, a startled moan escapes his lips. Phainon lifts his knees, causing Mydei to slide further into his space, his own desire twitching wantonly against Phainon's abdomen.

Slicked hands map out every ridge of muscle upon Mydei's sides, spreading the oil as promised, while depraved lips commit to memory the feeling of Mydei's skin against it, the taste upon his tongue—bitter from the fragrance oil, wet from the bathwater—and yet it manages to quench the deep-seated thirst that Phainon has been harboring for *days*—

No.

For *months* on end.

Phainon laps at the skin, teeth grazing every now and then with an intent to bite but never does. The groan that Mydei lets out reverberates from within his throat, head thrown back. Phainon savors the vibrations from within the flesh, hoping to feel it again so soon when he lightly sucks upon the crook of Mydei's neck and is rewarded with a choked-out gasp in return.

Mydei's grip upon his shoulder tightens every now and then, particularly when Phainon lightly drags the tip of his tongue from the notch in between Mydei's collarbones, up to the base of his chin.

"*Phainon*."

"Tell me what you want," Phainon says, heat creeping up on his face upon hearing Mydei address him by his name. To show his gratitude, he guides Mydei's hips to grind against him slowly, pressing open-mouthed kisses beneath the edge of Mydei's jaw as he does so.

Mydei pants above him, a hand keeping Phainon's head steady to where he wants it, pulling roughly at the snow-colored strands when Phainon's fingers press firmly on a certain area just above the base of his spine.

"You— *Hngh*..."

Phainon laughs breathily, teeth pulling upon the soft lobe of Mydei's ear, free of the assortment of earrings he typically wore. None of them suit him regardless of how good he looked with them. Perhaps a quest to find the perfect earring is due.

"Me?" he repeats teasingly, one hand sliding beneath Mydei's thigh, sating the desire to feel the firm muscle tense in his grasp. "You want *me*, Mydei?"

It's meant to be in jest. They both know that Mydei has yet to give him an answer. But Phainon can't help but *wish*.

Mydei's nails dig into his scalp, hips bucking against Phainon in a rare display of abandonment. "*Haikas*…"

"Calling me names does not count as an answer," Phainon says, equally strained with every languid slide of their bodies against each other.

"Shut *up*."

Phainon feels his cock leak pathetically, biting a moan into Mydei's chest, dangerously close to a reddened nipple. "Not your—*hah*—flashiest comeback, I must say."

Mydei grunts. "I— *Phainon*—"

Phainon pulls away from Mydei's heated skin with great difficulty, eyes blown wide as he centers his gaze upon Mydei's shaky ones.

The bathwater had already gone cold for some time now, and yet Mydei is indubitably flushed all over. Phainon is once again reminded of how good Mydei looks in red, naked or clothed it matters not.

The once searing pools of gold are rendered unfocused, the sharpness dulled into something softer, dazed in the heat of want.

Phainon's gaze drops to Mydei's lips, spit-slicked and swollen. No doubt from all the biting Mydei had done to keep his dignity intact. He could feel Mydei do the exact same thing, gaze directed upon parted lips in dire need to taste his own. Phainon wonders if it's wrong to assume—

"Mydei," he starts, warning-like. "Do you—"

Gold eyes flicker and in a brief moment, Phainon feels the coldness of the water and a slight blow of air bite into his exposed skin.

Mydei has left the tub, water sluicing down his back and pooling upon the hem of where he held his towel, clenched hands gripping upon the fabric tightly.

Phainon is quick enough to catch the unmistakable bulge tenting in between Mydei's legs, the towel flimsy enough to barely hide its shape—

"I'm done bathing," Mydei says, sharp amidst the silence. "Thank you for your assistance."

He doesn't turn around when he speaks. Phainon hopes that the reason is merely to hide his shame. For it to be something else, dancing along the lines of regret perhaps, Phainon wouldn't know how he'd be able to move forward then.

If Mydei sees him as a stranger after this, then perhaps the story of his demise brought on by an immense heartache would find itself told hand-in-hand with the tragedy that went down between Cerces and Mnestia.

The sound of the bathroom door closing startles Phainon from his thoughts. And he's left to shiver in the coldness that Mydei had left in his wake.

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...whether it be in public or in private, ***only a spouse has the right to help a royal wash and partake in Phagousa's blessings****.*

> ***What happens if I'm still unmarried and rendered injured to the point that I can't bathe? – M.***
>
> *Mydeimos wrote that? Mydeimos, of all people? –* ***Perdikkas***
>
> *I don't know which is funnier: Mydeimos staying unmarried, or him being injured long enough to consider such circumstances. –* ***Leonnius***
>
> *Mydeimos, what is this question… –* ***H.***
>
> *I heard Ptolemy is locking the tomes in a chest. –* ***Peucesta***
>
> *Borrowing of this text is no longer allowed. –* ***Ptolemy****, annotation date:* ■■■

— annotations found on a page of Kremnoan Royal Etiquette: Volume 2

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Chapter End Notes

> i divided the month of cultivation into two. oh and the month of joy is coming up so there's that. listen, i'm going to own up to the eventual smut tag EVENTUALLY so

here's a... whatever the fuck kinda edging phaidei's been doing the entire chapter for now. we'll get to the good stuff very soon, PROMISE.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

thank you so so much for reading and for your patience!! i'm sorry i couldn't be consistent with the updates... born to fujo out, forced to lock in. yaoi woes aside, your kudos and comments are everything to me!! thank you so much for them <3 much love :3

Chapter 8: acts of comfort, a weary mind is soothed

Chapter Summary

> Everything fades into the background as Phainon's thoughts nearly consume him with forbidden longing. Only Mydei could set him back right on track.

Chapter Notes

> special thanks to midnightcrownn for her insane phaidei art from this chapter 💗 do check it out if you haven't yet!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It is of no surprise that Mydei opted to stay with the Kremnoan detachment after the bathing incident.

Though avoidance was not one of Mydei's usual style of handling disputes—preferring direct confrontation above anything—Phainon wouldn't fault him for it, choosing to ignore the dull ache in his chest that never seemed to go away when he saw Mydei's belongings nowhere to be found in their shared spare room.

Phainon's strong suit has always been to look at the bright side of things, and he liked to think that this is for the best.

Keep deluding yourself.

If Mydei didn't know how to breach the subject, then neither did Phainon—regardless of the fact that the latter *should* be the one to take the lead in clearing the air between them considering it was his fault that everything had now gone sideways, and there's an undeniable possibility that Mydei might want *nothing* to do with him now.

However, something tells him that giving Mydei some space to reestablish some boundary between them (after Phainon had deliberately tore it down and invaded it with nary a reasonable mind) to be the appropriate course of action. He'd acted no differently than a beast craving for the taste of flesh on his tongue with how much he wanted to devour Mydei whole if given the permission.

But Mydei left. There's no permission to speak of.

Even if Phainon cried tears of gold or pleaded until his tongue bled, he would never have it. Mydei wouldn't cross a surging river with a boat even if Phainon had already swam across it, now waiting at the other side of the bend.

Phainon should be okay with that. Accept and be done with it.

And yet, he continued to lie awake on the bed with every Curtain-Fall Hour that followed, wondering if he'd done things differently—if only he didn't feel a certain way—then Mydei would still be here. They would bicker about their day in the fields, the delicious *deipnon*, and groan about sore muscles (which is admittedly Phainon's to do and for Mydei to make fun of him).

But Mydei is not here, choosing to spend the rest of his days in the Akashian village together with the detachment, sleeping in their tents, and indulging in honey brew after a good day gone by.

The faint singing that sounds arguably in Kremnoan tongue echoing from the outside suggests that they are making merry as well. And Phainon could only hope that it would serve as a distraction for Mydei. Come morning, they'll talk, and Mydei would've been able to set aside his grievances.

Only, Mydei kept to himself and remained with his people. Phainon didn't seek him out.

Unresolved issues aside, they still continued to help the others with the remaining fields, finishing up with the planting of wheat kernels, the pace of the activity much more leisurely now considering that their progress has led them to be ahead of schedule.

By the eighth day of the Month of Cultivation, during the Entry Hour, the Akashian chief fulfills the Revival Ritual by gathering a relative amount of soft dirt from the fields and placing it in a clay pot, one for each Akashian family to enshrine in their homes so they may be able to pray for a bountiful harvest.

Phainon's solemnity as he spectated was rendered superficial for his mind lingers elsewhere, as it had done these past couple of days. Across from him did Mydei stood, dignified alongside the detachment, his focus solely on Demeas now handing the clay pots to the family heads of each household.

The ache in Phainon's chest grows all the more palpable with each moment that his gaze lingers, for how could he bear to look away from such beauty so unparalleled that it might even be able to rival Mnestia? And to think that he's held said beauty in his arms albeit briefly, how right it felt, how he longed to experience it again.

Selfish thoughts for the unworthy, and he calls himself a hero of Okhema whose selflessness is meant to bring deliverance to the nation. How could he speak of his oath to protect when his heart is no longer fully in it?

His heart, which initially thrummed so steadily to keep him going in the long journey of what fate has in store for him, to see a prophecy fulfilled—now it burns with an insatiable need, a yearning to be offered and accepted, *not* by an entire nation in need of his aid.

But by a lone man. A prince. An *equal*.

If Mydei were to look at him at this moment, he would know of Phainon's sentiments in an instant. His secrets laid bare to be scrutinized, and he would be fine with it. Even if the question remains unasked, he wonders what Mydei's answer would be, what it *could* be.

Hope and despair never go hand in hand together, easily distinguished without much deliberation like true gold from rusting iron. Still, Phainon found himself teetering between the two the longer that Mydei maintains his silence.

Even if it's to be expected that Mydei is not inclined for such relations involving matters of the heart, Phainon can't help but hope that Mydei would at least see him as an exception. Would it be wrong to assume that Mydei desired just as much as he did in that pitiful excuse of a wooden tub?

But Mydei *left*. There's nothing to assume.

The reminder echoes in his mind, sometimes despondent, sometimes vindictive, but most of the time it just sounds empty. Like a line in a book, read and spoken a dozen times to warrant memorization, a fact proven true a long time ago and didn't need much of a debate to deem otherwise.

The skin surrounding Phainon's thumb bleeds from over-peeling, a nasty habit that even Aglaea couldn't scold out of him. The sting brings him comfort, clearing his mind severely.

In the end, Phainon's gaze remains unmet. A small mercy perhaps, for if he were to bestow Mydei's attention now, then he would have to do the painful act of looking away, his own world darkening for Kephale's Dawn alone is no longer enough to bring light to it.

Again, selfish thoughts for the unworthy. Phainon could see no end to this. Since when was he allowed to want for *so* much more than what is deserved? What is willfully *given*?

Mydei is kind and he's treated Phainon with respect and grace befitting of a close friend. If Phainon were to honor their relation, it'd be wise not to dwell on thoughts that involve asking Mydei for the impossible when the man has done nothing but humor his whims.

If Mydei wished it, he could've killed Phainon for his outrageous behavior. But he didn't, he simply left. And somehow, the action causes him pain more than if Mydei had just stabbed him in the heart with a knife and carved it out.

Phainon would do it for him. His heart didn't feel like it belonged to him these days with how much it rebels, how much it yearns to be in the hands of another. He might as well gouge it out and offer it to Mydei, and he wonders if that would solve everything.

"As with all the feasts of Georios, the flame is but a necessary element," Demeas says to the crowd, pulling Phainon out of his thoughts. He gestures at the pile of unlit torches. "Please, help yourself with one of these and partake with the tradition."

The crowd disperses, each individual taking a torch for their own. Phainon watches the impressive pile reduce in size, letting the others have their turn. When only but a single torch was left did he make his move to pick it up from the ground, crouching as he does so.

A hand collides with him, a golden gauntlet unmistakable to the point that Phainon didn't need to think too hard to know whose face he'll find when he looks up.

Mydei, with his hand brushing against Phainon's own as they both grip the handle of the torch, was unable to hide his surprise. Phainon could only hope that he'd at least look a little more put-together despite his racing heartbeat.

But the image of himself that he sees reflected upon those pools of gold says otherwise.

"Oh dear."

They both whip their heads to turn to Marpessa.

"It seems that I have terribly miscounted. My lords—"

"It's alright," Mydei says, sudden enough to startle Phainon from his daze. In a blink of an eye, Mydei had already put some distance between them, standing two paces away from where Phainon was still crouched. "You can have the torch, Deliverer."

Phainon frowns, taking the torch with him as he straightens up. "You had your hand on this first. You should take it."

"No."

"*No?*"

Marpessa bristles from where she stood in between them. "Ah, my lords, please don't fight."

The tension in the air grows thick, the crowd bracing themselves for what is about to be another tussle between the two Chrysos Heirs. Everyone knew that they opted to avoid each other like the plague due to their unsettled grievances, keeping to themselves in the hopes to preserve the peace.

But they both knew better than anyone that it wasn't really the mere act of wrestling in the mud that is to blame.

"W-Why don't you two just share?" Demeas adds meekly from their right, standing amongst his fellow Akashians.

The way he holds his torch so tightly seemed as if he's not ready to part with it. But in the event that the two Heirs were to turn down such an absurd idea, he's ready to give his own torch up, prayers to Georios be damned.

Phainon turns to Mydei. There's no reason to make everyone so unsettled. "I'm alright with sharing."

Mydei's eyes glint, his face showing neither anger nor relief. Fortunately, he was able to glean on what Phainon was trying to do here for he eventually says, "Fine. Let's share."

The sigh of relief that everyone collectively lets out was loud enough to be exaggerated. Phainon chooses not to dwell on it, uncomfortable at the fact that everyone had to witness the exchange.

The torches are to be lit up around the newly-tended wheat fields. Even if this practice came to be when night still existed, every follower of Georios knew how important the flame is despite the presence of everday in Okhema.

Mydei spreads the tinder on the ground, making sure that they're away from the grasslands just in case fire would spread uncontrollably.

"It is ready," he says.

"Do you wish for me to light it up?" Phainon asks, eyeing the flint and iron pyrite in Mydei's hand.

"No. I'll do it."

Phainon nods, gripping the handle of the torch tightly. "Alright."

Mydei strikes the iron pyrite with the flint a couple of times until sparks were made, lighting up the tinder in the process. Phainon lowers the torch head, soaked in resin and wax, allowing it to catch the flame. In mere moments, the torch burns bright.

He then settles it upon the torchbearer. Unlike Georios' Embers—torches holding the last unextinguished cinders of Georios—regular torches such as the one they have now did not possess the innate ability to float, nor did it have sentience.

They stare at the flame for what seemed to have been a long time until their faces bore the heat of it, the dance of fire reflected in their eyes.

"Have you—"

"We should—" Mydei stops talking, gesturing for Phainon to continue. "You go first."

Phainon does, in no mood to argue, swallowing down the curiosity of wanting to know what it is that Mydei wished to say. "Have you done a prayer to Georios before?"

Mydei shakes his head. "I never needed to."

"Then, I'll show you how." Phainon extends an arm. "Take my hand."

A flicker of what looked to be hesitation in Mydei's eyes causes Phainon to falter. He withdraws his hand immediately.

"Sorry. I'm not forcing you or—"

Mydei rolls his eyes and takes his hand in his. “You always think too much.”

Phainon eyes their intertwined fingers. The metal of Mydei’s gauntlet is cool against his skin. He turns to Mydei, an eyebrow raised challengingly. “And you don’t? That would make sense.”

Mydei’s grip becomes bruisingly tight for a mere moment as Phainon lets out a yelp. He shoots Phainon a glare and only then does the latter realize how much he missed having Mydei’s eyes on him.

“Quit dawdling and do what you must.”

Phainon nods, a smile on his lips. Despite the throb of pain in his hand, this is the happiest he’s felt in *days*. “Right. I forgot that a little teasing gets you riled up.”

“And it only took you four Entry Hours without talking to me to forget such a fact?” Mydei asks pointedly. “Your memory is abysmal.”

Well. They might as well talk about it now.

“I’m not the one who chose to sleep in a tent,” Phainon says, as if it would serve as a reason for their lack of communication. It does, to an extent.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Would you have preferred it if I stayed?”

Perhaps Phainon is still, in fact, not ready to talk. Mydei’s question required either a yes or a no for an answer. Phainon can’t find the voice to say either one of those simple words.

“I apologize if I made you uncomfortable—”

“You didn’t,” Mydei says, effectively cutting him off.

Phainon frowns, confused upon hearing the denial. “You’re not one to lie.”

“Never was. If I were uncomfortable, *you* would know.” Mydei’s eyes flash. “*I’m* capable of letting you know.”

There’s no question to that. However, “You left.”

“Yes. Only because I had to.”

Phainon makes a sound, expressing his perplexity, or is it something else—something much more dreadful. He no longer wishes to continue the conversation even if his doubts are about to be put to rest.

“You *had* to?” he echoes, feeling as empty as a shell.

Mydei sighs, looking away. He inhales sharply, as if to muster the courage he already possessed. His next words cause the blood running through Phainon’s veins to go cold.

“We can’t,” Mydei says. Resolute. “We’re not supposed to.”

There it is.

Phainon gets the answer he seeks, brought to him plainly and with no preamble, spoken so clearly that there could be no mistake. The only thing Phainon would’ve wished is for Mydei to have met his eyes when he said it.

He can’t even begin to marvel at the red dusting Mydei’s cheeks and the tips of his ears—no doubt brought upon by the sheer embarrassment of having to put himself in such a position neither of them should even be in. The sight should be an endearing one on a good day, but right now, all color in the world has faded.

At his silence, Mydei once again turns to him, his expression crumbling as he does so. It makes Phainon wonder what he’d seen on his face. He always liked to think that he can mask his emotions very well, but perhaps this occasion does not account for that.

“Deliverer, I—”

“No,” Phainon says, the sound of his own voice foreign. “I get it. You don’t have to explain.”

He’d been too presumptuous.

For once, Phainon regrets that he’s right about something: Mydei places great importance on his duty, there’s no time to indulge in selfish desires. If Phainon’s mind were any clearer, or if his affections had run shallow, he would thank Mydei for reestablishing the line between them.

Now it made sense why Mydei *had* to leave him then.

A reason such as the heavy weight of responsibility sitting upon their shoulders belie a bittersweet comfort. Mydei could simply… not like Phainon in *that* way. The incident from the bath nothing but a biological response beyond one’s control.

They’ve both seen each other in worse case scenarios during battle, the sight of each other’s arousal is nothing of comparison if they were to have reservations in displaying less-than composed dispositions. Most importantly, they’re *friends*. Trust has always been present between them.

That must explain why Mydei didn’t feel uncomfortable, he knew Phainon wouldn’t do anything that would cater to his discomfort. And the moment that Phainon did, he simply left.

Phainon feels sick, falling to his knees, Mydei’s hand slipping away from him. “I’m sorry. I’m *so* sorry. Mydei, really I’m—”

He feels like crying—disappointment, hurt, and guilt muddling into one deplorable ball and lodging itself deeply within him, a tumor that’s bound to eat him up from the inside.

Caught in his own downward spiral of thoughts, Phainon barely registers Mydei falling onto the ground alongside him, his scent invading Phainon's nostrils. Blonde strands brush lightly against the side of his face as he's pulled closer, further into Mydei's hold in a surprising gesture of consolation.

Mydei is comforting *him*, a hand behind him and at the back of his head. Phainon chokes on a startled gasp when Mydei tightens the hug, the sound muffled against Mydei's clothed shoulder.

"Idiot Deliverer. *Whatever* am I going to do with you?" Mydei murmurs against his ear, uncaring that the other could evidently hear him. "*Haikas.*"

Only Mydei could admonish him as if he were a disobedient child during such a vulnerable moment. Phainon didn't know whether he should laugh or cry. He does agree with Mydei's words, however.

"I feel like one."

Mydei huffs. "Good. Damned fool."

"Lay it off with the insults." *I just got my heart broken*, Phainon doesn't say out loud. He's already lost so much of his dignity that he might already be in debt with how he keeps losing more of it.

Thankfully, Mydei shows him mercy, rubbing circles on his back as if to soothe a spooked dromas. Phainon allows himself to relish the sensation. It *should* help ease the pain of rejection, but he can't deny the fact that such gentle gestures only serve to worsen it.

It does not make him want Mydei *less*.

With great effort, he peels himself away from Mydei's embrace, standing straight on his feet shortly after he does so. Mydei mirrors the movement, eyeing him quizzically.

"Feel better?"

Phainon stares at the lit torch, avoiding Mydei's gaze as he nods stiffly. "Yes." The lie passes through his lips easily this time. Keeping his voice steady, he tries to move the conversation away from... whatever this is. "We should proceed with the prayer. I'm afraid we've made Georios wait for too long already."

Mydei only hums before taking Phainon's hand in his once again, maintaining his silence as Phainon mutters the prayers for a bountiful harvest and a blessed land. Once the lighting of the torches have concluded, everyone who has come to help the Akashians with the fields now mount the dromases to make their way back to the main city of Okhema.

Phainon watched as Mydei rode ahead with his fellow Kremnoans, a grin on his face as he joked around with the soldiers. Sensing a certain piercing gaze on him, Mydei turns around to meet Phainon's stare.

His smile widens, the sight of it causing Phainon's heart to twinge painfully. In spite of everything, Phainon musters every ounce of strength in him to smile back.

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Mnestia's affections for Cerces is of no secret to the gods who unfortunately had to bear witness of it. Warm-hearted Georios had enough and told Mnestia to light a flame together with Their most beloved.

"Blessed is the flame. Have it burn as bright as your Love for Reason to ignore it no longer."

Alas, Cerces saw Mnestia's invitation as something trivial and thought nothing of it. Hence, the Titans pondered some more for another way to have Cerces reciprocate Mnestia's ardent Love.

— an excerpt. The Woes of Mnestia in the Eyes of the Divine

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Mydei's rejection continued to haunt Phainon like a ghost adamantly avoiding eternal rest.

At first, he thought it to be a standard reaction for rejection is not something most would see in a positive light. It is with great regret that Phainon falls upon the majority. If he could, he'd express his admiration to the select few who could take rejection as fuel for self-improvement.

He hoped he'd feel better, the pain dulling into something much more bearable. But it's been two weeks since the Revival Ritual, and Phainon only feels worse than ever before. There's no telling how he would be able to cope if something of a much greater magnitude denies him acceptance.

Phainon has had his fair share of failures before, and none of them he took lightly. Mydei's rejection only served to amplify this fact tenfold.

For someone regarded to be without flaws, Phainon considers this to be one of his. If Mydei already had such an effect on him, who's to say how Phainon would react if he *eventually* fails the demigod trial and divinity itself rejects him?

"Since Mydeimos is not willing, you should resume your initial goal of pursuing Nikador's coreflame," Aglaea told him when the threads informed her that Phainon had finally come to

know of Mydei's wishes in regards to the mad Titan. "Aside from Mydeimos, there really is no other Heir that's fitting to inherit Strife."

Phainon would beg to differ. Mydei is the only one that's fitting, and that should've been the end to it.

But Mydei had already made his decision. Thus, Phainon could only hope to shoulder the burden in his stead—be the Guardian that Amphoreus needed to purge the Black Tide, his initial goal fully realized even when his sentiments have changed, his worth questioned.

As his sword ran through the Titankin he'd been pursuing, he belatedly realized that Mydei had once again invaded his thoughts.

He should've known it to be a futile assumption: the less of Mydei he saw, the less he thought of him. This is proven false time and time again. Everything in Phainon's life involved Mydei somehow, his mind bound to circle back to the man one way or another no matter how hard he tried to steer clear of him.

With a heavy sigh, Phainon drags a heavy hand across his face, smearing the golden blood that had splattered onto his skin during the skirmish. He feels helpless. *Lost*.

During his return to Okhema, instead of wallowing in his misery, Phainon diverts his attention onto cleaning his greatsword. Thoughts of Mydei must cease at once if he were to keep his sanity intact.

It's already a relief that he's sent out on missions alone more often these days rather than with his usual *partner*. Perhaps he should give Aglaea a gift for a favor done so unknowingly. But who is he kidding, Aglaea knows *everything*. Even if Phainon didn't speak of his woes, the golden threads that surrounded him must've trembled with it.

By the time he reached the city gates, his blade could pass off as a mirror, polished excessively and coated with a thin sheet of oil to prevent rust and corrosion. The Dromas Workshop is his first stop, the place as lively as ever.

Upon seeing Phainon's arrival with Dorothea, a dromas caretaker readies a dromas pen and prepares a wooden stool to assist Phainon in dismounting.

"Welcome back, Lord Phainon."

"Thank you." Phainon gives the caretaker a smile as he leaps down while Dorothea was led to her pen for the other caretakers to tend to her. "The trip went smoothly thanks to Dorothea."

"Only because you're her favorite, my lord," the caretaker says, shaking his head. "Merchants who have fallen victim to her beauty have lesser praises to sing upon their return. Even Lord Mydei refused to take her when he goes out of the city on his own."

At the mention of the name, Phainon's ears traitorously perk up. The thought of Mydei riding a different dromas stings a little (actually, it stings *a lot*) considering that they're both meant

to share Dorothea. Several trips to the Abyss with just the three of them made Phainon think that the man had eventually forged a bond with the animal.

“Which unlucky dromas was bestowed with the honor of escorting the picky crown prince on his trips?” Phainon asks, keeping his tone light to mask his disappointment.

“He’s a newly matured one,” the caretaker answers, scanning the workshop for the aforementioned dromas. “Ah, over there with Ctesias. Lord Mydei named him Kokopo if I’m not mistaken.”

Phainon’s mind turns blank. “Kokopo? What kind of name…”

He turns his attention to the dromas by the far corner of the workshop currently being fed with redsoil. Its collar was engraved with rubies, no doubt the work of its newfound master. To think that a dromas was able to garner Mydei’s favor so easily, swathed in Mydei’s jewels, ridden by Mydei to battle—

Jealousy for a mere animal is not a good look. But Phainon never really cared about how he was perceived. If he wished he was a dromas named Kokopo, then that is his burden to carry alone.

“Good for him, then,” Phainon says sardonically before handing the caretaker a pouch containing the appropriate amount of balance coins. “Let it be known as well that Dorothea is not to be used by anyone else aside from me from this day forth.”

The caretaker only tilts his head. “Ah? Oh, of course, Lord Phainon.”

“Please feed her more redsoil for dinner as compensation for Mydei’s betrayal.”

Before the caretaker could ask what Phainon meant, Phainon had already stormed off, a thundercloud above his head as he made his way to the Marmoreal Palace to report to Aglaea. Just when he thought his mood couldn’t sour anymore than it already has, Mydei had to get himself his very own dromas and name it *Kokopo*.

Utterly outrageous. Phainon couldn’t make sense of it all, and he thought *he* was the one that’s bad when it came to naming basically anything.

Nearing Aglaea’s office, he makes an attempt to calm himself down, smoothing out his clothes, and checking his reflection from the shiny brass that lined the walls, trying to wipe away the dried golden blood on his face with no avail. He gives up. Aglaea has seen him practically drenched in golden ichor before, a mere splatter of blood on the face shouldn’t earn him sidelong glances.

He turns to the huge double door that led to Aglaea’s office. But before he could even knock, two voices from within could be heard—one of them sending Phainon’s instincts screaming at him to turn around and seek citizenship in a different land, Black Tide be damned.

“I’m afraid there’s nothing I could do, Mydeimos,” came Aglaea’s muffled voice from within. “The Council of Elders were very persistent this time around. Accompanied by

civilian witnesses, the odds are stacked against us."

A sigh resounds, heavy, deeply aggrieved by this news for some reason. "My people have already made the due preparations for the Month of Joy," Mydei says, an edge to his tone. "To simply call everything off would be a waste of their efforts."

"Allow me to apologize once again, Mydeimos."

Silence. And then, Mydei replies, voice low that Phainon could barely hear him, "It's… not your fault. I should've expected something of this sort to happen given how much those old fogeys hate us. But to go so far as to prevent such a ceremony…" Another sigh. "I must inform Phainon of this."

Phainon balks at the mention of his name, something tells him that he's not meant to overhear the conversation. But just as he was about to initiate a tactical retreat, Janus opens the door for him and two pairs of eyes come bearing down upon him in an instant.

"You've been standing there for so long," Aglaea says, seated upon her ornate chair behind the massive marble desk. "You should've knocked, Phainon."

Before Phainon could come up with an excuse, the subject of his torment *talks* to him. It's rather unfortunate, really.

"Were you eavesdropping?" Mydei asks accusingly, seemingly disconcerted about something, shoulders tense.

"I can't help it when I can literally hear the two of you from outside," Phainon replies, trying to maintain eye contact with Mydei without bursting into flames. He turns to Aglaea. "The Elders are causing trouble again, huh. Should we just kill them, Aglaea?"

He doesn't tend to result to such extremes, but he's been so pent up lately that he can't help but let some of his honest sentiments regarding the Council of Elders be known. To say that Phainon has had enough of their nonsense would be an understatement.

Instead of a reprimand for suggesting violence, Aglaea's lips are curved in a gentle smile, almost serene. "A magnificent idea."

"*No*," Mydei says, a hand on his face that barely conceals his frown. "I get that you're equally upset as I am, Deliverer, but this issue doesn't warrant such drastic measures."

Phainon shrugs, banishing thoughts of murder. "If you say so. Just let me know if you change your mind."

Mydei doesn't smile at the jest (Phainon was being serious). "I'll take my leave now. Come see me when you're done with your report, Deliverer."

Splendid. Mydei wants to spend time with him. It is with a great amount of strength that he stops himself from agreeing so quickly, like a habitual reaction to every single one of Mydei's requests.

“I’m rather tired, Mydei.” A sublime excuse.

Mydei raises a perfect eyebrow, eyelids lowering demurely, thick lashes fluttering as he blinked. “Surely you can spare me a quint or less?”

“Very well,” Phainon replies, quick as Zagreus’ footing. He might as well start roaring on Mydei’s command like an obedient little chimera. If Mydei fed him dirt, he would gladly eat it with no arguments. And then he remembers that he’d done exactly *that* for *three whole weeks* several months ago. Phainon accepts defeat. “I’ll go to your chambers after this.”

“Hm.” Mydei seems satisfied with this response. He then turns to Aglaea. “Have a good rest of your day, Aglaea. Thank you again.”

Aglaea nods. “You too, Mydeimos. I’m sorry I can’t do more for you and your people.”

“You’ve already done so much.”

And with that, Mydei leaves, closing the door behind him. Phainon can finally savor the air properly. He didn’t even realize that he was holding his breath.

“So, Phainon,” Aglaea began. “How is the situation?”

“Nothing out of the ordinary. The defenses of the northwest border remain as strong as ever without the boar king’s interference. Fewer Titankin roamed the area this time, and they were far less aggressive.”

Aglaea presses a finger on her chin, staring at the unfurled map on her desk, laid flat with gemstones for paperweights. “That’s good news. And what of the investigations as to the whereabouts of Castrum Kremnos?”

Phainon shakes his head, gaze lowered. “Nikador’s Titankin all spread out upon retreat, I could only track down a couple. Even those led me to dead-ends.”

“I see.” Aglaea rolls up the map, no hint of frustration in her movements despite the slight frown that graced her face. “No use dwelling on it now, I suppose. We have more troubles on our plate with the Council ceaselessly stirring up folly.”

She gives Phainon an unreadable look. Considering that it’s Aglaea, her strange stares are more typical than not.

“Mydeimos must be in dire need of comfort,” she continues pointedly. “The Elders have caused him a great deal of stress even if he doesn’t show it; the threads continue to tremble long after his departure.”

Phainon can’t help but feel as if he’s supposed to understand something here. He comes up with a blank. “I may have admittedly listened in on your conversation, but I still require context.”

Aglaea’s clouded gaze somehow turns even more severe than usual, almost like a reprimand. “The Council of Elders have raised a policy forbidding any ceremonial events—such as

weddings, and the like—to be held in a Kremnoan's honor due to Krateros' assault on your person during the previous month."

"So sudden?" Phainon says, unable to hide his surprise. "Aren't all policies up for debate? Lord Krateros and I could settle our grievances using a One-Day Talanton or—"

"It is a policy only in name," Aglaea interrupts. "We both know that it serves more as a punishment, Phainon."

"Even if that is so, isn't it a bit excessive? The Elders hardly care for the well-being of the Chrysos Heirs to have them depriving the Kremnoans of their traditions simply because of a minor disagreement."

Aglaea sighs. "The Elders are looking for any and every opportunity to dangle their authority over the Kremnoans. If that foolish old man Krateros kept his temper in check, we wouldn't have to deal with this."

"But part of the fault lies with *me*," Phainon argues. "It was *I* who provoked him."

"I'm afraid protests could only do so much. You could raise this matter in the next Assembly alongside the Kremnoans if you wish. But by then, I'm afraid it'll be too late." Aglaea looks over the tall windows, blowing in a pleasant breeze to the room, seemingly gazing at something so far away. Softly, as if considering, she says more to herself than at Phainon, "It seems the Festival of Phagousa is the next best thing."

Phainon knew better than to interrupt Aglaea's musings, but the mention of Okhema's harvest feast does catch his attention. Perhaps the Kremnoans also placed great importance in celebrating Phagousa's blessings considering their ancestry's close ties with the Titan.

No wonder Mydei was distraught. The detachment won't surely take lightly to being hindered from such a celebration; every nation has their own version of a harvest feast depending on their way of life. In the case of the Kremnoans, their history with Phagousa spanning thousands of years since the late days of Era Bellica is bound to warrant a festive ceremony in honor of the god. Phainon doubts that the Kremnoans would be amenable to joining the Okhemans during theirs regardless of how equally lavish it would be.

Aglaea turns her attention back to him, as if she's only reminded that Phainon was still in the room. "I shan't keep you for long now, Phainon. You may leave."

Phainon nods. "Right. I'll see you at the *deipnon*."

He was already one foot out of the door when Aglaea calls for him again, a recurring event now that Phainon thinks about it.

"Phainon."

"Yes?" he asks, turning around.

Aglaea takes a moment before she speaks, almost as if she's carefully considering her words. "Let it be known that Mnestia's blessings are shared to all even without the need of rituals or

ceremonies."

Phainon frowns. He's wearing an Aglaea-approved outfit today. She can't be throwing jabs at his chosen attire. Nevertheless, he still manages a befuddled, "Thank you for informing me."

Aglaea looks far from pleased. "Pray to Cerces and meditate during the Parting Hour," she says. "I'm beginning to think that you need Their guidance more than anyone. *Direly* so."

The door closes on Phainon's face before he could so much as get a word in. It takes a while before Aglaea's words register in his mind, and yes, she really did just call him an idiot in the most indirect, Aglaea-esque way possible.

This month really is doing wonders to his self-esteem. A week of seclusion is sounding more tempting by the hour.

Dejected, he trudges back to the Chrysos Heirs' tower and knocks upon Mydei's door as promised, already regretting every single decision that has led to this.

He should've said no to Mydei for once. He should've just gone ahead to his room, send Mydei a quick message detailing his excuse, the more pitiful the better. But before he could turn back, however, a deep voice beckons him in, sending tremors down the very essence of his soul.

"Come in."

Janus turns the lock and Phainon plasters the best smile he could possibly muster, concealing how he's currenty dying from the inside. Upon entering, the first thing he does is step on an unfurled scroll on the floor. He can't help but think that he is a walking mistake, picking up the item and rolling it up absentmindedly.

Then he sees another scroll. And another. An opened tome, a stone slate— Only then did he realize that the hallway leading to Mydei's main sleeping area was littered with various reading articles on every possible surface of sparse furniture.

Phainon steps further into the room, carefully navigating his way lest he accidentally step on something again and invoke Mydei's ire. The state of the main area is not that much different to the hallway. Except, there are jarring new additions to the room.

Huge shelves were now upon every wall, stocked with stone slates of varying sizes, thick tomes bound in worn-out leather, and scrolls of which some were cascading from the shelf's surface down to the floor, exposing written words of which Phainon is not familiar to. Even Mydei's kline was not spared, also littered with sheets of papyrus bearing foreign literature.

"What in Cerces' paradise…" Phainon mutters, looking around the room with muted surprise.

Mydei emerges from *somewhere*, carrying a *kápsa* overflowing with scrolls. A strange sight. Phainon had to direct his eyes elsewhere lest he allow himself to indulge in the way the

muscles of Mydei's arms bulged tastefully as he held the *kápsa* against his well-endowed chest that had been lovingly sculpted by the gods, evidently so.

"That was quick," Mydei says in lieu of a greeting as he brushes past Phainon. "I thought Aglaea would keep you for much longer."

Phainon's nostrils flare at the subtle scent of pomegranates. "She was in a *mood* today," is all he says, still bitter about Aglaea's criticism of his wits—the lack thereof, apparently. He picks up a stone slate the size of his palm from the floor and tries to decipher its contents. "You know, when I told you that your room looks so empty, I didn't expect you to retaliate with a whole library."

Mydei sets the *kápsa* down on the floor upon one of the rare empty spots left that's not already preoccupied by something else. "I've been meaning to do this for a while but never found an appropriate place to properly store everything," he explains. "When the Month of Joy comes, I shall forfeit the kline and have two more shelves brought in."

"Where will you sleep?" Phainon asks, setting the slate down at its initial spot, which is... on the floor as well.

Mydei looked taken aback by this question for some reason, as if Phainon had just asked him something inherently offensive, his face coloring in mere moments out of sheer anger, most likely.

"You treat me like a fish easily lured by baits," he says before turning away, opting to arrange some of the tomes spread upon the kline onto a nearby shelf as a way of diversion. "I'm not answering that."

Phainon didn't have the energy in him to pry. "Fine. Keep your secrets."

The other could sleep on the floor if he's so inclined. Perhaps even with some other Kremnoan at the settlement as he did so during their time at the Akashian village. Phainon can't be bothered by it.

Mydei can do whatever he wants, he thinks dolefully, swallowing down the acrid taste of jealousy in his tongue at the thought of Mydei spending his Curtain-Fall Hours elsewhere with somebody else.

He could only hope that the bitterness is not so prevalent in his tone when he says, "Why'd you ask me to come see you?"

"To talk about the Elders' new policy," Mydei replies, a tinge of frustration in his tone that's not entirely caused by Phainon this time. He turns around, back leaning against the shelves as he crosses his arms. "It is with regret that my people must acquiesce. I just wish they won't rebel."

So Mydei simply needed someone to vent his troubles to. Phainon would be lying if he admits that he's not the slightest bit relieved. At the end of the day, Mydei still views him as an equal, a trusted confidant. That alone lightens Phainon's mood significantly.

“The next Assembly won’t be for another year or two,” Phainon says, taking a step closer towards Mydei to rid themselves of the uncomfortable distance unbefitting of friends. “I can file several complaints to speed up the wait, if you want.”

Mydei sighs, gaze lowering dejectedly. Phainon itches to press a finger upon the crease in between his brows if only to be rid of it, but the idea of touching Mydei shouldn’t even be on the table right now considering his… er, *problems*.

“That won’t be necessary,” Mydei says. “Some traditions can be conducted in secret despite the policy. It’s just that, some are…”

Eyes of gold meet Phainon’s, indecipherable, belying an emotion that Phainon couldn’t quite place. It’s almost apologetic in a way, a hint of helplessness causing the knot in Phainon’s chest to tighten for the sight of Mydei’s distress is not, and will *never* be, a welcome one.

“Some aren’t supposed to be,” Mydei finishes. “I’m not blind to the preparations the detachment has made at my expense for the Month of Joy. I don’t want their efforts to be for naught.”

Phainon walks towards the shelf that Mydei was leaning on, mirroring the stance and hearing the wood creak behind him from their combined weight. Keeping Aglaea’s musings in mind, he says, “It won’t be.”

Mydei turns to him. “How so?”

“The Festival of Phagousa is grand every year,” is Phainon’s way of hinting that the Kremnoans could spend their harvest feast with the Okhemans. “Celebrations held alongside it won’t cause a stir. There’s even a play, if I recall correctly.”

Mydei seems to ponder this suggestion, bottom lip caught in between his teeth. “That seems plausible. I don’t really mind, and if it were only up to *me*…”

Such searing golden eyes glint dangerously as they look at Phainon from head to toe, seemingly appraising his less-than presentable countenance with dried divine blood still splattered upon his clothes and smeared on his face.

Mydei licks his lips and all Phainon could do is wantonly follow the movement of his tongue, leaving such irresistible plumpness glistening with a hypnotic allure. Eventually, Mydei’s gaze meets that of Phainon’s, dark and heady. Or perhaps Phainon is once again only seeing what he *wants* to see; Mydei already made it clear that he’s above any sort of indulgence.

“If it were only up to *me*,” Mydei continues. “Forgoing the ceremony *is* an option.”

Phainon frowns. For someone who mutters prayers to Phagousa every time he partakes in a cup of honey brew, Mydei sure cared less for harvest feasts.

“You shouldn’t,” Phainon says, a voice of reason. “The detachment had already made the due preparations, didn’t they?”

Mydei nods, turning away. “They have.”

Seeing Mydei's shoulders slumped and his eyes downcast, Phainon surmises that he must still have some apprehensions. "If there's anything I could help with—"

"No," Mydei says sharply, causing Phainon to flinch. "You are not to meddle in such affairs. That is my job."

Right. Phainon is, and would always be, an outsider.

The smile on his face becomes strained. "Of course. If you have no need of me, Mydei, I'd like to retire to my chambers." It's a cowardly retreat. "Aglaea is making me do meditations to Cerces for some reason."

Mydei snorts, oblivious to Phainon's turmoil. "She thinks you're an idiot." He squints at Phainon, a teasing smirk on his lips. "What did you do this time?"

"I have no idea."

"Your idiocy has no cure so don't bother praying for wisdom. And I still need you, Deliverer."

The insult barely even registers, the notion of being helpful catching Phainon's attention immediately. Suddenly, his cheeks were no longer weary, the smile he bears faint but genuine. "Oh? What does His Highness wish for me to do?"

"Keep me company."

Phainon heart thuds within his chest. "Are you lonely?"

"This is the longest I've seen you since the Revival Ritual," is Mydei's lame non-answer, avoiding Phainon's gaze. "And it's been a while since we last sparred. Are you up for it?"

"Aren't you busy at the moment?" Phainon turns his attention to Mydei's room. It looked as if a second Chrysos War had just taken place.

Mydei didn't seem to be in a hurry to handle the mess. "I can make time. I need a break, anyway. Unless you're too tired?"

Sparring with Mydei has always been a highlight of Phainon's day, even returning from grueling missions won't hinder him from accepting. That is until his body thought it appropriate to be in a perpetual state of popping a boner whenever Mydei is nearby. The amount of self-restraint he's been mustering since he entered Mydei's chambers should be applauded.

He thinks that he should start learning how to turn Mydei down. After all, he *is* tired. But there's something hopeful in the way that Mydei regards him, eyes of gold clear and devoid of any pretenses, *expecting* Phainon to say yes.

Phainon should say no. And yet—

"Race you there."

He bolts out of the room in mere moments after he said those words, barely able to take in the surprised expression that graced Mydei's face at the sudden challenge. It may be cowardly to admit, but the act of running away gives Phainon comfort, as if he's actually running away from his problems—away from *Mydei*.

But the relief is short-lived.

The swift rhythm of greaves clacking sharply against the marble floor of the palace closes in on him from behind. Phainon makes the mistake of looking back, only to see Mydei catching up to him rather impressively.

"Lose the armor and maybe you'll run faster!" Phainon jeers.

Mydei's next words fries his brain to a pitiful burnt crust. "You want me to run naked?"

Phainon trips and falls flat on his nose, Mydei pushing past him without so much as a remorse. What a wicked, *wicked* man.

With a groan, Phainon lifts his head only to blearily see a flurry of red running off to the distance before dropping back down once again. The image of a very naked Mydei haunts him—remnants of a memory from two weeks ago. Water sluicing down a muscled back, scarlet marks a striking sight against tanned skin, the bitter taste of oil, firm flesh beneath his fingertips, an echoing gasp, a whisper of his name—

Safe to say, Phainon lost the race to the training grounds. It's the first time he has done so for he's always the quicker one between the two of them. But now, he arrives with a bleeding nose and a wounded pride.

"Titans dead and mad," Mydei muses, eyes simmering with mirth, evidently fighting back a laugh. "Thought I'd never see the day that our darling Deliverer would look like a mess with just a little running."

Phainon wipes away the golden blood dripping down his nose with the back of his hand. "Pick up a spear and let's get this over with."

"You still wish to fight me in that state?"

"No weapons, then."

Phainon lunges first, a waver in his attack with how Mydei was easily able to dodge. His movements lacked its usual purpose—mind quicker than the body, mind drifting somewhere else.

The training ground is empty for the Parting Hour was among them. There's no one to witness Phainon's weakened strikes, lagging behind with how swift Mydei is able to counter every single one, predicting his every move before he could even have the chance to execute them.

Warm liquid drips down to his lips and Phainon feels himself go dizzy for a brief moment just as he aimed for Mydei's jaw, his fist slicing through the air like a blade only for Mydei to

duck low, retaliating with a swift kick at his feet to take down the lousy stance Phainon had been sporting.

Phainon expectedly falls to the ground, barely able to catch himself with his hands. Just before he could scramble back up, a foot on his chest pins him down, Mydei looming over him.

“Yield.”

Phainon takes hold of Mydei’s shin and pulls, locking Mydei’s other foot in between his knees, taking advantage of the way Mydei loses his balance to maneuver the other beneath him. But Mydei doesn’t relent, an elbow to Phainon’s jaw was enough for Mydei to wriggle free from his grasp while Phainon’s mind reels from the throb of pain.

Mydei pins him to the ground once again, both of Phainon’s wrists contained in a bruising grip. “Yield, Deliverer,” he says again, eyes of molten gold sharp as he stares Phainon down. “You need to be taken to the infirmary.”

That’s good and all, and Phainon really couldn’t care less about his defeat at the moment for his attention has been once again monopolized by the depraved *thing* in between his legs.

“On my stomach,” Phainon gasps, almost a hiss, the heat of a blush beginning to creep up on his face.

Mydei frowns. “What?”

“Sit on my stomach. Not— Not *there*.”

Phainon is already half hard when Mydei realizes what was going on. Fortunately, he immediately peels himself away, the firm hold enclosed around Phainon’s wrists disappearing along with the weight above him.

“Deliverer—”

“Don’t.” Phainon scrambles up to his feet, shame bearing down on him. “I need to go.”

“But—”

He turns around, his back facing the other. “Not today, Mydei. Just— Leave me alone.”

It’s a blessing that he couldn’t see Mydei’s face as he said those words, and he wonders if he’d been too harsh. The tides of regret came to drown him in its merciless waters, making it difficult to breathe with every step he took away from the training grounds.

By the time Phainon reached his chambers, it took everything in him to not just collapse into a sorry heap of misery by the door. Instead, he strips off his soiled clothes and slips into the bath in his own chambers, the warm golden waters doing nothing to soothe his low spirits and aching muscles. It’s rather fortunate that his nose had stopped bleeding during the journey back, he’d rather not have to deal with such trivialities, eager to move on to much pressing matters.

No prayers to Cerces occupy his mind as a hand reaches down slowly in between his legs, to that wellspring of desire never sated, abdomen tightening as his fingers ghost over the skin until his whole hand was submerged into the waters.

Phainon would blame the steam from the bath when he feels his face go tingly hot the moment that he takes himself in his hand and tugs lightly, a soft groan escaping his lips, the ache in his groin about to be relieved at last.

The callouses of his hand is a familiar sensation as he strokes himself to full hardness, shaky fingers running down his length in a steady rhythm, a loose hold. The hesitation draws his mind away from merely succumbing to the dizzying sensation of arousal, to thrust into his fist with abandonment.

He could feel himself leak, his head thrown back against the tiled edge of the bath and eyes clenched shut as his pace gradually grew desperate, his grip tightening with every downward stroke, breathless gasps echoing throughout the room. And though his body sings with pleasure, he knew more than anyone that satisfaction isn't within reach for how could a mere hand of his compare to the ever glorious subject of his affections?

"Mydei," he moans, lips swollen with how hard he's bitten on it, trying to suppress his cries. "*Mydei*."

This is not the first time he's done this—calling out Mydei's name so wantonly in the confines of his own chambers. His need echoes through walls ceaselessly, bound to haunt him even in the aftermath when his hand is soiled with the outcome of his depravity.

The water of the bath sloshes along with the frantic movement of his arm. A swipe of his thumb upon his sensitive tip brings him ever closer to the edge as he envisions muscular tanned skin, the sweet scent of pomegranates, Mydei's weight upon him, eyes of pure gold searing through his very soul—

Phainon's teleslate rings, loud and clear, winding golden threads invisible to the naked eye vibrating in the air. The initial shock of it causes him to squeeze himself rather painfully, halting his impending orgasm.

With a muttered curse, Phainon turns to his side and fishes his teleslate from within the pocket of his pants that lay discarded upon the floor, one hand still around his cock as he answers, not even bothering to check who the caller was.

He brings the teleslate to his ear and says a cold greeting, "It's Phainon."

"I know you said to leave you alone—"

A strangled, pathetic sound emerges from deep within his throat upon hearing Mydei's voice, his hand tugging upon his leaking cock without much thought, a subconscious decision unburdened by shame. The sudden pleasure almost had him dropping his teleslate into the bath.

"—are you alright?" Mydei asks from the other end of the line.

Phainon swallows down a whine. “*No*— I mean, yes! I’m fine.”

Phainon readjusts his hold of the teleslate, his legs spreading wider as he shifts to a more comfortable position in the bath. Just so he wouldn’t abandon all propriety, he slows his strokes down to a somewhat calming pace, ignoring how his cock twitches rather insolently against his palm, seeking a much needed release that he’s less than willing to provide now more than ever.

“If you’re unwell, would you like me to bring you your supper to your room?”

The idea of Mydei showing up at his door and seeing him in this debauched state only intensifies the heat pooling in his groin. Phainon laughs breathily, a blunt nail grazing at his slit to stave off some of the hunger that came with the vision, hips thrusting involuntarily into his hand at the spark of pleasure.

“How considerate,” he says, biting his lip before a moan could slip out.

Mydei hums, the mere sound of it so close against Phainon’s ear causing him to shiver, and he could almost imagine that Mydei is in the room with him.

“I could also bring you some medicine.”

“No need,” Phainon reassures shakily. “I’m—*nnh*—fine…”

It’s quiet at the other end of the line. Phainon wonders if Mydei had found out what he’s been up to, what he’s thinking about. A lust-addled mind had him caring less.

“You sound ill,” Mydei points out.

“That would be one way to put it,” Phainon manages, chest heaving. He wants to come *so* bad, desperate would be an understatement. He would have to invent an entire new word to describe just how much he *wants*—

“What does that even mean?” Mydei asks.

“I have—*hah*—no idea.”

“You’re not making any sense.”

“It helps keep the conversation going, doesn’t it?” Phainon admits, knowing Mydei wouldn’t pick up on it—that the mere sound of Mydei’s voice is enough to send him careening to the edge, the heat in his belly downright unbearable with how close he is to reaching his peak with Mydei *still* at the other end of the line.

He hears a huff, could almost envision the way Mydei rolls his eyes, too. “You confuse me. Not even a quint ago, you wanted to leave my presence so hurriedly. And now you wish to talk?”

“My apologies,” Phainon says, insincere to a fault as a wry smile creeps upon his lips, languidly pumping at his length to prolong the pleasure, or perhaps the agony. “My mind is

quite fickle these days, and it has thus influenced my actions."

"You always lose yourself to your thoughts. When will you learn not to dwell on them?"

"I don't know." Phainon licks his dry lips. "Got any advice to give a weary-minded friend?"

At this, Phainon puts the call on speaker and himself on mute, placing the teleslate upon the edge of the bath as he listens to Mydei talk: a mix of genuine advice, admonishments, musings, and even insults that were uncalled for.

It matters not what Mydei could be saying, his voice alone keeps Phainon going—smooth and deep, like a sweet thick syrup that has Phainon wishing he could taste it. His strokes against his length gradually speeds up as he allows himself to get lost in Mydei's rambles, every shift in tone and every inflection mixing in with the sounds that have been at the forefront of Phainon's mind since two weeks ago.

Gasps fitfully restrained as their bodies moved against each other in a rickety wooden tub that could barely even fit two people, parted lips pressed against his ear as his name was being called upon so softly. Unforgettable it was, the dig of Mydei's arousal against his abdomen, seemingly hesitant in the way he chased his pleasure even when Phainon had so graciously guided him to take it.

Phainon remembers the warmth that spilled from in between their bodies amidst the coldness of the bathwater, how it sent his mind reeling, *longing* for it, mourning the fact that such an instance wouldn't ever occur again.

He quickened his pace lest Mydei questioned his prolonged silence, movements growing more erratic as he nears his release, pleasure coursing through his veins spurred on by the mere memory of Mydei's skin against his, the taste of it on his tongue, an addicting ambrosia crafted just for him, and yet bound to offer the bitterest of aftertastes.

Reservations have been put aside, his breaths coming in ragged gasps, escaping his lips unbidden. In his mind, those twin pools of gold would stare him down, beckoning his release —a dangerous delusion bound to be his sole undoing.

Phainon comes with a broken moan, the tip of his reddened cock spurting thick, white fluid into the bathwater, swirling along with the golden shimmer. His vision is blurry with unshed tears as he tries to catch his breath, stroking himself slowly through the aftershocks until his body is wracked with tremors from oversensitivity.

Coming down from the high was never easy, the lust-filled haze clearing away as he's once again reminded of the reality. It is a dangerous habit to keep such fantasies in his head, for there might come a time where he'd rather live in them than face the truth.

No matter how many times Phainon swears that it would be the last time he'll indulge in such pleasures whilst keeping Mydei in mind, he somehow always forgets it the moment that Mydei would simply sneeze in his direction and suddenly, the ache in between his legs becomes too unbearable to ignore.

“—verer? You damn idiot, are you even listening?”

Right. Mydei is still on the call with him.

A part of him wants to simply hang up, unable to continue with the conversation with how mortified he is on what he had just done. But he can’t risk the possibility of Mydei barging in to interrogate him for his lack of manners. Simply ending a call without so much as a goodbye is considered rude, after all.

With a shaky hand, Phainon scrambles to unmute himself. “Yes.” He clears his throat, wincing at how rough his voice sounds. “Still here.”

Mydei sighs. “Well, that’s all I got,” he says. “I can’t say for certain that my methods would work on you or not, but let me know if you plan to try the molten iron bath method. It’s not exactly beginner-friendly, but I think you can manage.”

It is at this moment that Phainon is glad he hadn’t listened to any of Mydei’s advice. He knew Mydei’s suggestions came from a place of goodwill, but there’s simply no way that he’s subjecting himself to an early death. That confirms his hypothesis that Kremnoans are simply *not* human.

“Many thanks, Mydei. I’ll keep your suggestions in mind.”

A hum. “You’re welcome. I’ll see you later with your dinner.”

Phainon’s gut twists, wanting even more for something he can’t have. “You spoil me.”

“Indeed, how magnanimous I am.” The words were said so drily that even Phainon had to crack a smile despite everything. “Goodbye, Deliverer.”

“Goodbye, Mydei.”

The call ends, the invisible golden threads in the air going still. Two tolls of the bell signifying the beginning of two quints of the Parting Hour had come to pass before Phainon left the bath, flushing the used bathwater down the drain in the hopes that it would take with it the proof of his shame.

“Your room is a mess,” is the first thing that Mydei says when Phainon invites him in, right on time just as the Curtain-Fall Hour had begun.

Phainon closes the door. “I don’t think you’re in a position to say that when you can hardly see the floor you walk on in your chambers.”

Mydei chooses not to retort, setting down the tray of food, as well as a jar of what looks to be the Kremnoans’ signature honey brew, upon Phainon’s desk where a bunch of scrolls were unfurled and stone slates were stacked haphazardly.

Phainon offers Mydei a chair, a relic he'd appraised and bought from Theodoros only to find out that it had been a fake—no king of a nation had sat on it while disguised as a commoner as he ate with his servants apparently.

"What have you made for me today?" Phainon asks, the tempting aroma permeating the room as he also takes a seat by the desk beside Mydei, pulling the tray closer to inspect the meal. "Fig stew?"

"Just eat."

Phainon takes the spoon, but not before subjecting Mydei to some teasing. "Are you sure you're not feeding me your own dinner, Mydei?" he asks, knowing that the dish is one of Mydei's favorites. "Were you planning to feed me strange things again and didn't expect I would miss out on the *deipnon?*"

Mydei crosses his arms and legs, eyebrows raised. Sarcastically, he says, "You never fail to see through me, Deliverer. If only you weren't ill, you would be feasting on something much more… *creative*."

"Humor me."

"You really wish to know?" The corner of Mydei's lips curl upward in a smirk, eyes of gold glinting. "Prepare yourself for something very dreadful."

Mydei's answer was not entirely unexpected given how much the other liked to taunt him. Those words serve as nothing more than mere empty threats for Mydei had ceased feeding him atrocities months ago.

"As far as I remember," Phainon began. "I've been out of the city most of the time to even incur your wrath."

"The spar from earlier today was so lousy that I had to call upon twenty of my men back to the training grounds just to make up for it."

"Am I worth twenty men to you, then?"

Mydei shakes his head. "We both know the answer to that. They were of no match to me."

"Right," Phainon says, feeling a rush of pride course through him. "Because *I'm* the only one."

Mydei merely rolls his eyes before leaving his seat, walking over to Phainon's own bookshelf. "You don't mind that I peruse your collection while you partake in your meal, right?"

"Be my guest," Phainon says, now finally having a taste of the fig stew, velvety sauce clinging to the spoon like honey, bursting with that distinct sweet-savory flavor that has Phainon wanting for more. "It tastes good, Mydei."

Mydei was in the middle of unrolling some of the scrolls upon Phainon's shelf, simply making a noncommittal hum at the compliment. Phainon had consumed half of the fig stew in the bowl before the sound of rustling papyrus had stopped, Mydei finally finding something worthy of his attention.

As Phainon ate, his eyes wandered towards Mydei's well-defined body, leaning his weight against the shelves as he read, face devoid of any emotion. Half of Phainon's collection of reading materials are poetry; it would be funny to assume that Mydei cared not for it. He could be reading a tragic poem or a comedy with nary a crease in his fine face.

The fig stew had been consumed all too soon. Whilst wiping his lips with the napkin, the sight of the empty bowl had Phainon wanting seconds. But alas, every serving of food that Mydei provides is 'just enough' to nourish the body.

He abandons his seat in favor of walking towards the other, still absorbed with whatever it is that he's reading, only glancing up when Phainon leans over to take a look at the words written on the papyrus.

"I thought you were reading poetry," Phainon says, realizing that Mydei had gotten his hands on the scroll Aglaea gave him months ago. To say that he forgot entirely about it would be the embarrassing truth.

Mydei returns his gaze back on the page. "This scroll is pretty accurate. Perhaps it is a translation from the one I have in my library."

"Is it?" Phainon asks lamely. How in Amphoreus was he supposed to bring up that he forgot to give it to Mydei all those months ago? "You can… have it. If you wish."

He prepares himself for Mydei to take offense as Aglaea had said, reminding him that Kremnoans do not like it when they're given a scroll about their traditions. But Mydei is quiet, gauntlet-clad hands deftly re-rolling the scroll before placing it back to the wooden case, sealing it shut.

"I suppose you no longer have any need for it," is all that Mydei says before brushing past him, walking back towards the desk to take the jar of honey brew by the handle. "Do you have cups to share a drink with me?"

Phainon glances around. "I have just the one that I procured from Theodoros."

"Is it authentic?"

"I'd rather not talk about that."

Mydei suppresses a smile, his golden eyes simmering with barely-concealed amusement. "It'll do. As long as you don't mind sharing."

It takes a moment for Mydei's words to register, Phainon's mind seemingly unable to grasp that he's about to drink from the same cup as Mydei, the touch of Mydei's lips lingering upon

the bronze surface of the rim for Phainon to savor along with the sweetness of the pomegranate juice.

He wouldn't deny that it's entirely due to selfish reasons, how it didn't require much thought for him to say, "I don't mind."

Mydei's smile grows. Subtle, but Phainon notices it all the same, eyes peeled for every shift in emotion, every minute gesture that Mydei does either unknowingly or deliberately. Phainon appreciates it all, revelling in every single sweeping or tenuous motion that Mydei lets him witness, like a devout believer glorifying every single act of their god.

It's almost criminal that he feels this way for someone he shouldn't even be feeling anything at all, except for that genuine sense of comradeship. But even now, as Mydei beckons him to the balcony, all his heart does is ache with profound longing.

Mydei radiates warmth beside him as they stood by the railing, overlooking the Throne of Worlds in all Their magnificence. The cup is placed between them, just within both of their reach. All Phainon could see is a division, a mark signifying where the boundaries lie, never to be crossed again.

The drink is poured and Mydei gestures for him to have the honors of partaking first, creamy pink liquid swirling in the cup. Phainon takes a small sip, trying to hide the tremble in his hand as his fingers enclose upon the narrow stem. Even the sweetness of it is not enough to wash away the bitter haze that clouded his mind.

"You're thinking again," Mydei says as he takes the cup from Phainon's hold, their fingers brushing against each other albeit briefly, leaving Phainon's skin tingling even if Mydei wore gauntlets to prevent actual contact. "What is it that bothers you so much these days? You mentioned earlier that your thoughts have made your mind weary. Are the suggestions I offered of no help to you?"

"The only thing that caught my attention was the molten iron bath," Phainon says, not entirely a lie for that's really all he remembered considering how… *preoccupied* he was.

Mydei hums, taking a sip of the drink himself before saying, "That's the most effective method of clearing the mind. The pain is enough for you to think of nothing else."

Phainon had not been agreeable to the idea before, but perhaps it *might* actually help.

And then he remembers just a couple of days ago when a Titankin had stabbed him in a non-fatal spot, the pain had been close to unbearable that he arrived at Okhema with his consciousness barely hanging on, slipping from Dorothea's saddle entirely that he had all of the caretakers at the workshop concerned.

Aglaea subsequently had him taken to the infirmary before dumping him in the Heroes' Baths for Kephale's golden blood to soothe his injuries. Even in the throes of pain, the last thing he remembered was wishing for Mydei not to see him in that state.

So, maybe the molten iron bath is a bust. He could never stop thinking about Mydei, could he?

The cup is refilled, and Mydei gestures for him to have his share again. As Phainon takes a sip, Mydei says, “You can confide in me, as I have done with you.”

Even if Phainon is not entirely averse to the idea of sharing *some* of his secrets with Mydei, the current situation doesn’t really give him the option to do so. How does one even begin to confide about their heartache to the person that’s *causing* it?

“It’s nothing,” Phainon says, sliding the cup over to Mydei’s direction. He realizes belatedly that he’d left it empty. “Just thinking about the future.”

The excuse sounds reasonable, a bit of truth to it for Phainon does indeed worry about the days to come, and just the right amount of vagueness to not specify anything at all but enough to sate Mydei’s curiosity.

Mydei refills the cup, silent as he does so. It is only after he’s gotten his fill of the drink that he says, “You are not alone in this regard.”

“I always took you as the ‘live in the moment’ kind of man,” Phainon replies, a tease or a compliment, depending on how Mydei will take it.

Perhaps the latter, for Mydei smiles. “I’d rather not dwell on the past, and the present already has a lot going on with it. The future, however, is mired in endless possibilities.” He turns to Phainon, golden eyes sharp, swirling with an emotion that Phainon couldn’t quite name. “These days, it’s impossible not to think of it excessively.”

As the crown prince of a nation, it would be more worrying if Mydei didn’t care at all for the future of his people. Phainon’s troubles must pale in comparison. And yet, Mydei is still willing to hear him out.

It would’ve been easy, if Phainon were to desire an evil man. His heart and blade has always been guided by justice, and he’d find no reason for his feelings to linger any more than it should if love stood at an opposition.

But Mydei is a good man, a friend, an *equal*—honorable and just. *Beautiful*, devastatingly so. Enough to shred Phainon’s heart into a million pitiful pieces and stretch it thinner than Mnestia’s golden threads.

There’s no evil to blame in this regard, only duty. And what is Phainon if not evil if he were to forsake his role as a hero in favor of pursuing something so selfish as love?

“It’s the last pour,” Mydei says, tilting the jar until all that remained within were but a couple drops of the honey brew. He slides the cup to Phainon’s direction. “Leave half of it for me.”

It’s almost funny how such words relate to Phainon’s thoughts. *Don’t be selfish and drink all of it*. And though he knew that Mydei is generous enough not to mind if Phainon did in fact

drink the rest of it, it would say a lot to how a little sweetness has him forgoing all manners of propriety.

He partakes in the last of his share and leaves the cup half-empty for Mydei. “I apologize for my behavior today. And for… avoiding you weeks prior.”

Mydei is quiet, swirling the drink, the light from Kephale’s Dawn reflecting upon his gauntlets. “I understand that you’re troubled. I thought that sharing a jar of honey brew with me would ease your mind of worries, as it does mine.”

To think that Phainon’s company alone is comforting to Mydei despite the incident from two weeks ago plants a small seedling of hope within him. It makes him want to be honest. Not a single ounce of alcohol were in their drink, but Phainon could almost imagine that he possessed the brash confidence of a drunken man.

“So, this is your way of offering me consolation without knowing what upsets me?” Phainon asks, a teasing smile on his lips as he nudges Mydei lightly.

Mydei retaliates with a sharp jab of his elbow against Phainon’s arm followed by a glare. “You almost made me spill the drink,” he admonishes. “And I’d rather try to console you than see you moping around like a kicked chimera. Even Lady Tribios and Aglaea made several mentions of your foul mood. The other day, you almost made Castorice cry because, and I quote, ‘Lord Phainon kept frowning while we talked. I must’ve done something to offend him.’”

Phainon reddens out of embarrassment. Faintly, he manages to say, “I’ll never be mad at Castorice. What made her think that I was?”

“How should I know? If anything, I ought to punch you on the face for causing her distress. She’s already been through so much and you just had to make it worse.”

With his elbows against the railing and head in his hands, Phainon groans. “I’ll… make amends.” He peeks at Mydei in between his fingers. “Did you comfort her in my stead?”

“She’s my friend. Of course, I did.” Mydei takes a swig at the cup, the bob of his throat as he swallowed causing Phainon’s mind to go blank. “Get a hold of yourself, Deliverer. If the honey brew is not enough to ease your troubled mind, let me know at this instant and I shall try something else instead.”

Mydei’s lips glistened as he spoke, remnants of the drink yet to be licked away. Phainon can’t seem to force his eyes to look elsewhere, drawn to the mesmerizing plushness, bewitching him until the end of his days.

“There’s only one way to console me,” Phainon says, wistful. Both of his hands grip the railing if only to have something to hold on to. “But, I’m afraid it’s far beyond my reach at the moment.”

A light frown graces Mydei’s face. “You waste time with your roundabout words. Tell me directly, what is it?”

You, Phainon thinks without much delay, no considerations needed. *I long for your skin against mine, for your touch to linger until your warmth seeps into my very soul, and I can no longer distinguish one from the other. Since realizing this, every single day that I live without it has been miserable. And I hope to respect your wishes, I* really *do, but—*

"Phainon?"

A meaningless name. And yet, hearing it being uttered by Mydei's lips alone causes his heart to be twisted and pulled in several different directions.

"How could you call me so sweetly, and still expect me to be sane?"

Mydei's eyes widen, pools of gold reflecting the visage of someone undeserving of his attention. And yet, Phainon still makes an attempt to reach out, one hand raised until the tips of his fingers were but a small distance away from Mydei's face.

Phainon hesitates, but before he could let his hand fall, Mydei catches it with his own, the metal of his gauntlet cold, bringing Phainon's limp hand to continue a journey it had forsaken. The cup topples over to the ground, spilling the remaining honey brew it held within, but neither of them seemed to take notice.

This time, Phainon's feverish palm gently brushes against the soothingly cool skin of Mydei's fair face, bearing no flaws, cupping his cheek as if it were the finest of porcelains in all the land, more precious than gems and gold, even wisdom. Mydei leans into the touch, and Phainon feels as if all air in his lungs were stolen by Zagreus Themself.

"Mydei—"

"It's fine."

Phainon is not inclined to believe as such when his fingers brush against the large hoop earring hanging upon Mydei's left ear. The mere act of Mydei nuzzling into his hand is enough to send him to the afterlife.

"You're going to kill me, Mydeimos." It's the truth. And, "I spilled the honey brew."

The curved corner of Mydei's lips is grazed ever so lightly by the skin of Phainon's palm. And it makes Phainon wonder if such profound contentment comes with the feeling of holding one's world in his own hand. Perhaps he should ask the imposing figure of the Throne of Worlds lording over them.

"I've had my fill," Mydei tells him, the usual sharpness in his eyes softening, almost fond, *vulnerable*. "Did you want more of it?"

"From the first day we met, you know I could never get enough."

Phainon didn't even realize until now how close they've gotten, words spoken in whispers like secrets for only the two of them to share with no one but Kephale as their sole witness.

Mydei's forehead rests against his, the gold in his eyes flickering with an unspoken emotion. "Insatiable. Do you plan to lick it off the floor, then?"

"No." A wave of boldness encompasses Phainon, spurred solely by Mydei's touch. "But I do wonder, does the taste of the honey brew still linger on your lips?"

The silence stretches for an unknown period of time, enough for Phainon's resolve to waver, but not so that clarity invades his mind. How could it, when Mydei is so within reach? As he waited for an answer, not once did he expect for his patience to be rewarded tenfold.

He could feel Mydei's other hand upon his waist, yanking him closer that the tips of their noses bump lightly against one other.

"Why don't you find out?"

Phainon did not let the words hang in the air for more than a single moment, Oronyx's Time not to be wasted. There's no way to tell who among them had leaned in first, but the softness of Mydei's lips against his was enough to render all of Phainon's thoughts to be nonexistent.

A quick breath, hitched, before Phainon tilts his head, pressing Mydei gently against the railing, hands covering the small of Mydei's back to soften the uncomfortable dig of the stone edge.

He swallows down the muffled gasp that escapes Mydei's lips when he pressed upon a certain spot above the base of his spine, sharp claws digging mercilessly upon Phainon's shoulders. The sting of it is a dizzying contrast to the sweetness on his tongue. For Mydei to inflict both pain and pleasure even now only serves to leave Phainon wanting, no longer heeding to the calls of selfless virtue, or the heavy weight of duty that bears down upon them both.

At this moment, Phainon only *wants*, kissing Mydei fervidly, trying to sate his desire as much as he could with every slide of their lips against each other, the rough clack of teeth, licking into Mydei's mouth like a man who had first gotten a taste of ambrosia, excessively greedy for more, bound to yearn for it for the rest of his life.

It's overwhelming, to finally get a taste of what could only be considered as a fanciful dream —to be able to hold Mydei so close a second time, and be held just as ardently in return. Such warmth is enough to keep the cold at bay, a flame that burns away all the burdens, reducing it to nothing but ashes.

The softness of Mydei's lips, plush against his own, is addicting to a fault, bound to haunt Phainon in every waking and sleeping moment that he does not feel it, the sensation already ingrained upon the cracks and crevices of Phainon's lips. Every intentioned press, wet and lingering, is certain to leave a sting that would never quite go away, soothed only by the one that bestowed it.

He readily consumes every groan and sound coming from the depths of Mydei's throat, replying with ones of his own, uncaring of how desperate he seemed, the fact proven long ago with the way he kept Mydei close as if he'd loathe for them to separate.

Just as Phainon professes his prayers to the Titans for this moment to never end, a hand on his chest gently pushes him away, and Phainon could only be led by it despite the incessant need thrumming in his veins. At the end of the day, he could only be obedient to every single one of Mydei's wishes even if it brings such profound and unbearable ache to part after being so close that they're practically one.

A string of saliva connects their lips, shimmering against the light bore by Kephale, but not so enduring as a golden thread, dissipating quicker as Phainon's wits had abandoned him. His heart thumps wildly in his chest, Mydei's hand pressed above it, as if to stake claim to what already belongs to him.

Phainon relishes in the sight of Mydei's lips, swollen and slicked, redder than ever before. His chest heaves in the same manner as Phainon's does, unmarred tanned skin streaked in scarlet. Phainon itches to run his tongue across the vastness of it, as if he would only be able to be satisfied once all of Mydei had been devoured by him.

"Let's—" Mydei's voice is rough, low with unspoken need. "Let's stop here for now."

For now.

Phainon would be a fool to take it as a promise. But that won't stop him from hoping nonetheless. *Hoping* that there would be a second time. A third. A fourth. Until he could barely count how many instances he'd been able to indulge in whatever it is that Mydei is willing to give him. And for every single one of them, Phainon would offer a thousand prayers expressing his gratitude.

Not to the gods. But to the man before him.

Mydei takes Phainon's chin in between his fingers, pressing upon them until the pain sings through the latter's body, pulling him out of his reverie.

"What was that for?" Phainon asks, almost petulant, taking Mydei's hand in his if only to stop the other from pinching his chin further.

"You have that look on you," Mydei says. "Stop thinking."

"Of *you?* Easier said than done."

Mydei scoffs, feigning offense as he peels himself away from Phainon's hold, placing a much more respectable distance between them.

"It's good to see you in good spirits at last, Deliverer. But keep the jests minimal. It's a rather long drop from your balcony lest my hands *slip*."

Phainon smiles sheepishly, the tingling sensation on his lips making him very giddy despite the threat that Mydei just threw at him. "I guess your methods of comfort worked. Consider me comforted."

A huff. "*Haikas*."

“You still haven’t told me what that word means.”

Instead of a reply, Mydei turns away from him, walking back into Phainon’s chambers, the latter trailing after him like a chimera highly dependent on its owner.

Mydei picks up the tray on Phainon’s desk as well as the scroll detailing Kremnoan traditions. To Phainon, who stood still in the middle of the room like a statue, he says, “You can find the meaning of it on your own. But for now—” His gaze drops down to the tent in between Phainon’s legs, a smirk on his lips. “—you might want to take care of *that*.”

Before Phainon could get a word in, Mydei had already left, taking away Phainon’s pride with him.

This time, the warmth that Mydei leaves in his wake lingers, the scent of pomegranates permeating the air. That alone is enough.

Chapter End Notes

next chapter, i'll give the audience what they want… mweheheh— *coughs because smut will be the bane of my existence but i want to write phaidei fucking so bad with the vision that i have in my mind that i gotta lock in somehow*

▶ 🌟 **yap and reference/s**

thank you so so much for reading and for your patience!! i appreciate every single one of your kudos and comments aaa thank you so very much for them!! i love you guys

Chapter 9: unknowing oath, union bound by blood

Chapter Summary

> As the Month of Joy comes around, everyone is inclined to indulge in the revelry. And Phainon is of no exception.

Chapter Notes

> ▶ ⚠️ **click for chapter warnings** (might contain spoilers)
>
> special thanks to tojikunas, _yn319, and rxnneeshii for their wonderful depictions this chapter's ending scene: tojikuna's art, _yn319's art, and rxnneeshii's art.
>
> go check them out if you haven't yet!! 💗

See the end of the chapter for more notes

pillar season, month of joy

4 months before the present time

On the eve of the Festival of Phagousa, Okhema was understandably in a state of bustling activity even up until the final quints of the Parting Hour, all in preparation for the upcoming banquet.

Crimson silk cloth wrapped around lapis lazuli columns, the usual blue fabric draped from ceiling arches and winding around the sides of the walls now replaced with gold ones, and the edges of the lounge areas covered in red and blue velvety cloth complemented with elaborate, gold brocade runners.

Ornate chalices and fruit plates were being arranged upon trays and several attendants tended to the baths to clear up the shimmering waters of any impurities, muttering prayers to Phagousa as they did so. By the elevated section of the Nerid Spring, just below the Heroes' Baths, a temporary platform was situated to host the orchestra, several musical instruments already in their rightful stations.

Even the Kremnoans avidly helped with the decor despite their differences with the Okhemans, who at first showed signs of apprehension. When the Kremnoans proved their

contributions to be rather tasteful, the Okhemans were left with no words to say, silence as a way of conveying their apology, and in a way, a show of gratitude for the help.

It was quite surprising, how centuries of bad blood between two nations are fixed for a shared desire to hold a grand harvest feast honoring the Chalice of Plenty.

Phainon admires Aglaea's insight, it was her idea after all for the Kremnoans to celebrate alongside the Okhemans. Not even the Elders could forbid the Kremnoans from participating for Phagousa's waters aim to welcome all, and it is *still* technically an *Okheman* feast—a loophole in the new policy that Aglaea sought to exploit.

The preparations lasted for several days. Phainon had only seen mere glimpses of Mydei in the hubbub before he was whisked away by citizens asking for his help in sampling produce, carrying boxes filled with harvests of the season, and whatever else Phainon could lend a hand in just to ease the people's burdens.

Right now, he finds himself with Castorice, both of them currently seated at a giant lilypad at the Garden of Life, deftly folding colorful paper into shapes resembling that of flower blossoms meant to float upon the bath's surface during the feast. It had been enchanted with Aglaea's golden threads to ensure durability and to keep it dry enough so its shape would hold.

Compared to the strenuous labor Phainon had endured for the entire day, the act of folding paper is a stark contrast, almost soothing. Not to mention, Phainon is more than happy that he gets to spend time with a dear friend.

"This is the last of it, Lord Phainon," Castorice tells him, gently placing the final blossom paper in front of them, her pile of flowers crisply folded with nary any creases laying beside Phainon's. It was rather easy to distinguish who had made which pile.

Phainon takes a paper blossom in his hand, one of his creations. It's a far cry from the flawless ones Castorice had made—his work a mess of unequal petals, folding mistakes shown through visible lines that were not supposed to exist.

With a sad frown, Phainon says, "I'm glad to be of help, Miss Castorice." He then returns the blossom back to his pile. "Although, I don't think I've done a good job."

Castorice only smiled reassuringly. "It would have taken me much longer to work on these if you weren't here, Lord Phainon."

"You're too kind."

"The festival for this year is bound to be livelier than the previous ones," Castorice says in an attempt to change the topic before Phainon could have the chance to take his own pile of paper flowers and redo every single one of them. "Lord Mydei's people seem to be looking forward to it."

Upon the mention of Mydei, Phainon perks up. "To think that all it takes for Kremnoans and Okhemans to treat each other amicably is a shared harvest feast."

“Indeed.” Castorice’s smile fades. “I do wish the Elders would revoke the policy. I admire Lord Mydei and his people for handling the situation so calmly.”

Phainon nods sullenly. He has submitted several appeals toward the Council. But as expected, his missives have been deliberately ignored. Even Mydei told him to simply give it a rest—no point in reasoning with a wall, is what he said. The brute allegations against the Kremnoans needed to be put into question as soon as possible.

“It’s a good thing Aglaea kept the situation under wraps,” Phainon says. “I haven’t heard anything about the Elders’ new policy circulating around the rumor mill. Even the Verax Leos have kept their mouths shut.”

If the Okhemans were to find out that the Kremnoans wished to defy the Elders’ orders by celebrating their harvest feast despite the restrictions, they wouldn’t be merrily comparing fabric materials to drape around the Marmoreal Palace and sampling the Kremnoans’ pomegranate juice meant to be served during the festival.

No. There would be a *riot*.

“Lady Aglaea is thorough as always,” Castorice says. “I hope Lord Mydei and his people would enjoy the Okheman harvest feast regardless.”

Phainon hums in agreement, a fluttering sensation in his stomach. Mydei’s name simply had that effect on him these days.

“With such liveliness, I have every reason to believe that he’d simply stay in a corner and witness the revelry with a frown on his face, arms crossed and everything.” Phainon attempts to make a disgruntled sound, failing spectacularly with how much he’s trying not to smile, a warm fondness in his heart. “You know how he is.”

Castorice suppresses a giggle. “The Festival of Phagousa is the grandest event of the year. It would be a shame if Lord Mydei wouldn’t be able to experience it fully.” Her purple eyes glint with an unspoken mischief. “You should show him how to have a good time, Lord Phainon.”

Phainon scoffs, cheeks reddening as he avoids Castorice’s gaze. “We’d just end up arguing if I force him. That guy doesn’t know fun even if it punched him in the face.”

That, and Phainon simply doesn’t know how to deal with Mydei after their… last encounter. Even until now, his lips still tingled just from the memory of it, and it’s been *days* since. *Four Entry Hours* to be exact. It’s rather fortunate that Mydei has been busy with Kremnoan matters to even have the time to grace Phainon with his presence.

“I’m sure Lord Mydei would make an exception if it’s you.”

Phainon frowns. “But I promised to keep you company, considering you can’t even partake in the feast.”

Castorice shakes her head. “I’ll be alright, Lord Phainon. I thank you immensely for your consideration all these years,” she assures. “However, it is Lord Mydei’s first ever harvest feast since he and his people came here to Okhema. Such an occasion ought to be memorable.”

Mydei might not even care so much about the harvest feast considering how willing he was to simply forgo it. He agreed to join the Festival of Phagousa to appease his people from an unjust policy, and even then, it only serves as a temporary solution.

Phainon sighs. Castorice does have her rare moments of persistence. He could never bear to turn her down.

“Alright. I’ll make sure Mydei doesn’t keep to himself tomorrow.”

Castorice’s expression softens. But before she could utter a reply, her posture went rigid, attention directed at something behind Phainon—rather, some*one* judging from the sound of steady footfalls growing louder.

Phainon turns around, his smile fading away slowly from his face when he sees who it was that’s currently walking towards them.

Krateros had his usual severe expression as he approached, escorted by two guards trailing closely behind him. A quick look at their uniforms alone, one is able to deduce that they serve the Council of Elders rather than the Chrysos Heirs.

Both Phainon and Castorice stand up to address the Kremnoan.

“Lord Krateros,” Phainon greets, trying to keep his tone respectful in the hopes that the older would forget his past insolence. “To what do we owe the pleasure?”

Krateros nods at him lightly in acknowledgement before turning his attention at Castorice. “Lady Castorice, would you mind if I borrow Lord Phainon for a moment?”

At the question, Phainon can’t help but think that his ears have failed him. Since *when* did Krateros address him as such? All he recalls were the words ‘boy’ and ‘foolish child’ accompanied by flashing eyes and admonishing words. From the back of his head, he begins to feel a distinct phantom pain, brought only to life by memories from more than a month ago.

Their last conversation hadn’t really ended well. Perhaps it’s because of the guards that the Kremnoan had to be on his best behavior considering how the Elders could easily escalate trifling matters in the pretense of justice.

Castorice’s eyes dart between Krateros and Phainon, her unease palpable, aware of the supposed animosity of the former against the latter.

“If Lord Phainon permits it, then…”

Krateros turns his gaze towards Phainon, considerate enough to not urge Castorice to continue if it brings her great discomfort.

“I wish to speak to you in private,” Krateros says gruffly. “If you’re amenable.”

Phainon almost falls off from the lilypad out of shock. “Of course, Lord Krateros.”

Krateros then beckons him to the floating platform that leads to the grounds outside of the Marmoreal Palace. There’s an absence of small talk as they descended. Phainon deduces that it’s due to the guards breathing down their necks, evidently inclined to eavesdrop and take note of every word that escapes their lips just to report it to their superiors.

At a secluded spot, Krateros leans close, subtle when he whispers, “Follow my lead.”

As the words register in his mind, Krateros had already attacked one of the guards. It takes a moment for Phainon to realize what the older had wanted him to do and lunges towards the other one, swift enough to knock him out before he could even alert some unwitting bystander.

In barely any time at all, two limp bodies were dragged against the corner of a wall, inconspicuous enough that not even passersby would notice unless they took a second glance.

Krateros chuckles, eyes crinkling as he firmly pats Phainon on the shoulder for a job well done. “Not bad, hero of Okhema.”

Phainon laughs alongside him nervously, mind still reeling from what he just did. He’s pretty sure it warrants a punishment, but who is he to spoil an old man’s fun?

“If they were Aglaea’s people,” he began, surprised at his own behavior of beating up guards in the side of justice (debatable considering they serve the Elders, who were far from being just). “I would’ve done no such thing, to be honest.”

Krateros sighs. “I know, I know.” He glances at the unconscious guards and shrugs. “Eh, you don’t have to worry about these two weaklings. No one saw what we did, they have no evidence if they were to tattle to the Elders.”

“I see that you’ve thought this through.”

“With no question.”

Phainon still had his apprehensions but doesn’t push further. “Lord Krateros, I must admit that I’m quite curious as to why you wish to speak to me given our previous… *encounter*.”

“Right.” Krateros’ eyebrows furrow in thought. “As you’ve seen, the young master has already informed the detachment of the changes in regards to tomorrow’s occasion. Even if the young master hadn’t mentioned it, I have every right to believe that my assault against you was to blame for the Council to retaliate as such.”

“The Council favors neither Kremnoans nor the Chrysos Heirs,” Phainon reiterates.

He and Krateros both have their own share of faults in the matter, but he wanted to make it clear that it wouldn’t have made a difference if they ended up destroying a city or simply had

a light argument comparable to what a merchant would have with a cheapskate buyer.

The Elders were bound to choose a severe punishment if given the opportunity. It's just in their nature to be petty like that.

"They did this for themselves," Phainon continues, referring to the corrupted minds that unfortunately held a significant power of governance over Okhema. "It's simply their way of flaunting their influence. Even Aglaea wouldn't go so far as to hinder your traditions."

Krateros purses his lips. "I am well aware."

"...Oh."

"I'm not here to apologize," the older adds.

"I didn't expect you to," Phainon tells him. "And I'm not going to do so either."

Krateros nods, a hint of pride instead of offense in his lone dark eye. "I'm glad that we can both stand by our own opinions firmly enough to not be sorry for them."

Phainon would argue that his own opinions seemed more reasonable than Krateros,' but he's well aware that this is neither the time nor the place to recommence another round of debate. Without Mydei to mediate between them, things could go south pretty fast. Today, Phainon decides to take the high road.

"Is that all you wish to say to me? You opt to agree to disagree?"

Krateros shakes his head. "No. I'm here to let you know that—" He then pauses rather abruptly, interrupting his words with a heavy sigh as he uncharacteristically avoids eye contact. There's a slight hesitation in his words when he continues, "I will think through what you said that day some more."

Not like Phainon expected Krateros to immediately have a change of heart— Wait.

What?

"What?" he squawks.

Phainon had expected Krateros to simply say yes and leave. That, or he gets offended by assuming that Phainon thinks his time is being wasted for an inconsequential talk that didn't even resolve anything. Even if such a sentiment is unavoidable, he didn't expect Krateros' response to blindside him like this.

"Don't make me repeat myself, boy." Krateros crosses his arms. So the respectful address from earlier is only because of the presence of surveillance. "I accept *you*, and your naive opinions." Then he adds, as if it were an afterthought. "The latter, I will ponder some more."

"Oh. I—" Phainon tries to make himself sound more eloquent, struggling with how best to express himself. This is Mydei's teacher for Titans' sake. The least he could do is conduct himself with grace. "I'm surprised?"

Krateros scoffs, more amused than anything. Which should be a good sign, Phainon supposes. “What a candid reaction. You really are different from the others who have sought the young master’s favor.”

“Is that a bad thing?” Phainon asks faintly.

“I can’t say for now.”

“So,” Phainon feels his heart thud in his chest, beating with hope. “You’ll take Mydei’s wishes into consideration? Will he be able to confide in you at last without the worries of being misunderstood?”

Krateros nods once. “I will lend an ear, and my counsel shall remain unbiased. Although, regardless of what I say, the young master and I know that *he* will always be free to do whatever he wants. If he wishes to relinquish his claim to the throne, I cannot stop him. He’s just respectful enough to take into account the opinions of an old man such as I.”

“You are his teacher,” Phainon says. “Of course your guidance means a lot to him.”

“You are very sentimental. Kremnoans have no need for that.” Krateros pauses. “But I can see that you embody the Virtues of Nikador, enough to bestow my respect.”

Phainon thinks he’s hearing things for the second time that day. Unless he’s sorely mistaken, those words sounded like a compliment.

Krateros continues, “I had my apprehensions when the young master invited you to the Rite of Parting several months ago, but Mydeimos always has had a good perception when it comes to people.” He places a hand on Phainon’s shoulder and squeezes. “I’m keeping an eye on you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. You have earned something I don’t give away so freely to just anyone—my *trust*. Do not take it for granted.”

It’s quiet then, as Phainon tries to have a grasp on the situation. The weight of Krateros’ hand upon his shoulder bears a certain distinct heaviness, pressuring him to adhere to a responsibility that need not be spoken out loud, one that he’s more than willing to take on.

Krateros withdraws his hand with a huff at Phainon’s lack of response, his initial show of pride now replaced with exasperation. “Speak, boy! This is hardly an easy conversation to have. The least you could do is nod or fall dead.”

Phainon’s voice thankfully returns. “T-Thank you so much, Lord Krateros!” he says breathlessly, still in a state of perpetual shock. “Your acceptance means a lot to me, and Mydei would no doubt show his appreciation as well—”

“You are to keep this conversation a secret from the young master for the time being,” Krateros interrupts. “I wish to have a talk with him as well after this before the morrow comes.”

“I see,” Phainon says. “My lips are sealed.”

Krateros merely nods, turning his attention towards the foggy horizon. Somewhere out there, the mobile nation of Castrum Kremnos remains lost to this day. The lone eye of the warrior belied a hint of wistfulness, a longing for his home. Somehow, he looked accepting to put aside his desires to return to an age of glory—a decision made to trust in his prince who had no interest in the king's crown.

"I have taken up too much of your time," Krateros says after a brief moment of silence. "I should return to the settlement. There's still so much to do for tomorrow."

Like a habit, Phainon is compelled to ask, "Do you need help?"

Krateros scoffs. "You insult me. Hasn't His Highness informed you that such matters are not for you to bother yourself with?"

Right. It's evident that outsiders are not to meddle. And yet, Phainon keeps forgetting such a simple rule. Kremnoans have their pride after all.

"Yes," Phainon agrees amicably in place of insistence. "Mydei did say something of the sort."

Krateros tuts. "Foolish boy. And yet, the young master favors you immensely." He gives Phainon a long look. "Mydeimos puts a great amount of trust in you. Do not betray him, or it is my blade that will seek to slice your throat."

The threat is somehow expected. Instead of taking offense, Phainon merely smiles. After all, there is *nothing* to worry about.

"I would never," he says guilelessly. "Mydei is important to me. His trust is something I value more than any kind of riches in this dying world."

"Words mean nothing," the older tells him. Despite his curt response, his expression has softened. "The duty of taking care of the crown prince is one that I will never forsake."

Poised to leave, Krateros stops just beside Phainon, standing together on equal footing. And though they faced opposing directions, it is at this moment that their goals have simply aligned.

"That duty of mine," Krateros continues. "I now willingly share with you."

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For a couple to be bound in life and in death, courtship should last no less than six months. *The term 'marriage' is sparsely used, for Kremnoans favor a much more generalistic way of referring to it:* ***a union of equals.***

...unions involving royalty tend to be celebrated with sincere gifts followed by a parade from the outskirts of the capital to the inner city where a lavish banquet is held. The proceedings should be arranged with thorough consideration by the courted alone.

The nation honors the newly-bound with their offerings, and the newly-bound honors the nation in return with their acceptance. *Wise leaders would know better than to abuse the show of abundance. It is said that if a penny offered is returned in equal value or more, the nation shall prosper.*

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Traditions: Culture and Customs throughout History

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"It is time, Deliverer," is the first thing that Mydei says when Phainon opens the door for him.

The second quint of the Lucid Hour had barely even begun. Fortunately, Phainon rose early to prepare himself for the Festival of Phagousa, just in case his assistance was still needed for some last-minute requests.

He had only finished tying the straps of his sandals against his shin when a knock had resounded from his door and Mydei's presence served as his morning benediction. Phainon could already tell that the day is bound to be a good one.

Mydei is draped in regal elegance with a gold silken chiton, looking as radiant as ever, even more so than usual actually. But Phainon would argue that every passing day that he sets his sights on Mydei, the latter's beauty only grows, like a flower destined to bloom for eternity, never to wilt until the end of times.

And though Phainon wonders if Mydei's elaborate garment would be alright to wear in an event that involves bathing, he voices none of his concerns, well aware that he's the furthest to question a person's outfit choices.

He could only hope that he looks presentable enough in Mydei's eyes as well. Aglaea had already prepared a chiton for him beforehand—finely woven linen dyed navy blue, every edge bordered with hand-stitched, golden embroidery, cinched at the waist with a matching golden belt encrusted with sapphire inlays.

"Mydei," he greets, the smile on his lips an easy one, barely requiring much thought. "Isn't it too early? The festival doesn't start until the Action Hour."

Mydei does not return his smile. "If we are to elude the Elders' notice, it is advisable to begin the ceremony at a much earlier time."

"Oh."

And then it clicks: Mydei is inviting *him* to celebrate the Kremnoans' harvest feast despite the restrictions. Perhaps the Festival of Phagousa alone was not enough. Phainon is thankful

nonetheless that Mydei is willing to include him after days of treating him as if he had committed a crime if he so much as helped a Kremnoan carry a barrel of pomegranate juice.

He steps out of the room and closes the door behind him. “Very well.”

Mydei then leads the way, their hands brushing slightly against each other as they walked. It takes every ounce of restraint to not reach out and take Mydei’s hand in his, to hold on to it as if it was the lone rope that Phainon direly clings upon as he dangles from the edge of a cliff.

The last time he held any part of Mydei was when they kissed—a memory that remains fresh in his mind, one he’s never bound to forget even if the nether realm and the high heavens were to meet and reduce the land to a mere lifeless crust.

The act of reliving it, no matter how many times, never takes away the blissful traces that continue to linger in his thoughts during his waking moments. In his dreams, there are admittedly the occasional nightmares. But the feeling of Mydei’s lips against his, the warmth of it, is enough to shine light to the darkness that plagued his sleep.

Lost in his own thoughts, Phainon only realizes halfway through the journey that Mydei was leading him towards the Kremnoan detachment’s settlement. Mydei had been quiet the whole time, perhaps also preoccupied by thoughts so deep that the urge to start a conversation had escaped him fully. Not like Mydei was proficient when it came to initiating small talk in the first place.

Only upon nearing the settlement did Mydei speak at last. “Each Kremnoan household had prepared gifts for us,” he says. “We are to accept them together.”

Though it’s surprising for Kremnoans to do such a thing, it’s not unheard of for Chrysos Heirs to receive tributes during the Month of Joy—a gesture of thanks from the citizens for a year’s worth of protection. For Mydei to invite him specifically, perhaps the assumption that the Kremnoans have grown to favor him all these months is not entirely unfounded.

“I would be honored.”

Mydei gives him a small smile, a sight that makes Phainon’s heart flutter in his chest. Really, he ought to bid farewell to his pride if Mydei were to be made aware of the effect he had on him.

Men, women, and children await their arrival, crates situated in front of every household as they positioned themselves in a semi-circle. Mydei leads Phainon to the first one, a family of three brothers by the far left.

“My lords, here I present to you the finest shields we’ve crafted,” the young man says. From the looks of it, he seems to be the eldest. “Only the finest of materials have been used. May it protect you from battle.”

Phainon marvels at the handiwork. Such craftsmanship could even be comparable to that of Chartonus.’ It’s not a lie that he expected the gifts to be something more… *harvest-related*.

But Kremnoans are known to integrate the concept of war in their traditions, Phainon shouldn't be surprised by this at all.

"Thank you," Phainon says. "I'll make good use of these."

Mydei nods beside him. "It is impressive. You have my sincerest gratitude."

They move on to the next one. This time, a lone sword sits within the crate in front of an old man and his wife. Even with the absence of armor, Phainon could deduce that he'd been a formidable warrior in his prime. The old man takes the sword from the crate and presents it to him, who does the honors of pulling the blade out of its sheath.

"I heard that Lord Phainon favors the sword more than any other weapon," the old man says. "Please accept this humble offering of mine. 'Tis an heirloom passed down from nine generations and has seen many victories. I have no children to speak of, hence why I wish for his lordship to inherit the legacy of my family."

Phainon sees his face reflected upon the blade, feeling his hands quiver upon realizing the value of such a gift. "Can I really take this?"

His nerves have become alight with worry, apprehensive if he should have something so significant—if he's even *worthy*. Just then, a warm hand settles at the small of his back and he turns to Mydei. Those eyes of gold gleamed with something more than just mere encouragement, a nod to reassure him that it's alright.

It is then that Phainon finds his doubts thoroughly cleansed away.

The old man laughs good-naturedly. "My lord, my bloodline would only know honor if you were to accept."

"Thank you kindly. I will take care of it." Phainon only lets out a shaky exhale as he slides the sword back in its sheath. "The battles it will take on shall not sully the good name of your family, for I ensure that it'll only see victory from here on out."

The old man and his wife seemed satisfied, beaming at him with pride in realization that their decisions had been the right one. Phainon is not sure if he'll be able to take much more societal pressure for the rest of the day after that. Fortunately, the next crate of offerings is much more conventional for the Month of Joy.

"The finest harvests from my family's vegetable garden," the Kremnoan says, holding his husband and daughter close. "We are aware that this meager offering is not that impressive in comparison to others, but we are very proud of it."

Phainon fails to see how such a bountiful harvest from a garden is considered 'meager.' If anything, the contents of the crate is comparable to the ones that Aglaea receives from the noble families of Okhema during both the Month of Joy and Reaping.

Mydei leans down and inspects the produce before nodding in satisfaction. He gives the family a smile of his own. "There is no such thing as unimpressive in a ceremony such as

this. You take pride in your work, that alone is enough."

As they move on to the next, something shiny catches Phainon's eye from within the crate. What he saw had his jaw going slack.

"Gemstones that I have accumulated from my time as a miner in Kremnos," the woman says. "The ones I offer before you are the finest cuts that I have in my treasury. My lords, this is the only thing of value I possess that I could offer you."

Even Mydei stood still as a statue, lips slightly parted as he stared at the dazzling trove within the crate, nestled in coarse straw for protection, a faint mineral tang mingling with the air.

Phainon takes a sapphire in hand, lifting it up so it catches the light from Kephale's Dawn, splintering it into deep flashes of royal blue. He watches carefully as the color shifts with every angle, keeping a keen eye to discern its genuity.

As he did so, he could see Mydei's image through the polished facets, appearing distant, almost dreamlike—a reflection warped and tinted in deep blue hues. It makes Phainon wonder how Mydei would look swathed in azure jewels, a stark contrast to the rubies that adorned his usual accessories.

"Is it to your liking?" Mydei asks.

"Only such unparalleled magnificence for you, my lords," the Kremnoan woman adds, just in case Phainon needed more convincing.

Lowering the gem, Mydei's visage is now clear to see. Phainon's gaze holds steady, eyes meeting molten gold as he says, "Indeed. A beauty so unparalleled it has completely stolen my breath."

With those words, Phainon did not speak of gemstones, smiling when Mydei's face reddens, the realization expressed so openly. He returns the sapphire to the crate, satisfied with his appraisal. Such treasures fail to tempt him as much as the man who led him to the next crate with a gentle countenance and a warm hand that had never left the small of his back since it made its presence known.

He and Mydei accepted more gifts from the Kremnoans, more than what Phainon had initially expected to receive—blank papyrus and quills, fresh eggs and live poultry, a newly-born calf spawned from strong, native Kremnoan cows. A couple households even offered up freshly harvested pomegranates. Idaeus himself gifted three barrels filled with honey brew.

Even as a relatively popular Chrysos Heir, the extent of the offerings he had received in the prior years couldn't even begin to compare.

After that, Mydei instructs Praxis and the other soldiers to handle the gifts—the animals returned to their fenced pastures, the produce divided amongst all households, a pouch of jewels distributed fairly to every family head, while the rest of it, alongside the weapons, to be secured safely until either Phainon or Mydei were to fetch them.

With so many Kremnoans still at the settlement, Phainon expected all of them to make their way to Marmoreal Palace together with the Festival of Phagousa scheduled to begin in only a quint from now.

Nevertheless, it still caught him by surprise how the Kremnoans were trailing after him and Mydei with a distinct formation, carrying banners and baskets of fruits, predominantly pomegranates, like they were in some sort of a bizarre parade. Perhaps it's not so strange for warriors to behave so orderly.

It didn't take long for them to arrive at the entrance of the Marmoreal Palace, the Kremnoans beginning to disperse from behind them to join in the festivities.

"Were you satisfied?" Mydei asks him. "The pre-banquet ceremony still adhered to the traditions. If we were in Kremnos, I have no doubts that it would've taken us an entire day to make our way from the outskirts of the city to the inner capital."

Phainon huffs out a laugh. "A whole day of accepting gifts? That doesn't sound too bad," he jeers. "I must admit, I never expected the Kremnoans to practice such a custom."

He had the impression that Kremnoans didn't care much for material gains. But the Month of Joy is known for blessing everyone with abundance so perhaps it is not at all that surprising. Kremnoans are relatively nice and generous if you know how to deal with them.

(Exhibit A: The Crown Prince)

Just as Mydei was about to open his mouth to respond, the bells toll signalling the beginning of the Action Hour; it's time for the Festival of Phagousa to begin.

"Should we head in?" Phainon asks.

Mydei squints at him. "I'm surprised you have the patience to partake in the revelry."

"Only because the Festival of Phagousa has proven to be quite enjoyable from my previous years of experience since coming to Okhema. Much more so now that the Kremnoans have entered the picture. The more the merrier, as they say."

"I have no interest in banquets, I'm sure the same applies to you."

Typical Mydei to want nothing to do with socializing. Phainon can't help but smile, utterly enamored with this man. "*You're* the one who wants to skip the feast, not me."

Mydei reddens as he looks away, arms crossed. "I do not wish to lie, so I won't say anything to confirm nor deny your assumption."

Phainon laughs. "Mydei, you worked so hard to contribute with the preparations. The least you could do is savor the fruits of your labor. Isn't that what the Month of Joy is all about?"

That, and Castorice won't ever let Phainon live it down if he failed to show Mydeimos the Unhappy a good time.

Mydei seems to consider it. After a moment, he eventually acquiesces. “Fine.”

He then walks towards the waterfall without waiting for Phainon, the cascade parting in the middle and granting them entry. Even from the lobby, the chatter coming from the baths could already be heard, the sound bouncing through walls in excited echoes.

When they finally pass through the second curtain of flowing water, the sight of the Nerid Spring packed to the brim is the first thing that greets them. Citizens from all walks of life gathered in colorful chitons, like lilies sprouting from the waters, all basking in the revelry, indulging in conversations and drinks. Even the newly-arrived Kremnoans have begun to mingle with the Okhemans, nary a care to their history of less-than amicable relations.

From the Heroes’ Bath overlooking, Phainon could spot two silhouettes standing by the edge of the elevated platform. Aglaea and Castorice stood together, a relative distance between them. The Holy Maidens, on the other hand, flitted around with their little wings fluttering behind their backs, giggling as they showered flower petals and glittering golden dust onto the crowd.

“Everyone’s already here,” Phainon muses. “Let’s find a place to settle where we could get a good view of the play and the orchestra.”

Mydei only sighs, somehow aggravated by something. “How exciting.” Sarcastic. How oh how is Mydeimos the Unhappy going to have a good time today. “Lead the way, then.”

“Don’t be so impatient,” Phainon says lightly, the desire to kiss away the pout on Mydei’s lips much too strong. He wonders if he could even do such a thing. Though Mydei had somehow hinted that the last kiss they shared won’t be the only one, Phainon dared not hope lest the disappointment of rejection eats him alive. “When the music starts, you’ll find that there’s much to enjoy.”

Mydei says nothing, allowing himself to be dragged by the wrist, their sandals finally submerged into the shimmering waters of the bath. Fortunately, they were able to find an unoccupied floating lounge in a corner with only a few people surrounding it, but still a relatively acceptable place for them to see the stage.

As they settle, the musicians finally arrive, situating themselves before their chosen instruments. Before they could start playing, however, the clack of a heel meeting marble echoes throughout the place and silencing the crowd. Aglaea’s footsteps have been amplified by the golden threads, garnering the attention of everyone in the baths.

“Citizens of Okhema, the hour has begun where we ought to set aside the burdens of labor. Feast, not merely to nourish the body, but to uplift our weary hearts.” Her clouded gaze travels all across the people looking up to her from the Nerid Spring, only to land upon the two men in the far edge of the bath. Her attention lingers to her fellow Heirs. “Remember that such revelry should serve *not* to intoxicate you, but clear your mind of burdens and apprehensions. Let the festivities begin!”

Everyone erupts into mirthful cheers as the orchestra starts playing a bright and skipping melody, playful and full of life, urging everyone to dance and sing.

Ideaus comes by not soon after, holding up a tray with two chalices containing the Kremnoans' signature honey brew. "My lords," he says, almost a whisper as if he's afraid someone would hear him. "The Drink of Honor, blessed by Lady Aglaea herself."

"Thank you, Ideaus," Mydei says, taking the cups from the tray and handing Phainon his share. He swirls his drink, inspecting the pink liquid. "No liquor?"

"That's the fifth time you've asked that today, Your Highness," Ideaus jeers, cheeks dimpling as he grinned. "Do you not trust my humble self?"

Mydei's lips twitch, suppressing a smile. "This would have been the rare opportunity for you to serve me liquor. I wouldn't have minded."

Phainon can't help but think that Mydei's words vaguely hinted at something to which he had no clue as to what it was. Perhaps some inside Kremnoan joke, or maybe Mydei hated indulging in festivities that he would rather do it drunk out of his mind.

Nevertheless, the idea that Mydei is currently unable to enjoy himself despite being in Phainon's company causes the latter to fall silent, sipping his drink as his mind whirles with self-doubt. He'd been too confident that his presence alone would suffice and convince Mydei to have a good time. How presumptuous.

Beside him, Mydei simply stares ahead, watching the citizens dance in knee-deep water, faces flushed with wine and joy, spinning hand in hand and uncaring of how damp their clothes have gotten as the fabric swirled with every movement against the shimmering pool, sending ripples across the surface.

It is at that moment that Phainon is stricken with an idea. A *foolish* one.

He hops off the floating lounge, settling his drink on a nearby floating tray. With a hand outstretched towards Mydei—whose eyebrows had furrowed in question—he asks, "Will you do me the honor of being your first dance?"

If Mydei were to turn him down, then he'd simply go along with Mydei's wishes to ditch the festival altogether, their presence as Chrysos Heirs be damned. Perhaps then the other would begin to lighten up.

There's a huge chance that Mydei would say no to the dance, of course. He recalls a memory from months ago, of Mydei informing him that Kremnoans are no strangers to merrymaking. But the crown prince of Kremnos is much too reserved that even Phainon is unable to imagine a world in which Mydei sings, let alone dances.

And Phainon likes to think about Mydei *a lot*, his imagination running wild and plagued with golden hair and golden eyes, of tanned skin mired in streaks of scarlet, of muscles well-defined. A deep voice goading him on, the taste of sweetness on his tongue, the manifestation of a soft addiction against his lips—

Still, the simple image of Mydei dancing evades him, a possibility that had yet to exist.

Mydei stares at his outstretched hand, the look on his face thoughtful as he decides whether or not he accepts Phainon's offer. Patiently, Phainon waits. He keeps his hand steady and open, just close enough to be within Mydei's reach, but not so much to come off as forceful.

He would never lower his hand until Mydei gives him an answer. By the looks of things, he's about to be declined.

"Alright."

Phainon is pulled away from his thoughts when something warm meets his hand—Mydei had taken it, the touch of their skin a heightened sensation as Phainon's attention narrows down to this single moment, the revelry around them forgotten.

And then, Mydei's answer finally hits him, his own shocked countenance reflected against those twin pools of gold that seared through his very soul, shining with quiet amusement as Phainon struggles for something to say in return.

"Oh," Phainon says, rather intelligently. In his defense, his mind can't afford to process more complex thoughts when Mydei's hand periodically squeezes his own ever so slightly. "You can dance?"

Mydei's lips twitch downward in a little frown. "What a stupid question. Of course I can. More importantly, can you keep up with me?"

"Are you so familiar with Okheman dances to confidently issue a challenge?"

"I may not be familiar, but I learn quick," Mydei admits, eyes darkening as he pulls Phainon closer to him, situating him between muscled thighs. "What about you, Deliverer? You seem to know your way around when it comes to *dances* done during the Month of Joy."

Phainon huffs against Mydei's shoulder. Looking up to meet Mydei's gaze in a show of sincerity, he says, "I have only ever watched from the sidelines from celebrations past. You can ask Castorice if you refuse to believe me."

Instead of a response, Mydei gives him an indecipherable look mired in scrutiny. He gently pushes Phainon away, leaving his seat before placing his drink upon the floating tray.

Without a word or a single glance, Mydei walks toward the center of the Nerid Spring where the people danced to the music, the waters splashing against his bare thighs, a flash of gold wrapped around one of them, tastefully worn against the thick, flexing muscle.

Phainon could feel himself go slightly dizzy at the sight, standing dumbfounded still by the floating lounge, his hand tingling from the sudden cold now with Mydei no longer around to warm him.

Sensing that Phainon hasn't followed, Mydei turns around, an eyebrow raised in question as he smirks. "Well?"

A taunt.

Phainon takes in a breath before he steps forward, following Mydei towards the crowd. This could either end in utter embarrassment, or something much worse. Phainon casts a glance upon the Heroes' Baths where Aglaea and Castorice stood to watch.

Castorice gives him two thumbs up, a smile on her face. Aglaea, on the other hand, had her arms crossed, features graced with a frown. Phainon dreads to think what she would say when he and Mydei eventually end up ruining the Festival of Phagousa with a simple dance competition.

Just as they stood in position, the score changes. Phainon is familiar enough to know how to open the dance, taking the liberty to lead and for Mydei to follow. Mydei does, turning in the opposite direction smoothly enough before once again gravitating into Phainon's space like they were never meant to part for so long.

Gradually, they made their way to the center of the crowd, shallow waters splashing with every movement of their legs, their footwork in sync with the music. The citizens have parted away to grant the two heroes some space as they danced with wide and sweeping motions, spinning each other with breathless laughs.

Phainon catches sight of Mydei's grin as he takes three steps away and two steps back, turning, reaching out until his hand finds Mydei's waist. The damp silk against his palm is not unpleasant enough to hinder the sight of Mydei with his reservations put aside, alight with giddiness that he's positively glowing.

The air in Phainon's lungs has been taken away, a mild twisting in his chest whenever the dance makes them separate albeit briefly. Their hands brush against each other in passing, a continuous pattern of mirrored steps. Though their movements attempt to appear stately, their inexperience was still evident. And yet, Phainon finds himself uncaring of it.

Eyes may be on them as the citizens opted to form a circle instead, enclosing the two Heirs within, their arms locked around each other as they skipped and hopped, a continuous splash of shimmering water to aid the rhythm.

Those who remained to watch by the sidelines have begun to clap, spurring the dancers even more. Some of them have even begun to chant and sing—an ode to Phagousa and yet, the string quartet accompanied by the water lyre gave the song a touch of romance, Mnestia's influence weaving in so effortlessly like the golden threads that intertwined the fates of all.

As the dance goes on, the rhythm quickens signalling its eventual end. Mydei catches Phainon's wrist, spun him twice before letting go, sending Phainon a couple of paces away just as he does a high-stepped flourish causing the crowd to erupt into a resounding applause.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Show off."

Phainon laughs. "You try."

The Kremnoans' singing have grown loud enough to compete with the Okhemans,' more so when Mydei is spun around, mirroring the step Phainon had just done with the idea of besting

Phainon with his moves. They're drenched, but neither of them seemed to mind, hands slipping due to the wetness as they tried to hold on to each other.

During the last twirl for the dance, Mydei's sandals catch upon a stray tile beneath the waters of the bath and he trips just as the final note of the water lyre resounds. Phainon's body responds as if on instinct, reaching out to catch Mydei before he falls and holding him steady against his chest, arms enclosed upon the other's waist in a firm hold.

Mydei looks up at him, hands gripping his shoulders, so near and dear with lips slightly parted as he catches his breath—soft and warm, intermingling with Phainon's. And as Mydei's gaze drops to Phainon's lips, Phainon is very much inclined to lean down some more, the unmistakable look in Mydei's eyes one that Phainon has grown familiar with how much he's recounted their last kiss.

Phainon *longs* to have another taste, he had never once stopped to desire the man before him. Such greed will be his downfall. And yet—

The crowd bursts into applause and mirthful cheers, startling both Phainon and Mydei from their makeshift bubble. For a moment, they've forgotten that they're not alone. The dance has concluded. The first of many more, that is.

Mydei pulls away and steadies himself on his own two feet, his face slightly flushed with a tinge of red, almost shy. The sight itself tugs at Phainon's heartstrings so mercilessly.

"Are you alright?" Phainon asks.

"Of course I am," Mydei answers. Despite the haughty tone, a small smile has graced his lips. "It seems that you've won, Deliverer."

Phainon smiles, snaking his hands upon Mydei's waist to pull him closer just as they were before. "It seems that I have," he gloats. Teasingly, he adds, "Oh. Were you referring to the dance? I thought you meant something else."

"*Haikas*," Mydei scoffs, however, he doesn't make a move to pry Phainon's hands off of him. In fact, he takes another small step closer to ensure that there's barely even any space between them. "I refuse to believe that this is your first time dancing in an event like this. You must've had so much practice from the previous years."

This again. Phainon is *so* fond that his cheeks have begun to hurt with how much he's smiling.

"Dances like these are only meant to be shared with…" He allows his voice to trail off in favor of leaning closer, brushing his lips against Mydei's ear as if he were about to share a secret. "...someone *special*."

He pulls away, just enough to garner Mydei's reaction. As always, he was not disappointed.

Phainon continues, "I'm afraid I've never had anyone to consider as such before I met you."

The tips of Mydei's ears redden, down to his neck and chest. For the second time, he mutters a soft, "*Haikas*."

Phainon only laughs. Just then, the music starts anew. Lesser people have opted to participate, situating themselves a relative distance away to ensure enough space for every partnered couple. The rhythm this time is slow, almost languid in a way.

One of the hands resting upon Mydei's waist leaves in favor of taking Mydei's idle hand, an offer. "Another dance, my Dei?"

Mydei huffs, allowing himself to be led in step, one hand intertwined with Phainon's while the other firmly held Phainon by the shoulder as they glided through shallow waters.

"Not affording me rest, are you?" Mydei says.

Phainon hums, the tips of his fingers pressing lightly upon the small of Mydei's back. "Not like you to be so weary already." He twirls Mydei in uniform with the dance, but pulls him close quicker than the others, loathe to part. "Do you wish to be taken elsewhere, then? For some… relaxation?"

Mydei's eyes glint, narrowing slightly. "I've been meaning to do just that. But *someone* refused to have a blot on his perfect Deliverer attendance."

For once, Phainon is able to understand quicker than what should be deemed appropriate. "You're going to kill me one day with your words, Mydeimos."

Mydei smiles, a finger slipping beneath the fabric of Phainon's chiton, fiddling with the brooch upon his shoulder. The touch leaves Phainon's skin tingling in its wake.

"Don't worry, Deliverer. I'm more than willing to drag you back from the River of Souls if I have to."

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To dance with one's lover during the Festival of Phagousa ensures that the couple is bestowed with bountiful blessings and ***a love that flows strongly as the surging currents in an endless ocean****.*

— an excerpt. Feasts in Okhema: A Guide (2nd Edition), Chapter 5: Month of Joy

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Mydei lets out a soft grunt when his back meets the wood of Phainon's door, hands pulling upon snowy locks of wet hair. Phainon groans, licking into Mydei's mouth with abandon, uncaring if he seemed desperately needy.

Well. He *is* desperate. And he *needs* Mydei like he needs air. The latter he is more than willing to go without if it meant that Mydei's lips are the only thing he'll know in his demise. As of now, he ignores the cries of his body to *breathe*.

Mydei can't die from suffocation. Phainon would simply kiss his corpse back to life. He'll do so again and again until he himself is unable to escape the clutches of Thanatos. By then, contentment shall be within his reach, the last of his thoughts only consisting of the softness of his dearly beloved's lips against his.

The bliss is short-lived, however, when Mydei reaches a hand up against Phainon's mouth, gently prying him away and effectively halting the kiss. Phainon makes an unhappy sound.

"Eager," was Mydei's poor attempt at a reprimand.

Phainon licks at Mydei's palm in an effort to annoy. But Mydei doesn't react as expected, eyes of gold simply watching Phainon's tongue dart in between his fingers, pupils blown wide. He then spreads them out, pressing against Phainon's lips tentatively.

The urge to bite is tempting, and Phainon does just that, teeth clamping down against the joint near Mydei's fingertips before taking them in his mouth, sucking lightly, a soft keen escaping his throat when Mydei pushes down firmly upon his tongue.

Phainon groans and grinds his hips forward, seeking friction, all shame thrown out of the window with how much he *wants*. He is well aware that Mydei knows about the bulge in between his legs, the proof of his desire standing tall against the wet and flimsy fabric of his chiton.

"Mydei." Phainon manages to say, when Mydei pulls his fingers away. His vision swims with lust, his mind utterly clouded, body burning up with how much his skin tingles. "*Please*."

"Begging already," Mydei muses, voice dipped low. "Patience, Deliverer."

Phainon bites back a whimper.

Mydei cups his face, a rather gentle contradiction to how cruel he is with Phainon's plight. "We have to do this properly."

"Shall we move this to the kline?" Phainon asks.

"Even now you make jests," Mydei huffs, somehow amused as he pushes Phainon off of him. Did he wish to be taken by the door instead? Or is Phainon misunderstanding something here? "Prepare the honey brew, Deliverer. Ideaus must have already placed a jar on your desk."

Though it doesn't seem so strange for Mydei to want something to drink before engaging in intimacy, the thought of someone barging into his room without his knowledge makes

Phainon uncomfortable, questioning the locks on his door.

Before he could convey his sentiments, Mydei had already turned around, waiting for Janus to grant him exit.

“Where are you going?” If Mydei leaves him in this state, it would be akin to a catastrophe—one that Phainon isn’t so sure if he’ll ever recover from.

“I have to procure something from my room,” Mydei answers, stepping out once the door had opened for him. Without turning around, he says, “I’ll be back, Deliverer.”

That’s reassuring. Phainon is (*undeniably, absolutely, unreservedly*) glad that Mydei made that (*very*) clear.

“Okay.” He tries not to sound too eager, like a dutiful chimera waiting for his master to come back home after a day’s worth of toiling. “I’ll be here.”

Mydei stops in his tracks. He turns his head slightly, just enough for Phainon to see the curve of his lips. “Of course you are.”

And with that, Mydei makes a turn to descend down the flight of stairs to his room and out of sight.

The door closes. With shaky legs, Phainon manages to walk further into his room and spots the aforementioned jar on his desk that wasn’t even supposed to be there. He’ll have some choice words with Ideaus the next time he encounters him.

The chalice he shared with Mydei before had been washed clean and placed in a display box upon the shelf for Phainon to moon over and reminisce on the beloved moments of which the relic was involved in. Carefully, he takes it out of its case and pours the honey brew.

Phainon then uses the time to tidy up his chambers for a bit. It’s not that messy, per se, but it wouldn’t hurt to make it more presentable. As he busies himself, he swears he doesn’t keep count of every tick of the clock that passes by until he hears three loud knocks from outside his door followed by the turning of locks as Janus allows his visitor the right of passage.

Stuffing the last remaining stone tablets into a shelf, Phainon says as a way of greeting, “So how exactly did Ideaus get in—?”

His words get stuck in his throat when he sees Mydei by the door. Gone was the drenched chiton he wore, now replaced by a crimson red cloak. Eyelids and lips were smeared with shimmering gold dust, and exposed fingers were clad in an assortment of rings, holding an ornate bejeweled box.

Phainon can’t breathe, and Zagreus had likely stolen away his wits alongside his lungs.

“You…” He swallows. With every beat of silence does he realize he’s lost his ability to speak coherently. Much less come up with *words*. “I mean— You’re…”

Phainon goes quiet. It is either he says something profound—preferably a compliment—or something dreadfully stupid to the point that his freedom of speech should be taken away with utmost haste.

Mydei smiles. He's just making fun of Phainon now, isn't he.

"I'm flattered," is all he says before walking into the room and placing the box he brought upon Phainon's bedside table. He turns to the other who hasn't moved an inch. "Why are you standing so far away?"

I'm scared, Phainon wanted to say. *This has to be a dream.* At any point, he'll eventually wake up and face the reality that the Mydei in front of him is not real. It's simply all too good to be true.

"Come here, Deliverer." Mydei's beckons him over, his tone soft as if he were talking to an animal that's easily spooked. "Have you done what I asked you to do?"

Phainon takes the chalice and shows it to Mydei, seeing the flash of recognition in the latter's eyes when he sees the cup.

"I have," Phainon replies, keeping his voice steady. He then takes a step, and another, until he finds himself right in front of the lone temptation that seeks his undoing in this dying world. "You don't mind sharing, right?"

"No."

Mydei takes the cup from his hand. The mere act had Phainon shivering at the sensation of their fingers briefly brushing against each other. Then, Mydei places a hand on his chest, lightly pushing him back until the backs of his knees have met the edge of the kline.

"Sit."

Phainon does as he's told without much thought, looking up at Mydei with wide eyes, awaiting further instructions if there are any. He would do anything for Mydei, even the impossible.

Mydei looked pleased at the obedience, cupping Phainon's face and tilting his chin upward with his free hand, the metal of the rings cool against Phainon's feverish skin. The rim of the cup was then gently guided towards Phainon's now slightly parted lips. When the liquid sweetness meets the tip of his tongue, he begins to sip, eyes never leaving Mydei's.

"May you partake in the blood of my ancestors, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Mydei states, almost ceremonial. "Feel their might course through your veins before we become one and true."

Phainon's ears are ringing as he lets the honey brew coat his tongue before traveling down his throat, every gulp he makes an amplified sound against the silence of the room. He's *so* hard and Mydei is just *standing there*. Devastatingly beautiful and—

Talking about ancestors. Phainon wonders if such words are a precursor to intimacy for the Kremnoans. If it is, Phainon is absolutely not complaining. Mydei's voice is arousing enough to bring him to completion.

Mydei pulls the cup away, its contents now reduced in half. With the pad of his thumb, he gently wipes the corner of Phainon's lips for any residue. It's gentle, done so lovingly if Phainon allows himself to succumb to such fanciful delusions.

"And now," Mydei began, bringing the rim close to his lips, about to drink at the spot Phainon had. Deliberate or not, it makes Phainon's stomach flutter. "I, Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos, shall partake in the blood of your ancestors and feel their might course through my veins before we become one and true."

Those strange words again. Like a ritual.

Phainon is in a daze as he watches Mydei tip his head back, neck arched in a beautiful curve as he downs the rest of the drink in a couple of gulps, throat bobbing as he does so—a mesmerizing movement.

Once finished, Mydei flings the cup, a distant *clang* resounding from far away at some corner of Phainon's vast chambers. On a regular day, Phainon *would* have minded. But then he remembers how the relic is a fake and whatever Mydei does at this moment is simply a manifestation of divine acts, something that ought to be revered instead of criticized.

Mydei's lips shimmer against the light that streams from the open windows and the balcony, lips still wet with remnants of the pomegranate juice. "I want you bare, Deliverer."

Phainon takes in a shaky breath. "As you wish."

He stands up, his chest almost pressing against Mydei with how close they are. Then, he begins to peel the partially-dried chiton off of his flushed skin, the bite of the air cold and sharp. Mydei's eyes of gold darken as it followed the downward drag of the fabric, gradually exposing pale scars until it all but drops down to the floor, pooling against their feet.

It was quiet, the echoes of the belt and accessories as it fell with a clatter left to linger in the silence. Phainon lets Mydei stare all he wants. Though he may feel shy for being so exposed, it's nothing that Mydei hasn't seen before. Except perhaps the aching desire that hung heavy and erect between his legs.

After a long appraisal, Mydei eventually reaches a hand out, tracing the narrow gold curve etched across Phainon's chest as Phainon inhales sharply, trying to keep his breathing stable. However, every glide of Mydei's fingers against him renders his attempt futile, breathing erratically as he feels himself twitch, the tip of his cock slick and weeping, begging to be soothed.

Such a depraved display does not escape Mydei's notice. "Eager."

Phainon manages a laugh. "I thought we'd already established that."

In lieu of a response, Mydei pushes him to the bed, taking him by surprise (pleasantly so) as the mattress bounces due to bearing the sudden weight.

“Watch me,” Mydei tells him, an order of which Phainon is more than willing to obey for he really has no reason to do otherwise.

He supports himself on his elbows, eyes refusing to blink as he gazes up at the other who unclasps the pin holding his cloak together. Oddly enough, Phainon catches a glint of gold from within the thick fabric, his next exhale promptly halted when Mydei all but slips the crimson fabric away, baring himself in front of Phainon.

Except—

Mydei is *not* entirely naked.

Chains of gold encrusted in rubies hung tastefully by his neck and shoulders like an elaborate necklace, winding around his torso and chest, seemingly emphasizing every definition of muscle, keeping those twin points of temptation in perfect view with how it loops around the perk, dusty nipples.

Wrapped around his arms are ones akin to the bangles he usually fashions. Only now, delicate chains cascade until below his elbow, swaying mesmerizingly with every minute movement. And down the waist led by a small trail of blonde hair upon the navel was Mydei’s half-hard cock, flushed with want. He could only wish to carry its weight with his tongue.

In the presence of a *god*, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae is at a loss for words.

A knowing smirk graces Mydei’s lips, evidently aware of the devastating allure he holds, and revels in it. Phainon has never been so aroused in his entire life. Though he’s known Mydei to be quite humble beneath the firm facade he puts up, only he could wear ego so effortlessly.

Without a word, Mydei reaches for the box by the bedside table and opens it, revealing a dagger with a golden hilt. The sight of the weapon briefly gives Phainon a sense of alarm as he sits up out of instinct. But then, his eyes meet that of Mydei’s, such entrancing molten gold, soft and honest. And thus, he allows the dread to be cleansed away.

He trusts Mydei with his life. Mydei will never hurt him.

(In the impossible occasion that Mydei does bring him harm, Phainon would be ready to accept the unjust fate given to him so abruptly. To die in the arms of a peerless beauty is more than enough of an incentive to traverse the afterlife.)

Mydei steps closer, one knee upon the mattress in between Phainon’s legs as he held Phainon’s face with his free hand. It’s warm, and Phainon allows himself to indulge in the touch, leaning against it.

“Are you alright?” Mydei asks.

“You’re not going to kill me, are you?”

Mydei huffs out a laugh. “Figuratively or literally?”

“Both.”

Mydei pretends to think of an answer, humming lightly as he makes a move to fully climb atop the kline, straddling Phainon as he does so, the latter left to lie on his back against the mattress simply to witness the magnificent sight that is Mydei in all his glory—showered in gold and jewels above him, poised for worship.

Phainon’s fingers twitch at his sides, itching to touch but unsure as to where his hand should rest upon. Overwhelmed, he opts to make no move at all, simply allowing Mydei to take the lead and do whatever it is that pleases him.

And Mydei does just that, taking Phainon’s hand in his, the blade of the dagger appearing too late in Phainon’s periphery with how distracted he was at the view before him. He startles with a gasp when the sharp edge of the dagger digs upon his open palm, just enough to draw blood, golden ichor oozing out of the wound in tiny rivulets.

Before Phainon could react, Mydei transfers the hilt of the dagger onto his hand, pressing the cold metal against the wound. He hisses at the friction against the two encrusted gems of sapphire and ruby that have sought to rub the injury raw, golden ichor spilling onto the hilt and down to the blade, drenching it in divine blood.

Mydei then directs Phainon’s hand to cut a similar slit into his own palm. This time, with a shocked yelp, Phainon tries to pull back—

“Mydei—!”

Mydei digs the knife deeper than he’s done with Phainon’s, golden ichor gushing from the wound. He takes the hilt of the dagger from Phainon’s weak grasp and smears his blood upon the gem-encrusted surface until it covers Phainon’s own, the excess dripping down onto the sheets.

Phainon stares in disbelief as the steady spill of blood stops only mere moments later, the cut upon Mydei’s hand healing with nary a scar in its wake as he hands the blood-soaked dagger back to him.

Upon the blade was a small engraving of two letters written in an alphabet that’s distinctly Kremnoan, made visible by the combined golden ichor that had flowed and filled the narrow dip of rigid lines—words pre-written, and now sealed with golden ink.

“This dagger belongs to you now,” Mydei tells him, as if it would explain *everything* they’ve just done. “As my blood unites with yours and seeps through the crevices of this blade, its edges shall remain sharp as the day it was forged. It will *never* fail you.”

What in this dying world—

Dazed with several emotions, all Phainon could muster was a weak, “Thank you.”

That was *not* what he’d meant to say at all. Not even close.

His wounded hand was cradled by the warmth as Mydei brings it closer to his lips. All Phainon could do was to anticipate the other's next move with bated breath—a devastating one as expected. Fighting back a shiver, he watches as Mydei gently laps at the cut, sucking lightly, the sensation sending Phainon's nerves alight with a sharp heat that could rival even the hottest of flames when the sting of the injury is immediately soothed with wet comfort.

Only when the bleeding had stopped did Mydei speak, leaning in until their foreheads were pressed together. "You're supposed to say: I accept this blade with my soul laid bare, veiled not in falsehood nor adorned in pretense," he pauses, guiding both of Phainon's hands to hold the hilt tightly. Softly, he continues, "May the Lance of Fury bear witness to my sincerity."

The strangeness of the words, almost akin to an oath, was the only reason that Phainon was able to remember everything with his lust-addled mind that's swirling with so many questions. "Do all Kremnoans do this sort of thing?"

"Before engaging in intimacy, yes," Mydei answers patiently.

Phainon wets his lips. "I see."

A hint of hesitance flashes within Mydei's eyes, and he pulls away slightly. "It's an old-fashioned tradition. Forgive me for I…"

Although Mydei's gaze wavered, Phainon could still see his own visage reflected against the gold that shone with something unspoken and vulnerable.

"I simply wish to share it with you," Mydei finishes.

It was quiet then, as Phainon let his ears savor the declaration. His heart swells with so much emotion, fondness coursing through him in an unforgiving tide, consuming his entire being whole. Who knew that such simple words coming from Mydei would have this effect on him? He is so, *so* enamored with this man that it's bound to be the source of such immense sorrow—

And if fate allows it, *bliss*.

Phainon takes Mydei's hand in his as they held the hilt of the dagger together. He could only hope that he is able to convey his intentions just as ardently as Mydei had conveyed his.

"I accept this blade with my soul laid bare, veiled not in falsehood nor adorned in pretense." He rests his forehead against Mydei's, as they have done so earlier, and allows himself to be lost readily within the golden abyss. "May the Lance of Fury bear witness to my sincerity."

Mydei's eyes widen ever so slightly, seemingly surprised that Phainon had gone along with his wishes. Let it be known that Phainon would never deprive Mydei of *anything*, even if the stakes required the entirety of his body and soul—of which he is more than willing to offer.

He allows a moment of silence to encompass them, letting Mydei take his time to confirm the truth in his statement. Phainon sees when exactly it was that the other was able to do so, the

uncertainties in those eyes of gold melting away only to be replaced with relief, and something much more obscure to the untrained eye.

Phainon looks closely, searching, and decides he likes the hunger he finds there, heated enough to burn. If he were to catch fire, then the searing warmth shall aid him in the cold journey to the nether realm.

“Mydei.”

Ever so perceptive of his needs, Mydei pries the dagger off of his hands and leans back to place it at the foot of the kline, just right by the edge to avoid any untoward accidents. He then returns to Phainon’s embrace, who is more than willing to accommodate him.

With both of his hands free of duties, Phainon allows them to rest upon Mydei’s waist, pulling him ever so closer until the heat of their desires brush against each other ever so faintly. It is enough to send Phainon’s mind reeling, however.

“*Mydei*,” he says again with a little more urgency.

It is cruel for Mydei to smile amidst Phainon’s aching want. “Shall we begin, Deliverer?”

Phainon lets the teasing lilt of Mydei’s tone slide for this time only in favor of planting a soft kiss at the corner of the latter’s lips. They have much more pressing matters to deal with. Let his revenge occur at a later date.

“I’ll be in your care.”

It would seem that his gesture of affection didn’t satisfy, for Mydei immediately pushes him onto the kline in a sudden show of strength, pinning him down.

Phainon is only allowed a single intake of air before Mydei dips his head low and gifts him with a kiss. Unhurriedly sweet, so much so that it leaves Phainon wanting for more, desperately kneading at Mydei’s firm, muscled waist and feeling the back of his hand snag against the golden chains before it travels south, tentative touches growing more bold.

How he’s waited for this moment. The idea of having Mydei like this had been nigh impossible, a dream laden with guilt of which his morals could never win over. Already a vice even in the prison of his own thoughts, Phainon wonders of the extent in which the heat of Mydei’s embrace consumes him.

When his palms meet the soft globes of Mydei’s ass, Mydei’s response comes in the form of a breathy moan against his lips when he squeezes indulgently, leisurely feeling up the pliant flesh—softer and fuller than he’d initially expected beneath his touch. It is addicting, the act of kneading altering something in his brain and he fears that he might get addicted.

(He already is.)

Using his hold as leverage, he then guides Mydei to lower his hips, matching groans coming from the both of them when their cocks slid against each other, much more purposeful this

time. They're both wet enough to ease the glide, thrusting against each other instinctively in a rhythm that lacked finesse, spurred mostly by wanton desperation.

Feeling the heat gradually crest low in his belly, Phainon had already forgone the kiss in favor of panting pathetically against Mydei's parted lips, unbridled whines and gasps escaping from deep within his throat. It is without dignity that Phainon admits to himself how close he is to nearing the precipice, muscles taut and trembling with effort, every sensuous slide of his body against Mydei's blurring his vision in a lust-filled haze.

Phainon digs his nails at the soft flesh beneath his touch and feels Mydei's movements stutter above him. A distinct metallic taste floods his tongue as every single nerve ending in his groin had been seemingly ignited all at once before a wave of white-hot pleasure tore through him, cock pulsing as he spilled in between their bellies, painting both his and Mydei's cock pearly white.

Only then did he realize that he'd bitten down upon Mydei's bottom lip hard enough to draw blood when surrender had overtaken him. Mydei's groans are muffled, eyes clenched shut as Phainon soothes the cut with an apologetic lick, aware of the hands that gripped the sheets beside his head as Mydei grinds his hips against him in small aborted thrusts that evaded his softening cock entirely, somehow considerate of Phainon's oversensitivity.

Phainon would rather that Mydei set his considerate nature aside—for him to allow Phainon's body to tremble and quake as every spark of pleasure that's way too close to crossing the fine boundaries of pain drowns him. Mydei had yet to come, and Phainon wished that he hadn't been so focused in satiating himself so selfishly.

"How do you want me?" he asks as a way to make amends for releasing so fast, brushing his lips against Mydei's in a rather chaste kiss.

Mydei's hips halt in their movements as he pulls back, sitting up straight as he supports himself upon Phainon's thighs. With one hand, he takes Phainon's now softening cock in his palm and strokes slowly, feeling it twitch back to life in a show of utter depravity.

The cum makes the glide way too smooth, Mydei's grip just tight enough to have Phainon throwing his head back in sheer bliss. The sensitive skin of his cock catches with the cool metal of the rings, a stark contrast to the warmth that Mydei provides.

The conflicting sensations had his hips jerking into the friction without much thought as oversensitivity reduces his body in a pitiful, quivering mess beneath Mydei's ministrations—a hedonistic wish held in secret, and yet granted all the same.

He could come again just like this, feeling his cock leak from the tip as if he'd never gotten it empty just moments prior, a hiss escaping from between the narrow space of his gritted teeth when Mydei slows down his strokes to a pace that could even be considered as more cruel than torture.

"M-Mydei, *please*—"

It is as if Mydei had heard nothing, thumb digging upon the slit of Phainon's cock rather mercilessly, rubbing circles upon the leaking tip and making it weep some more.

A tear slips from the corner of Phainon's eye as he gazes up at the man who he had relinquished his control over, willingly so. With his other hand, Mydei reaches out and catches the proof of his weakness.

"You beg so freely," Mydei says, his tone laced with an affection so evident that even Phainon couldn't deny it.

With how much his heart sings at the moment, he'd rather receive Mydei's fondness with the absence of doubts lest his tears of pleasure morph into that of sorrow. Mydei had made his sentiments clear the last time he weeped. Perhaps the context of the situation allows Mydei to make some exceptions.

"Tell me, Deliverer," Mydei continues, tightening his hold ever so slightly with every downward stroke that has Phainon's grappling for purchase upon Mydei's hips, his grip downright bruising against the rippling muscle with barely-contained restraint. "How do *you* want *me?*"

Phainon makes a needy sound, high-pitched and garbled. "Any way— *Every* way I could possibly have you, as long as you allow it."

Mydei's eyes of gold gleam against the light. "You already have me."

"In my mouth," Phainon manages, realizing that the situation required him to be more specific, needing something to quench his parched throat. "I want to taste you. Let me make you feel good as well."

Mydei's gaze darkens at the request. He raised himself from Phainon's lap, knees dipping against the soft mattress as he beckons Phainon to sit up, a hand carding through his snow-colored locks before settling just above the nape, guiding him to where he's needed.

Phainon swallowed thickly at the sight of Mydei's desire so close and within reach. Beautiful, much like the rest of its flawless owner. It's curved just right, an expectedly impressive girth with a length that's sure to reach further down the back of his throat enough for its shape to linger in phantom sensations.

He inches closer, one of his hands placed upon the back of a muscled thigh, while the other opts to enclose the base of Mydei's cock within his fingers, feeling himself flush when the length in his hand throbs.

Phainon looks up. The view is magnificent—Mydei in jewels and gold looking down at him, *not* to condescend for a silent plea swims in the glimmer of his eyes, and Phainon could only assume that perhaps Mydei wants this just as much as he does.

Feeling giddy amidst the daze, Phainon lightly strokes Mydei against his palm, spreading the pre-cum that had accumulated at the tip and allowing the length to feel his hard won

callouses. It was the right call when he heard a shaky inhale from above, the grip on his hair tightening for a fraction, a light sting that keeps Phainon going.

“Deliverer,” Mydei says lowly, almost like a warning. Or something else that Phainon had yet to coax out of hiding beneath Mydei’s thick layer of inhibitions.

He caresses Mydei’s thigh reverently, kneading at the taut muscle as he presses a kiss upon Mydei’s hip bone where a scarlet streak met its end in a tapered edge. The cock in his other hand twitches, honest in the way Mydei is not.

Eventually, Mydei’s impatience practically drips from his breathlessly uttered words as he says, “You’re wasting time.”

Phainon’s teeth graze at the skin close to Mydei’s navel, tongue mapping out the ridges of muscles divinely sculpted. “I’ve been nothing but polite,” he croons, nipping teasingly just to hear Mydei grunt, hips jerking instinctively. “Surely you can afford me the same courtesy.”

“You were begging,” Mydei retorts, trying to sound aggravated but fails spectacularly. “Forgive me for assuming that you’d be eager to take what has been given—what you *asked* for.”

“By your words, it sounds as if *I’m* the only one who wants this,” Phainon says. Then, he withdraws, doubt beginning to trickle in. “Do you not want this, Mydei?”

Eyes of molten gold narrow down at him in a glare, more frustrated than angry. With a hand that still held Phainon steady at the back of his head, Mydei had the leverage to simply skip the delay and push Phainon onto his cock if he so wished, take his desire as he would a victory.

Phainon would’ve liked that, would’ve *thanked* Mydei for it even. He lets himself witness the control slip from Mydei’s regal facade, only proven by the slight trembling of the fingers and the dig of blunt nails against his scalp. And yet, Mydei chooses not to act upon it, a commendable show of restraint to Phainon’s chagrin.

“If you don’t want this,” Phainon began. “We should stop. I can’t be the only one begging here.”

Mydei lets out a sound of indignation. “I don’t beg.”

As expected. “I guess you’ll have to let me know what you want some other way, then.”

Phainon shuffles to extricate himself from beneath Mydei, poised to grab something to clothe himself when suddenly, a warm hand snatches his wrist and pulls him hard enough that the room spins sideways and he is once again on his back.

Mydei looms over him, eyebrows pinched, debating whether he should give in or not. It wouldn’t be Mydei if he didn’t at least choose to oppose Phainon, always the adversary for the sake of a thrilling competition of ideals.

“Well?” Phainon urges. Though he tries to sound composed, the sight of Mydei on top of him has never done any favors to his heart (and dick). “Do you want this, Mydeimos?”

Say yes. Say you want me.

Mydei’s eyebrows furrow even more. “Is there any reason for me to be here if I felt otherwise?”

“For a straightforward man, you are acting quite the contrary as of this moment.”

“*Phainon*.”

Mydei’s voice is shot, raw with frustration. If Phainon hadn’t looked down, he would think Mydei is starting to get genuinely riled up, using the same tone as he would when he’s about to issue a challenge that would end with the both of them beaten black and blue.

A soft, strained sound follows when Phainon allows his hand to rest against the meat of Mydei’s thigh, letting his touch travel upward until barely a space is left between his thumb and the pitiful leaking cock in between Mydei’s legs. Bottom lip caught between his teeth, Mydei trembles above him.

“Phainon,” Mydei says again, unfocused gaze half-lidded. “Cease your teasing.”

Phainon smiles, a flash of teeth, heart thumping upon hearing his name be called upon for the second time in a row, used so rarely that the occasion could be deemed as worthy of celebration.

“Much like you, I’ll only give what is asked of me. I’m not Aglaea to know what is unspoken.”

“You speak of another in this circumstance?” Mydei asks, affronted. “Have you no respect for the Goldweaver?”

“It’s just an example, dear Mydeimos.”

Mydei huffs, prickled like a chimera in a bad mood. “You were always so fond of theatrics. The fact that we talk with our mouths instead of our bodies—haven’t we hindered ourselves enough already?”

It’s not so much as the answer Phainon had hoped for. But then, Mydei takes Phainon’s hand and guides it slowly to his cock, allowing Phainon’s fingers to enclose upon the length as he thrusts his hips into the tight space in an effort to chase some much-needed friction.

Phainon merely stares from below, breath catching with pupils blown wide as Mydei uses his hand to take his pleasure, pools of gold hidden behind closed eyelids with choked little gasps escaping his slightly parted lips. It’s hot, and Phainon feels his skin grow warm from the mere sensation of Mydei’s cock sliding against his palm, wet with pre-cum that Phainon so *itches* to have a taste.

“*Gods*,” Phainon mutters with a curse.

Perhaps it's not entirely news at this point, but Mydei never fails to drive him insane.

He swiftly maneuvers the both of them, ending up with Mydei on his back and head nestled upon the pillows while Phainon crawls on top of him. This time, he strokes Mydei without the need for guidance, moderately quick pumps of his hand just to feel the tip leak some more.

Mydei is an utterly holy vision, blonde hair fanning out exquisitely beneath him, not a single ill-favored angle in sight. The rubies encrusted in the chains he wore gleamed against the light that flooded the room, the gold dust on his lips now smeared from when Phainon last kissed him, chest heaving as flawless tanned skin mired in scarlet streaks shimmered with a thin sheen of sweat.

And though Phainon thinks he is not worthy enough to behold such beauty, perhaps he was brought into this world with eyes to do just that, a voice to sing Mydei's praises, a hand to caress and touch, and *feel*.

He settles himself between Mydei's legs, dipping his head low to catch the other's lips in a needy, open-mouthed kiss of which was promptly reciprocated with equal vigor, more teeth than it is tender. He groans when strong fingers card through his hair, tugging lightly when he sucks at Mydei's tongue, sinful in the way it swipes against his lips.

Pulling away, Phainon then trails kisses from the hard line of his jaw, down to the length of his throat bared open for him like an offering. He had nothing against temptation as he sinks his teeth upon the crook of Mydei's neck, lapping at the salty taste of sweat and relishing in the vibrations against his tongue when Mydei lets out a guttural groan.

Down he goes, pressing his lips in the dip between Mydei's clavicles, his free hand travelling up beneath the chains of gold, past the jut of Mydei's rib cage and resting against one generous pec. He squeezes lightly, an act he's been longing to do since the first time he'd laid eyes on Mydei's glorious chest.

The muscle is malleable beneath his touch, pliant, second only to the softness of Mydei's ass and Phainon finds his vision growing dark, lightheaded in his desire with how much he wants to devour Mydei whole.

"Your body is so *lewd*," he mutters against Mydei's other pec, ignoring the rough friction of the chains against his chin. He spares a glance at the other just to garner his reaction. "Is that the reason why you always walk around half-naked? To tempt me?"

Mydei scowls without much heat, the corners of his eyes reddening, skin flushed to form a sight that could render *anyone* weak. "*Haikas*. How I dress does not concern you."

"I see," Phainon simpers, feigning skepticism. He breathes hotly against a perk nipple, swallowing the fast accumulating drool in his mouth—a testament to how much he wants to take the delicate bud, to be able to know if it tastes just as good as it looks. "Pardon me, then, for my impropriety."

Before Mydei could respond, Phainon had already enclosed his lips upon the nipple, swirling his tongue at the apex that had now grown endearingly stiff, like a fruit ripe for the taking, sweet in every sense of the word.

Mydei's jaw grows slack as he arches into Phainon's ministrations, head thrown back into the soft pillows as wordless sounds escape his lips.

"Deliv— *Phainon*, you can't—"

Phainon hums, the vibrations only serving to stimulate the nerve endings of Mydei's nipple and causing Mydei's cock to twitch from within Phainon's hold, his strokes consistently long and slow, just enough to limit the pleasure.

"What can't I do?" Phainon says, pulling away ever so briefly just to goad Mydei into finishing his halted sentence. "*Your* Deliverer can do *anything* as long as you ask him for it."

"*...Haikas*."

Mydei doesn't rise to the bait. Mildly disappointed, Phainon tries to cheer himself up by opting to grant Mydei's other neglected nipple the same amount of attention, relishing in the sting when Mydei grips at his hair, but not so much as to pull him away from the responsibility he'd so eagerly taken.

When the reddened buds have been deservedly showered with affection until they swelled as evidence, Phainon then moves on to trail open-mouthed kisses down Mydei's abdomen, laving his tongue upon the chain-clad skin and tasting both the tang of the golden metal and the saltiness of sweat—a combination he didn't expect he would like so much.

But then again, anything in relation to Mydei's body does he take delight in with no exceptions.

There will come a day where he will free up his schedule and bind Mydei to his bed with ropes or silks in favor of savoring every detail that such an exquisite, undying body possessed, set on unravelling each and every one of its well-guarded secrets.

He yearns for the time where he'll be familiar with every elusive spot that makes Mydei whine high on his throat, the quickest method to make him surrender beneath his touch, the limits he could take before he's pushing Phainon away and begging him to stop, and so many more mysteries that he is longing to discover.

Phainon will take his time. Mydei isn't someone that should be taken so hastily, but rather, be savored with reverence befitting of a prince. A king. A *god*.

He plants a long kiss upon Mydei's navel, now close to the heated desire he'd promised to take in his mouth in what had seemed to be an eternity ago. He commends Mydei's patience with him, and this time, delays no longer in licking a stripe from the base of the flushed length up to the tip.

Mydei's legs try to close up instinctively, trapping Phainon's head in a tight squeeze. The abruptness of it all leaves Phainon's mind reeling, panting as he grinds his hips into the mattress in favor of soothing his own cock, throbbing at the sudden surge of arousal.

It is rather unbecoming how he's able to want for more, to have Mydei suffocate him in between his thighs and break his neck from the sheer force of it. Such is bound to be an intoxicating experience.

"I—" Mydei frees up some space for Phainon to be able to breathe upon realizing what he'd just done. "Sorry, I wasn't—"

"Do it again."

"W-What?"

Instead of a reply, Phainon takes both of Mydei's thighs in his hands and forces them close, his head still in between. The feeling of those muscles flexing against the sides of his face is utterly incomparable to anything else. Rare are the moments where his mind is rendered into a state of emptiness.

If he knew that being trapped in between Mydei's thighs is able to grant him such peace, he would've asked Mydei to contain him in such a manner during days where he desperately needed to stop thinking.

He chances a glance upward and sees Mydei gazing down at him with slicked lips bitten raw, heavily lidded golden eyes glinting with realization. Benevolent as ever, Mydei indulges him by squeezing his head in between and rendering Phainon unable to come up with any sane thought, succumbing to the mind-numbing bliss as he puffs labored breaths against the sensitive skin of Mydei's inner thigh.

The hand behind his head lightly pushes him down until his lips meet the tip of a cock. In a show of gratitude, Phainon encloses the head in his mouth without needing much encouragement, swirling his tongue and letting it dig into the slit in favor of getting more of the slightly bitter taste of pre-cum that seeped from within.

A muffled gasp resounds above him, though Phainon could barely hear it with the ringing in his ears and Mydei's thighs squeezing him periodically with every deliberate suck, quivering as it does so.

Phainon takes more of the length in his mouth, the heavy weight of Mydei on his tongue thick enough for his jaw to ache a little as he's able to taste the dried remnants of his release from earlier. It's almost as if he'd laid claim of Mydei without knowing, without the intention of it, and wonders what Mydei had thought when his cum painted him white.

Eyes fluttering shut, Phainon rises in tiny increments, teeth dragging slightly at the length as he commits every vein to memory. When he reaches the head, he slides back down until he feels the tip graze the back of his throat. His grip on Mydei's thighs turn bruising when he chokes, but the hand at the back of his head keeps him low, combing through soft locks in a show of affectionate contradiction.

Eyes watering, Phainon watches from below as Mydei relishes in the feeling of the inexperienced throat spasming around his cock as Phainon gags. The sight of Mydei falling apart beneath him is enough of an incentive for Phainon to keep going, swallowing around the length until his nose is buried upon the fine hairs.

He groans at the thought of having Mydei on his tongue for as long as he's allowed, keeping him warm and drinking him in. Pulling back, he is able to take in a breath before diving back in once again, just to see how well he could take the length in its entirety for a second time, always aiming to please.

Though Mydei is not particularly loud in conveying his pleasure, the tiny sighs and gasps are more than enough to come from a man so inhibited. It serves as an encouragement more than anything as Phainon keeps his rhythm slow but thorough, eager for the day to come where his experience renders him capable of taking Mydei at a quicker pace.

In mere moments, the fingers on his hair who have only sought to offer gentle caresses have grown tight in their hold, nails digging into Phainon's scalp as the cock in his mouth twitches. Phainon was only able to glance up upon Mydei at the last minute before the hand pushes him down and holds him still.

A couple of pulses against his tongue was the only warning Phainon got before his head was squeezed so tightly he feared that he might lose consciousness, followed by something warm and thick flooding his mouth as the tip of Mydei's cock hits the back of his throat.

Phainon moans from the overwhelming sensations he's currently experiencing simultaneously, a rush of heat in his groin at the feeling of being used. He swallows Mydei's spend, heart singing with great fulfillment, his thirst rendered non-existent like a traveler who had finally gotten a drink of clean water after an arduous journey.

When he pulls away, the taste of Mydei lingers on his tongue, one that he's sure he would soon begin to seek the moment that it fades away, washed down by delicacies of which could not even begin to compare.

Mydei was breathless against the sheets, chest heaving. Even such an act as taking in air could be so enticing if it's Mydei.

"How did I do?" Phainon asks, crawling over so he could press himself fully against the other, longing to be close in proximity as much as possible. "Did you enjoy my services, Your Highness?"

Mydei does not smile. "You treat yourself like a common whore?"

"Can I not be that for you? I assure you, my rates are fair and cheap." Phainon leans in to press a kiss at Mydei's lashes, wet with unshed tears. "For you, I'll even allow a discount."

A huff resounds before Mydei pulls him in for a proper linking of lips, no doubt tasting himself within Phainon's mouth. "A *haikas* through and through."

Phainon hums, if Mydei calls him that word enough, he might be able to figure out what it meant through context clues alone. “Am I so undeserving of praise? Rest assured, I have now come to realize that the opposite results in the same effects.”

To further prove his point, Phainon grinds his aching cock against Mydei’s hip, raring to go again from the mere act of pleasuring the other. Contrary to what he initially expected, Mydei does not call him out for it, or leave the kline now that he’s satisfied.

Instead, against Phainon’s lips, he softly mutters, like a secret meant to be kept between them, “There’s a vial of oil in the box I’ve brought. Prepare me with it.”

Phainon’s mind blanks, staring unblinkingly down at Mydei who didn’t even seem as if he were kidding. *When* did Mydei ever make jests like *this?*

“Pardon me,” Phainon says, his voice a foreign sound to his ears as he slightly pulls back, supporting himself on his elbows. “Could you please repeat the question?”

“I didn’t ask anything,” Mydei tells him.

“Oh.” Phainon nods, feeling stupid.

He didn’t think they would go this far. Well. He didn’t think they would go this far *today*. They’ve only shared their first kiss barely a week ago. Surely there’s an appropriate sequence to be done before taking a lover to bed. Or perhaps, Mydei just doesn’t care for such trivialities.

Dread sinks low in Phainon’s gut, spurred on by terrible, *terrible* jealousy. He only made assumptions as to what Mydei does in his free time whenever he’s not with Phainon. And though engaging in casual intimacy hadn’t been something he thought Mydei would allow himself to indulge in, the idea that perhaps he’d been wrong in thinking as such makes him feel rotten.

“Phainon?”

The thoughts in Phainon’s mind hadn’t ceased in escalating themselves, but he still manages a half-hearted tease. “Be patient.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “You’re growing soft,” he says, nodding at Phainon’s cock who has now started to go flaccid in the face of his insecurity. “You won’t be able to take me in such a state.”

Phainon can’t even begin to be embarrassed. “I’ll be the judge of that.”

He leans over to the side of the bed to reach out for the box, opening it with one hand to procure the aforementioned vial. He then settles himself once again in between Mydei’s legs, popping off the cork and drizzling the oil upon his fingers.

“Will you guide me?” Phainon asks. “It’s just— I’ve never—”

And though he's sincere with his intentions of not wanting to do something that might end up hurting Mydei, he can't help the bitterness that gnaws at him incessantly. He only feels affection for Mydei regardless, but as of this moment, such yearnings of the heart is on par with how much he wants to bash someone's head in—particularly the person who's had Mydei like this.

A warm hand steadying his shaky ones pulls him out of his stupor. Mydei's eyes glint as he looks up at him with something akin to fondness.

"Come here."

Phainon falls so willingly, sighing against Mydei's lips. The kiss is effective in driving away the lingering doubts. Only then does he begin to think that it matters not if Mydei had done this before, and with *who*. If anything, Phainon ought to be grateful that Mydei even gave him the time of day.

Supporting himself with his other hand, he allows Mydei to guide his slick fingers between his legs, past his now hardening cock still soiled with his initial release, and down to his perineum, sliding it lower to prod gently against the furled texture of muscle.

In only a short period of time, his middle finger had begun to sink into the tightness, the slick oil aiding the slide until his sensations have been narrowed down to the pulsing warmth, squeezing him up to the knuckle.

"I—" Phainon swallows thickly, unsure what to do next. His instincts scream at him to take Mydei right then and there, to have the exquisite pressure be felt around his cock instead of his measly fingers. "Mydei—"

Mydei's hand holds his wrist steady while the other cups his face, pulling him for another kiss, enough to stave off the panic, and the hunger.

"You've been so eager to have me prior to this that I assumed you already knew what to do," Mydei muses, lips curling in a small smile, a show of amusement that Phainon didn't have the wits to dispute against.

Despite the teasing remark, a hint of warmth belies the tone. It almost sounds as if Mydei is pleased at Phainon's inexperience. He is at an utter loss on how he should take that for it didn't even seem like the other was undermining him.

So what does it matter if Mydei had indeed done this sort of thing before? It's *not* a competition!

(It is, and Phainon aims to win. If he beds Mydei more times than Mydei has bedded others, then the victory is his to claim.

And then he realizes that doing such a thing still adds to Mydei's count. Perhaps Phainon should just fling himself off a window, or do something else of equal fatality.)

“Only this once, I’ll assist you,” Mydei continues, pushing and pulling at Phainon’s hand so his finger slid into the warmth in slow and consistent thrusts. Phainon could see how Mydei’s breathing started to catch every time his knuckle met the cleft of his ass, eyes of gold becoming unfocused. “If you are to honor me as an equal even in intimacy, I’d like for you to pay attention.” Then, “Curl your finger for—*hnn*—”

Phainon had done the request in an instant, but stops upon hearing a low sound escape Mydei’s lips regardless of the hold on his wrist, of which had failed to keep him inside no matter how hard Mydei pulled considering that they’re evenly matched when it comes to strength.

“Did I hurt you?”

Mydei’s flushed face offers him a failed attempt at a scowl. “I’m not going to break, Deliverer. I won’t even die from this.”

“You can’t die from anything. So your statement doesn’t hold much water, really.”

A disgruntled huff. “*Insufferable*. Even in *this* circumstance—”

Phainon resumes his movements, guiding his finger back in, curled just slightly as instructed. Mydei’s grip on his wrist becomes tight enough that Phainon wouldn’t be surprised if there’s a suspicious, hand-shaped bruise forming hours later.

“Add another,” Mydei pants. “Now.”

“Gods, you really have no patience.”

“It’s been *two* Titan-forsaken quints!”

Phainon turns at the Oronyx device hung upon his wall to verify. The claim is near close to the truth, but, “It’s only been *a* quint.”

“Two if you keep up this pace.” With his other hand, he takes Phainon’s chin and pinches, thumb and forefinger digging harshly into Phainon’s cheeks. “Put another in, and I’ll let you claim me for how many times as you please.”

Phainon was going to do so anyway for he could never deny Mydei for so long, but he’s not going to turn down such a generous offer.

“Is that a reward?” he asks, feeling his length twitch out of interest at the mere thought of having Mydei for an entire day, and the next, *and* the one after that. “You think so highly of yourself.”

“Forget I said anything, then.”

Phainon laughs, coaxing Mydei’s lips to accept his as he adds another finger in, spreading them lightly for a more comfortable grip against the warm and tight walls, only to be pleasantly surprised when Mydei arches against him. The hold on his wrist has disappeared, replaced by a searing pain against his back, nails digging harshly into the skin.

Mydei pants hotly against his lips. "*Phainon*—"

Phainon catches the moan with a kiss. "I won't forget," he promises, thrusting his fingers in and out, quicker this time as he searches for that one spot that had rendered Mydei so pliant in his embrace. "My Dei, let me have you for as many times as I want."

It almost sounds like a plea, and it is. Though he is the one in charge of the motions, Phainon realizes that he's not exactly entirely in control. Mydei could say the word and everything would cease; Phainon would stop at command, his own pleasure be damned.

With his head buried against Phainon's neck, Mydei's entire body quivers when Phainon presses lightly against a distinct area within the fleshy cavern, soft and rubbery. It produces the desired effects—Mydei's embrace tightening around his neck and legs wrapped around his waist as if having something to hold on to keeps him from slipping into a territory deprived of reason.

Though Phainon feels his length be caught in between their bodies, he pays no mind to the throbbing heat pooling low in his belly in favor of giving Mydei his pleasure. That alone is more than enough.

"Another," Mydei mutters wetly against his ear. "I can—*hah*—take another."

Phainon inhales deeply at the sweet-scented hair, half-damp from earlier's revelry and the sweat. "Of course you can," he replies softly, a praise meant to be said out loud. "I bet you can take anything I give you. An immortal body like yours is bound to withstand it."

There's no need to wait for a reply when Mydei could barely speak, the only thing escaping his lips being wordless sounds muffled against Phainon's skin.

A third finger presses upon the entrance, joining the other ones in a single thrust. Mydei's chest heaves irregularly, the slide of the chains in between their bodies growing slightly more uncomfortable with each passing moment.

With his fingers still enclosed within Mydei's warmth, he pulls away, hearing Mydei let out a soft disgruntled sound as he does so, peering up at him with a frown. Phainon resumes the thrusting of his hand to sate the other while he examines the golden chains with furrowed eyebrows, wondering if there's a way to have it undone and set Mydei free from its ornate confines.

He loved the accessory more than anything, sure, but he would *really* like for it to go. Though Mydei is a magnificent sight to behold wearing it—as is once again proven right at this moment when the chains of gold shimmered with every enticing quake of Mydei's body, neck craned to the side with eyes clenched shut as a knuckle was pressed against his lips to muffle any sinful noise—Phainon yearns to simply have Mydei's bare skin pressed against his, devoid of fanciful elements.

Mydei is more than stunning enough when bare, and that much is the truth when Phainon finally unclasps the tiny lock by the side of Mydei's exposed neck, holding the entire

ensemble together no longer. The bejewelled chains spill away from Mydei's skin like a waterfall parting to expose the real treasure within.

Without the shiny distractions, Phainon is able to see the pattern of the scarlet streaks upon Mydei's skin so clearly. The thin sheen of sweat makes him look positively glowing, or perhaps the winding crimson seemed more prominent than before, a striking contrast to the golden honey it is etched upon.

"You are so beautiful," Phainon is able to say, breathless as he does. *You've taken my heart so ruthlessly and I let you.*

The corners of Mydei's eyes redden with shame as he covers his face beneath shaky hands, little sounds of pleasure nothing but a blessing for one's ears despite being muffled.

Phainon leans close to pry Mydei's hands away. "Don't hide from me."

The gleam in Mydei's gold eyes remain, but the quiver in those glazed pupils conveys the lack of usual attention. Lost in the throes of pleasure as Phainon presses his fingers in once again, prodding gently at the cheeky bundle of nerves that have rendered the crown prince of Kremnos in such a state.

"Need you," Mydei gasps, hands pawing at Phainon's shoulders and back, the legs wrapped around Phainon's waist squeezing down pointedly, trying to get him ever so closer. "Phainon —"

After one final thrust, Phainon pulls his fingers away with a slick sound, using the remaining oil to lubricate his cock. It didn't require much to ease the glide with how Phainon has been dripping this entire time.

Taking in labored breaths, Phainon feels his face flush warm and his sight turn hazy when he nudges the tip against Mydei's loosened hole that's clenching around nothing. He presses his forehead against Mydei, nosing lightly at his face to get him to pay attention.

"Mydei."

Eyes of gold flash in a bout of clarity upon being called upon so desperately, and the next thing Phainon knew is of him being maneuvered on his back as Mydei straddles him.

"If you plan to take me like so, you should do it with the conviction befitting of a Kremnoan's mate," Mydei tells him, the supposed sharp edges of the admonishment softened by his obvious desire.

Phainon feels heat lick low in his belly. He'd rather die than admit out loud how much he likes this, rendered so helpless beneath such radiance. He smiles, half parts teasing and sheepish as he settles a hand upon Mydei's waist. He doesn't squeeze the flesh, just needed to touch.

"I simply don't wish to hurt you with my inadequacy," Phainon tells him. With his other hand, he takes Mydei's in his and brings it close to his lips, pressing a kiss to convey his

adoration. “Please, have me as you see fit, my Dei.”

Mydei’s lips part ever so slightly, seemingly pondering on what to say in return. “If you think of yourself so lowly, you only serve to insult me.”

He reaches behind him and aligns himself with Phainon’s aching desire, sinking down the length without much preamble, slow and steady, gradually enclosing Phainon in his heat that only served to bear various exquisite sensations, deserving of odes and praises sung to its name.

Now fully seated, the light shivers of Mydei’s body beneath Phainon’s touch betrays the calm facade that formers intends to show. But those twin pools of gold, swirling with unspoken want—it has always been honest.

Mydei takes Phainon’s hand on his waist and brings it to his lips, just as Phainon had done for him. A soft kiss is pressed upon every scarred digit, their gazes locked in an unblinking connection that wouldn’t be severed even if all of Amphoreus were to be thrown in peril.

“*Philtas*, you have always been, and always will be *my equal*.”

Phainon’s breath catches in his throat. The Kremnoan word of address bears the same inflections as the other one that Mydei tends to refer to him. But *why* does this one feel different?

Questions would serve to torment his mind no longer, brain reduced to mush when Mydei starts to move, hips grinding in indulgent circles that only serves to drive Phainon insane. The clench of searing hot walls around him is simply intoxicating, his body alight with pleasure until all he could do is pant into Mydei’s hand that he holds for purchase, face nuzzling against the touch of warmth intermingling with the coolness of the golden bands worn so tastefully around Mydei’s long fingers.

It does the job to keep Phainon grounded for the *most* part.

“Mydei,” he manages, gazing up tearfully. “*Mercy*.”

Mydei ruthlessly does not grant him such, rising from the length ever so slowly before dropping back down with a shaky exhale, leading Phainon’s hand lower to rest upon his chest so that Phainon may feel the erratic beating of his heart as he rode him like he were the mightiest steed in all of Amphoreus.

Phainon could only ever take it, powerless. If this were a competition, he had already lost. Willingly so for he could only ever bear to lay down his defenses in the hands of his dear Mydeimos.

Such overwhelming emotions had him desiring to be much closer than he is now regardless of how intimately connected they already were. And so he pulls himself up, fulfilling the need for proximity—to be a moth devoured by the flame so fully he’d no longer know anything else. In their embrace, there were no soft caresses, only desperate need.

As Phainon latches his lips upon the heated skin of Mydei's neck, he longs to be consumed by his lone beloved's essence entirely—to drown in Mydei's scent, in the aborted sighs and choked moans, the sensual slide of their bodies as he lets Mydei drag them both to the edge where the stars make themselves known in a land where night is foreign.

"Mydei—" Phainon moans, catching Mydei's parted lips in a wanton kiss, licking into his mouth like a man starved for sustenance.

"Phainon," Mydei murmurs back, an answer amidst the clack of teeth and the sting of bites. "You're being so good for me."

The praise sends shivers down Phainon's spine as he feels himself thrust further into that tight heat, heels digging against the mattress as his other hand grips the sheets from behind him for balance, matching the pace Mydei had set with equal urgency.

Pleasure sings through his veins as he lets himself drown in it, the sounds of their bodies coming together with every filthy grind, every push and pull, open-mouthed kisses mingling with labored breaths and shaky exhales.

It is a lascivious score that drowns out the melodic strings and happy singing echoing all throughout the Marmoreal Palace, fueling the revelry for hours to come. In this quiet corner of theirs, a solace is found in each other—away from the outside world, from watching eyes and judgement, from duties that bore a weight so heavy.

Here, Phainon lets Mydei have him as he is, and claims Mydei in return. Not as rivals in a duel, or as friends in a spar; this is far more intricate than that.

Phainon wallows in his delusions and calls them lovers, for in this period of time with Oronyx as their witness, he is held as one and beholds Mydei in the same manner. He'll keep his sentiments a secret for only his heart to bear. Even when his lips spill a single name, not once did it dare utter anything more, letting his touch speak for itself, rubbing Mydei's skin raw until it rippled hot beneath his hand and the numbed callouses of his skin is able to know the shape of Mydei's flesh even in blindness.

Blunt nails begin to dig into his scalp as the tempo quickens, Mydei's need palpable enough to taste in the air, ever rising as his breaths strained and his neck craned back, baring his throat for Phainon to sink his teeth into hard enough to draw blood, staining his lips in shimmering gold.

Mydei gasps. "*Mmmh*— Close—!" His thighs begin to quiver, from the exertion or pleasure. Perhaps both.

"Pay me no mind," Phainon manages as he snakes a hand between them to aid Mydei in his completion. "Release it upon me whenever."

Mydei only makes garbled sound, hips moving in shallow grinds to chase his own pleasure, situating Phainon's cock deep within him to hit a certain spot that had him arching into the embrace. Phainon was there to hold him through it, pumping his hand swiftly while the other supported Mydei's back, the pads of his fingers digging slightly upon the muscle.

When the bone of Mydei's spine encounters his touch, it is then that Mydei surrenders fully against him, a choked moan quickly pressed into Phainon's lips in a barely-kiss to suppress it as warm spurts of cum painted the narrow space between them white.

Phainon groans at the tightening sensation against his cock, maddening enough to be the sole reason for his undoing as he thrusts widely into Mydei's warmth, savoring how it welcomes him still despite the shivering of Mydei's body from too much stimulation.

"Mydei," he whispers through heavy pants, jostling Mydei above him. "*My* Dei."

Mydei watches him from above as he gasped for breath, reflecting so clearly his desperation in a golden mirror. It is then that Phainon had forsaken all reason. If he were to look like a man gone mad, he might as well act like one.

He maneuvers Mydei on the kline, a hand at the back of his head to pin him down against the pillows as he presses back in, covering Mydei's body with his own from behind, thrusting wildly with abandon into that searing heat that serves to drive him dizzy with want.

"Phainon— *Haikas*, slow down—*ngh!*"

"A little more," he promises emptily against the shell of Mydei's ear, sucking lightly at the sensitive skin. "Endure for me."

Mydei muffles his cries and curses into the mattress, his cheek chafing against the sheets. And yet, not once did his hips falter in meeting Phainon's deranged motions, surprisingly accepting of such outrageous behavior.

"You take me so well," Phainon says, sinking his teeth into the flesh of Mydei's shoulder, tasting the skin and sweat. "How are you so perfect?"

Everything about Mydei is comparable to that of the most intoxicating ambrosia, and Phainon lets himself indulge in several mouthfuls like a classless glutton. A walking temptation, and Phainon is no such higher being to have the power to look away, nor is he above such instincts spurred on by desires of the flesh.

Mydei says nothing, only capable of spilling wordless sounds as Phainon has his way with him, eyes glazed over whilst his fingers tore through the bedding, grappling for purchase.

Phainon takes Mydei's hand in his, nearing his own high. Shakily, he makes an attempt to sound coherent while he's still able to afford the courtesy of asking, "Where do you—*hah*—want it?"

Mydei tightens upon him at the question, and Phainon could only gasp against the heated skin of Mydei's nape at the sudden jolt of mind-numbing pleasure.

"Inside," Mydei says raggedly through moans and barely-contained whimpers. "Claim me from within…"

The request had his inhibitions swept clean, words he's only ever heard in dreams that left him laden with unadulterated want upon his waking hours finally spoken to reality.

Mydei meets his gaze from beneath, glinting gold against the light, watching him succumb to his undoing. Phainon's climax leaves him winded, curling over Mydei as he spills into the searing confines with a wrecked moan, hips rutting a few more times without much finesse.

The walls only clenched against his twitching length as if to milk him empty, wickedly greedy as Mydei's hole drinks him in with nary a care to the aftershocks of his release.

It is a stark contrast to his considerate behavior from earlier, and Phainon really wonders if Mydei had read his mind, laying bare his needs meant to be kept hidden lest Phainon is to be considered as insane. And maybe he is, huffing out a breathless laugh when Mydei moves against him in small grinds, but not subtle enough to be an accident.

He relishes in the pain that oversensitivity has brought, and with it, tiny jolts of pleasure that had his cock stirring with interest in no time. He hasn't even pulled out yet, keeping Mydei plugged up with his spend as if they had hopes to conceive. And now, it is Mydei who's already urging him for another round.

Almost like a challenge.

"Not affording me rest, are you?" Phainon asks, throwing Mydei's question from the dance back at him.

In return, Mydei responds with a line of Phainon's own making. "Not like you to be so weary already."

Phainon turns him around to lay on his back, raising an eyebrow at the obviously recent splash of cum against Mydei's abdomen. Regardless of the proof in front of him, Mydei is still, by all means, raring to go.

"What a beast."

The beast in question tilts his head to the side, flawless skin on display regardless of how many times Phainon had sunk his teeth into it. His lashes flatter demurely, gold eyes half hidden behind heavy eyelids. It does a poor job in concealing the headiness of want.

Mydei strokes himself languidly, the rings on his fingers glinting with the movement, putting on a show for Phainon alone as if to entice him into having him again. Safe to say, Phainon didn't need much convincing, dipping his head low as he captures Mydei's lips in bruising kiss, pressing back into the tight heat that welcomes him fully with ease.

Time persists as it always does, and the bed has been soaked through with the evidence of their depravity. Their tangled limbs dragged across the kline, leaving no surface untouched by the intensity of their embrace. In this moment, they have relinquished all that they are—their titles, their responsibilities, their well-crafted facades.

It is rather impossible to uphold all pretenses when their bodies moved as if they were made to come together. As Phainon pushed relentlessly into the man beneath him, Mydei makes it impossible for him to forget the gleam of searing gold that engraves itself permanently in

Phainon's memories, in his *soul* even, so he may take such a vision to the nether realm to aid him in finding Mydei again in the next life.

In return, Phainon makes sure that it is impossible to forget this. Even if Mydei might have taken past lovers before, Phainon strives to reduce those encounters to nothing—make *him* be the forefront in Mydei's mind whenever he aches for pleasure. And it will be Phainon that he seeks. No one else.

Though the revelry in the Marmoreal Palace had ended when the bell signalling the end of the day tolls, welcoming a new Entry Hour, neither Phainon nor Mydei withdrew from each other's embrace. Every tremble of their release have been ignored in favor of chasing the next one.

In the silence of the morning anew, Phainon's chambers knew no such peace. Gasps traded in between parted lips and wet kisses, murmurs of names and of prayers, of pleas and teases and taunts, of the slick sound as their bodies slid together in a tireless dance.

The walls shall echo with it long after they've risen to the bank of clouds in the skies, descending shortly after in complete satiation. With even the palace attendants drunk in wine and fruit, no witnesses were able to attest how the muffled sounds of a kline creaking for several quints long had resonated through the halls.

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*A **Kremnoan matrimonial dagger** is the most essential element in sealing the union between equals. Before consummation, the couple must first **smear each other's blood onto the blade's initials as a way of binding their souls unconditionally in both life and in death**.*

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Traditions: Culture and Customs throughout History

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present time

Oh.

Oh.

Two pairs of eyes stare at him, faces pale with unbridled shock.

He'd wondered, given how confident Mydei had been, if he'd taken past lovers before—if Phainon was nothing more than a passing fancy meant to soothe his burdens brought on by the Flame-Chase Journey.

No.

Phainon had been *right* in his assumptions that Mydei isn't one to indulge in such acts. He only ever did so with Phainon because—

"We were married."

Castorice and Tribbie didn't even bother to clap for his astounding revelation.

Phainon buries his head in his hands. "By Kephale, I am an idiot."

"I can't say I disagree," Castorice says calmly. Despite how soft-spoken she tends to be, the way she said those words was distinctly louder than what Phainon is used to. "Lord Phainon, you are indeed, as you have said, an idiot."

Tribbie, on the other hand, looked at a loss for words. Though Phainon made sure that his story-telling didn't contain anything too explicit or embarrassing, it seemed that he still managed to get the point across.

The point of which he failed to see before Mydei threw him off the balcony. Perhaps the fall had rattled his brain for good.

"Snowy," Tribbie began. "Why didn't you just read the scroll Agy gave you?"

A damn good question. Even better than the utterly unhinged ones Professor Anaxa writes in his exams.

"I was going to read it at some point," Phainon reasons to an audience who is so, *so* tired of him. It's been a full day. "But I rarely had the time to read anything!"

Tribbie shakes her head, tutting like a thoroughly disappointed mother. "You are in deep trouble, Snowy."

"Very well said, Lady Tribbie," Castorice adds.

Phainon comes to realize that no one in the room is on his side. Which is fair. He'd also take Mydei's side any day. Actually, it would really make him happy if he were at Mydei's side right now.

"Have you come up with a plan to pacify Lord Mydei?" Castorice asks, as if there's still a chance for Phainon to turn things around (there isn't). "Now that you've recounted the whole story leading up to your marriage, I can't help but sympathize with Lord Mydei's situation."

"I'm in the process of it," Phainon tells her, ignoring the throbbing pain in his ribs. "Titans, he must really hate me now."

Tribbie gives him a pat on the knee, light enough to not hurt him through the bandages. “De might be angry, but we believe that he wouldn’t be able to truly hate you,” she reassures. Her wide eyes give Phainon hope. “You’re his husband, Snowy. As long as you play your cards right, we’re sure he’ll return to you in no time.”

Love advice from a centuries-old child. At this point, Phainon would take all the help he could get to save his failing marriage. First day as a conscious husband and he already screwed it up by almost dying. He has his work cut out for him, he supposes.

“Thank you for the words of encouragement, Lady Tribbie,” he says.

“We’re sorry we weren’t able to help you sooner, Snowy. Even we didn’t know about this until now.”

Tribbie and Phainon both turn to Castorice.

“I had no idea as well,” Castorice tells them. “Although, Lord Mydei does talk about you a lot, Lord Phainon.”

Phainon perks up and winces at the pain the slight movement had caused him. “Good things I hope?”

Castorice smiles mysteriously. Perhaps Aglaea’s company has been rubbing off on her. “I cannot disclose what he has said during our recreation time. You’ll have to ask Lord Mydei when… you’ve settled this.”

This is the first that Phainon hears of this ‘recreation time,’ and he wonders why he’s not invited. That’s the thing about Mydei: he’s the type of man to see or do something so interesting (read: get married) and keep it to himself unless someone asks. It ~~endears~~ annoys Phainon to no end that from now on, he’ll make it a point to ask about literally *everything* the man had done for the day.

“Have hope, Lord Phainon.”

Phainon tries, really. May the gods strike him down this instant. He’d been an utter fool that even the murals painted on the walls of the Marmoreal Palace possessed a better eyesight than him to see through this farce. If Mydei wants nothing to do with him after this, then it would be better to forfeit his existence entirely to make up for his sheer stupidity.

He sighs. “You know, Miss Castorice, I could really use a hug right now.”

“And that is my cue to leave,” Castorice says, walking towards the door in graceful yet hurried steps. “Lady Tribbie, have a good rest of your day. Lord Phainon, I hope you get well soon. Oh, and for your injuries to heal nicely, I suppose.”

Phainon gapes as the door closes behind Castorice, before turning to Tribbie who was fixing up the medicine tray, deciding which ones to take back to the infirmary.

Seeing his chance, Phainon bolts out of his chair, ignoring the pain that sparks throughout his entire body as he limps towards an open window. Before he could reach it, however, Tribbie

had already run past him to slam the shutters close.

“Snowy! What were you thinking?”

Phainon concedes and crumples into a pitiful ball on the floor. “My husband is mad at me. I should die.”

Chapter End Notes

well. they finally did it (and they'll be doing it some more oh god rip to my thesaurus)

don't ask me why the foreplay is several thousands of words long. this fic in its entirety can be considered as foreplay itself. also, let it be known that smut reduced my vocab to a mere 3 words.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

as always, thank you so so much for reading ALL OF THIS 20k MESS. really, if you read all that, i appreciate it so much. i love yall *sends hugs and kisses*

Chapter 10: a heart unmade, again with hope

Chapter Summary

> Thoughts mired in uncertainty fester in the shadows. In the stillness that remains, Phainon eventually finds the answer that he seeks.

Chapter Notes

> special thanks to riikyun @_yn319 for drawing phainon asking for forgiveness from his husband... drooping ahoge and everything :'>
>
> do check it out if you haven't yet!! 💗

See the end of the chapter for more notes

the marriage

a couple of months before the present time

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To His Highness, the Crown Prince Mydeimos,

I write with sincere appreciation for your kindness toward my family. ***The kline you have so generously gifted brings us immeasurable relief.*** *Thus, our bodies shall rest in the quiet hours, capable of rising fully and ready to be of service in the coming morrows.*

I shall speak of your consideration to my sons and daughters, and they too shall pass it down to generations next. ***Then, this bloodline of mine would only know of the Crown Prince Mydeimos as the most benevolent and honorable of all.***

Your loyal servant,

Perimlaus

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The curtains were drawn open, letting Kephale's Dawn spill into the room from the open windows. The balcony door follows, and a cold gust of morning air sends a distinct chill upon the exposed skin of Phainon's chest, the only thing that kept him warm still being a mere blanket haphazardly thrown over his lower half in his sleep.

He hears footsteps walking around the room, the pace steady and unhurried, metal greaves a familiar wake up call. Still wrestling against the desire to remain unconscious and just sink into the pillows, Phainon pulls the blanket over himself only for it to be sharply pulled back by a merciless perpetrator.

Phainon makes a disgruntled noise, eyes still adamantly closed. A soft huff resounds then, followed by the dipping of the mattress beside him.

"Get up, Deliverer."

Phainon turns the other way around, away from the shine of Dawn. "No."

He can hear Mydei shuffle about, grabbing the pillows strewn all over the bed. Phainon has an inkling as to what the other was planning to do, and instead of turning around to see for himself if his assumptions are correct, he would rather cherish the remaining time he has left before he's—

As if willed by the fates, Mydei hoists him up in a sitting position, resting him against the aforementioned pile of pillows. Phainon's head droops down. Though his eyes remain closed, he's very much awake now.

A warm hand lightly grabs him by the chin, and Phainon knows through routine that it's his cue to open his mouth obediently or there *will* be consequences. The cold metal of the spoon grazes his bottom lip as Mydei feeds him something sweet and flaky, the taste enough to comfort his soul after such a rude awakening.

Phainon talks as he chews. "What's this?"

"Bougatsa," Mydei replies. The hint of dismay in his tone is noticeable. "Don't talk to me while your mouth is full. Have you no manners?"

Phainon withholds the cheeky reply he's come up with in his mind in favor of his survivability, and swallows. "Too early."

"It's already the third quint of the Entry Hour."

"Not helping your case," Phainon says, a yawn slipping out. "Still too ear—*mmph?*"

Mydei had used the chance to shove another spoonful of bougatsa into Phainon's open mouth. Already an opportunist this early in the morning. Phainon is incredibly impressed and disgruntled.

He opens his eyes to shoot a glare, gaze softening immediately at the sight of Mydei bathed in the morning light. At this moment, Phainon knew he'd lost the battle. And the war. And all things thereafter.

“This is unfair.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. This mild shift in expression had some drastic effects on Phainon’s poor heart. “Says the man currently being fed like a *child*. Should I dress you up as well?”

Phainon smiles. “We both know you prefer me *un*dressed, dear Mydeimos.”

“You really have no shame.”

Despite the words, Mydei then proceeds to undo the loose ties of Phainon’s sleeping pants. Phainon can’t help but bite back a laugh, reaching an arm out to wrap it around Mydei’s waist in an attempt to pull him back to bed.

“Well, it’s never too early for *that*, I suppose.”

Mydei surprisingly doesn’t put up much of a fight, begrudgingly letting himself be situated on Phainon’s lap. It doesn’t escape Phainon’s notice, however, how the other’s golden eyes have grown sharper, a crease in between his brows, looking equal parts exasperated and amused.

“Haven’t you had enough from yesterday?” Mydei asks.

Phainon nuzzles against Mydei’s neck, breathing in the sweet scent of pomegranates and tamping down the disappointment of Mydei taking a bath without him. He paws at Mydei’s armor, hands sluggish with sleep when it would otherwise be skillful.

He replies, “You know I can never get enough of you.”

Before Phainon’s hand could undo Mydei’s belt, Mydei had already left the bed quicker than Zagreus Themself would have, leaving Phainon cold. He stares up, bewildered at the sudden loss only to witness the flush creep up on Mydei’s face, high on his cheeks.

“Eat your food,” Mydei tells him, voice rough around the edges. He then proceeds to right his armor after Phainon did the liberty of messing it up. “If I see even a single morsel left on your plate, Deliverer, don’t expect me to serve you anything by the *deipnon*.”

Phainon turns his gaze at the tray of food by the edge of the bed. A generous serving of bougatsa, some fresh fruits, and a… cup of an unnamed liquid that Phainon would bet his life on is a mix of juiced pomegranates and some other abominable ‘ingredient of the day’ that Mydei decided to add.

Ignoring the existence of the drink, Phainon picks up a piece of grape and pops it in his mouth. “You know I always eat whatever you make.”

Mydei says nothing at the poorly-disguised attempt at getting in his good graces. He throws Phainon a satchel, substantially heavy as the latter caught it with a grunt.

Perplexed, Phainon opens the flap to examine the contents. “What’s this?”

“Take it with you on your mission,” Mydei tells him, his tone making it evident that there’s no room for negotiations.

Phainon raises an eyebrow when he sees two loaves of bread from within, sliced meats and cheese neatly arranged in a portable clay container, as well as a jug of water. “You packed me some lunch?” His heart swells with affection as he gazes up at Mydei. “Thank you.”

Mydei does not return his smile. “There’s also some medical supplies in there.”

“For what? I’ll be back by the Parting Hour.”

It’s not like Phainon is going on an expedition. Aglaea only tasked him to check the current state of Okhema’s borders just in case the Titankin had broken through somehow. If he’s lucky, he wouldn’t even need to engage in battle.

Mydei scoffs. “‘For what?’ he says. The last time you were ‘back by the Parting Hour,’ I had my teleslate bombarded with several messages informing me of how their Lord Phainon is gravely injured and in *dire* need of assistance.” His frown deepens. “All for a measly stab wound on the leg. You bled so much you put Kephale to shame.”

Phainon stares, taken aback (and feeling severely faint).

“You… knew about that?” he asks nonetheless even if there really was no point in doing so.

The truth was clear as day—Mydei knew of his blunder from several weeks ago where his mind was far too distracted (unsurprisingly, by thoughts of Mydei) to even focus on his skirmish against Nikador’s Titankin. As a result of his carelessness, he came back to Okhema with his consciousness hanging by a thread with how much he’s bled all the way from the Abyss.

Mydei crosses his arms, looking far from being impressed. Voice dripping with sarcasm, he replies, “Perhaps not, considering that *I* was the one who carried you to the infirmary.” And then he adds a sardonic, “You’re welcome, by the way.”

“You ask for gratitude now when you didn’t even bother to bring this up at a much earlier date?” Phainon demands, hiding his shame by feigning offense. He just wants to be buried under a rock at this point. Mydei must’ve thought him to be pathetic and *weak*.

“You kept mumbling ‘don’t tell Mydei’ in your sleep,” Mydei says. To his credit, he doesn’t seem to be making fun of Phainon for it. Or perhaps he’s just that good at masking his expressions. “Mydei was being kind and decided to honor a dying man’s wishes.”

Phainon scoffs. “I wasn’t *dying*. The stab wound was not fatal.”

“With your groaning and moaning, I’d think you were.”

“Odd of you to put emphasis on the sounds I make.”

“Simply returning the favor,” Mydei retorts drily. “I wouldn’t want you to feel alone in your fixation.”

Phainon parses the words with a sleep-addled mind. And then he recalls the many times he'd pinned Mydei's hands upon the sheets just so the latter wouldn't muffle the sounds he'd make in his pleasure—breathy hums and gasps, mumbled curses, ones that echo within Phainon's mind for the entire day that by the time the day has concluded, he's longing to hear it again.

He ought to feel shameful, apologetic even. But the warmth that pools in his groin as he recalls their trysts gives him a feeling he'd rather not dive into this early in the morning. Unless, of course, if Mydei is amenable—

"No."

Phainon's thoughts dissipate into thin air, much like his dreams, and he wilts like a flower. "I haven't even said anything."

Mydei scoffs. "You have that look on you. I know you well enough by now to have an idea as to what's going on in your head."

Phainon envisions sweaty tanned skin, contrasting nicely with scarlet streaks. Blonde hair fanning upon the pillows like a golden halo, and of muscles rippling with every slight shift.

"Why don't you take a guess?"

"Why don't you *start eating your food?*" Mydei shoots back. If Phainon's meal consisted of the Kremnoan crown prince, he would do so in a heartbeat. Figuratively, of course. "Aglaea expects you to be ready to leave by the Lucid Hour, doesn't she? Make sure to bring that satchel with you."

Phainon huffs, feigning exasperation. He usually would rather take nothing on relatively short trips so he wouldn't have to worry about his items in between fights. But it seems his dear prince is quite adamant this time.

"Fine," he acquiesces. "I'll bring your medical supplies just in case you'd cry yourself to sleep worrying about me."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Well, would you look at that," he muses. "The Deliverer has learned not to be stubborn."

"So you're indeed worried about me."

"Why wouldn't I be? You and that fragile mortal body of yours."

"I don't recall you saying such things about my body during our previous encounters upon this very bed."

The words seemed to have taken a moment to register. When it does, however, Phainon is blessed for the second time this morning with the sight of Mydei's face coloring a pretty shade of red, up to the tips of his ears and down to his shoulders.

Mydei scowls with significantly far less heat than if he were actually offended. Flushed and disgruntled, he doesn't humor Phainon with a reply as he walks away, leaving the room in a

flurry of crimson fabric and muttered Kremnoan curses, greaves stomping against the floor vindictively.

Phainon laughs lightly to himself as he takes the plate of bougatsa from the tray after he heard the door slam shut at Mydei's rather hasty retreat. His victory this morning was hard-won. But knowing Mydei, he's sure to pay the price for it later on.

Once the tray of food was devoid of its contents (the pot of plant upon the desk was watered with the strange version of pomegranate juice), Phainon then makes his way to his Aglaea-approved closet, his attention immediately caught by another set of clothes beholding a style so distinct that it was evident to whom they belonged to.

Mydei's own no-need-for-Aglaea-to-approve wardrobe was folded and hung neatly beside Phainon's own. Unable to help himself, Phainon takes a sleeve from Mydei's side of the closet and puts it against his nose, inhaling the fabric deeply. It smells clean, but the scent of Mydei that lingers causes a smile to draw upon Phainon's lips. He misses the man already.

Ever since Mydei had given away his kline to a Kremnoan family of seven right after the day of the Festival of Phagousa, Phainon's chambers have been serving as his place of rest and recuperation.

Seeing the situation of the said family of seven when both he and Mydei went down to the Kremnoan settlement, Phainon too had felt a rush of sympathy course through his veins, cleansed away promptly by a sense of pride upon witnessing Mydei's kindness. The man he adores is simply perfect in everything he does, dazzling both inside and out.

When Mydei had no intentions to procure another kline, however, it was Phainon's selfishness that made him suggest for Mydei to stay with him. He thought that it was a better alternative than for Mydei to stay with another. Besides, it's not like Mydei would be able to return to his chambers (now turned into a small library with Aglaea's permission).

Mydei hadn't explicitly said yes to Phainon's offer that day and merely gave him a look as if he had grown two heads. But when he came over to Phainon's chambers by the Curtain-Fall Hour with his personal belongings behind him, Phainon knew he had won.

Nothing much has changed in their relationship since then. They still fulfill their assigned duties as Chrysos Heirs during the day, and once the quiet hours have descended, they will lay together. Though their responsibilities have left them exhausted, there is something in the mere act of being in each other's embrace that invigorates—and even soothes—their weariness.

An aching body from a full day's worth of helping the citizens of Okhema is soon forgotten the moment that Phainon feels Mydei's warmth against his. Though his home is long gone, such a comforting sensation is the closest to having one, a solace only Mydei could provide.

It makes him wonder if Mydei sees his presence in the same way, but he's well aware that such pondering would only bring doubts. For now, Mydei is with him, and it should be as simple as that.

Perhaps he should've known better than to believe that something this good would last in a world mired in impermanence.

Phainon returns to his chambers later that day during the second quint of the Curtain-Fall Hour. He had made a detour to Dawncloud upon his arrival to the main city after patrolling Okhema's borders upon remembering that he had yet to submit his weekly appeal to the Council regarding their unfair policy against the Kremnoans.

He had lost count of how many appeals he had submitted, but the Council continued to shoo him away as if Phainon was nothing more than a bothersome fruit fly. The next time he'll make a visit to Dawncloud, it will be Lygus that he seeks.

Mydei was already upon the kline in his night robes, reading a scroll with a light scrunch in between his eyebrows. He simply glances up to address Phainon's presence.

"Do you serve a different Titan of Time by any chance?" was Mydei's chosen greeting, drier than the deserts of Amphoreus.

Phainon walks over to the side of the kline to approach the grumpy crown prince, leaning down to catch Mydei's lips in a kiss that's thankfully reciprocated despite Mydei biting down at his bottom lip harder than necessary. The sting lingers when Phainon pulls away.

"I didn't mean to miss the *deipnon*," Phainon reasons sincerely. He did say he would be back by the Parting Hour; Mydei must've waited for him for several quints now. He lowers himself to his knees on the floor and rests his head upon Mydei's lap, looking up apologetically in the way he knew would make Mydei forgive him. "I'm sorry."

Mydei rolls his eyes, but he looked far less aggrieved this time, one hand carding through snowy locks of hair as if on instinct. "Your supper is over there." He nods at the tray upon the desk at the far side of the room, covered with a silver lid.

Shifting to get a better view, the sight of his desk was somehow foreign, and only then does Phainon realize that it's far more bare than when he had last left it. He then takes the time to look around his room—his antiques have been arranged in designated spots, shelves of stone slates, scrolls, and tomes reorganized, furniture evidently dust-free, and wilted flowers have been replaced with fresh ones.

Phainon laughs lightly in disbelief. His room had been quite manageable since Mydei moved in, but he didn't think it would be so bad of a state to have Mydei cleaning up still. Mydei never complained about the mess. Although, Mydei is known to never complain about most things.

"I see that you've had some free time today," Phainon states.

Mydei only hums. “Most of my men were out for some mercenary tasks so I wasn’t able to spar with anyone,” he says. “The children I’ve been training for some self-defense techniques, on the other hand, achieved a new milestone today. So, I treated them to some golden honeycakes and let them go early.”

Though the adults of Okhema have much to say about the crown prince of Kremnos, the children who have a more honest view of the world—untainted by any form of judgement—could look past the prejudice and see Mydei for who he truly is: someone kind.

Phainon should be used to it by now—the sudden warmth that engulfs him, a sensation that could rival soaking in the hot baths after a long and tiring day, his heart close to bursting with so much affection whenever Mydei does something inherently endearing.

He wants to scoop the other up and tuck him in a ball. Mydei would protest about it, sure. But Phainon needs to do it just once for the sake of his sanity. But since he wouldn’t be able to indulge in his peculiar desires at this moment, if at all, Phainon settles with some light teasing instead.

“Are you sure that’s all you did?” Phainon asks, reaching out to touch the end of Mydei’s braid. Mydei had long since replaced the cuff with something far more durable. But Phainon knew that somewhere in the corner of his room, Mydei had hidden the one he made for him. “No playing house today? Or perhaps, acting as the prince of Aedes Elysiae?”

Mydei gives him a rather brief but wary glance, tensing when Phainon’s fingers drop down to slip past his loose robe just to touch the honeyed skin beneath, warm where Phainon's hand runs cold.

“That was one time,” Mydei says, reddening out of shame for having to admit it, or maybe it’s due to the pad of Phainon’s forefinger brushing lightly across a nipple as he moved to trace the pattern of winding scarlet. “Does Aedes Elysiae even have a prince? Why don’t *you* tell me?”

Phainon stops his ministrations, retreating away from Mydei’s lap as if the mere mention of his hometown causes him to cower instinctively. It’s been so long that talking about his origins shouldn’t affect him this much.

Mydei eyes him with concern. “I didn’t mean—”

“It’s just a village,” Phainon says softly, staring at the woven pattern of his quilt. “A far cry from Aristia’s grand palaces and the monarchy of Kremnos.”

He looks up to see Mydei staring at him indecipherably, as if he had much to say but decides against it. “Your food’s gone cold,” was Mydei’s chosen response, and Phainon is grateful despite such an abrupt end to the topic. “You’ve kept your meal waiting.”

“Right.”

Phainon pulls himself off the floor and starts stripping himself of his armor and clothes, aware of the searing gaze upon him. He lets Mydei watch as he changes into nothing but a

loose robe. Not like much clothing would make sense considering that it ends up on the floor later on anyway.

He walks over to his desk. But before he could take off the lid from the tray, the absence of a certain object catches his attention in an instant. Heart beginning to thud erratically within his chest, he takes a sweeping glance at first just in case he'd been mistaken.

But when he finds nothing, his hands begin to shuffle through the neatly piled-up papyrus, sliding away some stone slates, and knocking over several paperweights. His ink bottle spills and shatters upon the floor, and yet he still couldn't find what he was looking for.

It's hard to miss; Phainon has always kept a close watch on it for a couple of months now. For it to be gone—

"Looking for that box?" Mydei asks, his voice sharp amidst the silence.

Phainon jolts and turns around slowly, afraid of what he might see, what the other's reaction would be. Mydei is looking at him like he's figured it all out. The box— If Mydei had opened it and saw what was inside—

"I can explain."

Mydei frowns and Phainon's heart sinks. "Explain what? It's in the drawer."

Phainon pulls open the only drawer below his desk and sees, beside his set of unused quills, the dreaded box. The relief doesn't come. He could feel Mydei's gaze prickling at his neck and braces himself for the questions that would soon follow.

He tenses when Mydei speaks once again. "You shouldn't leave something so precious just lying around."

The box is locked. And yet, Phainon couldn't help but to turn around and ask, keeping his tone light just in case he'd give himself away, "You opened it?"

If Mydei had done so, Phainon expects a more… pronounced reaction. But he didn't think that Mydei is the type to snoop around other people's belongings like that.

"I didn't open it," Mydei answers, and Phainon lets the tension in his body gradually ebb away but not completely. "The box itself is intricate enough. I have no doubts that what you've stored within is worth of equal value, or more."

Perceptive as always. Phainon could only manage a quiet, "Oh."

At this point, he really has no idea what to say as to not make the atmosphere even more awkward.

Mydei, on the other hand, didn't seem to notice his disgruntled state, rolling up his scroll before settling it upon the side table. "Did you purchase it from Theodoros?" he asks. "The box, I mean."

“I did,” Phainon answers with a nod, more than grateful for the sudden change of discussion. “One of the antiques I’ve successfully deemed authentic. Paid out a huge sum for it, too.”

“That sounds promising. I was just about to ask you to accompany me to the market tomorrow to peruse some decorations for the library.” Mydei leaves the bed, tying up his night robe in a loose knot before approaching. “I initially had doubts whether or not you’re qualified to help me given your gaudy taste since Castorice is pre-occupied for the week and I can’t ask her.”

Phainon scoffs good-naturedly, feigning offense. “Come on now—”

Mydei takes the tray from the desk. “I’ll heat this up for you, *haikas*.”

“Ah, I’ll do it—”

“I don’t trust you.”

Phainon flinches. Though Mydei’s tone was light as he spoke, he couldn't shake the feeling that those words seemed to account for something far more grievous. Or perhaps it’s the guilt.

“You’ll burn the food and you have that ink to clean up,” Mydei continues, lingering pointedly within Phainon’s space before subsequently turning around to leave the room.

Once the door clicks shut, Phainon takes the box from within the drawer once again. The lock is intricate, almost like a miniature puzzle in its own right and it takes Phainon a couple of tries to get it to unlock.

It opens slowly on its own atop Phainon’s palm, and from within, the sight of a golden signet ring bearing the seal of Strife gleams against the light spilling through the open windows.

Gorgo’s words echo in his mind. *The right time*, she had said. Even if she never mentioned anything about Mydei’s kingship, it was the only reasonable answer Phainon could think of. But Mydei would never, he had already expressed his sentiments regarding Kremnos’ throne so clearly that there could be no mistake.

Godhood, then?

What would Mydei even think—for Phainon to procure such a significant thing unprompted? Was he being too presumptuous? Though Mydei expressed his desire to be reunited with the ring, should he be made aware of his mother’s bidding?

Phainon locks the box and returns it back within the drawer, stuffing it against the far end and out of sight. Though Gorgo’s words were vague at most, all Phainon could do was to trust her. The last thing Phainon intends to do is to insult the memory of the dead, and for some reason, Gorgo had faith in him to figure this out.

Mydei returns sometime later with a tray of heated food to see Phainon lounging upon the bed with a frown on his face as he tries to decipher the Kremnoan scroll Mydei had been reading.

Seeing that the other had arrived at last, Phainon perks up and straightens himself as Mydei carefully places the tray upon the mattress.

“Thank you, Mydei.”

“Don’t spill anything,” Mydei warns.

“I won’t.”

Phainon rerolls the scroll and hands it to the other whose eyes glinted with mild interest.

“Did you even understand what you just read?” Mydei asks, almost teasing in a way since they both knew Phainon had yet to learn Kremnoan.

Phainon shrugs as he picks up the bowl of what looks to be a piping hot avgolemono. The aroma is simply divine. “Absolutely not,” he says, swirling his spoon against the broth before having a taste. “But I’m confident that the benevolent crown prince would give me credit for trying.”

Mydei scrunches his nose. “And I already told you, quit talking when your mouth is full.”

Phainon tries to heed Mydei’s words this time. As he digs in, he hears the shuffle of papyrus as Mydei unfurls the scroll.

“This is a record of the various kings of Kremnos during their reign written by a late friend of mine,” Mydei tells him. “There’s several volumes, and this is the third. Though my friend insists that his work is unfinished, I like to think otherwise.”

“How so?”

Mydei doesn’t look at him when he replies, “The last king that’s recorded is Eurypon.”

Phainon goes very still.

“It’s a pretty detailed text,” Mydei continues as if nothing was amiss. “Very informative and a fascinating read, I’d say.”

Swallowing the soup with much difficulty, Phainon was able to say, “For someone who has no interest in being king, I am surprised to hear that.”

It was quiet then, and Phainon thought he had overstepped his bounds. He fears that Mydei might take his words the wrong way. The blame would be on him if that were the case. He should cease the urge of wanting to say anything just to ease the tension.

“The crown matters not. What I’m most after from this piece of literature is how the people of the nation were treated in generations past,” Mydei explains. He didn’t seem to be

offended in the slightest, but his tone lacked the usual firmness in it. Almost as if he's unsure about something. "No king of Kremnos ruled perfectly. Knowing about their mistakes is advantageous. I'm sure that my people would find this read to be of substance when the library is opened to the public."

"No wonder you wish to decorate it," Phainon muses in an attempt to stir the topic away from kings and ruling just in case it made Mydei uncomfortable. "If it were only you, I doubt you'd even bother to adorn the place."

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Those salvaged archives belong to the nation. It would be wrong of me to have it all to myself, and I have been meaning to have a place to store those texts," he says. "What remains of the Garbaniphoro Grand Library is not meant to be hidden away and out of sight."

"Are the Kremnoans the only ones welcome in that library of yours, then?"

Mydei seems to contemplate it. Eventually, he says, "Anyone can access the collection. Although, I doubt that it would be of any interest to those from other nations since the literature salvaged are mainly written in Kremnoan."

Phainon nods. "That makes sense."

"If that was your way of asking if you can spend time in my library," Mydei began, gaze softening as he spoke. It does no favors to Phainon to be regarded so tenderly. "You're free to do so."

"A generous offer," Phainon says with a smile, looking away when he feels the heat on his face become too overwhelming. "If I'm finally able to familiarize myself with the Kremnoan alphabet, I'd probably spend an entire day just reading. Back in my days at the Grove, the Library of Philia was where I spent most of my free time.

"There's tons of books there on every topic one might be interested in. Although, the more intriguing ones are well-hidden so you'd have to be keen on finding them."

Mydei looks at him warily. "By 'intriguing,' are you referring to some nonsense literature perhaps? Knowing your tastes, Deliverer, I wouldn't be surprised."

"Of course not," Phainon defends. "I'd disgrace my professor if someone were to catch me reading embarrassing stuff."

"Your professor?"

Phainon nods. "Professor Anaxa…*goras*." He keeps forgetting to add that last bit. "You might have already heard of him. He's… pretty eccentric, but he's taught me a lot of things that have helped me to this day.

"Speaking of which, I think he'd find your archive interesting," Phainon continues. "He doesn't like to come to Okhema much because of Ag—" He coughs. "I mean, because he's busy. But I'm sure he'll make an exception this time around."

Mydei's eyebrows furrow slightly suggesting that he's deep in thought. "I have heard of him from Castorice. Seeing as you both have good things to say about him, I'll send word."

Phainon beams. He wonders what opinions his professor would have on Mydei and vice versa. It would be interesting to witness having two extremely different people meet each other.

"That's great! I think you'll like him," Phainon exclaims. "But like I said, he's pretty eccentric so public opinion on him is divided."

That is the understatement of the era. Anaxa's reputation is in the trenches. Phainon could only hope that Mydei keeps an open mind.

"You think I care about what other people think?" Mydei asks, dispelling Phainon's apprehensions in an instant. "Besides, it would be nice to finally get a face to the name."

"If he agrees to visit, you should have him meet Kokopo," Phainon says, almost as an afterthought. "He likes dromases."

Somehow, this seems to offend Mydei severely. "He is *not* just 'Kokopo,'" he corrects sternly. "He is *the* fierce beast of Kremnos, Kokopo the Third. You will address him properly."

The idea of there having a Kokopo the *First* and Kokopo the *Second* is enough to strain Phainon's mind from all the thinking. "I was worried for nothing. You and Professor Anaxa would get along just fine."

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To Professor Anaxagoras of the Grove,

I have arranged a humble library here in Okhema showcasing the records of my lost nation, Castrum Kremnos. I was advised that you would be interested, hence why I extend this invitation. ***I have utmost confidence that the literature of my people will not disappoint you.***

Looking forward to meeting you,

Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos

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"No. It's too on the nose."

Phainon frowns, lowering the dolium he was carrying. “It’s authentic.”

“And I already told you, I want to keep it simple,” Mydei argues.

“This *is* simple,” Phainon says with an aggrieved huff. “Mydei, you can’t possibly be asking me to help you buy exceptionally bland decor. That is against *me* as a person. You have to trust me if you wish for your library to look splendid.”

Mydei narrows his eyes. “You ought to know, even if the records in my library are simply what was left of the Garbaniphoro Grand Library, those texts remain to be more precious than treasures—it beholds the history of the Kremnoans, even spanning years before Nikador’s manifestation.” He gestures at the antique that Phainon had presented to him, giving it a look as if the object had offended his entire ancestry and spat on their graves. “I don’t want this gaudy dolium to ruin the literature’s dignity.”

Phainon stares at Mydei for a good moment, feeling affronted, before sighing heavily and accepting defeat. He never thought Mydei would be this picky. They’ve almost gone through Theodoros’ entire stock at this point; the poor man even had to turn away other customers just to accommodate the two Chrysos Heirs.

It’s a good thing that Mydei promised to pay a generous sum for Theodoros’ time. Can’t say the same for Phainon’s, though.

“That one.” Mydei points at a tapestry. “I want that on my wall.”

Phainon whips his head around and squints at the said tapestry that has managed to catch the picky prince’s attention. The image vaguely depicts the impressive figure of a man with a huge sword, a flowing cape, and a… sun marking on his jugular.

It takes a moment for the image to sink in. And once it does, it feels as if Phainon had been hit by a sack of bricks that sends him directly to the twilight zone. *What* in Kephale’s ruined world—

“That’s me.”

It’s a tapestry of Phainon. And Phainon had *no* idea of its existence until now.

Who in Amphoreus would weave something of this sort? Chrysos Heirs merchandise are not foreign in Okhema and he’s aware of how well it sells (he himself has spent a relative sum just by purchasing items that depicted the image of a certain crown prince of Kremnos). But Phainon would rather live his life by not encountering any that involved him.

Mydei crosses his arms, looking smug at his find. “You hang my billboard on your wall, I hang your tapestry in mine. Sounds fair, no?”

Phainon feels extremely faint. He had already taken down the billboard the moment that Mydei had moved into his chambers. To think that such an embarrassing act would be mentioned now, and in *public* no less. He may have a thick face during times where it most counts, but there’s a limit to that.

Theodoros clears his throat behind them. For some reason, he avoids both Phainon and Mydei's gaze as he informs them that, "The tapestry is worth five thousand balance coins."

Phainon turns around to see Theodoros making an obvious attempt to hold back a laugh.

"Lord Phainon, if you were looking for antiques depicting Lord Mydei's image, you should've just asked," Theodoros tells him. "I thought someone of refined taste such as yourself wouldn't hang something so atrocious as a billboard on a wall."

First, Phainon would like to argue that the billboard was *far* from being atrocious—it had Mydei's image for gods' sake. Second, he'd like to thank Theodoros for complimenting his tastes in front of Mydei. And third, he's going to have to come up with a method to keep Theodoros from sharing this *incriminating* piece of information to someone else.

If word gets to Akmonides, he can bid farewell to his dignity when the entirety of Okhema finds out that he has a billboard of Mydei hung upon the wall of his chambers.

This is the first time Phainon has ever wished for Aquila's Sky to rain havoc upon them. He knew well enough that Theodoros would never let him live this down. Perhaps he should withhold his patronage to the Treasures of Ages for a week or two.

"Theodoros," Phainon addresses, voice clipped as he feels the tips of his ears tingle with sheer mortification. He then shoves the dolium to Theodoros' hands. "We'll take this. And that tapestry as well. Actually, we'll just take the lot."

Theodoros is smiling now. "Lord Phainon, if you wish to buy my silence, there's no need to go to such lengths."

Phainon hears none of it.

It's safe to say that by the final quint of the Action Hour, Theodoros' stock was swept clean in exchange for Phainon's dignity. There's no doubt that a month would be needed to refill the shelves of the Treasures of Ages.

As Mydei beckons him into his chambers-turned-library, it is only then that he lets out the heavy sigh that he seems to be holding for so long. "I can't believe you just spent a hundred thousand balance coins for decor."

Phainon was still in the middle of inspecting the receipt which dragged onto the floor behind him. He tries not to dwell on the fact that his entire life savings are gone and there's nary a coin to his name. On the bright side of things, Theodoros is sure to keep his mouth shut.

(There's no bright side. He's so broke that even Zagreus wouldn't dare steal a strand of his hair. At this point in his life, he's the type to make thieves be capable of generosity and perhaps let him steal from them instead.)

"I'll just resell them if we have no need for it," he says, feeling rather faint and in desperate need of a drink.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Sure you will."

They spent the majority of their day tidying the library up some more and making organizational changes to house the plethora of antiques that Phainon had bought (Mydei didn't spend a single dime due to Phainon's insistence). It would all be delivered the next day since Theodoros still needed to process the paperwork of several items.

Once done, both he and Mydei found a corner to rest on, their backs resting against the shelves that contained tomes of varying thickness. Phainon takes one for himself and flips through the pages mindlessly.

As he eyes the Kremnoan script, a question comes up in his mind. "Have you read all of the stuff here in your library?"

Beside him, Mydei nods. "Of course."

"That couldn't be true," Phainon teases.

Though he knew that Mydei liked to read—an admittedly surprising past-time for someone so ingrained in war—he had no idea that Mydei's dedication to such an activity would reach this extent.

Mydei frowns. "Why would I lie about something like this?"

"I just didn't think you'd have the time," Phainon reasons. "In between war campaigns, that is. And didn't you say that these records were stored in a library in Kremnos?"

"A friend of mine stole them before he was exiled," Mydei explains. "He was the master of these books and we were close enough that I could simply access them in my youth. As for the Garbaniphoro Grand Library, it belonged to my family and was said to be an archive bigger than the one here in Okhema. Or so they say, for I never even saw it.

"My friend—Ptolemy—said he'd establish a new library in my name," Mydei continued, his tone wistful. "But, he died during an ambush in Aidonia. Perhaps having this library is me honoring his wishes, even if it was supposed to be done in my name."

Phainon flips through the pages as he listens, scribbles of six different handwritings upon the margin catching his eye. He wishes he could read them.

He turns to Mydei and gives him a soft smile in the hopes to assure, in tune with that feeling of loss all too well as if it were an old acquaintance. "I admire your friend for his dedication. I'm sure he'd be proud of what you've done with his collection today."

Mydei mirrors his smile, the sight of which never fails to tug at Phainon's heartstrings. "Thank you, Deliverer."

His eyes then landed on the page of the tome that Phainon was holding (because Phainon sure can't read what was written on it). Mydei hums, reaching out so his fingers brushed against the faded ink.

"This book gives me memories," Mydei says. "I recall the days where I'd sit beneath a tree and study its contents."

“What is it about?”

“It details the etiquette expected of Kremnoan royals,” Mydei answers.

Phainon flips through the pages, the annotations upon the margins growing more frequent. Some notes were entirely ripped out or blackened for reasons unknown to him. Some even had drawings—peculiar ones that were, in a way, *funny*. But Phainon dared not laugh just in case it was culturally significant.

The doodle of five stick people running away from one who seemed to be holding a thick book seemed rather profound if one were to think about it.

“Etiquette, you say,” Phainon began, lips twitching as he tried to keep a straight face. “You should’ve taken this book more seriously.”

It was meant to be in jest. He half-expected Mydei’s hackles to rise after hearing such a remark. To Phainon’s astonishment, Mydei merely laughs softly.

“I can’t say I have. Leonnius, our messenger, didn’t have the time to join me due to his responsibilities. Perdikkas was ceaselessly called to tend to the injured. Peucesta’s songs only served to distract me. And Ptolemy—the one I’ve mentioned before—was too busy burying his nose in his books than to be bothered to tutor a naive prince such as I.

“If not for Hephaestion bearing down on me about the significance of these lessons, I don’t think I’d take the time out of my day to read any of these texts at all.”

Phainon can’t help but sense the vulnerability in Mydei’s tone, and it makes him grateful for the trust. “I take it they’re your closest friends before you came to Okhema?”

There’s a pause as Mydei takes in a breath.

“We were family.”

Family. The word sits heavy in Phainon’s chest. He knew what it meant to lose one—and to find pieces of it again in places unexpected. And those pieces are meant to be held tightly, just in case it slips away again.

“Fate has been… rather cruel, Deliverer,” Mydei continues as he leans in close and rests his head against Phainon’s shoulder. He sounds exhausted. “For those who walk the path of war, perhaps not much is to be expected. My friends may have died honorable deaths, heralded as heroes, their praises sung.

“But those joyful odes could never compare to the happiness brought by a connection felt so rarely in one’s lifetime. Even in the glory of it all, it is still a loss.”

Phainon says nothing. Silence is a comfort after all, and Mydei shows his appreciation with a gauntlet-clad hand offered, of which Phainon accepts in a heartbeat. The cool surface of the metal does not discount the intimacy brought on by the gesture.

It is only after moments passed since their fingers have entangled, that Mydei continues, “Not even Hephaestion, a most dearest companion, was spared from the clutches of Death.”

Despite the warmth and the proximity, the sudden shift in tone at the mention of another in such a context causes Phainon’s throat to constrict in on itself for why must this man be singled out among the rest.

“You two must’ve been very close,” Phainon says.

Mydei nods, the stray strands of his hair brushing softly against Phainon’s cheek that it almost tickles. “In the end, it was only him and I. You’d think that after all the loss, I’d at least see it coming.” Mydei sighs, heavy with grief, and perhaps a longing to the name that now lingers like a shadow amongst them. “But not once did I ever imagine walking this world without him by my side.”

Phainon felt the corners of his lips grow heavy, downturned into a slight frown of which he could not seem to refrain from expressing. He wonders how admirable of a man Hephaestion had been for Mydei to speak of him in such a manner, sickening thoughts of selfishness having him wish the same for himself even when he knew full well that he’s in no position to compare.

It is unacceptable—for Mydei to open his heart and share something so inherently personal, only for Phainon to feel this way. He’s not deserving to know of Mydei’s story if he fails to look past the fog of his own doubts and to simply appreciate the show of such blatant vulnerability.

Though he’s long since believed that the world was not made for him so he alone would matter, desires well-hidden where greed ran rampant wished so ardently that he alone would matter to Mydei.

He wanted to flee at this moment, a cowardly act. But Mydei’s head on his shoulder anchors him down, like an ask unsaid to make him stay.

And Mydei recounts more stories, of glories he’d received in his victories, of nights by the campfire, of petty squabbles with his friends, of times they’ve stood together when it seemed as if the world was against them.

Mentions of Hephaestion, the *honorable* Hephaestion—a darling in Mydei’s stories, affectionately spoken of as if he’d done no wrong, and it does seem that way—is sprinkled throughout these little excerpts of Mydei’s life before the Flame-Chase.

Phainon listens. And he stays.

Someday, he would apologize for his inconsiderate thoughts mired in insecurity. Today, he’ll ask for Mydei to tell him more for his greed to know everything about the man he so desires far outweighs his jealousy.

“He sounds like a good man.”

There's a ghost of a smile on Mydei's lips.

"Yes. He was."

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Your Highness, I regret to inform you that Sir Hephaestion's illness had worsened overnight.

If you have the chance before leaving for Kremnos, please see him beforehand. I'm afraid he has not much time left in him.

Your humble medic,

Cephalos

—

Cephalos,

His Highness had already departed for the Kremnos Festival. *Rest assured, the moment we see his visage on the horizon upon his return, he will be informed of Sir Hephaestion's state right away.*

Scylla, Lochagos

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"So, how are you and Lord Mydei doing recently?"

"We're great."

Phainon doesn't meet Theodoros' questioning glances for fear of being caught lying. The man is capable of appraising antiques, able to read its flaws with severe accuracy that Phainon is sure the same applies for people.

"I haven't seen you in the market these past couple of weeks," Theodoros says again, writing something in his notebook after inspecting a small amphora. "Chrysos Heir duties not allowing you to have a break?"

Phainon places a rusty ornament into a crate marked as 'fake.' "Sort of," he answers blithely. "Nikador's Titankin grows more troublesome by the day."

“I can tell. You look exhausted.”

That’s probably one reason for it. He can’t even fault Theodoros for such a straightforward remark on his appearance. Perhaps Aglaea rejecting his proposal to patrol the borders of Okhema for the second time this week had something to do with that as well.

You need to rest, Phainon, was what she said. *Tiring yourself out hardly works as a distraction for your troubles.*

Phainon didn’t even have the energy in him to be bothered by the fact that Aglaea is very much aware of his poor state of mind these days. At first, he had wanted to have a soak in the baths to clear his mind of unwanted thoughts, but Mydei had other ideas: a trip to the market.

By the corner of his eye, Phainon sees the other standing by Demetria’s store, no doubt examining the new freshly harvested fruits delivered straight from Okhema’s orchards. Demetria’s eyes are crinkled into crescents as she chatted with Mydei, handing him a plate of sliced kiwis for Mydei to sample.

Phainon watches, a fond stirring in his heart at the sight of Mydei leaning his head down for Demetria to feed him straight from the fork. An absolute charmer—no wonder the elderly women and the children always sang praises of the crown prince of Kremnos.

There’s the urge to ditch Theodoros with his antique appraisal just to be closer to Mydei, to listen in on his conversation with Demetria and wonder what the old lady had said to put a small smile on his lips.

But before he could, however, an Okheman guard slid beside Mydei without much preamble, standing way too close as acquaintances would. By the color of his cape, Phainon could deduce that the guard held the rank of a captain.

Even from this distance, he sees Mydei’s once-relaxed shoulders tense visibly at the sudden intrusion. But the stranger didn’t seem to notice, keeping the proximity close and uncomfortable.

Demetria entertains them both as any dutiful shopkeeper would, and the scene shouldn’t be so strange in Phainon’s eyes as it currently is. He feels unsettled by the presence of this guard, but there’s no hint of danger in his movements. Just that Phainon wants him *gone*.

And then it happens—

The guard’s hand makes its way onto Mydei’s arm way too easily as if boundaries had not been set clearly, evidently feeling him up, and Phainon’s gut twists into something inherently dreadful.

It didn’t take a moment before Mydei brushes the hand away and puts some respectable distance in between him and the thrice-damned stranger. Phainon is just glad that Mydei has his back turned on him, for he would’ve seen the barely-hidden dismay etched all over Phainon’s face at an interaction his heart deems to be outrageous.

No relief comes in knowing that such an encounter might not be the first, and it would certainly not be the last.

Phainon feels shame enclosing in on him, and only then does he realize why the past few weeks have been downright punishing with every moment he'd spent alone with his thoughts. Though Mydei's presence always served to alleviate the incessant self-doubt, Mydei also serves as a reminder as to why he's like this.

He's jealous. And he's never heeded such a petty sentiment until Mydei spoke of another man like one would speak of a lost lover. Only, the love seemed to have remained.

Phainon knows nothing about Hephaestion apart from the many anecdotes that Mydei had shared with him in good faith. Stories are not enough to be closely familiar with a person for they could only shed light to so much—a limited perspective rather than the entire picture.

But one thing is for sure, the dead sure does haunt the living in many ways. And Phainon considers himself haunted by the ghost of a man who he never even met but continued to linger in the shadows of his mind ever since its introduction.

As he witnessed Mydei being deliberately propositioned by this tactless, unnamed guard, he comes to know of the fact that whether or not the person who beholds Mydei's affections is dead or alive, Phainon could do nothing.

Jealousy is a disgusting thing he wishes to relinquish entirely for he knew well enough that he didn't have the right to succumb to such trifles. Mydei is not his to lay claim over. They have an arrangement, that's all there is to it.

He may wear his heart on his sleeve, and perhaps Mydei had already caught wind of his affections, but Phainon is not foolish to assume that Mydei felt the same. Perhaps what they have is merely indulgence in the long and arduous journey that is the Flame-Chase. He'd fare better if he were not to dwell on such pointless thoughts.

A moth never questions its instinct to approach the flame, ignorant to its detriment. Phainon knew from the very beginning—in that secluded area of the forest where the Kremnoans had laid the souls of their comrades to rest—that Mydei's magnificence would soon come to burn him.

It was simply inevitable.

Some days, it is Phainon that is at Mydei's mercy. Actually, Phainon *is* always at Mydei's mercy.

Though he values the sight of Mydei sprawled across the sheets, skin flushed alluringly as Phainon showed his reverence without a lick of hesitance after mastering the spots and secrets that made Mydei keen and arch into his touch, nothing still beats having Mydei on top

of him, gasping and panting as he took his pleasure—riding Phainon until his release as if Phainon's cock is nothing more than a subservient tool.

Mydei takes him apart like it's easy, and Phainon lets it happen. He would let Mydei do anything to him. Mydei is more than worth the pain and the doubts, for he no longer knows what he and Mydei are supposed to be.

They have crossed the boundary of strangers to allies, rivals to equals. 'Friends' would be the appropriate term to describe them. But now, Phainon is not so sure.

Do friends bear such ardent affections for one another? Do friends yearn for the other's kisses? For the taste of the other's sweat to linger upon one's lips? For his flesh and blood to be lodged within the narrow space beneath Mydei's nails—the only lasting proof of Phainon that won't fade away with his curse.

When Mydei reaches his high with a choked groan, spilling onto Phainon's belly and Phainon following not soon after, flooding Mydei's insides with his spend, he is at a loss.

He knew from the start that such an affair is bound to be a complicated one. Perhaps he had been too presumptuous that he wouldn't desire for more than what is being offered, and now, there's no one to blame but himself.

The greed that had grown to taint his soul would be his downfall for he wants something more than just a tumble in bed, and he yearns to pull Mydei close and proclaim his love with a conviction free of the burdening clasps of self-doubt.

It is rather ludicrous to wish for a time where he'd be able to take Mydei beneath the Tree of Union and ask for his hand properly instead of simply standing alongside the crowd, clapping forlorny when a new couple seals their bond in matrimony.

Phainon is loath to admit that such a sight always bestowed him with the urge to visit a jeweler, browsing through the assortment of wedding rings meant to cater to the taste of every patron in Okhema.

(“This is the fifth time this week, Lord Phainon. The twentieth this month. If you still haven't found what you're looking for, I do bespoke rings at a fair price.”

Phainon flounders for the right words. Even with the cover of a cloak and hood, it seems the jeweler has grown familiar with him to see through his disguise entirely.

“Oh, uh—”

“Your significant other is lucky,” the jeweler says. “Only a few people take this much time to deliberate. I applaud your meticulousness.”

Instead of a reply, Phainon simply bids a hasty goodbye with a promise to avail the jeweler's services in the future. Not like it mattered, anyway. Phainon won't be coming back anytime soon, if at all.)

“Your mind wanders.”

Phainon is then brought back into the present with Mydei's voice, stark amidst the silence and the quiet catching of breaths. He raises his attention to the man above him who eyed him with a question.

"What is it that occupies your mind so much that you've grown disinterested in our coupling?" Mydei asks.

The tone makes it sound like a joke, but the way Mydei's fingers twitch against Phainon's skin alludes to something far more delicate, nearing suspicion even. Or perhaps—for a single hopeful moment—Phainon assumes that Mydei also shares his fear of being made secondary.

He takes Mydei's hand that's splayed across his chest, and brings it up to his lips, brushing a reverent kiss across his knuckles as a way of an apology. "The Sky would have to fall first before I lose interest, and even then, I'd still only be able to think of you."

It's not a lie. But the words are no doubt a blatant attempt to divert the topic. A vague non-answer.

Subtle amusement graces Mydei's features upon hearing such exaggerated words. "You seem to forget: flattery means nothing to me, and there's no need to result in it when you wish to gain my favor."

Phainon responds by catching the tip of Mydei's finger between his teeth, grazing it lightly before releasing it. "Tell me I have it, nonetheless."

"Fishing for praise is not a good look on you."

Phainon raises an eyebrow and rolls them over with an ease born of familiarity. After a climax, Mydei is always pliant. Easy smiles and vulnerable angles. But like this—as Mydei regards him softly, pulling him in for a kiss that could convey a thousand different meanings as their bodies slotted together perfectly after a mere brief separation—Phainon could never truly know what Mydei is thinking.

Why is it that Mydei's warmth is so freely given when he and Phainon are nothing better than a blurry sky? Middling between sun and storm as Aquila's fickleness seeps through what should have been something direct and constant as the ticking of Oronyx's Time?

What are we? Phainon wanted to ask.

But instead, the words that escape his lips couldn't be far more different.

"You're beautiful," he mutters against Mydei's mouth, uncaring whether or not the other even heard or understood in between the exchange of feverish kisses. "I am so taken by you."

Mydei exhales into the kiss, grappling at his shoulders as strong legs urge him to move once more. They never settle to doing this just once, only stopping when their bodies have tired each other out thoroughly, a challenge with no distinct victor but felt so far away from a loss when their skin tingles with the last vestiges of warmth and pleasure.

He could feel Mydei gradually hardening in between them, the resulting friction of Phainon's every move enough to stimulate as he thrusts his hips lightly, testing the drag of his cock against twitching walls with a shaky exhale against Mydei's neck.

It's far more wetter than it was earlier with his cum easing the glide, and he could already feel most of his screws go loose at the thought of filling up Mydei some more until it spills onto the sheets, past the tight space of where Phainon's cock plugs him up.

Phainon leans back slightly to witness the dizzying sight that is Mydei with his head thrown back against the pillows, swollen lips parted around breathy moans with every thrust, eyes of gold peeking from half-lidded eyes.

It is then that he's overcome with a dangerous type of hunger, hiking Mydei's legs higher upon his shoulders, folding Mydei nearly into half to test just how far his body could reach. The angle allows Phainon to carve himself deeper, fulfilling his own selfish desire of staking claim in the way he's longed to, the sounds of their bodies coming together and drowning out the helpless static in his mind brought upon by thoughts so clouded.

His hands grip Mydei's hips with a newfound urgency, fingers pressing hard enough to leave bruising marks—ones that he ensures would stay far longer before Mydei's curse could wipe it away and presents him with a clean canvas.

The sensation of his own possessiveness rising within him makes him ache in places he's tried to ignore, his thrusts becoming more forceful and primal, as if he's trying to erase that lingering doubt that anyone else could ever touch what he considers to be his.

His.

Phainon sinks his teeth into the sweaty skin of Mydei's neck, the metallic taste of golden ichor coating his tongue. Mydei groans beneath him, but he doesn't shy away from the pain, one hand making its way to the back of Phainon's neck to further pull him in, letting him draw as much blood as he'd like until the both of them have become light-headed amidst their depravity.

In return, Mydei carves up marks of his own upon Phainon's back with his other hand, nails digging into the meat even if the ones left previously have yet to heal properly. It's not enough to leave a scar, and Phainon has half a mind to let Mydei wear his gauntlets the next time they do this—have him claw at his back and for the wounds to run so deep it puts his many scars from battle to shame.

The thought sends him shivering, feeling his cock swell even further upon imagining what state his body would be in once they're done. To mutilate out of sheer passion, violent and yet romantic all the same.

Sweat drips from Phainon's brow as he watches Mydei writhe, lips parted in desperate, wordless gasps. There's something sacred about the way Mydei breaks apart under him, the kind of wanton abandon that Phainon has never been allowed to witness outside of moments like this—where he's allowed to believe that Mydei could belong to him.

But he shouldn’t.

A person is not an object to stake ownership of, and that knowledge claws at Phainon like a second hunger, carving itself into every motion, fueled by something far less noble than love.

It spurs him on how Mydei simply *lets* him—lets *Phainon* reduce him to such an undignified state, breaking him down past the point of incoherency until all he could do was find purchase on the sheets, or better yet, pinch and grab at any skin of Phainon’s he could reach.

Phainon knew he wouldn’t last long like this. But the way Mydei squeezes him tightly with every pull out as if to persuade him not to leave is enough to tell him that Mydei is close as well.

He leans forward, supporting himself on a single elbow as he licked the sweat off of Mydei’s shoulder, nipping at the skin, and up to the crook of Mydei’s neck, salt on his tongue sweeter than fresh honey.

The bite he’d done earlier had long since faded away, and so too will the bruises soon follow. Though Mydei’s curse is far from being a foreign concept unlike several months prior, it never fails to bring in a twinge of frustration that Phainon has yet to quiet.

(“Even if your body forgets, would you remember?” Phainon had asked one Curtain-Fall Hour several days before, forehead pressed against Mydei’s collarbone, lips tracing the place where he swore he’d bitten just moments ago.

Now there’s nothing. Just warmth.

Mydei’s chest rumbled as he spoke, “Of course.”)

At the memory, Phainon gentled the motion of his hips, as though pulled back from the edge by a tether he couldn’t name. The tempo ebbed into something quieter, more searching—like rain tapering into a fine mist. Beneath him, Mydei’s body remained pliant, but the lull between their movements drew breath into something more precarious than silence.

In this narrowing space, with sweat cooling on skin and desire still simmering low between them, Phainon no longer moved with the single-minded urge to claim, every slow press of his body lingering just long enough as if to make up for the roughness from earlier.

He whispers reverent praises into Mydei’s ear, ones that make him redden so beautifully like an apple ripe for picking. Phainon will make sure that Mydei will hear of it—how good he feels, how perfect Mydei is for him, how he wants to fill him up and keep his seed within until it bears fruit.

A harsh tug at his hair suggests of Mydei's mortification. But upon pulling back, he finds no real resistance in Mydei’s eyes, reddened at the corners and brimming with unshed tears.

“*Cease* with your foul words.”

Phainon smiles, planting a gentle kiss on the bridge of Mydei’s nose, a stark contrast to how roughly he thrusts into that sweltering heat. “You don’t like it?” Phainon asks nonetheless, his

voice just shy of a murmur near Mydei's ear, his breath brushing over damp skin. "That I make it known how well you take me?"

He lets the words hang like smoke, curling in the air between them.

"Are you perhaps shy, Your Highness?"

The title is a tease, yet there's reverence in the way he says it. He shifts his weight, and the angle drives deeper. Mydei lets out a soft sound, startled in his haze when the tip of Phainon's cock prods at his prostate more deliberately this time.

"It would be nice," Phainon began, his voice the hush of silk slipping off marble. "To spend the entire day like this. In bed with you."

That way, he'd be able to have Mydei in his sights, and Mydei's attention would be solely focused upon him because in these circumstances, wrapped around the heavy veil of lust and pleasure, how could Mydei dare think of anything—

Of *anyone* else?

"I'll keep you nice and warm," Phainon adds, trying to sound convincing but ends up seemingly insane instead. "I'll keep you full, just how you like it."

Mydei's breath stutters, words laced with something far too soft to be scorn as his fingers remain tangled in between pale strands. "*Haikas*…"

"What? Don't deny it, Mydei."

A smile is pressed against Mydei's throat as he draws a line down Mydei's stomach with his hand, pointedly ignoring the leaking cock that twitches in anticipation between their bodies, before firmly pressing upon the slight bulge protruding just below Mydei's navel.

"You like this," Phainon says, insisting on the truth, relying on past entanglements where Mydei asks (demands) to be filled up before slumber, and again before the day starts—leaving Phainon to imagine how Mydei walks around with cum leaking from his hole, far more filthy than his wildest dreams could ever come up with. "You like to be seeded much more than you let on."

Mydei says nothing, head turned to the side as he chews upon his bottom lip in a desperate attempt to keep quiet. An admission of defeat perhaps. And Phainon is merciful enough to let Mydei go so easily.

Though he'd like to tease Mydei for it, the grin he plasters on his face is fractured at the edges. He won't deny the wave of possessiveness that engulfs him whenever he claims Mydei from within. And as the pleasure crests, the tight grip of Mydei's legs around his waist spurring him on, Phainon's control slips and his facade cracks, spilling a tiny bit of his true emotions.

Too much want and too much ache caught beneath his tongue. The heat of Mydei's body around him, the way he trembles, the sweat slicking every inch of skin between them—

Every time Phainon reaches for him, his hunger bleeds into something more *hollowing*.

“Mydei.”

The name falls from his lips like confession, the single word weightier than all the filth he'd whispered before it. And for a moment, Phainon sees clarity shimmer across golden irises as Mydei meets his gaze once again, catching the light spilling from the balcony like dawn breaking over snow.

Mydei is listening.

Phainon’s throat tightens, his words amassed beneath his tongue likened to voices once sealed within temple walls, straining for a god to hear.

I wish for you to be mine forever.

But what escapes his lips instead is far more softer, the greed a mere smidgen rubbed in between the lines for those who wish to scrutinize.

“Will you let me have you for much longer?” Phainon asks, stilling against Mydei to avoid any distractions.

Mydei frowns at the sudden question. “We have to rise early tomorrow.”

Phainon stares, the surprise most likely gracing his features upon hearing a response entirely unexpected. But the fondness grows nonetheless because *of course* that’s what Mydei would say.

“That’s not what I meant,” Phainon tells him anyway, planting a kiss on Mydei’s cheek, smiling as he does so, awashed with so many emotions that he thinks he might simply lose his mind.

Mydei blinks, something flickering in the gold. “Then what—?”

Phainon doesn’t let him finish.

He buries his face in the crook of Mydei’s neck, hands tightening around slender hips as he thrusts forward, sudden and sharp, forcing the question back into the earth before it can grow roots. He’s not ready for an answer. Not if it means hearing something measured, if it means hearing Mydei pull away with kindness instead of clarity.

His rhythm breaks apart, driven by the ache beneath his ribs. Each movement is jagged, needy, more plea than pleasure. He chases the high like it will erase the vulnerability he’s let slip between his teeth.

Mydei gasps, muttering curses in Kremnoan, the word bitten off as his nails dig cruelly into Phainon’s back. Phainon moans at the sting; he wants to bleed, for Mydei’s claim to be inked across his spine in torn flesh and sacred ruin.

“Don’t hold it in,” Phainon rasps, voice breaking around the edges. “Fall apart with me.”

Mydei bares his teeth, a growl blooming from his throat like muffled thunder.

“Bastard…”

With a choked sound, Mydei locks his legs tighter around him and comes, shuddering violently, lashes fluttering as his body seizes around Phainon’s cock.

Phainon follows a breath later, spilling into him with a strangled groan, forehead pressed to Mydei’s chest as his body breaks in the midst of his surrender. His grip never loosens. His breath never steadies.

And as the silence curls in around them, sweat cooling on flushed skin, Phainon stares at the hollow of Mydei’s throat and mourns the answer he didn’t receive.

“Did something happen?” Mydei asks after a while.

“What do you mean?”

Phainon’s voice betrays a hint of carefulness, as if he’s mere moments away from one wrong answer. He lifts his gaze slowly, searching Mydei’s eyes for the origin of the question, as though its weight might tip the balance of whatever fragile intimacy they still held.

Mydei doesn’t answer immediately. Instead, he studies him in the soft aftermath—their limbs still tangled amidst the messy sheets and thrown about pillows, the air heady with salt and sweat.

When he finally speaks, it’s a quiet, “You seem… different today.”

The words hang between them, delicate as frost on a blade. Not an accusation, and not quite a concern either. Just something that neither of them had a name for at the moment.

Phainon smiles, but it doesn’t quite reach his eyes. It’s the kind of smile worn thin by practiced deflection, carved more out of insecurity than amusement.

“Were you not satisfied?” he says, a teasing lilt in his voice that feels brittle.

Mydei frowns. “That’s not it.” Hands thread through snowy locks, gentle as if to soothe even if he had been the receiver of such rough handling. “I am here. Confide in me.”

A tense silence creeps in, fraught with all the words not one of them they ever dare say. The warmth between them now teeters upon a dire edge, a tenderness made precarious.

Phainon doesn’t look away even though he wants to. He takes a breath, fingers drifting across Mydei’s wrist where bruises bloom faintly, fading with each passing moment. He watches them vanish—silent testaments to the roughness from earlier, wiped clean by a curse that knew nothing of permanence.

“Nothing happened,” he says eventually, voice subdued. “I’m fine. It seems I was a bit... too much today. You’ll have to forgive me.”

Mydei scoffs lightly and hooks an arm around Phainon's waist. "Desperate is a better name for it," he murmurs.

A strained laugh leaves Phainon's lips, muffled into Mydei's chest as he buries his face there, cheek pressed to the warmth that never denies him.

"Should we bathe together?" he asks, eager to divert the conversation just in case Mydei prods further.

"There is no need to ask for permission, Deliverer," Mydei says, and Phainon was able to hear the unspoken truth nestled in those words—that it has now become a habit of theirs, bathing together late into the quiet hours of the day. "The bath can wait. Let's stay like this for a while."

Before Phainon could say something in startled protest considering how fussy Mydei gets when he's not cleaned up right after their coupling, he was then shifted to the side, Mydei adjusting their bodies with a grunt.

It is considerably more comfortable now than before. However—

"Do you… want me to pull out?" Phainon asks meekly, assuming that Mydei had forgotten about such a glaring fact—which is Phainon's dick still inside of him.

Mydei answers with a simple, "No." There's a lack of hesitation, as does with every word that comes out of Mydei's mouth. "You kept babbling about keeping me full. Now make good on your promise, *haikas*."

Phainon should probably commission a plug for Mydei's personal use with how often this happens (he's not complaining). But the thought of going to Chartonus and describing his order makes him rather do ten laps of running on foot from the holy city to the Abyss.

He stays inside as promised, just to feel whole for a little while more. And even if Mydei's breaths had already evened out moments later signifying his slumber, Phainon dared not leave, cradling Mydei close as the tides of doubt kept him awake.

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To Mydeimos, the Crown Prince of Kremnos,

I did not expect to hear from the Crown Prince of Kremnos himself. ***The Garbaniphoro Grand Library was indeed an archive that I've long been curious about.***

Your invitation has piqued my interest enough to have me put aside my disdain of stepping foot in Okhema. I shall arrive in three Entry Hours' time.

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"Quit fidgeting. It's distracting me."

Phainon stills his leg. "Apologies."

Stay with the professor, Mydei had said before leaving for the Abyss alongside a small cadre of Okheman city guards when he received word that several of his men from the detachment were two days delayed of returning. *It's not my intention to slight him with my absence. Convey this, Deliverer.*

Phainon had no qualms with keeping his former professor company. It is, however, the group of reinforcements Mydei brought with him that serves to tick every nerve in his body, blood surging in a dizzying wave of helplessness mired in vexation.

He hadn't been mistaken—the captain that rode alongside Mydei on the same dromas during their departure was the same brazen man who accosted him at the market a couple of weeks prior, who approached with such an unsettling familiarity that it's almost impudent.

Phainon's knee resumes its restless movement, bouncing in quick and jerky intervals. The Kremnoan literature he chose to study had been forgotten since Mydei left, the page unturned for far too long that one would think he'd have memorized its contents already.

His heart sinks thinking how much time that Okheman captain is to spend with Mydei, the conversations they're having, to hear Mydei speak in his low clipped tones during a long ride, and the dry replies he'd have the honor of receiving.

To be subjected upon by Mydei's steady gaze, to notice the way his eyebrows furrow in thought, to indulge in the rare curve of a dry smile when something amuses him, to be close enough to see those precious little shifts in expression, to receive a curt, knowing remark that Phainon had once thought were reserved for him alone—

Is it wrong to be so sullen when his mind envisions the sight of Mydei enjoying the company of another? It is rather unbecoming now for these abstract fixations of his to warrant such extreme emotions.

He clenches his jaw and goes back to his reading—learning basic Kremnoan requires his full attention, and just as he tries to regain his focus, he wills the foreign words to behave. An act he'd come to know would be quite futile given how his mind traitorously continues to wander, hoping that the papyrus would soon morph into a mirror that would show him what was transpiring so far away.

The worst of it is not knowing, not being there. That damned captain, with his loud voice and easy arrogance might be close enough to touch Mydei's shoulder, to lean in during a

whispered exchange in the midst of the journey's boredom, and even to trade battlefield glances.

He's probably annoying Mydei by now, Phainon thinks bitterly, deluding himself to feel better. *Probably filling the air with inane chatter or useless posturing. Mydei wouldn't tolerate that for long.*

Right?

The thought that Mydei *might* sends another wave of heat upon Phainon's neck, shame and jealousy burning like twin suns—far brighter than the Dawn, far brighter than if Aquila opened all of Their eyes at this moment.

He dares a glance toward the door.

How long before they return? How long must he sit here, reading words he cannot absorb, with an image of Mydei slipping further and further into someone else's lecherous grasp? To wriggle free from a snake's venomous hunger, one must—

The sound of a tome slamming harshly upon the surface of the table resounds across the small library, pulling Phainon out of his trance in an instant.

"Perhaps," Anaxagoras began, dangerously low, impatience seeping through every syllable. "You'd find it less taxing to fidget outside."

Phainon tries his best to look remorseful and apologizes for a second time in such a short while. "Forgive me, professor."

"Spill it, then," Anaxagoras says. "What is it that muddles your thoughts that you feel compelled to burden me as well?"

"It's… nothing."

Phainon directs his attention at the book he's 'reading' and turns a page over. More Kremnoan words he has yet to learn only serves to fuel the simmering headache that's about to bubble over.

Just as he'd thought that the other had laid the matter to rest, he was sorely mistaken when Anaxagoras' sharp voice cuts through the silence, enough to make Phainon flinch.

"If you wish to lie, do it properly at least."

Phainon turns another page again. More Kremnoan words. Less illustrations.

A sigh follows when Phainon deigned him with nary a response. "Does the absence of Mydeimos worry you so?"

There's no use to withhold the truth. "It's not like I can help it."

“You worry too much. That woman made him bring along some reinforcements. He’ll be fine.”

Phainon laughs lightly, a little too strained for his liking, the faux calmness he hoped to portray now fraying at the edges. “Will he, though? I have no doubts about Okhema’s forces, but the captain whose orders they take is… easily distracted and… incompetent. I doubt if he’d be of much help. Mydei is sure to find him a nuisance more than anything.”

He belatedly realizes that he’s rambled the sentiments he’d long hoped to keep to himself. Speaking ill of others behind their back is something Phainon refrained from. It’s disrespectful, and he’d dare not stoop to such lows. Until now.

If only he could be rid of the sickness that plagues his heart, then perhaps he’d see past the darkness that sullies his perspective. A Chrysos Heir protects every citizen, and what he’s doing now can’t be further from the duty he’d taken upon himself to fulfill.

And yet, he can’t stop.

“You sound awfully confident about your claims,” Anaxagoras says. “Didn’t I teach you that sufficient evidence is a must?”

“I’ve seen him train,” Phainon reasons, the thumping of his heart a roar in his ears. *Stop talking*— “He’s merely the son of a wealthy Council Elder who got him the rank. I know more than a handful of Okheman soldiers more deserving of such an esteemed position.”

Disappointment curdles in his gut. At this point, could he even consider himself as worthy of Mydei’s affection? To think that he’d once thought he could be as noble as the man of which Mydei speaks highly of. How presumptuous of him to think that he could even compare himself to Hephaestion.

The silence of the library is near deafening as Anaxagoras stares him down. There’s no doubt he could read through his selfishness even with only a single eye. Would the professor feel shame for having such a wicked student?

Only, Anaxagoras’ reaction brings about a shock that stills every single thought in Phainon’s mind. Head thrown back and chair nearly toppling over, Anaxagoras laughs, loud enough to reverberate throughout the entire library.

Though it’s not exactly unusual to witness the professor in sudden bouts of laughter, it never fails to catch Phainon off-guard.

“W-What’s so funny, professor?” Phainon asks faintly, debating whether or not he should interrupt this display of amusement.

A new breakthrough in his research perhaps?

It takes a moment for Anaxagoras to calm down. And even then, the curve of his lips doesn’t quite flatten as it usually does on a normal occasion.

“It’s amusing to see you so vindictive,” he explained once he’d composed himself. “And here I thought you’re above bearing foul sentiments towards others. Interesting how jealousy makes you more honest.”

Phainon pales. “I’m not—”

Anaxagoras raises an eyebrow, as if challenging him to continue on with the lie. Phainon seals his lips shut.

Once again reopening the book to the page he was reading, Anaxagoras continues, “Mydeimos is with you now, isn’t he? Even *I* could see that—”

It’s not like that.

“—shouldn’t you just make the most of it instead of pestering me with your senseless woes? Mind not the behavior of others for it is not something you can control. What matters is that you’ve already proven yourself to him. So why do you doubt still?”

Phainon lets the words turn over in his head, worrying his lips as he does so. “...Have I really proven myself?”

If anything, it is the mere fact that Mydei is simply indulging him in his whims that they’ve now found themselves in this circumstance—an unnamed relation far more intimate than those shared in between the closest of friends.

They’re rivals first and foremost. Friendship merely comes a close second. And yet, they’re far more than any of that.

Anaxagoras gives him a dry stare. “You tell me, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. If you feel it’s inadequate, then try harder. Do *more*. What’s stopping you?”

Do more.

Phainon feels like he’s about to grasp onto something—an answer to a question yet to be asked.

“If you feel like you’ve done enough,” Anaxagoras continues. “Only then will you be able to see past your insecurities.”

Everything halts for a brief moment upon hearing those words, and for once, Phainon’s mind goes quiet. But just before he could say something, Anaxagoras had already begun to leave his seat, his book splayed open upon the table.

“Where are you going?” Phainon asks.

“Out for a walk.”

Phainon still had some questions. “But, professor—”

“Spare me.”

The door closes behind him, the lock spinning fast as Phainon was once again subjected to the silence of the room, now in his lonesome.

Across from him, he catches a glimpse of the page that Anaxagoras had left on. It depicted two illustrations drawn side-by-side: two armored people in a clash of blades, while the other is of a person offering a bouquet of flowers to another.

Though Phainon is far from being fluent in Kremnoan, he can at least deduce what these two illustrations meant, to *some* degree, and it feels as if he'd just been burnt by the sheer realization of it all.

With a renewed perspective, Phainon ventures out, Janus granting him passage. Professor Anaxagoras was wrong—Phainon hasn't done *anything* to prove himself to Mydei, and yet here he is, bearing sentiments of entitlement and even had the gall to put another down in favor of making himself seem far more appealing of Mydei's attention.

If you feel like you've done enough, only then will you be able to see past your insecurities.

The answer is right in front of him.

All he'd done so far was to wallow in his cowardice, duty in place of reason. Being careful and responsible had done him no favors; he was simply avoiding to take the first step, the fear of making a mistake and ruining what he and Mydei had—something fragile and clandestine, a relation that strings him up in knots before letting him fall apart—looming over him like a dark cloud.

The lines have long since been blurred between them, and yet nothing has changed. So what difference does it make if Phainon smudged it out entirely?

Making his way out of the Marmoreal Palace and towards the market, Phainon's mind is set, no longer split like it had been several days— No, weeks— *Months* prior.

Heart thudding in his chest, he stands in front of a store. The florist welcomes him, and it was then that Phainon makes a choice.

He's going to court Mydei.

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Though there is no word for 'Romance' in the Kremnoan Language, Kremnoans do still engage in courtship. However, their approach is rooted in seeking an equal rather than simply affection.

Unlike Okheman courtship traditions, of which involve the offerings of flowers and lavish gifts, Kremnoan courtship has always been tied to themes of war and glory.

For a more detailed read in regards to this topic, please refer to: ***Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship.*** *Written by Cretheus, Son of Methelaus*

— an excerpt. Kremnoan Traditions: Culture and Customs throughout History

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Chapter End Notes

next chapter about to be more fun than this one. and yes, a certain balcony is involved. one more chapter of phainon being an idiot. i'm tired of this grandpa.

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

thank you so much for reading!! <3 all your kudos and comments go to my lifespan. thank you so very much for them :3

Chapter 11: desires laid bare, revealing truth at last

Chapter Summary

> For man to demand nothing in the midst of longing is an exercise in futility. And what are they? Nothing but foolish men.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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In Okhema, a single blossom offered speaks of admiration. A verse crafted sincerely confesses longing. A gem set in gold declares intent beyond whim or fancy.

Thus, affection becomes devotion, and devotion becomes a bond.

— an excerpt. On Okheman Courting Practices: Introduction, Revision no. 173151

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The whispers, like clockwork, tend to grow louder the moment he steps out of the Marmoreal Palace with the sole intent to go straight down to the market. By the time he leaves Ianthe's Flower Shop, the citizens nearby don't even bother with the guise of keeping their conversation amongst themselves.

"I heard he's courting someone. Been purchasing Ianthe's flowers every first quint of the Action Hour for two weeks straight now."

"Who do you think it is?"

"Have you been living under a rock? Who else would it be but the Kremnoan crown prince!"

Phainon paid them no mind as he walked, inspecting the bouquet in his hand whilst lightly humming the tune of one of the many odes to Mnestia. The fragrance of today's flowers is subtle yet sweet. The colors, though muted, could be admired as a choice of simple elegance —something the receiver would surely appreciate.

Two weeks was enough of a time for Phainon to gauge Mydei's tastes in flora. Lilies, orchids, and blue hyacinths were among the ones that have been a frequent presence in every bouquet that Phainon has procured. The constant, of course, being the forget-me-nots.

This has birthed many a topic amongst attendants as to why the Chamber of the Flame Lily always housed these dainty blooms. The blue of the petals don't quite match the red interior after all, but the crown prince of Kremnos is known to have taken a fondness for them. Just the mere presence of it was enough to garner a rare smile nothing less of radiant.

Phainon wonders what it is about the said flower that Mydei likes so much. He'd first seen them when Mydei offered to help tend to his wounds, which was months ago, implying that this was no mere passing preference that would fade after the itch had been scratched.

Perhaps he'll find the opportunity to ask next time. Whatever makes Mydei happy is first and foremost the only thing worth pursuing.

He takes the scenic route towards the training grounds just to appear not so eager regardless of the anticipation coiling beneath his ribs. Knowing Mydei's schedule like the back of his hand by now, he has more than enough time before the Kremnoan's turn to use the grounds would be up.

When he arrives, Mydei is unsurprisingly in the middle of dismantling some poor new recruit —a Kremnoan youth that had come of age perhaps, whose enthusiasm far outstrips his skill.

Mydei's torso is bare of any coverage with the exception of his jewelry, gleaming as it reflects Kephale's Dawn with every movement and the crimson marks on his skin exposed for everyone to see.

His face was hidden behind a helmet this time. Thin, hairline scratches marred the helmet's metal surface whilst the crimson plume swishes behind as Mydei parried every single attack of his opponent with a precise ease. It's almost absurd how it never fails to knock the breath out of Phainon's lungs, as if he were the one receiving every blow. *Wishes* for it to be the case.

Phainon catches the moment that Mydei spots him standing by the crowd of onlookers—a glint of gold from within the helmet's narrow slits.

A subtle falter in his step causes his opponent to seize the opening. Nothing but a brief advantage for Mydei easily disarms him with his spear and kicks him off balance in a blink of an eye with a single swipe at his feet.

"Yield," Mydei says, voice a little muffled from within the helmet but no less commanding.

The mere word alone sends shivers down Phainon's spine, an involuntary thrill that he tries to suppress. He envies the recruit that bears the honor of having the dulled tip of Mydei's spear be pointed at his throat.

The youth nods immediately with jerky movements, uncaring of how his hair has been soiled by the ground. He was evidently out of breath with the way his chest was heaving.

Mydei, barely a dent in his composure, helps his opponent up as the spectating crowd of idle warriors and citizens alike clap amicably, muttering amongst themselves the play-by-play of the spar.

It was then that Mydei removes his helmet, revealing the way his hair had been tied in a low knot that exposed the vulnerable line of his nape. The layer of sweat that shone upon the skin renders Phainon's throat unbelievably parched.

"We should conclude for now. Let the others have their turn," Mydei announces to his Kremnoan kin, his voice carrying easily across the training grounds. He turned to the youth he'd been sparring with. "Nepthis, practice your footwork. I'll come around to check on that later."

Nepthis nods enthusiastically, eyes brimming with sheer adoration—an emotion Phainon understands all too well, for *who* in Amphoreus wouldn't admire Mydeimos? Who would even *dare?*

"I'll make sure of it," Nepthis exclaims, bowing so low that the tip of his nose almost touches his knees. "Many thanks for your time, Your Highness."

The crowd begins to disperse—either going to the nearby well for a drink, or heading out towards the Marmoreal Market for some lunch. Phainon, however, remains rooted upon where he stood, patiently waiting for Mydei to come approach him like a loyal chimera dutifully on standby for its master.

It didn't take long, Mydei's measured footsteps a slow contrast to Phainon's beating heart.

"Deliverer."

Phainon opens his mouth to speak, memorized lines on the tip of his tongue—

"Renowned warrior whose very stride bids the trembling earth fall silent,

I entreat thee to receive this humble flora from my unsteady hand.

Though unrivaling of your radiant valor,

It bears the tender murmur of my devotion."

Mydei stares. It always takes him a moment to process the dramatic overture, and Phainon finds it quite endearing of him. He likes to see Mydei ponder some more as to whether or not Phainon deserves to be punched in the gut due to his sheer audacity, or a simple dry reply would suffice. Phainon would be thankful for either of those, or both.

Today, the latter has weighed heavier in Mydei's unvaried pool of choices. A gauntleted hand reaches out and unceremoniously takes the flowers from Phainon, followed by a sigh and a disbelieving shake of the head.

"You and your never-ending antics," Mydei muses with the enthusiasm of a grain of sand.

Phainon feigns his sadness. “I can’t believe my affections bear so little of value in your eyes.”

“I assure you they bear a value far greater than you’d imagine.”

Regardless of the deadpan tone, Phainon still finds his heart soaring from the implications. No matter if Mydei is just saying such empty words to perhaps not shatter Phainon’s ego, the mere fact that Mydei is humoring him despite the man’s blatant aversion to false niceties is already enough for Phainon to feel special.

Mydei appraises the flowers, his features softening as he brings them closer to subtly smell their scent. It’s more than enough for Phainon to deduce that the bouquet is satisfactory to Mydei’s tastes.

It was then that Mydei remembers they’re in public, turning to look around the surrounding area and causing Phainon to mirror the action.

There were Okheman soldiers training nearby, glancing a little too long in their direction to be considered as casual vigilance. Phainon hears Mydei sigh for a second time beside him, the exasperation a bit more genuine compared to earlier.

“People are beginning to talk.”

Phainon shrugs, ignoring the way the soldiers immediately look away the moment they catch Phainon’s gaze. “Let them talk.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “I thought you cared for discretion.”

Nothing about the way he’s courting Mydei is discreet. He simply has forgone any need to care for others’ opinions about who he indulges his time with.

At this point, their relationship must already be a most favored topic of hushed conversations spoken amidst gossiping civilians. No thanks to Akmonides fanning the flames with his ‘notes,’ selling them at the baths with prices that could render a regular merchant bankrupt.

As long as they don’t say anything that inherently disrespects Mydei or his people, Phainon hasn’t had the reason to intervene—factual information be damned.

“What gave you that idea?” Phainon finds himself asking.

Mydei looks away as if deep in thought, staring at nothing specific. Phainon sees how Mydei’s grip at the bouquet tightens with how the paper holding the flowers together crumples a little.

Quietly, Mydei answers, “Many things.”

The trance was short-lived. Rare are the moments that Mydei allows himself to get caught up in his thoughts. He then turns to Phainon once again, all traces of his previous somber expression nowhere to be seen.

“Let’s go,” he tells Phainon. “Before my soldiers hog all the meat at the diner.”

The questions were caught up in Phainon's throat, unsure which ones should be asked first. He settles for speaking of them another day when Mydei continues to trudge ahead without so much as waiting for him.

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Lord Phainon is now officially courting the crown prince of Kremnos.

Though tensions between the Council of Elders and the Kremnoan detachment are at an all-time high, it seems that our two Chryos Heirs can't find it within themselves to be bothered to care.

As per my predictions (and standard Okheman courtship customs), Lord Phainon and Lord Mydei should be due to wed in three months' time. Lord Phainon was also seen snooping in at jewelry shops looking at engagement rings. To know which ring he bought, purchase my insider scoop bundle for a 1% discount.

— from Akmonides' note, sold for 49,500 balance coins (sold out). Attached is a receipt of an additional 30,000 balance coins purchase for a more detailed, never-before-known insider scoop from a legitimate source

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"So, how's your courtship with Lord Mydei faring?"

"Being honest with you, Miss Castorice, it's not going as well as I'd hoped."

Phainon and Castorice were currently seated on the marble floor at a secluded area of the Marmoreal Palace where no attendants or unwitting civilians would be privy to. The large, open windows provided them with ample light and a gentle breeze that set the curtains fluttering lightly with the wind.

Castorice adds some more petals into a relatively large, granite mortar to grind for her next art endeavor, giving Phainon a sympathetic look in the meantime.

"How so?"

"For one, he doesn't seem to like my poetry that much," Phainon answers glumly as he sorted the petals by color.

"Is Lord Mydei not the type to enjoy such things?"

“I don’t think that’s the case. Although, he only ever speaks highly of Kremnoan literature.”

Castorice gives him a look. “Have you been quoting Okheman poetry all this time, Lord Phainon?”

“No. He once expressed his disdain for how flowery and obtuse Okheman poetry is, so I’ve been composing my own.” Phainon sighs, head drooping into his hands. Though it’s not good practice to expect the worst of things, perhaps things are indeed as bad as they seem. “Maybe I’m just really horrible at being a suitor.”

In Aedes Elysiae, courting was far more simple.

When a youth fancies another, they do not utter absurd metaphors about anything of poetic value. They ask the father of the courted which field ought to be cut and arrived before dawn the next day with their own sickle.

If the courted brought them water beneath the shade at noon and asked them to stay for dinner, that would mean acceptance. By next spring, they would be wed if their hearts had not wavered.

Phainon has come to know since then that everything about Okhema is never simple. And that also applies to courtship, it seems.

“You gift him a bouquet of flowers daily well past the Month of Everday,” Castorice notes placatingly. “I’d say consistency is the key, Lord Phainon.”

Procuring flowers out of season in an era where the Black Tide is rampant has caused its prices to become quite absurd. Phainon had already pawned most of his prized antiques just to have the money for it. Still—

“The effort only matters within the context of Okheman customs,” Phainon says, inconsolable. “I have yet to make it past the twenty-page preface detailing that of the Kremnoan’s. Miss Castorice, when I tell you that book is *huge*.”

Castorice giggles despite her sympathetic demeanor. “Then just skip past the twenty pages, Lord Phainon.”

“I’m on page twenty and it’s *still* going. All it speaks of is how the nation of Strife cares not for Romance. Not very beginner friendly and I’m desperate.”

He hands Castorice more petals to offset the hopeless feeling by being useful. Unfortunately, it’s of no use when he remembers the expression that Mydei had worn just earlier. Try as he might to forget about it, Phainon can’t simply help but think that there’s something he’s missing.

“Say, Miss Castorice,” he began. “Have you noticed anything weird about Mydei recently?”

Castorice shakes her head, purple eyes squinting lightly in thought. “I have not.”

“It’s just that, I can’t help but think that he’s been in a rather odd mood as of late,” Phainon explains. “More quiet than usual. I have reason to believe it’s because of me.”

Was Phainon’s poetry so bad that it warrants such a discouraging reaction? And if it is, why can’t Mydei just say it outright? He’s always been quick to criticize and hide it beneath the guise of speaking his mind.

“Perhaps it’s something entirely unrelated,” Castorice says lightly. “As long as he’s aware of your motives, there’s little to misunderstand. It’s likely that Lord Mydei already knows of Okheman courtship.”

Phainon pauses, intently eyeing the red and yellow petals in his hand. “Right.”

The movement of the pestle stops mid-grind as Castorice’s entire body goes rigid. There’s a long unbearable silence before she finally manages to find her voice.

“You *did* inform Lord Mydei that you’re courting him.”

It sounded like an accusation more than anything else. Phainon is at a loss on how he should even begin to explain it. He throws all hesitance to the wind and simply braces himself for the disapproval about to be heading his way.

“Well.” He clears his throat. “I haven’t told him *explicitly* that… I’m trying to court him.”

Upon hearing this, Castorice’s already pale face seemed to pale even further, her horror more evident than Phainon would’ve liked.

“With all due respect, Lord Phainon, *what?*”

“He already knows!” Phainon exclaims defensively. “For the first three days straight of offering him flowers and sharing affectionate poetry morning, noon, and in the quiet hours, he told me that courting him was very strange of me and that he had no further need of it.”

Lord Phainon, you’ve been rejected, was written all across Castorice’s face, her features unable to suppress her pity. “But you haven’t stopped.”

Phainon draws in a breath. “He also told me to do as I please. I think he’s trying to challenge me or something, and I’m not going to give up anytime soon.”

Castorice sighs and resumes her grinding. “That certainly puts things into perspective."

Phainon just continues to hand her some more petals in order to regain lost favor. When Castorice maintains her silence, he can’t help himself but ask, “What do you propose I do? Do you think his current strange mood is because of me?”

“Based on what you’ve told me, it probably is,” Castorice replies, an absolute turn-around from her earlier response to the question. “Have you tried talking to him about it?”

“I did and he just brushed me off. Said he was *fine*—” Phainon makes a pinched expression, one that’s born of the many times Mydei insists that everything’s alright on his end when it

very much is not. "—and to *stop pestering me, Deliverer*. And then he asked for a spar of which I got promptly defeated."

Castorice purses her lips, deft hands scooping the powdered petals out of the mortar and placing them upon the parchment paper beside her. She gives Phainon a side-long glance.

"Maybe flowers and poetry aren't working in your favor, then," she says. "What about jewelry?"

"He already has so many," Phainon tells her, feeling every bit resigned than ever before as their conversation continues. "How special would my courting gift be if I gave him one more accessory to add to the bunch? It'd be like offering fruit to the owner of an orchard."

"He does have many jewels," Castorice agrees.

At this, Phainon dramatically falls back onto the marble floor, the reverberations from the impact causing the carefully sorted petals around him to stir into the air in a chaotic spiral. By then, the piles he had so meticulously arranged were partially no more.

A red petal lands on the tip of his nose. Phainon follows the movement, mesmerized. "And yet, despite the odds seemingly going against me, I can't bring myself to give up."

Castorice sighs, eyeing the petals scattered everywhere. It was her kind heart that restrained her from having Phainon pick them all up and rearrange them to how they were before, his woes be damned.

"How about this, Lord Phainon—"

Phainon sits up immediately.

"Why not try to make the act of giving more special?" Castorice suggests. "I have read many romantic texts detailing various manners of offering. I'm sure you'll be able to decide on one of those and ultimately win Lord Mydei's heart."

"That does sound promising," Phainon mutters, a finger on his chin. "As for the gift—jewels it is, then. I know where to get those. In regards to the design, I can't really go far in that direction with Aglaea still stuck at Dawncloud."

Castorice's expression softens. "Lord Mydei has been telling me that he's been meaning to change his earring, but worries that it must match the usual set of accessories he's wearing." She shoots a knowing look towards Phainon's direction. "I reckon he's been too busy to commission Sir Chartonus for such a task."

Phainon nods in understanding, a smile on his lips. "I might have something in mind."

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~~*My most fearsome beloved*~~

a bit over the top maybe

Renowned warrior whose very stride bids the trembling earth (?) ~~*quake in terror cower dis to coll*~~ *fall silent,*

I ~~***beg***~~ *entreat thee — humbly? entreat thee? — to receive this* ~~*meager paltry*~~ *humble flora from my unsteady hand,* ~~***lest yours truly would find it appealing to welcome Thanathos' embrace***~~

Though unworthy? ~~*wholly unworthy*~~ *eclipsing? unrivaling of your radiant valor* ~~*which outshines Kephale's Dawn itself*~~*, it bears the [tender murmur] of my* ~~***love***~~ *devotion.*

(find more appropriate synonyms)

— contents of a notebook belonging to a person named 'K.' found on the rooftops of the Marmoreal Market

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"Are you *certain* that you haven't seen my necklace?" Mydei asks for the nth time that morning, rifling through the drawers and cabinets. Even going so far as to check the contents of every single antique amphora in Phainon's possession. "Even my arm bangles are missing, too."

Phainon sighs, comfortably settled upon their shared kline trying to read through volume one of *Kings of Kremnos*. Mydei recommended it as 'light reading' that might help Phainon learn the language and Kremnos' history all in one go. Phainon has come to realize that Mydei was overselling the lack of difficulty of the text in question.

"You've misplaced them, Mydei. Just admit it."

Mydei lets out an indignant sound, revisiting nooks and crannies he'd already gone through three times prior. "I *didn't*. I always put them in their usual spots." He then turns to Phainon, gaze accusatory. "You're the only other person in this room, Deliverer. I have no time for your tricks."

Phainon rolls his eyes. "It is rather offensive that you would blame me for something like that," he says, miffed but ultimately doesn't blame Mydei for his assumptions.

He *has* hidden Mydei's stuff before if only to mess with him. However, he's not trying to implicate himself any further by bringing that up now.

"If I remember correctly," Phainon continues. "The last time your items went missing, it was a hooded thief with a tail who stole them. You're lucky Aglaea was able to help."

A hint of uncertainty graces Mydei's features. "Do you reckon they're back? Those accessories are the last of their kind. They sure know to take something of worth."

“It’s likely.”

It’s very hard for Phainon to lie with a straight face when Mydei’s crestfallen expression was directed at him. However, there is a saying that, *sometimes*, the means can justify the ends.

“I’ll see if I can let Aglaea know of the matter by sending a letter to Dawncloud,” he amends, leaving his restful state to walk towards Mydei and coaxing him into what should seem like a comforting embrace.

It felt rather insincere with the guilt gnawing in Phainon’s gut, but Mydei just allows himself to be held for longer than a moment until he eventually calms down. When Mydei pulls away, the troubled look on his face has subsided.

Phainon brushes a lock of blonde hair to the side to see Mydei’s eyes better. “Go handle your princely duties,” he says as a way of teasing and lightening up the mood. “I’m sure the detachment won’t mistake their crown prince for a peasant due to his lack of refinery and effects.”

Mydei swats at his hand with a huff like an offended chimera, rolling his eyes as he does so. “I’ll leave it to you, then,” he tells Phainon as he walks towards the door. “Send Aglaea my apologies in the meantime for having her share this triviality.”

“It’s not trivial.”

“I have no time to debate with you. Don’t land yourself in trouble while I’m gone,” was Mydei’s response as Janus closed the door behind him, leaving Phainon alone in their shared chambers.

As soon as the rhythmic sound of Mydei’s greaves against the marble floor no longer echoed throughout the hallway from outside, Phainon finally rushed to the closet where he had hidden an unsuspecting wooden box labeled ‘Phainon’s old clothes.’ It was no short of a miracle that Mydei hadn’t spared it a glance.

Phainon lets out a breath as he opens the lid to see the aforementioned necklace and arm bangles Mydei had been scouring the room for, nestled in a pile of brightly colored clothes Phainon had worn in his youth.

By the end of the day, he would make it seem that he found it in a place Mydei had never looked. No need to send a letter to Aglaea or chase down that elusive thief.

Mydei would doubt the claim, or perhaps accuse Phainon of hiding his accessories from him as a form of entertainment. Phainon would deny this, of course, and he’d be left to deal with a very irritable Mydeimos as a result. However, there’s also the possibility that Mydei would thank him once the air of doubt has dissipated. It gives Phainon something to look forward to for later.

The trip to Marmoreal Market was short-lived. It was the middle of the Action Hour and everyone was engaged in the bustle, fortunately paying Phainon no mind as he slipped into the crowd and headed straight towards the smithy.

Chartonus was just reigniting the flame of the forge when Phainon arrived. “Chartonus, I’m here to put down a commission and… I’d like to be *discreet* about it.”

The mountain dweller turns to him with a slight tilt to his head. To keep things professional, Chartonus merely says, “Whatever it is, of service, I am.”

Phainon affords a quick glance to his surroundings, making sure no one was looking, before unwrapping the package he’d been carrying. He shows Chartonus the contents before subsequently handing him a bag of sapphires—an eighth of his share from the ones given to him by the Kremnoans during the Month of Joy.

“I want a new set of these but embellished with these gemstones,” Phainon says, gesturing at Mydei’s usual accessories. “I’m not confident in designing a new set that I’m sure Myd— *er,* the receiver would like so—” He clears his throat. “Perhaps something that looks similar would be nice.”

Chartonus stares at him long enough to make him feel unsettled. With the helmet in the way, Phainon couldn’t quite make out Chartonus’ expression. It’s probably for the best to not see the judgement in those eyes; nothing else could scream ‘*this belongs to Mydei*’ than the distinct necklace always seen worn on Mydei’s person.

“Something in mind, I have,” Chartonus tells Phainon as he carefully takes Mydei’s accessories in one hand and the bag of sapphires on the other, placing it upon his work table. He then deftly lays all the items upon the surface to inspect them better. “Easy to replicate, this is.”

Phainon smiles. Chartonus never disappoints. “I do, however, have a specific style for an earring I’d like for you to make.”

He pulls out a small folded sheet of parchment paper from his pocket before showing it to Chartonus. Drawn on it was a sketch of an earring he’d asked Castorice for help with the day before.

“It might be able to house the gemstone better in this shape,” he explains. “And it doesn’t quite conflict from the original design, is what I’m hoping. But if you have any suggestions, Chartonus, I’m open to them.”

Chartonus shakes his head. “This design, Mydei would like, I’m sure.”

“W-Who said these are for Mydei?” Phainon asks, wincing at the strain in his voice. “You’re funny, Chartonus.”

He couldn’t blame the other for being able to see through his pretenses so quickly. At the very least, he could maintain some dignity through denial.

Chartonus merely ignores him and starts sketching out the design of Mydei’s accessories on a separate sheet of parchment paper, adding in notes and measurements in the meantime.

“The order, for when do you want it finished?” he asks Phainon.

“You can take your time with it, Chartonus. I’m in no rush.” Phainon pauses. “I might have to take back the accessories before I leave, though.”

Chartonus nods. “Two weeks, done,” is all he says.

Though there’s a specific timeframe to follow when it comes to Okheman courtship, Phainon would like to think that he and Mydei are an exception. Marriage was not something the Chrysos Heirs place priority upon, but it’s not forbidden. Not exactly.

Still, from what Castorice had advised him to do, Phainon has had no intentions to hurry.

“Maybe Lord Mydei thinks you’re rushing him. How about flowers every other day? And perhaps limit the poetry to only once a week.”

Castorice has never once led Phainon astray, so who is he to go against the sincere counsel of a good friend? He’ll take it slow, then.

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Borrower’s Log

Date Borrowed*: Day 24 of the Month of Everday, Light Year 4928*

Item*: Book*

Title*: Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship*

Borrower*: A besotted nobody who will return this once he’s mastered the Kremnoan language and earned the affection of his heart’s desire.*

Status*: Unreturned (OVERDUE)*

Fine*:*

~~*200 balance coins for the first week*~~

~~*400 balance coins*~~

~~*800 balance coins*~~

~~*10,000 balance coins*~~

~~***Return this or die.***~~

Notice**: This item is now taken from the library's records for an indefinite period of time. To the person who borrowed this, **I will find you.

Anyone who refrains from signing their full name in the borrower's log is banned in my library.

— signed: Mydei, librarian and owner

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It wasn't so hard at all for Phainon to 'take it slow' for the following weeks.

The moment that Aglaea had returned from Dawncloud, both he and Mydei had been beyond swamped with fending off Nikador's Titankin and launching rescue operations for refugees stranded in the Abyss. Something about Aglaea setting foot in that place always sets the tensions high, and the workload of the Chrysos Heirs pile up even higher as consequence.

It's no surprise that the Council of Elders, albeit nearing death's door, still found the energy to complain about the 'worthless interference' of those with golden blood. Not like the old fogies do much to help the remnants of Amphoreus' civilization when they're too busy warming their cushions, basking in the comfort Kephale's Dawn brings.

In Evernight, light nor warmth permeated the air. It made the days bleed into each other in a blur of darkness, and the scent of blood and smoke almost a fixture in one's nostrils.

Aside from him, only Mydei really understands the dreadful effects of the Black Tide with how often they're sent into two different directions of the Abyss for weeks on end. The only time they get to see each other is when it's time to report back to Aglaea, and even that was not a guaranteed possibility considering that it's rather rare for the two of them to even be in Okhema at the exact same time.

To somewhat offset the distance, Phainon had sent several letters towards Mydei's end of the camp—some serious ones with new information to be shared, and most just asking how Mydei was faring. He'd received short and clipped responses in return. As to be expected from Mydei, he supposes.

Hunched over the fire light, Phainon thumbs through the pages of *Kremnoan Rituals of Courtship*, making productive use of his downtime while the rest of the soldiers are recuperating from their prior skirmish with Nikador's Titankin. It isn't for another two quints for them to have to move to a new location.

As Phainon flips through the thick tome from where he'd last stopped, he frowns when he sees that it still didn't depict the first chapter.

“For a nation known to value actions over words, the author of this book sure had a lot to say,” Phainon mutters to himself.

He proceeds to slowly go through each line of Kremnoan text, taking comfort in the fact that perhaps when the day arrives that he reaches the actual preliminary steps of Kremnoan courtship, he’d have a much easier time deciphering what was written due to how much practice he’d gotten from the mere preface alone. It’s consolation enough.

The optimism unfortunately dissipates shortly after when he finds himself struggling with no Kremnoan dictionary in his satchel to speak of. Just as he was about to give up for the time being, he hears the soft crunch of footsteps against the ashen ground approaching him from behind.

“My lord, the reconnaissance team has returned.”

Phainon looks behind him to address the soldier, stiffening almost immediately when he notices who it was that stood alongside him.

It was the guard he’d spoken ill of in front of Professor Anaxa. Guilt made him vow to never do so again, and in the process, have the virtue to at least know of the guard’s name as recompense.

The soldier who had informed Phainon of the reconnaissance team’s return dismisses himself towards the tents after earning a nod from Phainon, leaving the latter alone with the guard.

“Iosif,” Phainon addresses, closing his book as he stands up. He tries to keep his tone neutral as he speaks. “You have news for me?”

Iosif nods. “Ruins to the southwest from here seemed clear at the moment. But we spotted a few groups of Titankin around the camp on our way back,” he says. “Nothing we couldn’t handle, of course, but I suppose it would be best to relocate at an earlier time than what was initially planned.”

It was a sound judgement and Phainon knows better than to doubt a fellow soldier regardless of personal matters. “Very well,” he agrees. “Take a moment to rest before you inform the others. We move out in a quint.”

Phainon doesn’t wait for Iosif’s response, opting to bend down to pick up his book and satchel. His mind was already set to take down his tent the moment he returns to it, only to see Iosif not moving a single muscle from where he stood.

“Is there something else I can help you with?” Phainon prompts, an eyebrow raised.

Iosif was eyeing the book held under Phainon’s arm. “Lord Phainon, I hope I’m not overstepping here by asking: are you and Lord Mydei lovers?”

Phainon takes a long moment to stare him down, his hold on his book tightening a little. “You’ve overstepped,” is what he’s opted to say. “You may go now, Iosif.” He then brushes past the guard, taking brisk steps away from the campfire.

“I asked for his hand twice and yet all I received in return was rejection,” Iosif says after him, voice a touch louder than what was considered appropriate.

Phainon stops in his tracks, willing himself to not grind his teeth when he replies with a terse, “You didn’t think to stop the first time he turned you down?”

“He didn’t give me a reason as to why he’d do such a thing.”

“Perhaps he just doesn’t like you,” Phainon simpers, feigning sympathy. “Mydei always means what he says. But I suppose he’s a kind enough man that he would rather choose silence than to blatantly hurt your feelings.”

Iosif’s gaze turns sharp as he frowns. “It’s not a matter of whether or not he likes me. I have reason to believe that his heart has already been taken. Which is why I ask, Lord Phainon, are *you* the one who has done so?”

“Apologies. My mood has soured and I’m now disinclined to let you pry into my personal life, let alone Mydei’s. Now, if you’ll excuse me—”

“And what of the rumors of your courtship?” Iosif pushes.

Phainon slowly lets out a breath. “What of it?”

“My father is in the Council,” Iosif says, not even bothering to disguise the vague threat in his words. “Courtship is of no use if you can’t marry. Kremnoans are forbidden from their ceremonies until a year has passed. Have you forgotten?”

Phainon has forgotten *nothing*, especially not when it concerns Mydei and his kin. He’d probably have a better grasp at his patience were it to be any other day, but he’s already pretty irritated.

“And why do you think I expect Mydei to marry me?” he snaps.

Iosif falters visibly. “Isn’t that the purpose of courtship?”

“My decision to court Mydei does not correlate with *his* decision to marry me, *if* he even wants to. For now, I’m just content that he's letting me do as I please and that is to shower him with affection whenever possible. I am not entitled for any sort of reciprocation.”

“No man can withstand such futility,” Iosif tells him like it’s a fact.

Phainon only smiles. “Be ready in a quint, soldier.”

Jaw clenched, Phainon walks away. He deludes himself that retreat this time does not equate to defeat, nor does he allow himself to dwell on the pointless rambles of a soldier he has no reason to take seriously.

A single backhand to the head from Phainon would’ve given Iosif a serious concussion, and hopefully perhaps induce a permanent memory loss for the already reasonably deficient man.

Phainon only hopes that it'd be enough for Iosif to forget Mydei's existence entirely. For Mydei to exist in Iosif's memories is already an insult to Mydei himself.

The gravel crunches beneath Phainon's boots as he passes by several tents on the way to his own. Even if the Abyss was seldom troubled with noise, the quiet does nothing to help Phainon with the roaring that occurs in his mind.

No man can withstand such futility.

Futile. Is that what *this* is? Is that what it has always been?

Phainon has brushed the surface of its meaning during days shrouded in doubt. And perhaps in doing so, he's already begun to know the true essence of his actions without truly realizing them, refusing to acknowledge it altogether if only to preserve some semblance of purpose.

There's no marriage in the future to speak of. Not for the likes of them whose body and soul should solely be dedicated to the cause of the Flame-Chase. All Phainon has to offer Mydei is his heart.

No man can withstand such futility.

With how much time Phainon has spent with Mydei, he knows that the latter is not the type to lead someone on. Mydei has principles, far more than Phainon does and it gives him relief to know that there's a miniscule chance Mydei is indeed taking his feelings seriously.

Sure, he'd been rather dismissive of Phainon's efforts at courtship, but he still accepted it—although exasperatedly. Almost like it's… *futile.*

Then again, he ventured into this courtship with no expectations. All he wanted to do was let Mydei know of where his heart truly lies. If he sought to blame anyone, it would be himself.

But nothing about courting Mydei warrants any blame, for it is not a mistake to love.

Phainon draws in a shaky breath. He could only trust in himself to remain sincere until the very end. Mydei deserves as much if not more. If the day comes that the Era Nova is fulfilled, Phainon would make sure it is with Mydei that he sees it.

"My lord."

A Kremnoan messenger stood in front of Phainon's tent, clearly waiting for him. His presence immediately halted Phainon's train of thought.

"You're here," Phainon greets with a smile, his foul mood gone in an instant. "Did Mydei send you?"

The messenger nods. "A response to your letter," he says before procuring a small folded piece of parchment, reaching out to give it to Phainon. "His Highness says that a reply isn't necessary."

Phainon's heart sinks at the implications. "I see," was all he could muster to say, failing to hide the dejection in his tone. Perhaps he is no better than a twice-rejected guard after all—both of them pining for an affection far out of their reach.

Sensing Phainon's disappointment, the messenger clears his throat. "His Highness was in good spirits when he wrote his reply. I assume whatever he's written must bring happy news."

"Is that so," Phainon says absentmindedly, still unconvinced. The paper is a heavy weight in his hand. "Regardless, my sincerest thanks for delivering this. Keep safe on your return to Mydei's camp."

The messenger nods and rushes back into the darkness. Once alone, Phainon enters his tent and unfolds the letter immediately, his breaths quickening in anticipation.

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Aglaea permits our return. I'll be waiting for you, Deliverer.

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The air had grown heavy, spurred on by the heady scent of perfumed candles and the subtle musk of sweat. The curtains were drawn shut, only slivers of Kephale's Dawn slipping through the gaps, barely illuminating the room.

Though Phainon would've initially preferred seeing Mydei in an adequately lit room, the dimness only does wonders in highlighting the thin sheen of sweat coating his skin, accompanied by the faint glow of those scarlet marks that decorated him.

In the quiet lull, Mydei was a pliant weight against him, the usual rigid lines of his figure softened into a boneless sprawl with his back to Phainon's chest. To have a man so formidable upon him, Phainon wouldn't have it any other way; there's a certain satisfaction to it. To know so intimately the dormant current of strength Mydei possesses be rendered moot in this temporal moment. And the fact that Mydei allows for it, that in itself could subdue Phainon quicker than any near-fatal wound he's experienced in the past.

"Phainon."

Phainon continues his ministrations, reverently mapping out the valleys and ridges of Mydei's body as he'd done so countless times before—as if he'd purposefully forgotten how it feels to the touch if only to relive the rush the first time his palms met heated skin.

"*Phainon*."

Mydei calls out to him again, a little impatient this time. And yet Phainon notices the slight tilt of his head if only to allow Phainon more skin to lave his tongue on.

"Is something wrong?" he asks, fingers brushing against the ladder of Mydei's ribs, feeling the subtle expansion of breath.

Mydei huffs against him, frustration in his voice when he says, "Is this really necessary?"

Phainon raises his head from the crook of Mydei's neck, the salt of Mydei's sweat coating his tongue. He examines Mydei carefully, spit-slicked lips slightly parted, the flush of his skin a stark contrast to the blue silk that covered his eyes.

"It's necessary," Phainon answers, planting a soft kiss against the corner of Mydei's mouth. He doesn't miss the way Mydei leans towards him to catch his lips fully, but Phainon pulls away just in time with great effort to resist. "I don't want to ruin the surprise."

"You exhaust me," Mydei snaps without much heat.

And though Phainon could hear the fond exasperation in Mydei's tone, he still says, "I suppose I've satisfied you enough. Should we stop?"

Mydei says nothing, lips now pressed into a straight line. The only answer Phainon gets is the subtle shift of Mydei's hips against him, clenching almost dizzyingly tight against Phainon's cock that he has to stifle a moan against the shell of Mydei's reddened ear.

Phainon allows himself to slowly grind into Mydei after a period of staying still. To his defense, simply being hyper-aware of every twitch of Mydei's hole against his cock is more than enough to keep him satisfied, confident that the same applies for Mydei. If the sticky dampness of the sheets beneath them—a mix of Mydei's release and Phainon's own that leaked from Mydei's body with every minute thrust, an indication of just how long they'd been like this—isn't evidence enough, then Phainon doesn't know what is.

He skims the sensitive skin of Mydei's inner thigh, his hand drifting higher to lightly tug at Mydei's cock, softened from his recent release. Sensitive, no doubt, but nevertheless gradually fills out from Phainon's attention.

Mydei hisses, a wounded sound slipping past his lips that's more reflex than intent. His body shudders against Phainon's hold just as Phainon's other hand retraces the path up to his chest, firmly cupping the pliant muscles that fills up his palm so well. He teases a pert nipple in between his fingers, relishing the way Mydei arches to the touch and causing Phainon to bury even deeper into him.

He presses open-mouthed kisses along the column of Mydei's neck, nipping at his jaw before licking into the seam of his mouth, catching the soft sounds Mydei makes in the process.

Seeing to it that Mydei was distracted, he uses his hand to blindly pat the space beside him where he'd deliberately hidden the earring he'd commissioned from Chartonus beneath the

disordered pillows and ruffled sheets. It was an effort to make sure Mydei wouldn't accidentally find it during their earlier coupling, and far more tedious for Phainon to avoid crushing it with their weight.

Chartonus' craft is delicate (and expensive). It would be a waste if it were destroyed due to a moment's carelessness.

Just as he was able to finally locate the earring, the accessory feeling impossibly small and heavy all the same in his hold, he then regretfully pulls away from the kiss. Mydei lets out a disgruntled noise at the back of his throat, seemingly confused when the tip of his nose met Phainon's chin instead.

"Don't move," Phainon tells him gently, his free hand guiding Mydei's jaw to lean sideways, head now resting fully upon Phainon's shoulder.

Phainon works the clasp of the earring with his fingers before bringing it up near Mydei's left ear. A startled gasp slips past Mydei's lips when he feels Phainon's knuckle brush against the sensitive skin of his neck, only growing imperceptibly quiet when the cool metal of the earring's clasp is secured on his earlobe with a definitive click.

The sapphire gleams from where it rests snugly right at the center of the golden frame, an embodiment of Phainon's desperate need to leave a piece of himself on Mydei's skin.

Seemingly out of breath, Phainon watches as the weight of the earring stretches Mydei's lobe ever so slightly, unable to resist the urge to caress the delicate skin.

"There."

Mydei shifts slightly after the initial shock. "What—?"

His hand starts to rise, perhaps curious to touch the earring Phainon made him wear. But Phainon stops him just in time, lacing their fingers together.

"Just look," Phainon whispers against the shell of Mydei's ear, lips brushing the contrasting feverish skin and the coolness of the earring's clasp.

With his right hand, he reaches up to undo the knot of the blindfold with a single tug. The blue silk slithers away with a quiet rustle, almost unceremoniously.

The brief glimmer of light that reflects from Phainon's periphery makes him aware of a mirror's presence tucked away at the corner of the room. He meets Mydei's gaze upon its reflection, his breath rendered lost at the lewd sight they paint.

Mydei is beautiful like this. Framed by the quiet stillness of the room and gilded edge of the mirror, the sight becomes something almost entirely unreal. It doesn't matter if Phainon has seen Mydei completely bare multiple times. He's already come to terms that he'll never grow tired of it, much less consider it anything less than breathtaking.

And though Phainon's eyes have lingered on Mydei's figure every chance he gets since he'd first laid eyes on the man, there's still always a certain layer to it that makes seeing Mydei up

close inherently intimate.

Up close, the intimacy makes everything *immediate*. But in the now, from the mirror's reflection, there's time to linger. To take in every detail wholly without the fear of anything going unnoticed and vanishing just as quickly.

For a moment, Phainon simply watches as Mydei slowly blinks the daze away, reacquainting himself with his sense of sight after being deprived of it. Then his gaze of muted gold shifts slightly, finally acknowledging the vivid point of blue hanging beneath his left ear.

Phainon holds his breath, anticipating Mydei's reaction with a growing discomfort. He expects a protest, or a dismissive roll of the eyes. Maybe even a passive comment about the excess of it all, or a scolding about Phainon's spending habits.

But there was only the barest hitch in Mydei's breathing, something Phainon felt with his touch with a hand against Mydei's chest. Eyes of gold that are soft in their exhaustion widen fractionally as it sharpens with sudden clarity and a flush much deeper than what was already coloring Mydei's skin grows ever darker.

Mydei makes no point to move, his attention absolute on the gleaming sapphire as if trying to comprehend its meaning.

"It's not your usual color, I must admit," Phainon says, nosing at the space behind Mydei's ear. He's unable to help a smile that curls itself against Mydei's feverish skin. "But I'm assuming that you like it, seeing as you have yet to say anything mean?"

Mydei scoffs, averting his gaze from the mirror at last. Then, with a reserve of strength that never failed to astonish Phainon, he began to move. Slow and deliberate rolls of his hips that renders Phainon weak as heat pools low in his belly.

He chokes out a gasp, burying his face into the crook of Mydei's neck, helpless to resist with how the languid burn of friction causes a wave of aching pressure that brings him closer to the edge.

"You didn't have to," Mydei manages, voice barely a whisper as his pace quickened.

Phainon meets his thrusts. "I'll show you the rest of the set later."

"I ought to wear them, then," Mydei tells him, a small smile to his lips as if aiming to tease. "Brand myself in your colors."

The words go straight to Phainon's head, dizzying him with their weight. He exhales a breathy, helpless sound against Mydei's skin, unsure whether or not to take the claim seriously.

"*Mydei,* you can't just say that," he says, *pleads* through gritted teeth.

Mydei pays him no mind, lost in the pleasure when Phainon begins to stroke his leaking cock in tandem with their pace.

“Close—” Mydei gasps. “Properly— Take me properly—”

Phainon flips them in a fluid motion, laying Mydei back against the tangled sheets. A choked sound escapes Mydei’s lips when Phainon once again slides into that slick heat, the arch of his back supported by Phainon’s hand with the tips of his fingers pressed against his spine.

He looms over Mydei, the squeeze of Mydei’s thighs against his hips beckoning him to go faster. It’s nigh impossible to deny Mydei of anything, and the sight of Mydei beneath him has Phainon unable to decide where to fixate his gaze on—those lidded eyes of gold brimming with unshed tears, the flickering glow of scarlet marks that signify Mydei is close, those lips caught in between the teeth to silence any sound, or that sapphire glinting from his left ear with every thrust.

With his free hand, Phainon brings Mydei’s wrist to his lips, leaving soft and almost reverent kisses against the frantic pulse before moving up to Mydei’s palm where the tip of his tongue traces a line not seen. The line stops when his lips brush against the base of Mydei’s fingers, an intrusive thought suddenly surfacing at the back of his mind that’s nothing more than a dangerous and possessive urge.

I want to put a ring here someday.

The realization doesn’t startle him in the way he expected it should have. There is something deeply unsettling in how easily his mind accommodates the thought, insidious in its clarity despite his initial adamancy to never yearn for something that isn’t within reach.

And as though he was a man who has truly lost his wits, he bares his teeth and bites down into the thin flesh that housed the vein that led straight from Mydei’s heart. He felt the skin give from the sharp pressure, the taste of blood against his tongue immediate and dreadful.

Mydei’s entire body went rigid beneath him, and only then does Phainon become aware of what he had just done.

He leans back if only to see the proof of his undoing. The small wound at the base of Mydei’s ring finger welled freely with golden blood. It caught the candlelight as it gathered, luminous against his skin before beginning its slow, ribbon-like trail towards his wrist.

“Mydei—” Phainon’s voice cracks as he struggles to come up with the right words to even excuse his behavior. If there is any. “I wasn’t— I didn’t mean—”

Mydei stares at his hand, his face devoid of any emotion. “It’s fine.”

As if on cue, the small wound simply closes on itself barely a moment later with the terrible efficiency of a body that had long since stopped being permitted to scar. Almost as if the bite had never even been, leaving only the golden trail tracing its path down to where his pulse is, now dripping to his forearm.

Though Phainon had bitten Mydei hard enough to break skin before and vice versa, there’s something irrevocably different about this instance that leaves Phainon deeply unsettled—as if what he’d done isn’t ‘fine’ as Mydei had put it.

They were no strangers to either violence or intimacy, or even the presence of both. Yet Phainon feels strangely disturbed, and it is then that he comes to realize that neither of those had been the intent that preceded the act. And even if he admittedly hadn't been right in the head to think so before, what he'd done could be reframed into something that borders too closely on a claim he has no right to make.

Phainon's throat closes up on him as the air around them grew charged with a sudden, terrifying weight that neither of them could seem to pinpoint. And Mydei looked like his mind had wandered so far away that Phainon worries if he could even reach him.

"...Mydei?" he tries.

For what seems to be a long while, they both stay unmoving, as though Oronyx allowed time to freeze over in the midst of their entanglement. As if they're nothing more than sculptures depicting tragedy in the moment.

Phainon almost wills the ground would swallow him whole. Voice barely above a whisper, Phainon tries again. "Mydei?"

This time, Mydei's gaze shifts to him but no less distant. As if he's looking at a stranger. He opens his mouth to speak but Phainon could barely follow along with what Mydei has to say.

"I've never once prided myself for my patience," Mydei tells him, a heavy sigh the regretful preamble to his words. "But for you, *philtas*, you make me feel as if I'm the most patient man in this dying world."

Phainon has indubitably crossed a line he should never have crossed. "I'm sorry."

There is no confusion in what he has done. He couldn't even grant himself that small mercy. And he knows far more than anyone that Mydei is not an idiot.

"You have your reasons, and I have come to realize that it is not something you part with so freely regardless of coaxing," Mydei continues, examining his bare ring finger with a somber look on his face. It almost sounds as if he's trying to defend Phainon's transgressions.

He lowers his hand, gaze now directed at nothing in particular, if Phainon counts as nothing. It doesn't feel as if Mydei was scolding him. There's no sharpness of anger in his tone, nor is it inherently frustrated. It just sounds unnervingly… *sad*.

"Perhaps I shouldn't have expected anything from you," Mydei says, strangely soft despite his words. "You'll have to forgive me for being disappointed."

Phainon tenses, every single muscle freezing in their existence. The pleasure that had been singing through his veins had long since curdled, his hope shattering into a million pieces whilst dread cements itself into the very marrow of his bones.

This is a confirmation, if nothing else, that Mydei is disappointed at Phainon's blatant gesture of wishing for something far more than what is freely given.

No man can withstand such futility.

Mydei allowed for courtship thinking that Phainon knew of their limitations. And Phainon *did*. For a time, he stood obediently behind that line of constraint.

Regardless of his regrets, his mind traitorously soothes itself with hollow excuses to justify what had been—that his actions were nothing more than a thought that surfaced without permission, taking shape before he could properly discard it.

It is only because of this that Phainon learns his lesson: a thought left unchecked has a way of revealing more than one intends, and what it had revealed in the moment was not something Phainon could easily deny. Not to Mydei.

Yet, despite everything, Mydei simply gazes at him like he's already been forgiven. It renders Phainon physically sick to his stomach.

There is no marriage to speak of for the likes of them, Phainon has always known this. And it is the narrow space between their bodies—deceivingly intimate in their nature—that is the unfortunate witness of Phainon's humiliation.

"I'm sorry."

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Wedding rings are a must in order to signify the marriage of two people*—to be worn on the fourth finger of one's left hand. It is a tradition practiced in the majority of Amphoreus' city states, not only in Okhema.*

…one notable state who have deviated from this tradition and have opted to the use of other items to signify union is ***Castrum Kremnos, where a matrimonial dagger is considered enough****.*

Though it is not strange for rings to still be used, it is simply uncommon—often hinders battle —and only worn to signify the merits of one's lineage.

— an excerpt. A Guide to the Perfect Okheman Wedding

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They haven't lain together in weeks.

Contrary to what he'd initially expected, nothing has changed between him and Mydei. At least, nothing of note *yet*. It is perhaps the most disquieting outcome he could ever have imagined.

He’s never thought about a time where normalcy would unnerve him this much. Even the rare instances where Mydei is the one who initiates intimacy has rendered Phainon conflicted.

Upon the third day of Phainon’s refusal to do anything more than indulge in light kisses and chaste touches, Mydei had stopped trying altogether. Still, he didn't show his dismay, simply nodding understandingly and stirring their conversation to something else.

He knows Mydei found it strange considering how insatiable Phainon usually is. It’s quite hard these days to keep himself in check especially when he always sees Mydei parade himself wearing the accessories Phainon had commissioned.

The blue of the sapphires look devastatingly good on him. After all, Phainon did once consider dressing Mydei in his clothes—have Mydei walk around Okhema in blues and whites for the entire city to know that Mydei allowed for such a blatant claim.

Nevertheless, no amount of depravity on his part could offset that unsettling feeling that had settled seemingly permanently in his gut whenever he sees, or even *thinks* of Mydei. What’s most distressing of all is how Mydei does really seem *fine.* He acts like his words that day were nothing more than casual honesty when Phainon is losing sleep over it.

He’s spent more than half a year trying to understand Mydei and his many complexities that he had fully expected Mydei to simply up and leave the moment that Phainon had stepped over an unspoken boundary. Mydei would most certainly make it known that he is not to be in a place he doesn’t want to be in.

And if Phainon has disappointed him, why does he act as if that fact is nothing more than a minor mishap? Mydei has punished Phainon before for much pettier reasons. And though he’d grown lenient as their familiarity became intimate, surely Phainon still deserves at least something akin to a harsh reprimand? Anything definitive enough that would allow Phainon to fathom where he stands even if that place is nowhere at all.

He would take a ‘*you’ve disappointed me greatly. Let’s end this arrangement. I have no further need of you, Deliverer’* than whatever Mydei is playing at.

Instead, he is left in this uncertain in-between where nothing is addressed and nothing is resolved, and the absence of consequence begins to feel like something far more deliberate than indifference.

Everything just feels indubitably wrong somehow and Phainon is unsure if he could even make *anything* right.

“Phainon,” came Aglaea’s voice.

It does little to pull Phainon out of his stupor as he stares at the marble floor before him. There’s interest to be felt in seeing the winding cracks drawing abstract images upon the concrete. Like veins.

The image of Mydei’s golden blood dripping generously from the tiny wound at the base of his finger paints a vivid picture in Phainon’s mind. Suddenly, what he’d eaten for breakfast is

threatening to leave his stomach.

"*Phainon*."

Phainon snaps his head up. Aglaea's clouded gaze was directed at him, but not quite. Despite the amicable curve of her lips that could very well pass off as a smile, Phainon knew well enough that Aglaea was growing a little frustrated at him.

"I'm sorry," he says lamely.

"You are distracted," Aglaea tells him like she's not to be argued with.

Phainon could only nod, feeling as if his head was nothing more than a foreign body he'd just attached to his neck. At this point, agreeing to whatever Aglaea says would be better than trying to put up a dignified front.

The golden threads had long since seen past his pretentious layers. He would only serve to invoke Aglaea's wrath if he were to lie straight to her face.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says again, head tipped low.

He hears Aglaea sigh from behind her desk. "It will do you no good to head out into the Abyss if your mind is elsewhere."

Phainon looks up immediately. "It's fine. I can manage."

Aglaea merely stares him down, evidently not believing a single word Phainon has said. Phainon's shoulders sag, accepting defeat.

"I'm… not fine."

"It's about time we've established that," Aglaea muses.

Phainon frowns. "What?"

"Since you're not one to refuse a mission outright," Aglaea continues, clearly not inclined to elaborate further. Phainon couldn't blame her. There's more important matters to discuss than Phainon's woes and apparent unstable mental state after all. "Why don't you take someone with you? You're in no shape to make decisions alone."

"I'm not opposed."

Aglaea nods lightly just as a yellow butterfly—a Mnestia Titankin—perches daintily on her finger. "I've already informed Mydeimos. He should be here shortly."

Phainon's mind becomes an alarming mess at the mention of Mydei, and he trips over words on his tongue trying to come up with a reason why this is a bad idea.

"Aglaea, there's really, *really* no need—"

The door to Aglaea's office swings open as Janus allows someone passage. Mydei strides into the center of the room beside Phainon in long, deliberate steps.

Phainon's mind blanks, the first thought forming after the initial erasure being: *Mydei is so beautiful.* His second thought simply consists of an internal debate of whether or not he should cause a diversion and escape while both Mydei and Aglaea are distracted.

Third, *Aglaea, if you can hear my thoughts through your threads, I am going to wear the most detestable robes in all of Amphoreus and I'm going to parade myself in front of you.*

Aglaea coughs lightly, a delicate hand covering her mouth. "Mydei, I see you've received my message."

Mydei's attention was at Phainon, an eyebrow raised and everything as he stares the latter down. "I never thought I'd see the day where the Deliverer would require assistance in escorting refugees to the holy city."

"I *don't* need assistance—"

Before Phainon could finish his retort, Mydei was already in his space, taking Phainon's face in his gauntleted hands. Phainon winces at the stark coldness of the metal against his skin, but the sensation couldn't even begin to distract him from the sudden warmth when Mydei presses their foreheads together.

Phainon had stopped breathing altogether, unable to grasp the situation fully with how his hands had remained uselessly limp by his side. Mydei's eyes were closed, and it's almost disorienting for Phainon to count his eyelashes like it's instinct given their proximity.

"You're not ill," Mydei tells him as he finally pulls away, giving Phainon a worried look if Phainon allows himself to indulge in a little bit of delusion. "Did you not sleep well again?"

"I'm alright," Phainon replies, the lie a rough friction against his teeth. He takes a step back to allow some much needed space in between them. "Aglaea just thinks we're both suited for this mission instead of me going by my lonesome."

Mydei eyes him carefully. "That's odd."

"I'll be fine on my own."

"I'll go with you. I have nothing better to do, anyway."

Phainon sighs. They *really* have to do this right in front of Aglaea, don't they? "It's just to rescue refugees. I won't even have to fight if it's not necessary."

"I'm not worried about you having to deal with Titankin," Mydei shoots back. "You can deal with them all you want and I'll stay at the back watching."

"Then why even bother coming in the first place?"

Mydei's lips press into a thin line as he crosses his arms. "Do you want me to go with you or not?"

"I—" Phainon flounders for a response, ultimately going with a resigned, "*Fine*."

"Fine what?"

"Do whatever you want, Mydeimos. As you've always done," Phainon says, turning his attention back to Aglaea who seemed unperturbed by their usual back-and-forth in favor of arranging the piles of paper on her desk.

When both Phainon and Mydei had gone quiet at last, Aglaea looks up and smiles, barely reaching her eyes.

"I'm glad that's settled," she says pointedly. "Your dromases have already been prepared. I wish you the best of luck, heroes."

It's come to dawn on Phainon early on in their journey to the Abyss that Mydei was in the mood to talk. Strangely so given how the latter usually preferred the sound of silence in such situations—often telling Phainon to keep the ramblings to a minimum lest they fail to hear the sound of any approaching hostilities.

"You should go to the Twilight Courtyard and get some of those sleeping draughts they have," Mydei tells him.

Phainon nods absentmindedly. "I'll find the time."

"I've been trying to make your dinner help induce sleep for weeks now but I suppose it's not effective."

"Thank you, Mydei."

A stillness in the moment settles upon them as they near the site where the refugees were last thought to be. They disembark the dromases together and led them to a hidden spot safe enough that they wouldn't be at risk of collapsing structures.

Just as they pass beneath a dilapidated arch, Mydei speaks. "A moment, Deliverer."

Phainon turns around to face Mydei. "What's the matter?"

"Just so there's no misunderstandings between us as I have come to assume, I'm not mad at you. For anything."

"You've established that quite clearly," Phainon says with a strained smile. "But I wish you wouldn't be so considerate when it comes to my transgressions. It leaves a foul taste in my mouth."

Mydei sighs, eyes closing briefly as exasperation lined his features. “I’m not going to punish you for something like that. It doesn’t matter to *me*, Deliverer. I have no need of it and already made my peace months ago. *You* know this, I’ve never even brought it up with you.”

“Well, it matters a great deal to me *now,* Mydei,” Phainon shoots back, unable to hide his frustration any longer. “I’ve disappointed you, as you’ve made so clear, and yet you take it all so magnanimously. Are my actions not significant enough for you to warrant at least anger? Or is it just how it is in Kremnos?”

Phainon immediately regrets the words that have left his mouth. He didn’t mean to bring Mydei’s origins into this after the trust Mydei had placed on him regarding his past. Still, given what he’s known of Kremnos and their culture, he wouldn’t be surprised if they didn’t take the concept of marriage that seriously.

Mydei’s lips curl into a frown, eyes narrowing into golden slits that gives Phainon the impression that if he says another tactless thing, Mydei is going to put him down.

“Though you are right in your assumptions,” Mydei confirms slowly. “I find your tone very displeasing. I suggest you mind your tongue, *haikas.*”

The word lands differently than the many times Mydei has referred to Phainon as such. It almost sounds like he means it this time. *Scoundrel*, the word translates to as Phainon had come to know during his time studying the Kremnoan language.

Nevertheless, it would seem that neither of them are ready for this conversation, and Phainon is sure that continuing would only make matters worse.

“I’m sorry,” he says, his own voice a foreign sound in his ear before turning away. “Perhaps we should speak of this no further.”

They eventually find the refugees later on deep within the ruins with little to no conversation. It works as a distraction to the tension that has accumulated between the two of them. By the time the refugees have been rounded up and accounted for, Phainon’s bitter mood has been awashed with relief that everyone was fine.

He could tell that Mydei was no longer irate when the tension evident in the muscles of his shoulders had dissipated, focusing his attention on assisting the elderly. The softness of his voice was a stark contrast to how he’d called Phainon a scoundrel in perhaps only a quint ago.

“Please watch your step,” Phainon hears Mydei say from a distance.

The refugees were remnants of a vassal state of Okhema called Adian who worshipped Talanton after the First Flame-Chase Journey. It was only due to a device personally given by Aglaea herself that they were able to send a distress signal.

Phainon is currently keeping the children preoccupied while they take a break to patch up the injured. He casts a glance at Mydei’s direction, spotting an old woman and a young lady alongside him.

The old woman gives Mydei a smile, a hand gripping Mydei's forearm to support herself. "What a handsome young lad. Isn't he, Larisa?"

Though Mydei doesn't grace them with a response, Phainon could tell he'd gotten rather flustered by the praise judging from how the tips of his ears slowly began to redden.

Larisa, the young lady also assisting the old woman, only nods shyly but keeps her head down as though trying to keep a low profile.

"Are you in need of a wife, good sir?" the old woman continues, chuckling to herself as Mydei makes her sit on a relatively smooth rock to rest. "My granddaughter here seems to be of your age."

"*Yiayiá!*" Larisa hisses before shooting an apologetic look towards Mydei.

Phainon cranes his head to get a better view of Mydei's expression from where he's situated, only to find golden eyes meet his gaze albeit briefly. Stunned, Phainon looks away and turns his attention back to the children. His hearing, however, drowns out all the unnecessary noise apart from the not-so-hushed conversation that Mydei was having.

"I am in no need of a wife," Phainon hears Mydei say eventually.

Nothing in the way Mydei spoke betrayed how he truly felt from having such a personal question directed at him. By a stranger, no less. Phainon remembers Mydei being on the verge of chewing his head off during those first few months of their acquaintance whenever his curiosity got the better of him.

It is rather unfortunate that Phainon couldn't see the expression on Mydei's face this time, the latter's back turned to him completely when Mydei had moved to the side to have Larisa sit with her grandmother.

"How so?" the older woman questions, eyebrows furrowed. "You can't possibly be married with no ring on your finger! Isn't that how they do it in Okhema, too?"

"*Yiayiá*, that's enough. I'm so sorry, my lor—"

"Ladies."

Phainon swoops in just in time, ready to rescue Mydei from the old woman's probing clutches. He knew he had to intervene somehow when he saw the lines of Mydei's back go stiff.

He smiles at the two women, an arm casually slung upon Mydei's shoulder. "Do you mind if I borrow him for a moment?"

Larisa's grandmother was positively stunned at the sight of Phainon. "Another handsome young man," she gushes. "Do tell, are you in need of a wife?"

Mydei was quiet beside him. He hadn't even shrugged Phainon away as Phainon expected him to do. Nevertheless, Phainon just leaves him to regain his composure while he shoulders

the burden of the old woman's questions.

"Ma'am, you'll find yourself in abundance of suitable prospects for your granddaughter once you arrive in Okhema."

Larisa's grandmother frowns. "But they don't compare to a Chrysos Heir, surely?"

"A Chrysos Heir barely has time for oneself, let alone a spouse," Phainon reasons smoothly, some semblance of truth in his words. "Your granddaughter would fare better in the hands of, perhaps, a merchant?"

"It's of no matter at all!" the old woman dismisses with a wave of her hand. "My granddaughter can withstand minimal affection, all she needs is marriage. Now that her parents are gone, it is up to me to find her a suitable husband—someone who would be able to take good care of her even after my soul journeys to Thanatos' embrace."

Phainon couldn't even get a word in as Larisa's grandmother rambled on. He glances at his side to check on Mydei considering how quiet he'd been during the entire conversation, but finds the man staring blankly out into the dark distance of the Abyss.

Huh.

"—are you?"

Phainon turns to the old woman. "Pardon?"

"My lord, you are unwed, are you?" Larisa's grandmother repeats.

Phainon sighs. "I am indeed unwed. And I assure you, I am only such because I'm the furthest from being suitable for married life."

"What a pity," the old woman laments before turning her attention to Mydei. "And what about you—? *Oh!*"

Mydei slaps Phainon's arm away from his shoulder before storming away.

Phainon stares at his retreating figure, ignoring the sting. "Mydei?"

"My goodness, it seems I have offended him thoroughly. He looked very much distraught."

Mydei? Distraught?

"I shall give this matter a rest," Larisa's grandmother says. "Please, my lord, do convey this old woman's sincerest apologies."

Larisa huffs. "*Yiayiá*, you should've listened to me when I told you to stop…"

Phainon couldn't hear the rest of their conversation anymore as he chased after Mydei, already an impressive amount of paces ahead of him that Phainon could almost lose him in the fog.

“Mydei!” he calls. “Hey, wait!” He touches Mydei’s shoulder once he’s caught up. “Where are you going—?”

Mydei shoves him away roughly, hard enough that Phainon almost stumbles back. Phainon feels the sting of rejection ache tremendously. Mydei isn’t even looking at him.

“...Mydei?”

Mydei’s voice quivers, uncharacteristically meek yet Phainon hears him loud and blaring amidst the howling winds of the Abyss.

“I know that you’re only trying to get her off your back. But were those words really necessary?”

Phainon’s mouth goes dry. “I—”

Mydei walks away, not even sparing a single thought to hear what Phainon has to say. When Phainon calls for him again, Mydei no longer listens.

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Mydei had been ignoring him for the better part of yesterday even when they had already returned to Okhema alongside the refugees they rescued from the Abyss.

Phainon deludes himself into thinking that it was simply because they had been too busy helping the followers of Talanton settle into the holy city. But when the Curtain-Fall Hour came and went, Mydei had not come.

He remained at his desk writing reports until his fingers could no longer pick up his quill and the ink on its tip had dried. His ears had strained to hear approaching footsteps from outside the hall, but at some point, he had ultimately fallen asleep from the exhaustion of the mission and waiting for Mydei to return.

The next morning, he’s surprised to find himself on the bed with Mydei waking him up for breakfast as usual.

“You’re back.”

Mydei hands him the tray stiffly. “Eat.”

The terseness in Mydei’s voice sets Phainon on edge almost immediately, dissipating what’s left of his appetite and rendering it difficult to even think about consuming anything at the moment.

He forces himself to comply, nonetheless. The food looked good (unsurprisingly) and he’d rather avoid worsening the ominous frown that seemed like a permanent fixture on Mydei’s

face this early in the day.

Phainon takes a bite and chews slowly, barely registering the flavors as he does so. Mydei simply watches him eat. What Phainon would give to know what he's thinking.

"So," Phainon starts, making sure he'd swallowed his food before attempting conversation. "About yesterday."

"Have you found the initiative to apologize?" Mydei says, his tone clipped.

Ah.

Phainon assumes that Mydei meant that dig he made at Kremnos when it came to marriage.

So he was *still* mad about that despite Phainon already apologizing right after he'd said the words. Honestly, he can't bring himself to blame Mydei for ignoring the apology. The comment was unnecessary and out of line, and the memory of it sits poorly with him.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says again just for good measure. "I didn't mean to disrespect you or your culture, Mydei. I am willing to make amends. Just tell me what to do."

"That's not the reason I'm cross with you."

What? Then what was Mydei pertaining to?

Phainon knew better than to ask. Mydei looks as if he's only mere moments away from reaching across the food tray to strangle Phainon and put him to an eternal sleep.

"Uh, Larisa's grandmother passes on her apologies," he tries, feeling idiotic. The words feel clumsy even as he utters them, a voice in his head telling him that he's saying the wrong thing. "Is that what you mean?"

Mydei stares him down, bearing none of its usual warmth. It's enough for Phainon to feel unsettled. The sharpness in those golden eyes could be unnerving whenever they so wish to be. If looks could kill, Phainon would've been long gone.

"Use your brain, *Phainon of Aedes Elysiae*."

Phainon opened his mouth but no words could come out. Mydei is *livid* for some reason. And though Phainon had wished this was the reaction he'd gotten *that* day when he'd overstepped and made his desire for marriage implicitly known, the idea that Mydei is mad at him for something else entirely renders him very much concerned.

A stray thought flickers through his mind, absurd and terribly ill-timed: he's the only one who could take Mydei in a fight. But is that really what he ought to be thinking of right now when Mydei looks as if he wants to *kill* him?

"Um—"

"I suppose you need encouragement."

Mydei rises from the bed in one smooth motion, the mattress settling as it readjusts to the lack of his weight. He then starts pacing back and forth in slow deliberate steps, like a predatory lion savoring the fear from its prey.

“I ran across Larisa yesterday,” Mydei began as though he’s telling a story. Phainon is positively scared for his life. “She sought me out to convey her apologies and mentioned in passing that you were kind enough to introduce her to a merchant’s son. They were smitten upon first sight.”

Phainon nods a little too quickly. “Y-Yes. It was the least I could do.”

“Because you couldn’t step in to be her spouse?”

What a strange question.

“Even if I could, I wouldn’t want to,” Phainon argues, wondering where this conversation is headed. “She would only come to live a life of regret if she were to be with me.”

Mydei stops pacing and stares at him blankly, lips pressed into a thin line. The abrupt stillness is most jarring.

Despite the lackluster reception, Phainon thinks his reasoning is quite sound. He wouldn’t have time for a spouse with his attention solely focused on being a Chrysos Heir and fulfilling a prophecy—which is why he tried to nail it down in his head that there’s no marriage to speak of for the likes of him and Mydei.

It would be unfair to subject an unsuspecting lady to so many worries considering how Phainon is handling danger most of the time.

Those reasons put aside, Phainon’s heart already belongs to someone else. Fervently so. To the point that it burns as long as he shares the same sky and existence with the man he offered it to, beating and bleeding in equal measure.

Mydei blinks slowly and looks away, his gaze this time far more distant and pondering. As though something had pulled his thoughts far beyond the confines of Phainon’s chambers.

“Yes,” he says at last. “I do agree that a life with you would be quite regretful.”

Phainon winces. “You do, huh.”

He doesn’t mind portraying such an image to others. But to Mydei…

“Any advice on how I could change that?” he finds himself asking, trying his luck with nothing more than a nervous smile playing on his lips and the dread of anticipation.

Mydei’s brows draw together. “Change what?”

“Be a suitable marriage candidate.”

“You’re asking *me*.”

“Why not?” Phainon says, debating internally whether or not he should’ve just kept his mouth shut and ate his food. “As the person I’m courting, I’m sure you have some insights on what I could improve upon regardless of your… obvious aversion to being wed.”

To me, remains unspoken—simply hanging quietly beneath the layer of his words.

Mydei stares at Phainon as though he’d grown two heads. “*My* aversion?” He scoffs, seemingly incredulous. “*What?*”

“What?” Phainon asks in turn, growing confused by the moment.

“Phainon.”

“Yes?”

Mydei lets out a shaky breath. “All these months, what am I to you?”

Phainon hesitates, his composure fracturing as the words continue to snag against his throat. The question lands with this strange, bitter symmetry; it’s the very thing he’s been meaning to ask Mydei all along, now turned back on him like an accusation.

“You’re— You—”

“Someone you’re ‘courting’?” Mydei answers for him, his voice sharp and unsteady. “Or perhaps some passing lover who warms your bed? Or are those too generous of a definition?”

Phainon was vehemently caught off guard, because why is Mydei purporting to be a mirror of his thoughts that he’d dare not say out loud? Why would *this* even be something of importance to Mydei when it is Phainon who longs for him regardless of his own self-detriment?

It was then that Phainon realizes he’d taken too long to answer Mydei’s question, the latter already turning heel and marching towards the door.

“Wait—!”

Phainon leaves the bed in a hurry, bare feet almost slipping on the marble tiles as he reaches out for Mydei’s arm.

“Mydei. Wait.”

Mydei stops in his tracks. “Let go of me.”

“At least tell me what this is about,” Phainon pleads short of breath. “You confuse me and then you just— *leave?* This is so unlike you. You’re being unreasonable right now.”

Upon hearing this, Mydei turns around, his eyes ablaze with barely concealed fury.

“*Me? Unreasonable?*” He snatches his hand from Phainon’s grasp before roughly shoving Phainon away. “You—”

Mydei scoffs, cutting himself off to look away briefly in disbelief. His eyes began to glisten as he blinked rapidly, as though trying to hold back tears.

“I’ve had an inkling for a couple of months now since you began that stunt of yours about courting me. But I thought you were simply being an idiot *haikas*, always with your grand displays of affection.

“But that day when you bit me—as if you were mocking the fact of your own shortcomings with how my finger sat bare of your claim for *months.* And you even dare to be upset over the fact that I made my peace with it. I demanded nothing of you because I have no need of any other significance when we are already bound by blood.

“And now it all makes sense to me, you foolish *haikas*.” He pauses. “No. Maybe it is I who is the foolish one.”

Phainon’s ears are ringing, his mind reduced to nothing but a whirling mess like an inferno caught in a storm. His voice is small and quiet when he speaks, unreflecting of the chaos that he feels at the moment.

“Mydei, you are not making any sense right now.”

Mydei’s lip quivers. Phainon wants to hold him close but he fears he’s lost the strength to move.

“Phainon. This whole time, you never once thought of *me* to be your *husband?*”

Everything seems to have stilled at that very moment—Phainon hears of nothing, thinks of nothing, and speaks of nothing.

All he sees is the uncharacteristically broken expression on Mydei’s face, and the lone tear that finally allows itself to fall freely from the corner of Mydei’s eye, solidifying in mere moments before it could even drip from his chin if only to form an indistinct scarlet crystal that falls to the floor mutedly.

What?

“I—”

Phainon swallows whatever insignificant thing it was that he was about to say. Or perhaps the apology on the tip of his tongue like it’s of any use. As if any word that slips past his lips at this moment could even begin to resolve whatever this is.

Mydei brings a gauntleted hand up to briskly wipe his eye, the sharp tips of his fingers accidentally cutting a thin ribbon just high off his cheekbone. It wells slightly with a shimmer of gold that’s gone in an instant.

When he returns his focus on Phainon, his eyes have dimmed. “It’s fine. You need not answer.”

“Since when?”

“Since the Month of Joy.” Mydei turns away. “I have to leave.”

The thought of Mydei leaving again knocks Phainon out of his initial shock. Desperately, “Where are you going?”

“Away from you.”

Phainon grabs Mydei’s wrist once again before Mydei could even land another step towards the exit. This time, however, no words were needed to be exchanged as Mydei shoves Phainon away *hard*, the sudden surge of strength catching Phainon off-guard as he barely registers the sight of red crystals surrounding him.

The swift force was enough to send him across the room, slamming towards the door that led to the balcony before knocking him off the railing entirely.

Phainon barely had the instinct to brace himself for impact. The moment his body hits the ground, Phainon thinks he’d broken at least more than half of his ribs, the only thing to cushion his fall being his arms (which were now broken as well, unsurprisingly).

If he were an ordinary human, he’d be dead.

Horrified screams could be heard around him, the shrill sound muffled by the sharp throbbing pain in his head. The last thing he sees before his vision eventually goes dark were the remnants of red crystals that had fallen alongside him.

Even in these moments, all he could think of was Mydei, and the panicked expression on his face when he realized that Phainon was a tad too late to be saved.

≪ ☼ ≫

present time

creation season, month of weaving

Phainon draws in a shaky breath as he enters his room.

With Hyacine herself deeming Phainon’s legs somewhat capable of working after a full day of rest and healing magic from the Twilight Courtyard, Phainon had immediately sought the opportunity to limp back to his chambers, unsteady on his crutches as the attendants shoot him worried looks.

His room was expectedly devoid of a certain someone’s presence. For a moment, Phainon simply stands still to stare at the mess left in the wake of yesterday’s disaster. It is unavoidable for his heart to ache at the trace of Mydei’s fury.

Ignoring the jagged, red crystals that have now scattered prominently around the room, Phainon slowly limps to the bed where the tray containing his half-eaten breakfast lies untouched.

Just as his mind could be swallowed by the memory of his and Mydei's conversation before everything went sideways, a yellow butterfly nymph lands at the edge of his plate daintily.

"Aglaea?" Phainon calls, feeling stupid.

The butterfly's antennae flits subtly before it flaps its wings once again, fluttering towards the door. Janus immediately grants it exit, and he at least had half a mind to realize that the Mnestia Titankin wanted him to follow.

Tightening his grip on his crutches, Phainon tries to keep up with the nymph, careful to not lose his balance (as he already did so for more than five times in a row on his way to his chambers from the infirmary).

The nymph led him straight towards Mydei's library—thankfully empty at this time in the Curtain-Fall Hour.

It hovers about for a moment around the room before ultimately perching itself delicately upon an unfurled scroll on a table.

Beside the scroll, a half-empty cup of honey brew was situated, seemingly too recent with how it still emanated its signature sweet aroma. The subtle swirl of milk made it obvious to whom the drink belonged to.

Phainon cranes his neck to read the title script at the top of the scroll:

Kremnoan Traditions: Culture and Customs throughout History

Without a moment's hesitation, Phainon strains to balance himself as he leans forward to grab the scroll with his working fingers. After a brief nod to the nymph, who he *swears* had nodded back at him, Phainon limps out of the library to head back to his room.

Chapter End Notes

uh hii :D it's been a while >< i honestly didn't expect for the update to take this long given that i had the outline done like months ago. i kinda just didn't have the time to sit down and lock in and write it all out :(

▶ 🌟 **reference/s and yap**

anyways, thank you so much for reading and for being patient with the updates 💗 i really am sorry that i can't reply to every comment (i'll still try my best to reply!!) but please know i read all of them while giggling and kicking my feet. i appreciate you all

so much for taking the time to leave me super kind words and for all the kudos 💗 thank you thank you 💗

End Notes

special thanks to these lovely people for their amazing art!!

lilure for a wonderful phaidei sketch from chapter 6.

Sarikha_15 for their lovely phaidei sketch from chapter 7, and _yn319 for their amazing scene animation also from chapter 7 that i myself can't just stop watching. it's THAT good please please go check it out and support the wonderful riikyun (@_yn319) for their efforts!!

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riikyun @_yn319 for drawing phainon asking for forgiveness from chapter 10.

and bunnyclvb for their phaidei balcony doodle!!

go check them out if you haven't yet and support these lovely artists!! 💗

my twitter & bluesky if you wanna drop by and say hi

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